



Tenets of Prayer¹

expressed in practical words born of much grief
 on repentance
 on counsel for the benefit of the soul,
 on self-discipline,
 on the rules of contrite living,
 on dedication and commitment,
 on exposing the unseen,
 on confession of sins,
 on disclosure of secrets,
 on laying open of the covered up,
 on reproach for the hidden.

powerful salves for incurable wounds,
 effective medicines for invisible pains,
 multi-symptom remedies for the pangs of turmoil,
 for the passions of all temperaments,
 occasions for tears, impulses to prayer,
 prepared in response to the requests of the hermit fathers and the multitude in the desert,
 called the book of lamentations written by the monk Gregory of Narek Monastery.

Prayer 1 (U)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

The voice of a sighing heart, its sobs and mournful cries,¹
 I offer up to you, O Seer of Secrets,²

¹See prayer 88, ll. 43-49.

¹Cf. Ps. 6:7; See, also, Ps. 38:9-10, ("For my soul is filled with torment, and there is no cure for my body. I am tortured and laid low in the extreme, and I groan with the sighs of my heart."); Rom. 8:26 ("Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with sighs too deep for words, and he who searches the hearts of men knows what is in the mind of Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints according to the will of God."). But See Is. 6:10.

²Ps. 44:21.

placing the fruits of my wavering mind³
 as a savory sacrifice on the fire of my grieving soul⁴
 to be delivered to you in the censer of my will.

Compassionate Lord, breathe in
 this offering and look more favorably on it
 than upon a more sumptuous sacrifice⁵
 offered with rich smoke. Please find
 this simple string of words acceptable.
 Do not turn in disdain.

May this unsolicited gift reach you,
 this sacrifice of words⁶
 from the deep mystery-filled chamber
 of my feelings, consumed in flames
 fueled by whatever grace I may have within me.⁷

As I pray, do not let these
 pleas annoy you, Almighty,
 like the raised hands of Jacob,
 whose irreverence was rebuked
 by Isaiah,⁸ nor let them seem like the impudence
 of Babylon criticized in the 72nd Psalm.

But let these words be acceptable
 as were the fragrant offerings

³Ps. 42:6 ("Why are you cast down, my soul?"); also incanted by the deacon during the Ascension to the Altar at the beginning of the Armenian Divine Liturgy.

⁴Ps. 39:3.

⁵Ps. 51:15-20, Am. 5:22.

⁶Cf. Divine Liturgy, Hymn of the Angels "Hresh-takayin" ("myriads of angels worship you, yet it was pleasing to you to receive praise in a mysterious voice from human beings.").

⁷Ps. 92:14 ("They [the righteous] shall still bring forth fruit in old age; they shall be fat and flourishing."); Cf. Pr. 11:25 ("The liberal soul shall be made fat; and he that watereth shall be watered also himself."); See Lev. 1:8-13; For "fat as a choice offering," See, Lev. 4:8-9 ("and the fat that is upon them"); Philip. 4:18 ("I have all and abound: I am full . . . an odor of sweet smell, a sacrifice acceptable, well-pleasing to God."); Lk. 6:46 ("For the good man out of the good treasure of his heart produces good . . . for out of the abundance of the heart his mouth speaks."); But see, Is. 6:10.

⁸Is. 1:15.



in the tabernacle at Shiloh⁹
 raised again by David on his return from
 captivity
 as the resting place for the ark of the covenant,
 a symbol for the restoration of my lost soul.

¶

Because your stern judgment
 echoes mightily in the valley of retribution,¹⁰
 contradictory impulses in my soul
 brace for battle like clashing mobs.
 Crowds of thoughts strike each other, sword
 against armor, evil against good,
 ensnaring me for death, as in other times,
 when your grace had not rescued me –
 that grace of Christ, which Paul,
 chosen among the apostles,
 taught was greater than the law of Moses.¹¹

For as the Scripture says, “The day
 of the Lord is upon us,”¹²
 and in the narrow valley of Jehoshaphat¹³
 on the banks of the Kidron,¹⁴
 those small battle grounds
 foreshadow on earth
 victory in the life to come.
 Thus, the kingdom of God in a visible form
 has come already, charging me
 on truthful testimony with wrongs
 graver than those of the Edomites,¹⁵
 Philistines and other barbarians –
 wrongs that brought down the hand of God.
 And whereas their sentences were measured in
 years,
 my transgressions will be punished without
 term.
 As the prophet and the parable-teller warned,
 the dungeon and shackles¹⁶
 are already at my threshold to show me
 here and now my eternal disgrace.

⁹2 Sam. 6:17.

¹⁰Jl. 3:14.

¹¹Acts 13:39, Rom. 8:2-3.

¹²Jl. 2:1, 3:14.

¹³2 Chr. 20:16, 20:26-27.

¹⁴2 Chr. 15:16.

¹⁵Is. 14:26-29, Jer. 47:1, 49:7-18.

¹⁶Is. 24:17, Jer. 48:43.

Only you can work the miracle
 to make life possible for a soul
 so imperiled by doubt,
 O Atoner for all, exalted beyond saying
 in your boundless glory on high
 forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 2 (¶)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

And now, my heavy laden soul,
 what will you do?
 You call with your lips and voice to
 God most high,
 God, who cares only for deeds and
 is not taken in by words.
 You, my soul, with a heart always turned
 toward Egypt,
 how can I describe you?¹

Am I
 a Sodom, to be punished likewise with de-
 struction,²
 or the prosecutor of Ninevah, who was struck
 dumb?³

Am I
 more cowardly and barbarous than the
 queen of the south,⁴
 lower than Canaan,⁵
 more stubborn than Amalek,⁶
 incurable as the city of idols,⁷
 a relic left behind from the rebellion of Israel,⁸
 a reminder of the broken covenant of Judah,⁹

¹Is. 29:13. Acts 7:39

²Gen. 19:1-29.

³Mt. 12:41.

⁴Mt. 12:42.

⁵Hos. 12:7.

⁶Ex. 17:8-16.

⁷Jer. 51:9.

⁸Ex 32:1-4.

⁹Jer. 3:6-11.



more reproachable than Tyre,¹⁰
 more shunned than Zidon,¹¹
 more immoral than Galilee,
 more unpardonable than faithless Capernaum,¹²
 maligned like Korazin,¹³
 slandered like Bethsaida? ¹⁴

Or am I
 immodest as Ephraim as he grayed,
 or a dove, whose gentleness seems due to
 feeble-mindedness and not to inner calm, ¹⁵
 or an evil serpent born of lion's cubs,
 or the serpent's egg filled with decay,
 or like the last blow against Jerusalem?

Or am I
 in the words of our Lord
 and the sayings of the prophets,¹⁶
 an abandoned tabernacle about to collapse,
 the unlatched doors of the stronghold,
 my speaking edifice stained again,
 having given up my rightful inheritance,
 my home built by God,
 as Moses, David and Jeremiah prophesied? ¹⁷
 My thinking body now consumed by disease,
 afflicted with carping counsel, rehabilitated by
 the law,
 anointed with the clay of mildness,
 incapable of finding my own salvation,
 torn away from the maker's hand,
 expelled as just punishment
 by order of the Almighty, to an unholy place,¹⁸
 rejected, exiled, greatly shunned, nothing
 spared,
 having buried my gift in the ground,¹⁹
 like the one chastised in the Gospel by
 losing his inheritance.

¶

¹⁰Jl. 3:4.

¹¹Jl. 3:4.

¹²Lk. 10:15.

¹³Mt. 11:21.

¹⁴Mt. 11:21.

¹⁵Hos. 7:9-11.

¹⁶Lk. 21:20-24, Jer. 30:7.

¹⁷Jer. 12:7-13.

¹⁸Lev. 14:40.

¹⁹Mt. 25:18.

But you, God,
 Lord of souls and all flesh,
 in the words of one divinely graced,²⁰
 you are long-suffering and abounding in
 mercy.

In the voice of blessed Jonah,²¹
 grant that I finish to your delight
 this book of prayers, now begun.
 And having sown these words with tears
 and set forth on this journey toward the
 dwellings you have prepared,
 may I return joyfully in the time of harvest
 with the bounty of atonement,
 with sheaves of goodness and the fruits of
 delight.

Do not give me a barren heart,
 like the childless womb that was Israel's,²²
 or eyes like dry breasts,²³
 but hear the prayers of your thoughtful servant,
 almighty and merciful Lord,
 before the prayers of heaven,
 as those of heaven are heard before those of
 earth,
 the earth before offerings of wheat, wine and
 oil,
 and the wheat, wine and oil before Jezreel,²⁴
 so may the pleadings of the heavenly host
 move my soul more than worldly temptation.
 You – the potter, I – the clay.²⁵
 Show me, here at the threshold of these contrite
 prayers,
 the sweetness of your will.
 Strengthen me that I might not be unworthy
 of the light when the heavens open,
 so that I might not be consumed and snuffed
 out
 like a candle.

Rather as you would for any earnest entreaty,²⁶
 give me heart, for I am exhausted,
 give me strength, for I am weary,

²⁰Num. 16:22.

²¹Jon. 4:2.

²²Gen. 11:30.

²³Hos. 9:14.

²⁴Hos. 2:21-22;

²⁵Is. 64:8; Jer. 18:6.

²⁶Is. 25:4 (Arm. 25:5).



give me life, for I am worn by pangs of conscience,
and relieve my anguish in seeking you.
Accept the gift of my prayers
and grant the mercy of your grace.
Accept this meager offering from a weakling like me,
and grant greatly from your heavenly might.
Fortify my words of repentance, having sent the
Holy Ghost, endowed with the message of the breath of God.
Grant, benevolent Lord, that we might be enlightened like Isaiah.
Offer me, although I am deserving of death, the gold of grace instead of the brass of a disregarded voice,
the brightness of copper instead of blackness of unadorned iron, remembering copper as a symbol of virtue shining from Lebanon.²⁷

¶

Why have you hardened my miserable heart so I do not fear you, who is beyond words and awe? ²⁸

Help, so I will not be unfruitful in this task like the planter vainly sowing seeds into barren ground.²⁹

Spare me that I may not labor without birth,
sigh without tears,
meditate without voice,
cloud without rain,
struggle without reaching,
call without being heard,
implore without being heeded,
groan without being comforted,
beg without being helped,
smolder without aroma,³⁰
see you without being fulfilled.
Hear me, Lord, before I cry out to you, who alone are almighty,
Do not leave the wages of my suffering uncompensated

²⁷Is. 60:17.

²⁸Is. 63:17.

²⁹Mt. 13:5; Jn. 10:11.

³⁰Lev. 3:3-5, 1 Sam. 2:15.

for the tallied days of my life of sin,
wayward soul that I am.

¶

Grant me life, compassionate Lord.
Hear me, merciful Lord.
Be charitable to me, forgiving Lord.
Save me, long-suffering Lord.
Protect me, defender Lord.
Be generous, all-giving Lord.
Free me, all-powerful Lord.
Revive me, restoring Lord.
Raise me again, awe-inspiring Lord.
Enlighten me, heavenly Lord.
Cure me, omnipotent Lord.
Grant pardon, inscrutable Lord.
Bestow gifts, bountiful Lord.
Adorn me with grace, generous Lord.
Let us be reconciled, healing Lord.
Be accepting, unvengeful Lord.
Wipe away my transgressions, blessed Lord,
so that on that Day of Misery,
when I stare at the abyss on either side,
I may also catch sight of your salvation,
my hope and guardian,
and on that terrifying journey
your angel of peace may sweetly guide me.

Endow me, Lord, on the day my breath is finished
with a clean spirit raised in light among the joyful heavenly host,
with gifts of your love overtaking me.
May I arrive with the workers for justice.
Grant to my wayward soul an unexpected kindness
on that day of despair.
Do not assign, blessed Lord and Savior,
a wild beast to guide your sick sheep,
but grant me health, for I am dying of sin,
grant me salvation, for I am ruined by transgressions.

¶

Will you, I wonder:
Forget to be charitable, my expectation?
Neglect to be compassionate, caring Lord?



Regret your charity toward humankind, constant Lord?

Retreat from your life-giving, everlasting Lord?

Abandon the cheerful fruit of your mercy?

Corrupt the gracious flower of your sweetness?

Dishonor the grandeur of your generous bounty? ³¹

Vary the glory of your white-haired exaltation? ³²

Waste the fitting splendor of your crown?

If bliss is for the merciful,
then you, a kingdom unto yourself, filled with love,

will you not grant me full salvation?

Will you not offer a salve for my wounds?

Will you not minister to my pains?

Will you not cure my weakness?

Will you not shed light upon the darkness,
for me who trusts in your strength?

You, gift of life to the universe,
who alone have glory in oneself and of oneself,
whose everlasting being is witnessed by everything,

blessed and glorified through three eternities,
and beyond the limits of all conceivable infinities.

Amen.

Prayer 3 (Գ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Lord, my Lord, grantor of gifts, root of goodness,
ruler of all equally, creator of all from nothing,
glorified, awesome, awe inspiring,
beyond understanding,
dreadful, mighty, stern,
unbearable, unapproachable, incomprehensible,

inconceivable,

ineffable, invisible, unexamined,

untouchable, unsearchable,

without beginning, outside of time,

unclouded knowledge, bold vision,

true being, exalted and humble,¹

blessed existence, shadowless dawn,

ray shining upon all, light professing to all,

unwavering assurance, undisturbable calm,

indelible seal, infinite image, witnessed name,

taste of sweetness, cup of bliss,

soul-nourishing bread, love in dark exile,

unambiguous promise,

covering most desirable, garment most protective,

cloak most worthy, ornament most glorious,

great help, trustworthy refuge,

undiminishing grace, inexhaustible treasure,

pure rain, glittering dew,

universal cure, free healing,

health restored, sublime spur,

undeceiving call, good news for all,

king who lifts up the slave,

defender who loves the poor,

giver of endless wealth,

safe harbor, unyielding command,

hope without bounds,

long in vision, unsparing in generosity,

just right hand that dispenses to all,

impartial eye, voice of comfort, consoling tidings,

harbinger of bliss,

living name, finger of foresight,

unstumbling start, sincere course,

life-giving will, candid advice, unenvying honor,

broad possibility, narrow restriction,

track without trace, path without markers,

image indescribable, quantity immeasurable,

model inimitable,

unparalleled compassion, inexhaustible mercy,

humility celebrated, kiss of salvation.

And more than these worthy epithets,

dedicated to your Godliness,

you who are blessed, praised, lauded,

³¹Dan. 7:9 (white-hair of the ancient of days).

³²Rev. 1:14.

¹Ps. 138:8.



preached, evangelized,
 proclaimed, exalted, recounted, sought with
 unflagging desire,
 whatever your streams of sweetness bring us,
 shall be illustrated in these image-filled
 psalms,
 showing you joyful in my salvation, blessed
 Lord,
 as if a ravenous hunger had been relieved by a
 sumptuous feast,
 for you are glorified not because of some
 vain song of mine,
 but because you may accept these modest
 prayers
 as justification for granting your great salva-
 tion.

¶

A new book of psalms sings with urgency
 through me,
 for all thinking people the world over,
 expressing all human passions
 and serving with its images
 as an encyclopedic companion to our human
 condition,
 for the entire, mixed congregation of the
 Church universal,
 for the newborn who have just arrived,
 for adolescents in the second stage of life,
 for adults whose days are ripe and numbered,
 for the guilty and the just,
 for the brazenly haughty and the falsely
 modest,
 for the good and the evil,
 for cowardly and brave,
 for slaves and underlings,
 for nobles and clerics,
 for the middle class and princely,
 for artisans and the lords,
 for men and women,
 for commanders and servants,
 for high and low,
 for exalted and menial,
 for royalty and commoners,
 for knights and footmen,
 for city and country folk,
 for those brutally bridled by arrogant kings,²

²2 Kg. 19:28.

for those cloistered in heavenly contemplation,
 for sages with God-given wisdom,
 for priests, pious and chosen,
 for bishops, properly arrayed,
 for patriarchs, charged with pious supervision.

May this book of prayers
 I have undertaken to compose
 with the strength of the Holy Spirit
 and with a view to the multitudinous needs of
 all
 serve for some as heartfelt pleas of intercession
 and
 for others as counsel toward virtue
 that through this book they might constantly
 appear before you, Great Mercy.

¶

May you heal the souls and wash away the
 transgressions of those who read this
 book with pure hearts.
 Forgive their debts and free them from the
 bonds of sin.
 Release the flow of tears from those who study
 this book,
 and instill in them the desire to repent.
 And with them, Lord, grant me, contrition for
 my
 willfulness, and give them grace-filled inspira-
 tion
 through my voice.
 May their prayers, through this book, also be
 offered for me, and may their sighs rise like
 incense in place of mine.
 May your light enter and dwell in those
 who taste and embrace these mournful psalms.
 And if through me some pious readers dedicate
 themselves to you, receive me also, merciful
 Lord, with
 those who live for you.
 And if this book brings forth cleansing tears for
 our ills,
 may they also rain upon me, Keeper.
 And if those who share the passion for life con-
 tained in
 this book are enrolled in your heavenly king-
 dom and
 earn salvation, grant that by your will,



O blessed Lord, I might be in their number.
And if sighs pleasing to God should be evoked
through
this book, may the benefit overflow to me also,
exalted Lord.

If a pure hand lifts incense to you,
may my voice join with the sound and sighs of
prayers and reach you.

If others' petitions labor to be born with mine,
may mine, thus multiplied, be rededicated to
you.

If my offering of the words of my soul is pleas-
ing,

may they be offered to you with those who
have gone before.

If disheartened people falter in exhaustion,
may they regain their steadiness through these
sighs, setting their hope on you.

If the bulwark of their faith crumbles with sin,
may it be rebuilt with these writings shaped by
your protecting right hand.

If the thread of hope is severed by the sword of
transgressions, may it be restored by the good-
ness of
your almighty will.



If the perils of death besiege a person with
pain,
may redemption and hope of life be found
through
these words, victorious in you, O Life Giver,

If a confused heart is wounded by doubt,
may these words make it whole through your
sweetness.

If one is defeated by an irreparable loss,
or buried in the depths of an abyss,
may he come to the light under your watchful-
ness,
hooked by this invention.

If one is ensnared by drugs and their torpor,
and surrenders to dark tendencies,
let him be strengthened on your account, Sole
Refuge,
and find tranquility in you.

If deserted by the armor of faith,
may he be sustained through the hand of
your intercession,
and held in your steadfastness.

If one strays from the watchful eye of his
caretakers,
let him be watched over by these words until
their
return, Renewer.

If one is seized by the tremors of demonic
fevers,
awake his soul with the sign of the cross,
proclaiming and worshiping this miracle.

If a violent storm suddenly strikes
the vessel of the human body on
its voyage through this world,
steady its course with your rudder and
send it sailing back toward you.



And may you make this book of mournful
psalms
begun in your name, Most High,
into a life-giving salve for the sufferings of
body and soul.

May you perfect what I have started
and may your spirit be mixed with it.
May the breath of your great might
infuse these verses with grace
so that you may brace the wilting heart
and accept praise from us all.
Amen.

Prayer 4 (Გ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*



Since I have begun
these conversations with you
who holds in your hand
the life breath of my sinful soul,
I am shaken, and rightly so,



trembling in constant fear, remembering,
with unbearable terror that defies words,
O creator of heaven and earth,
your inescapable tribunal,
which justly judges me a sinner.
And what is more, there exists no remedy
for the multitude of incurable, mortal wounds
and the stinging bites inflicted by the deadly
fangs
of him who pursues my soul's destruction.
Especially since according to the Prophet,
there is no putting off the day of confrontation:¹

Not by words of justification,
not by a cloak of protection,
not by a mask of obfuscation,
not by speeches of propitiation,
not by appearances of deception,
not by compositions of prevarication,
not by swift feet of evasion,
not by aversion,
not by the ashen dust of abnegation,
not by fixing one's mouth to the earth,
not by self-burial in the depths of the earth,
for even the covered and the invisible are
readily seen by you.

¶

My virtue is dissipated and depleted,
my sins laid open and ever worsening,
my wrongs permanent and I am lost as
the weight of the right is ever decreasing
and the weight of wrong is increasing,
the harvest of goodness washes away
and the errors of my ways harden to stone.

The bail is lost even as the sentence is
sealed.
Death's mortgage is signed,
while the covenant of good news is voided.
The doer of good is despondent,
while the doer of evil is jubilant.
The host of angels grieve,
while Satan's horde dances in glee.
The army on high is orphaned,

¹Ec. 8:8.

while the army below is elated.
The murderer's bounty grows,
while the protector's treasure is plundered.
The third parties' rights are upheld,
and the true heir's legacy is betrayed.
The creator's gift is forgotten,
while the destroyer's ambush is remembered.
The Savior's grace is mocked,
while the tricks of Satan are celebrated.
The fountain of life runs dry,
while the tyrant's rust continues to corrode my
soul.

¶

And now, would it not be better.
as the prophecies foretold,²
never to have been conceived,
never to have taken shape,
never to have been born,
never to have seen the light of life,
never to have been counted among mortals,
never to have struggled toward the state of im-
mortality,
never to have been dressed in the image of
beauty,
never to have been armed with words,
than to be seized by such horrible sins,
too great for a hard rock to bear
let alone the frail body?

¶

And now, compassionate God,
I pray for your mercy,
as you instructed in your own words,
"Make offerings in the name of God's salvation
and you shall be made holy,
for I want contrition not sacrifice."³
Be exalted anew in remembrance of this offer-
ing in
incense,
for everything is in you, and everything is from
you.
To you glory from all.
Amen.

²Job ch. 3 passim; Jer. 20:14.

³Hos. 6:6, Mt. 9:13, 12:7, Ps. 51:16-17.

Prayer 5 (Ե)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

And now, I, earthbound
and preoccupied with the cares of everyday existence,
numbed by the deceitful wine of foolishness,¹
I, who lie in all things and am truthful in none,
marked with these faults,
how shall I come before your judgment, Just Judge,
terrible beyond words and telling, mighty God of all?
The more I compare my sinful ingratitude with your
loving-kindness,
the more I prove that your law is always stronger,
and my lawlessness, always defeated.

Բ

You made me in your glorious image,²
favoring a weak being like me
with your sublime likeness,
adorning me with speech,
and burnishing me with your breath,
enriching me with thought,
cultivating me with wisdom,
establishing me with ingenuity,³
setting me apart from the animals,
endowing my character with a thinking soul,
embellishing me with a sovereign individuality,
giving birth as a father, nurturing as a nurse,
caring for me as a guardian,
You sowed a wayward being in your courtyard,⁴
irrigated me with the water of life,⁵
cleansed me with the dew of the baptismal fount,

¹Ps. 60:3 (Arm. 59:5).

²Gen. 1:26-27.

³Ex. 31:3.

⁴Ps. 92:13 (Arm. 91:14).

⁵Jn. 7:38.

nourished me with heavenly bread,
quenched my thirst with your blood,
acquainted me with the impalpable and unreachable,
emboldened my earthly eyes to seek you,
embraced me in your glorious light,
permitted my unclean earthly hands to make offerings to you,
honored my base, mortal ashes,
like a flicker of light,
imprinted upon a worthless wretch like me
your father's image, awesome and blessed,
out of your love for mankind.

Գ

You did not scald my mouth for daring to call myself your co-heir,
did not reprimand me for arrogantly associating with you,
did not darken the sight of my eyes for gazing upon you,
did not exile me in shackles with those condemned to death,
did not break the wrist of my arm for improperly reaching to you,
did not crack the digits of my fingers for touching the word of life,⁶
did not engulf me with fog for dedicating this to you, fearsome Lord,⁷
did not crush the rows of my teeth for chewing your communion, infinite Lord,
did not turn in anger as I did with you, as with the stubborn house of Israel,
did not dishonor me at your wedding party,
I, who am unworthy of singing and dancing,
did not scold me for my disheveled clothes,
I, who am disorderly,
did not cast me into the dark, my hands and feet shackled.⁸

Դ

And I exchanged all these portions of goodness, patience and forgiveness from you,
O beneficent, blessed and always-tolerant God,

⁶1 Jn. 1:1.

⁷1 Kg. 8:10-12.

⁸Mt. 22:12-13.



for all manner of waywardness of the flesh and the ego,
for the wavering passions of the mind and the diversions of worldliness.
Yes, that is how, my God and Lord, I repaid you for
your abundant goodness.
Thus did I offer you evil in the manner of Moses' ingratitude.⁹
Abandoning wisdom and pursuing foolishness, thus did I foully dissipate the bounty of your favor with the ways of vanity,
thus in a storm of mindlessness did I lose the beacon of your ineffable grace glowing with your care,
God most high.

᠖

And although on many occasions you attempted
to draw me to you by reaching out your helping hand,
I rejected it, as the prophet accused Israel.¹⁰
And although I promised and made a covenant to please you,
I did not keep it,¹¹
but again perverted it into something evil.
Reverting to my old ways,
I sowed the field of my heart with thorns of sin for a harvest of dissension.
The words of the God-fearing holy prophet apply to me,
for you expected grapes but instead I sprouted thorns.
I became an unappetizing fruit of bitterness, outcast from the garden.
Swaying violently in unsteady winds, always blowing to and fro, I wavered.
Like the voice of blessed Job, I followed my path of no return.¹²
I built my house upon the sands in foolishness.¹³
Misled by the broad gate, I missed the

⁹Dt. 32:5-6.

¹⁰Jer. 6:8.

¹¹Ps. 78:10 (Arm. 77:10).

¹²Job 16:22.

¹³Mt. 7:26.

narrow gate to life.¹⁴

I closed myself off from the pilgrimage of exodus.

I spitefully uncovered the abyss of destruction.
I blocked my hearing against your teaching of life.

I covered the eyes of my soul against the cure of life.

I did not recoil from the wasting of the mind from torpor,

in spite of your trumpet of wrath.

I was not sobered by the reports of the fiery trial,

on the day of judgment.¹⁵

I did not awaken from the slumber of mortal sleep.

I did not give comfort to your Holy Spirit in my bodily tabernacle.

I did not inhale the allotment of grace you granted me.

With my own hand I wreaked havoc, in the words of the proverb teller,

killing my living soul.¹⁶

᠙

And what is the use of composing these meager and

paltry verses

in my state of remorse which passes all measure and evades all cure?

Now it is up to you to offer life to my dead soul and without vengeance to visit me,

a condemned prisoner,

O Son of the Living God, to you be all glory.

Amen.

Prayer 6 (᠙)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

᠒

What use, what good is it to me
to exhaust myself with this stream of words,

¹⁴Mt. 7:13.

¹⁵Mt. 24:31, Rev. 21:8.

¹⁶Wis. 1:15-16.



the voice of my sighing heart?
 Would it not be better to lance the accumulated
 words, like deadly pus,
 or with fingers in the throat, to vomit up the
 heaviness of my heart, weighed down with
 the wounds of my soul?

ⲡ

And since I was not found worthy of sharing
 in the glory of the saints with their blissful
 laughter and smiles, as described by the
 proverb teller¹
 and psalmist,² I shall be granted the second
 rank,
 the rank where people like me are assigned.
 But in view of the error of my ways,
 even they are superior to me just as the penitent
 is
 superior to the impenitent.
 Manasseh should be celebrated,
 when compared with the excess of my trans-
 gressions.³
 The Pharisee should be honored when com-
 pared with my foul baseness.⁴
 The Prodigal Son should be praised
 when compared to the betrayal of my vows.⁵
 The deceit of the Amasseh's son should be
 commended,
 when compared with my thankless ingrati-
 tude.⁶
 More blessed is the thief who was prosecutor
 of the faithless.⁷
 More honorable is the prostitute, the example
 and the mother of all repentant.⁸

ⲓ

No less than Pharaoh have I hardened my heart.
 No less blameworthy than the frenzied Israelite
 mob,
 have I rebelled against my creator.

¹Job 8:21.

²Ps. 149:5.

³2 Kg. 21:1-18, 2 Chr. 33:1-20.

⁴Lk. 18:11-14.

⁵Lk. 15:11,31.

⁶2 Chr. 26:16-19.

⁷Lk. 23:43.

⁸Lk. 7:35-50.

No less than the enemies of God have I
 taken the battlefield,
 and I did not refrain from denying the creator
 of
 all from nothing.
 I make waves like the turbulent sea during a
 storm,
 but I do not tremble, humbled by your
 severe commandment,
 like the waves of the sea against the shore.⁹
 My countless misdeeds are measured like
 mounds of sand.
 The boundless accumulation is less than the
 mass of my lawlessness.

ⲓ

For although small things mount up
 as sands on the shore,
 nevertheless, they are unique and distinct in
 their
 origin and increase,
 and like my transgressions, so countless that
 they are impossible to comprehend:
 one with its kith,
 the other with its kin,

 one with its defects,
 the other with its dangers,
 one with its thorns,
 the other with its roots,
 one with its stem,
 the other with its fruits,
 one with its limbs,
 the other with its branches,
 one with its shoots,
 the other with its joints,
 one with its claws,
 the other with its fingers,
 one with its shakiness,
 the other with its sturdiness,
 one with its causes,
 the other with its effects,
 one with its imprint,
 the other with its traces,
 one with its shadow,
 the other with its darkness,

⁹Job 38:11, Ps. 104 (Arm. 103):6-9.



one with its tactics,
 the other with its strategy,
 one with its guile,
 the other with its intent,
 one with its trajectory,
 the other with its size,
 one with its depth,
 the other with its baseness,
 one with its spark,
 the other with its passion,
 one with its goods,
 the other with its treasures,
 one with its pipes,
 the other with its fountain,
 one with its torrents,
 the other with its lightening,
 one with its flames,
 the other with its shame,
 one with its pits,
 the other with its abysses,
 one with its embers,
 the other with its dullness,
 one with its thunder,
 the other with its raindrops,
 one with its currents,
 the other with its floods and frost,
 one with its gates,
 the other with its roadways,
 the furnace and its heat,
 the fire and its fumes,
 the melting tallow and its scent,
 the wormwood tree and its bitter sap,
 the destroyer and its victim,
 the thief and his assassins,
 the bully and his accomplices,
 the master and his servants,
 the beast and its whelps,
 the biter and the bitten,
 the corrupter and its imitator.

G

And these are but the main categories
 of the soul's common afflictions.
 They are further divided into smaller classes,
 each of which has thousands upon
 thousands of subclasses,
 but the total number can be comprehended
 only by the one who sees as done

that which is scripted in us.¹⁰

If a person does not indulge in self-deception
nor

put on a mask,

and is not tricked by lack of faith,

but has self-knowledge,

and senses our common human nature,

and is cognizant of being earth born and knows
our proper place and limitations,

then he shall understand this list of attributes,

not as some meaningless scribble,

nor as a complete description of even the essen-
tial types and kinds of imperfections whirling
in our nature.

Rather, he will know that I have identified cer-
tain seeds of the thousands of evils,

and even if through these he learns of others,

he realizes that even these categories are not
enough.

Prayer 7 (E)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

So that I will not give up hope of salvation,
 and, laying down my arms, surrender to so
many

invisible attackers,

which are nothing other than the tribe of foes,

springing up, of their own, in the categories

just described,

in numbers and forms that are terrifying,

I shall show here as against these warriors,

the mightiest of godly champions,

most victorious and undefeated,

which at the same time are summoned by a

most painful grief,

like a difficult-to-swallow fruit of an unreach-
able tree,

or the toil and hardship of an untrodden path.

For a small teardrop from the eye

can cause an entire evil platoon of the
Tempter's

¹⁰Rom. 8:29-30, 2 Cor. 3:2-3.



army to shrink away,
 like the squirming of centipedes or earth-
 worms,
 drowning in a puddle of oil or a drop of
 some lethal potion.
 And the faint groan of a sighing heart,
 rising from the soul,
 is like a warm southerly breeze, mixed with
 sun,
 that melts the fiercest blizzard,
 for like storms, they are easily born and when
 opposed, quickly die.

¶

But I shall never stop judging my condemned
 self with anguished words,
 or reproaching myself for my sins,
 like a wicked, irredeemable and incorrigible
 being.
 For although I have slain some of my tormen-
 tors,
 I helped others to live and lost my soul.
 Like a plant with bitter branches,
 I have blossomed with the odor of wrongful
 ways,
 with corrupting and fatal fruit,
 which I have made into the wine of destruction.
 The offspring of Canaan and not Judah,
 in the words of the great prophet Daniel.¹
 I am
 the child of hell and not paradise,²
 the heir of Hades, not of coveted glory,
 the stuff of torment, not of rest,
 ungrateful rather than grateful,
 disgraceful rather than graced,
 ever sinful rather than forbearing,
 one who embitters the sweetness of your
 beneficence,
 an evil and bad servant like the one who
 was reprimanded by our Lord,³
 one who, as the Prophet Isaiah said,
 uses my learning for evil.⁴

I am

¹Dan. 13:56.

²Mt. 23:15.

³Mt. 25:26.

⁴Is. 5:18-21.

diligent in the baseness of corruption,
 conscientious in angering the Lord,
 ever active in satanic ventures,
 a daily cause of grief to my Maker,
 weak in my flight toward goodness,
 lazy in the blessing of fidelity,
 slow in observing my promises,
 fainthearted in the necessary and useful,
 an unfaithful and ungrateful servant.

¶

Woe to my sinful soul, for I have angered my
 creator.
 Woe to this son of perdition,⁵
 for I have forgotten the gift of life.
 Woe to this debtor of untold thousands of
 talents,
 for I haven't the means to repay.⁶
 Woe to this porter heavy laden with vile sins,
 for I cannot lay down my burden to rest.
 Woe to this debtor of the Lord,
 for I cannot face the Almighty.
 Woe to this heap of dried up reeds,
 for I am consumed in Gehenna.⁷
 Woe to me as I remember that the arrows of
 the
 wrath of God are fitted with flames.⁸
 Woe for my stupidity, for I did not
 recall that the hidden shall be revealed.⁹
 Woe for my impiety, for I always and
 ceaselessly wove the web of evil.
 Woe to my well-fed body
 which shall be food for the immortal worms,¹⁰
 for how shall I endure their fierce venom?
 Woe to me for having drunk of the cup of
 death,
 for how shall I suffer eternity?
 Woe to me for raising this unworthy soul from
 this corrupt body,
 for how shall I face my judge?
 Woe to me for the lack of oil in my lamp,
 for its darkness shall not be relit.

⁵Jn. 17:12.

⁶Mt. 18:23-34.

⁷Is. 5:24.

⁸Ps. 7:14.

⁹Mt. 10:26.

¹⁰Is. 66:24, Mk. 9:48.



Woe to me for the sudden alarm of the
fear of dismay
when the door of the marriage feast is closed.
And woe to me for the terror of the voice of
these words,
trembling and quaking, before the pronouncement
of our heavenly king's judgment:
"I do not know you."¹¹

Prayer 8 (Ⲙ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ⲙ

And now, what will you do, my lost soul?
Where will you hide?
How will you live?
And how can you escape the prison of your
sin?
Your transgressions are many and your
punishments countless.
The scoldings severe and the harsh words
endless.
Even the angels have lost patience and the
judge cannot be bribed.¹
The court is mighty and the tribunal just.
The vengeance is terrible and the retribution,
merciless.
The sentence terrifying and the condemnation,
direct.
The rivers fiery and the streams impassable.
The darkness is thick and the fog impenetrable.
The pit is vile and the torment eternal.²
Hell is all-encompassing and the blizzard
unrelenting.
Now, indeed you have piled up all these bitter
things,
a depraved and terrible cell of unbearable
punishment,
O my worthless sinful soul, evildoer, prostitute,

¹¹Mt. 25:1-12.

¹Is. 5:23.

²Ps. 55(54):24.

soiled, a refuse dump of filth.

Here then are the wages of your handi-
work:³
You have turned from the straight path and
strayed from holiness.
You have been outcast from the ranks of the
righteous and honest.
You lack spiritual gifts and riches of our
most jealous benefactor and almighty king.

ⲡ

You have ensnared yourself in an inescapable
prison,
by confessing that your wounds are incurable
and your punishment unequaled and
testifying that your soul is condemned to
death and incurably broken.
You are
evil among the good,
bitter among the sweet,
dark among the light,
bruised among the adorned,
rejected among the praised,
impious among the pious,
brute among the thoughtful,
stupid among the intelligent,
foolish among the wise,
unclean among the elect,
dead among the living,
filthy among the saints,
drunken among the sober,
deceptive among the just,
useless among the useful,
dishonored among the glorious,
deficient among the abundant,
underling among the superiors,
most lowly among the sublime,
poor among the wealthy,
unworthy among the saved,
homeless among the rich in spirit,
cast away among the blessed.

³Is. 3:10-11.

Prayer 9 (Θ-)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

And now, O wretched soul of mine,
what appropriately revolting words shall
I use to describe you
in this book of woes, my testament of prayers?
You who are so completely discredited that
I am at a loss for words to answer,
unworthy to communicate with God and the
saints.
If I were to fill the basin of the sea with ink,
and to measure out parchment the length and
breadth of a field of many leagues
and were to take all the reeds of the forests and
woods and turn them into pens,
I still would not be able to record even a frac-
tion of my accumulated wrong doings.
If I were to set the Cedars of Lebanon as a scale
and to put Mount Ararat on one side and my
iniquities on the other,
it would not come close to balancing.

P

I am like a tree, towering with branches,
covered with leaves, but barren of fruit,
a true member of the same species as that fig
tree that the Lord struck dry.¹
For although covered with lush flowing hair,
that is,
with an attractive exterior,
as if adorned with a halo,
mesmerizing like a drumbeat at a distance,
if the sower were to come close to pick the
harvest,
he would find me devoid of any goods
and revolting without beauty,
an object of ridicule for viewers and a specta-
cle
for the malicious.

For the bushy plant without fruit and spirit is
but a metaphor for the hapless, unprepared

¹Mk. 11:12-14, 20-21, Mt. 21:18-20.

soul
cursed at an unvigilant moment.
If the earth, moistened with dew,
cultivated by the farmer,
does not produce crops to multiply this effort,
it is abandoned and forgotten.²
Then, you, my miserable soul,
a thinking, breathing plant
that has not given timely fruit,
shall you not suffer the same fate as those in
the parable?
For you have indulged with unsparing excess
in the harvest of all the human evils
from Adam till the end of the species, and even
found some new ones,
despised and repugnant to your creator, God.

Q

And I have fixed my mind's eye upon you,
O worthless soul of mine,
sculpting a monument in words.
I cast stones at you mercilessly like some
untamed wild beast.
For although I may never chance to be called
just,
still following the counsel of the wise,³
as my first rebuttal, I criticize myself of my
own free will,
as if criticizing some bitter enemy,
and having confessed the angst of the
secrets of my mind, that is, the accumulated
burden
of my evil deeds,
I spread them before you, my God and Lord.
With what measure I mete out reprimand to my
soul,⁴
let your undiminishing compassion be mea-
sured for me,
that I might receive your abundant grace
many times greater than the magnitude of my
sins,
though my wounds and injuries overpower me,
incurable and inescapable,
yet the genius of your curative art, exalted and
honored Physician, shines twice as brightly.

²Heb. 6:7-8.

³Pr. 28:13.

⁴Mt. 7:2, Lk. 6:38



The increase of my sins is more than matched
by
your generosity, my benefactor.
Blessed Lord, may you always be wreathed
in incense as in your parable.⁵

¶

For yours is salvation,
and from you is redemption,
and by your right hand is restoration,
and your finger is fortification.
Your command is justification.
Your mercy is liberation.
Your countenance is illumination.
Your face is exultation.
Your spirit is benefaction.
Your anointing oil is consolation.
A dew drop of your grace is exhilaration.
You give comfort.
You make us forget despair.
You lift away the gloom of grief.
You change the sighs of our heart into laughter.
To you is fitting blessing with praise
in heaven and on earth
from our forefathers and unto all their genera-
tions
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 10 (✠)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

Both unruly sin and deep regret
plunge us into damnation, being
essentially similar even though from different
sources.
But when compared they share the same char-
acter flaws:
one doubts the strength of the Almighty's
hand like a cowardly skeptic,¹
while the other, like a wild beast,

⁵Lk. 7:42.

¹2 Sam. 15:12.

brutally cuts the thread of hope.²
Satan, flattered by the first,
constantly rejoices; while the second
provides fresh blood for the hounds of hell to
lap up.

¶

I catch my breath like one bludgeoned with a
thick club,
until he reaches death's shores. I catch
my breath, mustering whatever life remains
hoping that my soul will be rehabilitated, pro-
tected,
restored, and resurrected from mortal perdition
with the help of Christ's hand,
Christ who is merciful in all things.
And with help from our heavenly Father,
who has granted salvation and healing
to a failing sinner near death,
I begin this book of prayers with supplications.
I will build an edifice of faith,
as one of our faith-filled forefathers did
when he was instantly transported to heaven
through the balm of repentance,³
thus bequeathing us the promise of immortality
on earth,
perhaps more so than the Apostle writing about
those
who, enduring their trials on earth,
put their faith in heaven and the hope of things
to come,
and were filled with the abundance of the un-
seen.⁴

¶

For even he who has committed mortal sin,
even he, recaptured in the evil spirit's prison
and cast down into the abyss of evil,
even he still can grasp the slender hope of sal-
vation.
Even he has hope of escape through redemp-
tion,
like the remorseful sinner miraculously re-
claimed

²Acts 8:9-24.

³Gen. 5:24 (Enoch), Heb. 11:5.

⁴Heb. 11:1.



through the raindrops of his eyes
 caused by the compassion of the Almighty,
 the Almighty who again made the earth flourish,
 as a gift from the Spirit of God.
 Let us remember also the healing and encouraging words of our Lord,
 “With faith, anything is possible.”⁵
 First and foremost let us consider this the measure
 of what is good and favored in the eyes of God;
 for the way to the holy of holies is through faith.
 Without faith, the Lord of glory did not, will not
 show his miraculous power to us, asking first
 that his good work be met by our faith.
 For this reason he who is with God
 is, of his own, capable of receiving life,
 for the blessed mouth of God has promised,
 “Your faith shall save you.”⁶



Faith, that happy and favored word,
 which lasts forever untarnished and unbounded,
 honored together with charity and hope⁷
 brings the rewards of truly clear vision, perfect wisdom,
 acquaintance with God and familiarity with the Exalted.

For if the faith of a mustard seed⁸
 can cast a great mountain
 into the depths of the sea, then truly
 we should accept it as the first step
 toward eternal life.
 Faith, this simple and clear form of worship,
 means setting aside doubt to see the future and hidden
 with the eye of the soul.

Faith is honored in a glorious trinity
 with charity and hope. For if you view

⁵Mk. 9:23.

⁶Mt. 9:22, Lk. 7:50, 8:48.

⁷1 Cor. 13:13.

⁸Lk. 17:6, Mk. 11:23.

these three as distinct aspects
 of one and the same mystery,
 you shall forever be magnified in God.
 And if you believe, you shall love
 and through love have hope in his unseen rewards.
 Glory to him forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 11 (ԺԱ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart



And now, I, the most laggard of believers,
 devoid of goodness, contemplate with my
 mind's eye
 all creation out of nothing by the hand of our
 maker.
 And with hope, my faith grows
 that Jesus Christ can do anything he wills,
 as Paul advised¹ and David taught.²
 As I believe, so have I spoken.
 May their prayers take life in me
 so that through faith I might know him and the
 power
 of his resurrection. And that I may,
 in the words of the Apostle, share in
 his torment³ and the glory that followed.
 For true faith attends and resembles
 the transformation of renewal,
 from sin to atonement,
 from wrongdoing to righteousness,
 from uncleanness to holiness,
 from unforgivable mortal transgressions
 to blameless bliss,
 from earthly bondage to heavenly freedom.



For what is more wondrous
 than the sinner laughing for all to see,
 yet secretly weeping, when his heart
 with the help of God is purged

¹2 Cor. 45:13.

²Ps. 114.

³Phil. 3:10 - 11.



of the thick darkness of doubt?
 And though cast from the highest summit
 into the pit of the perdition,
 and weighed down by unforgivable sins,
 never before conceived,
 he grabs the life-giving wafer of salvation,
 clinging as to the last glimmer of light
 preserved in mind and soul.⁴
 Or like the amazingly intense fire, kindled
 at the bottom of the sleeping well,
 by the Almighty's command, the sinner,
 consumed with grief,
 all expectation of goodness abandoned,
 all assurance of grace lost,
 can but hope to regain
 the blessed innocence of the new-born.
 This spark of hope, which God keeps alive
 for broken, contrite hearts,⁵
 souls laid low, whose offerings are
 sweeter to God than the finest of incense,⁶
 for they proclaim the good tidings
 of the Giver's almighty power.
 It was for this reason the Savior asks
 the blind, "Do you believe I can do this
 for you?"⁷ thus obtaining a token of faith
 before restoring light to their eyes.
 And what hope of revival seems more remote,
 than for a corpse four days dead?⁸
 Yet, armed with faith the women of his family,
 fell at the feet of the creator, and they saw
 the manifestation of God's glory when their
 brother was resurrected.



And there is proof that even after sin
 the grace of God persists: First there is
 the case of Enoch,⁹ then Aaron,¹⁰
 then David¹¹ and next Peter.¹² And Eliezer,¹³
 the younger, upon whom God took great pity

⁴2 Macc. 1:19-20.

⁵Ps. 51:17.

⁶Ex. 30:7-8; 25-26.

⁷Mt. 9:28.

⁸Jn. 11:39, 43-44.

⁹Gen. 5:24, Heb. 11:5, Sir. 44:15.

¹⁰Ex. 32:1-6.

¹¹2 Sam. 12:1-16.

¹²Mt. 26:75.

¹³Ex. 18:4 (Moses' youngest son).

that he might be an example to his elders.
 And it is unnecessary to add the example of
 the Prodigal Son,¹⁴
 the prostitute praised by the Lord,¹⁵
 the tax collector remembered for his good
 deed,¹⁶
 the lucky thief, who, with his last breath,
 earned a halo through faith.¹⁷
 Or even those whose sins cannot be atoned for,
 such as those who took part in killing our cre-
 ator,¹⁸
 or Paul, foremost of the chosen,
 who was formerly the chief of the unjust.¹⁹
 And there are others who stumbled,
 even knowing the law,
 but then raised themselves up ten thousand
 times higher
 than those who lived under the law. And what
 of him
 who, before the law was given,²⁰
 honored the traditions of his fathers,
 remaining more faithful to the commandment
 of
 his forefather
 and taking the guilt of man's original sin upon
 himself,
 paid for it with the torment of mortal passions,
 atoned for it, not by burial in earth,
 but through the torments of the body,
 was transfigured, miraculously triumphing
 over death's grip to become the herald
 of the possibility of eternal life for us mor-
 tals.²¹



And consider those who chose a dissolute life
 from a tender age and in the fullness of time
 did not tumble from their high stations but
 rather
 were raised from their squalid lives
 into the vault of heaven.

¹⁴Lk. 15:11-32.

¹⁵Lk. 7:36-50.

¹⁶Lk. 18:9-14.

¹⁷Lk. 23:39-43.

¹⁸Lk. 23:43.

¹⁹Acts 8:1.

²⁰Abraham

²¹Enoch



In times past the wayward
changed their ways by their own efforts,
turning earthen vessels into gold and
etching a princely image of our heavenly model
in majestic, imperishable and irreplaceable re-
lief.

Triumphing over the betrayals toward which
our nature inclines us, they give us more cause
for hope,
especially now that the Light has been re-
vealed.

Its veil lifted, its curtain drawn,
by the promise of our Lord Christ
by whom the divine word is fixed firmly
in us, and who is according to the voice
of the prophet,²² “The covenant of peace and
the seal of constancy,”
the mediator of our reconciliation,
our heavenly advocate, immortal, living and
eternal.

And therefore by this most true law,
and the immutable terms set by the creator,
I kiss the image of the Word with lips of faith
and await the glory of grace,
For verily, in the words of the Apostle,
“If God absolves us, no one retains
the power to condemn.”²³

ⲧ

And taking refuge in this unclouded assurance,
I who was broken, am restored,
who was wretched, am triumphant,
who was dissipated, am healed,
who was desperately outlawed, find hope,
who was condemned to death, find life,
who was mortgaged by damnable deeds, find
the light,
who was debauched by animal pleasures, find
heaven,
who was twice caught in scandal, again find
salvation,
who was bound by sin, find the promise of
rest,
who was shaken by incurable wounds,
find the salve of immortality,
who was wildly rebellious, find the reins of

tranquility,
who was a renegade, find calling,
who was brazenly self-willed, find humility,
who was quarrelsome, find forgiveness.

Therefore, to Jesus Christ
and his almighty and awe-inspiring Father,
to the name and the will of
the beneficence of the true Holy Spirit,
the blessed essence and one Godhead,
all power and dominion, majesty and glory
forever.
Amen.

Prayer 12 (Ⲫⲉ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ⲙ

Although I have let myself fall
into seemingly eternal despair,
beating myself with the rod of doubt,
let me now dare with the slightest hope
to call upon the Holy Trinity to help me, a sin-
ner.

For upon blessing and acknowledging
the life-giving God of all, and calling out to
him

as to a family member,
it becomes possible for the benefactor
who grants all grace, to grant life
to me, a mortal, as the Prophet foretold,
“Whoever calls out the name of the Lord shall
live.”¹

ⲡ

Not only do I call, but I believe in the Lord’s
greatness.

I pray not only for his rewards but also for him-
self,

the essence of life, guarantor of giving and
taking of breath

without whom there is no movement, no
progress,

²²Is. 54:10.

²³Rom. 8:33-34.

¹Jl. 2:32, Rom. 10:13.



to whom I am tied not so much by the knot of
hope
as by the bonds of love.
I long not so much for the gifts
as for the giver.
I yearn not so much for the glory
as the glorified.
I burn not so much with the desire for life
as in memory of the giver of life.
I sigh not so much with the rapture of splendor
as with the heartfelt fervor for its maker.
I seek not so much for rest
as for the face of our comforter.
I pine not so much for the bridal feast
as for the distress of the groom,
through whose strength I wait with certain
expectation believing with unwavering hope
that in spite of the weight of my transgressions
I shall be saved by the Lord's mighty hand and
that I will not only receive remission of sins
but that I will see the Lord himself
in his mercy and compassion
and receive the legacy of heaven
although I richly deserve to be disowned.



Now for my many humiliations
my head bowed in shame
my lips locked with embarrassment
my tongue not daring to move
I resort again to intoning supplications,
mournful sobs and cries, offered on high.

Accept with sweetness almighty Lord my
bitter prayers.
Look with pity upon my mournful face.
Dispel, all-bestowing God, my shameful
sadness.
Lift, merciful God, my unbearable burden.
Cast off, potent God, my mortal habits.
Spoil, triumphant God, my wayward pleasures.
Dissipate, exalted God, my wanton fog.
Block, life-giving God, my destructive ways.
Undo, secret-seeing God, my evil entrapments.
Fend off, inscrutable God, my assailants.
Inscribe your name on the skylight of my
abode.
Cover the roof of my temple with your hand.

Mark the threshold of my cell with your blood.
Imprint the outside of my door with your sign.
Protect the mat where I rest with your right
hand.
Keep my cot pure from all seductions.
Preserve my suffering soul by your will.
Steady the breath of life you have given my
flesh.
Surround me with your heavenly host.
Post them on watch against the battalion of
demons.



Grant blissful rest
like the slumber of death
in the depth of this night
through the intercession of the Holy Mother of
God and the elect.
Firmly close the windows of sight,
sentient faculty of the mind,
with impregnable fortifications
against the waves of anxiety,
the cares of daily life,
nightmares, frenzy, hallucinations,
and protected by the memory of your hope
to wake again from the heaviness of sleep
into alert wakefulness and
soul-renewing cheerfulness
to stand before you
raising my prayerful voice
in harmony with the heavenly choirs of praise
with the fragrance of faith,
to you in heaven, all blessed king,
whose glory is beyond telling.
For you are glorified by all creation
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 13 (✠✠)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*



Beneficent, almighty, awe-inspiring God,
good Father, charitable donor of mercy,
whose very name heralds the good news of



your grandeur, compassion and fatherly affection,
you are gentle even toward the bitter and discontented.

With you also is your Son, who is like you,
whose hand is strong like yours,
whose awesome reign is eternal like yours,
whose exaltation is shared with you in your creation.

So too the Holy Spirit of your truth,
that flows from you without end,
the perfect essence of existence
and eternal being, is equal to you
in all things, reigning with the Son
in equal glory.

Three persons, one mystery,
separate faces, unique and distinct,
made one by their congruence
and being of the same holy substance and nature,
unconfused and undivided,
one in will and one in action.
One is not greater, one is not lesser,
not even by an eyelash, and because
of the unobscurable light of heavenly love
revealed in our midst both have been
glorified with a single crown of holiness
from before the ages.

¶

For verily, as Peter's open profession of
faith in the Trinity earned for him
the blessed name, Rock, so
in expectation of your clemency,
do I, a sinner condemned, await exoneration,
O deliverer of captives.
And though all rewards may be yours,
so too is all mercy,
but you are not so acclaimed for rewards as for
mercy,
for while the first brings glory, the second
merely
recognizes the effort of labor,
since rewards are compensation for merit,
but mercy is an act of generosity toward the un-

worthy.

¶

And now, God of compassion, may human
deeds
not prevail over your grace, even if they
transgress
the laws of nature, but rather may your forbearance
triumph so that your ways may never be less
than those of mortals.
For when your light came to herald the new
covenant,
those, like the Jews who prided themselves
in keeping the law, were abandoned to greater
heartache
and became more needy of your charity,
than those wretched persons,
forever lost in the wilderness.
Since everything is possible for you, O benevolent God,
hear my sighs of supplication to you.
Have mercy, save us, and be generous.
For yours is forbearance, gentleness, salvation,
atonement and glory for all time, to all peoples.
Amen.

Prayer 14 (ԺԴ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

I pray to you, ray of light,
heavenly king, praised beyond telling,
Son of God, majestic beyond words,
incline your ear once again,
exalted compassion, refuge of life,
toward the feeble sobs of this
wounded soul.

¶

Nowhere is it shown,
nowhere can we read that the traveler
all but slain by the swords of bandits,¹

¹Lk. 10:30-35.



cried out to you in his distress,
 for he had grown stiff from his wounds.
 Nor did he utter a single plea
 for he was struck dumb.
 Nor did he point out his serious plight
 with trembling fingers, O Seer, for
 he was shattered. Nor did he fix eyes
 filled with tears upon you, doer of good,
 for he was ashamed. Nor did he try to
 gain your favor through messengers
 for he was disconsolate.
 Nor did he try to rend your heart,
 compassionate one, by showing
 his blood soaked clothes and beaten body,
 for he had lost hope. Nor did he crawl
 upon his knees, since he could not stand and
 walk
 for his dead half said to the living half,
 death is at hand.
 All the more since, after receiving your coun-
 sel,
 benefiting from your forbearance and
 basking in the radiance of your glory,
 he nevertheless did not forswear his wicked
 ways
 but in stiff-necked revolt,
 joined the ranks of your enemies
 allying himself with those who hate you.²

¶

But you, generous, kind, unspiteful, giver of
 life,
 not only did you not record his sins
 but you did not even scold him,
 you did not kick him, but rather approached
 him in sympathy and treated him with care.
 Unlike the priest's custom in Aaron's
 weak law, hurling aspersions and fistfuls of
 stones
 to speed death,³ you were in no rush
 to crush a wounded man.
 And unlike the Levite, our early predecessor,
 who was the end of the old and the start of the
 new,
 caught between the two, in soulless limbo,
 you saw the plight

²Lk. 10:30, Is. 2:3.

³2 Cor. 3:7, 9.

of the wounded man and did not aim
 the deadly axe at the root of life,⁴
 frightening him to death at what is to come
 by appearing as the minister of death.
 But rather like the Assyrian pagans
 known as the promise keepers,⁵ who received
 the law from the Jews
 and kept it in tact, even when Jews
 had forgotten it, you donned
 the mortal cloak of our body to proclaim your
 good tidings of deliverance to all peoples.
 And by the work of your incorruptible divinity,
 you extended your hand to raise
 the man condemned to death by his mortal
 sins,
 raising him along with all his generations.⁶

You brought joy to the gloomy heart.
 You steadied the fainting soul.
 You restored happiness to the despondent
 spirit.
 You filled his emptiness with the anointing
 of the life-giving baptismal font
 and the cup of light.
 You renewed him through regenerative,
 heavenly bread, your body.
 Through the watchful company of the happy
 elect, you cared, cured, and comforted him.
 With a mare's gentle gait you transported him⁷
 unharmed until his deliverance to the abode of
 light.
 You cured him through two
 intercessors, the life-giving testaments,
 old and new, given out of your love
 for humanity. And as it was once with Moses,
 like an eagle with outspread wings, you
 snatched⁸
 him midair and deposited him in calm safety,
 in the land of happiness, ordering
 his doctors to nurture him with
 the sustenance of your word.

¶

⁴Mt. 3:10 - 11.

⁵1 Kg. 16:24.

⁶Rom. 5:15-18.

⁷Gen. 33:14.

⁸Dt. 32:11.



And now, you who have miraculously endowed
all things with the supreme light of your good-
ness,
gathering as your own, the scattered treasures
and re-establishing your inheritance,
redeem me also, wiping out the debt of my sins.
You, who minister without charge to the un-
worthy,
grant me also atonement and healing,
O compassionate, mighty, inscrutable, incor-
ruptible
and awesome, eternally blessed one,
unto the ages of ages.
Amen.

Prayer 15 (ԺԵ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Now again with the same sighs
from my distressed heart
pouring out the same wordy strains,
I seek your mercy, bestower of all gifts,
and with my soul immersed in torment ¹
like the dead, I pray to you
living, immortal God, confessing
before your honor, my disgrace,
before your goodness, my evil.
I am more devastated than cured,
more embarrassed than emboldened,
having broken my vows and forsaken
the trust reposed in me.

I am like the pathetic sheep in the second
parable,²
which strayed into inaccessible hills
and wandered in a daze among beastly
demons³
and fierce idols, without the slightest chance of
returning to the fold. Although my tongue was
lost
for words to tell my anguish, and my hands

¹ 1 Tim. 5:6.

² Lk. 15:4-7.

³ Ps. 48:15.

lacked the agility to communicate like the
mute,
still you found me, you who alone
are praised from beginning to end
throughout the generations.

You found me, a sinner, lost in darkness
crying like the psalmist in prayer,⁴
and because of your willing care
you were called Shepherd, for not only
did you care, but you sought,⁵
not only did you find, O worker of miracles,
but with the goodness of your love,
a love that defies description,
you rescued me,
lifting me upon your shoulders,
to set down alongside your heavenly army,
the heirs to your fatherly legacy.

Բ

And now, mighty savior,
blessed visitor, compassionate comforter,
you, who heard the unspoken supplication
of one suffering in silence at death's door,
and of another who wandered into
the wilderness, helpless, lost,
unable to speak, bleating inarticulately,
you, who in your divine providence that
graces the universe,
cared for those lost or in peril, now
show again your compassion and the bounty
of your kindness to me whose iniquity
exceeds everything told above,
whose mortal sins come in all varieties,
whose flavor is that of evil among the
sweet taste of goodness,
whose body deserves to be broken to the last
bone,
whose wounded soul is infected with
all manner of vile ills,
whose stupor is on a level with the speechless
beasts,⁶
whose alienation has removed him from intel-
ligent life,
whose nature no longer resembles that of his

⁴ Ezek. 34: 11-12.

⁵ Jn. 10:11

⁶ Ps. 48:13.



species.

If there were an example, I would cite it.

If there were others like me, I would describe them.

If there were a category, I would name it.

If there were my equal, I would note it.

If there were a parallel, I would mark it.

If there were a model, I would show it.

If there were a precedent, I would use it.

If there were a present example, I could take heart.

But since mine surpasses all measure and defies all categories, you are my only hope of

atonement, healing and salvation, redeemer of all mortals, renewer of the universe.

¶

For if in the view of blessed David's pure heart, his lawlessness was piled over his head, his transgressions outweighed the heaviest burdens, then my wrongs are even greater than all the waters of seas in torrential flood, inundating and submerging the mountains.

Release but a breath of your kindness⁷ as in Noah's day, a breath that can melt mountains,

and the stormy flood of my billowing misdeeds will evaporate along with my earth-shattering transgressions and my mountain-high sins.

¶

Now with your sharp and mighty word and the unbounded discretion of your swift judgment,

give me a way to redeem myself, even as the Prophet

promised, even in my advanced stage of lawlessness.⁸

And forgiving my stubborn defiance, O long-suffering, merciful, blessed one, be truly generous and forgive me all at once, wiping out my unrepayable debts

⁷1 Kg. 19:11.

⁸Is. 5:18.

and the crushing interest which has accrued, for you have no wrath in your heart, nor vexation,

nor deceit, nor traces of darkness,

for you wish only life and light.

And as David and Solomon attest,⁹

you did not make death or take joy in human misery.

¶

In your just laws, you set as a key rule that one wrong should not be returned for another,¹⁰

but that we should forgive seventy times seven¹¹

the sins committed against us each and every day.

You addressed this to us, wicked by nature, the germs of sin sprouting in tens of thousands upon the fertile field of our thorny natures.

As you so rightly witnessed, "The human mind from childhood is inclined toward evil."¹²

Even John, the Evangelist of your word of life, who was exceedingly pure, nevertheless shared our common nature and said frankly in contrast to my roundabout manner of speech,

"If we say that we have no sin, we make him a liar."¹³

And now, your prophetic word is fulfilled and borne out beyond question by my iniquities.

So deliver me with your mercy,

O fount of lovingkindness,

who alone are blessed through all eternity.

Amen.

Prayer 16 (♠2)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

⁹Ps. 29:6, Wis. 1:13.

¹⁰Rom. 12:17.

¹¹Mt. 18:22.

¹²Gen. 8:21.

¹³1 Jn. 1:10.



U

Yours alone, God, in heaven, exalted and generous,
yours is the power, and yours, forgiveness.
Yours is healing and yours, abundance.
Yours are the gifts and yours alone grace.
Yours atonement and yours protection.
Yours is creation beyond knowing.
Yours are arts beyond discovery.
Yours are bounds beyond measure.
You are the beginning and you are the end.
Since the light of your mercy is never obscured
by the darkness of indignity,
you are not subject to disease in any form.
You are too lofty for words, an image beyond
framing,
whose being is immeasurable,
the breadth of whose glory is unbounded,
the reach of whose incisive power is indescribable,
the supremacy of whose absoluteness is uncontainable,
the compassion of whose good works is unflagging.

You turned, according to the Prophet,¹
the shadow of death into dawn.
You willingly descended into Tartaros,
the prison of those detained below,
where even the door of prayer was sealed
to free the captive and damned souls
with the commanding sword of
your victorious word.

You cut the bindings of wretched death
and dispelled the suspicion of sin.²
Turn toward me, trembling in the confines
of my squalid cell,³ fettered by sin,
mortally wounded by the Troublemaker's
arrows.

P

Remember me, Lord of all, benefactor,
light in the darkness, treasure of blessing,

¹Am. 5:8.

²Zech. 9:11.

³Jer. 38:6.

merciful, compassionate, kind, mighty,
powerful beyond telling, understanding, or
words,
equal to all crises, you who are, in the words
of Jacob, always ready to do the impossible.⁴
O fire that clears away sin's underbrush,
blazing ray that illumines every
great mystery, remember me, blessed one,⁵
with mercy rather than legalisms,
with forbearance rather than vengeance,
with lenience rather than evidence,
so that you weigh my sins with your kindness
and not with judgment.
For by the first, my burden is light,
but by the second, I am damned forever.

Q

Now, cure me, O kindness,
even as you did the ear of the one
who attacked you.⁶
Take away the whipping winds of death
from this sinner, so that the calm of
your almighty spirit might rest in me.
Unto you all glory, now and forever.
Amen.

Prayer 17 (ԺԷ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Now, tormented by bitter grief I pray
to you, keeper of imperiled souls.
Do not add to the pain of my sighs.
Do not wound me. I am already injured.
Do not condemn me. I am already punished.
Do not torture me. I am already tormented.
Do not cudgel me. I am already beaten.
Do not push me. I have already fallen.
Do not destroy me. I am already discredited.
Do not reject me. I am already banished.
Do not exile me. I am already persecuted.
Do not embarrass me. I am already humbled.

⁴Gen. 35:1.

⁵Heb. 4:12, Wis. 24:25.

⁶Lk. 22:51.



Do not scold me. I am already cowering.
 Do not crush me. I am already broken.
 Do not upset me. I am already agitated.
 Do not shake me. I am already quivering.
 Do not confuse me. I am already bewildered.
 Do not flay me. I am already picked over.
 Do not pound me. I am already crushed.
 Do not taint me. I am already debased.
 Do not blind me. I am already in the dark.
 Do not frighten me. I am already perplexed.
 Do not roast me. I am already charred.
 Do not kill me. I am already dying.
 Do not overload me. I am already weakened.
 Do not yoke me. I am already bent over.
 Do not double my wailing. I am already weeping.
 Do not till my soil too deeply.
 Do not scatter my ashes too harshly.
 Do not judge my works too roughly.
 Do not blow my dust too meanly.



Do not measure your greatness against my smallness,
 your light against my dimness,
 your good nature against my native evil,
 your cornucopia of blessing against my cursed fruit,
 your genuine sweetness against my complete sourness,
 your unchanging glory against my total debasement,
 your shrine of life against my vessel of clay,
 your lord of lords against my dust of the earth,
 your undimishing fullness against my slavish poverty,
 your unpillaged abundance against my abandoned torment,
 your unblemished goodness against my most wretched squalor,
 for who can reach morning and
 at the light of daybreak expect dark,
 or at the portal of life expect death,
 or at liberation expect bondage,
 or at grace expect condemnation,
 or at salvation expect destruction,
 or at renewal expect ruination,
 or at blessing expect banishment,

or at cure expect injury,
 or at fullness expect want,
 or at abundance of bread expect famine,
 or at the flow of rivers expect drought,
 or at motherly compassion expect deception,
 or at the care of God's right hand expect persecution?



And now with my body shaken by disease
 and my soul in peril I pray,
 "Lord, if you want you can make me clean."¹
 Like a groping blind man,
 I cry with laments and call to you
 not only the son of David,
 but also profess your divine birth.
 I not only call you, "Rabbi,"²
 the name of honor given to teachers
 who claim to know the truth, but I also
 believe you to be the Lord of heaven and earth.
 I not only expect to be cured when you are close,
 O compassionate God, by the touch of your hand,
 but also when we are separated by great distances
 through the power of your words.
 I do not draw a line between your will
 and your compassion, a line of doubt,³
 for I believe that you will, because
 you are compassionate and you are able,
 because you are our creator.
 Say the word and I will be cured.⁴
 Let me join the centurion in his faith.⁵
 Let my faith be not just for the short
 distances from altar to altar,
 for I know you are able to raise
 the dead and make them whole.
 Even sitting in heaven you work miracles
 over the whole world below.
 And I have nothing to give in return.



¹Mt. 8:2.

²Mt. 20:31.

³Mk. 9:21.

⁴Mt. 8:8.

⁵Mt. 8:5-10.



Grant me forgiveness, with the word of your judgment,
 even as you forgave the debt
 of 500 dinars in the case of the prostitute,
 God of goodness, Lord of bliss.
 The more you bestow, the greater your glory.
 The more you give, the more you are loved.
 The more your mercy, the more your greatness.
 For all your benevolence, you are rightly praised.
 Though Lord of all, you came to us as our equal.
 Though possessing everything, you weigh by our measure.
 Though you have gifts beyond telling,
 you accept our skimpy payment.
 And to the account of mortals, you grant unlimited credit. Your generosity is sublime,
 yet not too high to receive our meager praise.
 Show the same compassion to me with my countless debts so that I might
 in expressing gratitude for your gifts also commemorate your love.
 To you glory in all things.
 Amen.

Prayer 18 (ԺԸ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

I was born in sin, the child of mortal labor.
 Now, in one day, a penalty of countless thousands
 has come due.
 I turn to you for forgiveness not on the meager human
 scale, but with the full undiminishing measure
 of lovingkindness shown toward us
 by our Savior Jesus Christ:
 Before I was, you created me.
 Before I could wish, you shaped me.
 Before I glimpsed the world's light, you saw me.
 Before I emerged, you took pity on me.
 Before I called, you heard me.

Before I raised a hand, you looked over me.
 Before I asked, you dispensed mercy on me.
 Before I uttered a sound, you turned your ear to me.
 Before I sighed, you attended me.
 Knowing in advance my current trials,
 you did not thrust me from your sight. No, even foreseeing my misdeeds,
 you fashioned me.

Բ

And now, do not let me
 whom you made, saved and took into
 your care, be lost to sin and
 the Troublemaker's deceptions.
 Do not let the fog of my willfulness prevail
 over the light of your forgiveness,
 nor the hardness of my heart
 over your long-suffering goodness,
 nor my mortal flaws
 over your perfect wholeness,
 nor my weak flesh
 over your invincible strength.

Գ

In your name, Almighty,
 I extend the shriveled arm of my soul
 so you will make it whole as before,¹
 as in the garden of Eden,
 when it reached to pick fruit of the tree of life.
 The misery of my incorrigible soul,²
 bound up, infirm, bent over,
 is like the stricken woman in the Gospel,
 bowed by sin, her gaze on the ground
 in Satan's tyrannical chains,
 kept from your heavenly blessing.

Turn your ear toward me, last hope of mercy
 and raise this humbled, fallen, dried up,
 thinking piece of wood,
 to make it blossom in piety,
 as foretold in the words of the holy prophet.³

Դ

¹Mt. 12:10-13.

²Lk. 13:11-13.

³Ezek. 17:24.



Like one without light, blind from birth,
I do not have vision to look upon your face, O
creator,
almighty and compassionate, my only protec-
tor.

If you turn the caring gaze of your immeasur-
able love
upon my breathing speaking vessel,
you could rekindle, out of nothing,
the light of being within me.

Like the wretched woman in the Gospels,
afflicted by evils for twelve years,⁴
I bleed with rivers of infirmity.
Look down upon me from on high
cloaked in blinding light,
where sewn clothing does not exist,
but everything is covered in mighty miracles.

ⲉ

Condemned as I am, I do not approach
the soles of your life-giving feet
to anoint them with oil⁵
or offer to wash them with my
tear-drenched hair. But rather, a true believer,
I kiss the earth, with pure faith,
hands reaching up, sighing with streaming
tears,
begging for the healing of my soul,
a soul wasted by shortcomings,
dissipated by weakness.

ⲉ

And these two feet, means of motion,
foundation of my body's structure,
now lame and unsteady,
vanquished by evil,
impede my ascent to the tree of life-giving
fruit.
May you again inhabit them, my only hope of
cure.
And the organ of glorification with which you
endowed
me, whose voice when moved by the magna-
nimity of

your mercy used to turn back the breath of the
Troublemaker, silencing him,
may you miraculously restore your living word
to me,
so I might speak again without faltering,⁶
like the one you healed in the Gospel.

ⲉ

I lie here on a cot struck down by evil,
sinking in disease and torment,
like the living dead yet able to speak.
O kind Son of God,
have compassion upon my misery.
Hear the sobbing of my agitated voice.
Bring me back to life
with the dew of your blessed eyes
as you brought back your friend from breath-
less death.⁷
In a dungeon of infirmities, I am captive, bitter
and
in doubt.
Give me your hand, sun that casts no shadows,
Son on
high, and lift me into your radiant light.

ⲉ

Like the pitiful, wailing voice of the widow
Nain,
mourning her only son,
fingers trembling, chest heaving,⁸
tears streaming down her face paralyzed with
grief,
I beg with my last sighing breath: Grant me,
who has lost hope, your comfort and pity.
Teach me not to moan and protest like a pris-
oner,
kind and praiseworthy creator of the universe,
but rather, like the young man you brought
back to life,
who comforted his grieving mother,
may I too receive from you
a second chance for my condemned soul.

ⲉ

⁴Mt. 9:20-21, Mk. 5:25-29.

⁵Lk. 7:37-38.

⁶Mk. 7:35.

⁷Jn. 11:3.

⁸Lk. 7:11-15.



You took pity, O Savior of all,
 even on demon-possessed brutes,⁹
 and those unfortunates, stoned, beaten, and de-
 formed,
 with their unkempt, knotted hair
 and their wild faces, raving in delirium.
 Like them, I petition you,
 turn back the legions of evil defiling
 your sanctuary within me
 so that when your Spirit arrives
 your goodness might dwell here
 and fill my body with your cleansing breath,
 bringing lucidity to my reeling mind.

✠

Like souls banished to hell,
 I am held captive by illness.
 Let your light dawn in radiant rays of mercy
 upon my torture to rescue me
 from the clutches of the sickness
 tearing me apart.

The infirmities that cause disease
 traveling invisible paths, secretly lying in wait,
 straying from the ordained ways with
 malicious purposes –
 all torment my soul.¹⁰
 Hidden from examination, the
 malignant growth proceeds
 with the poisonous work of the Evil-doer.
 With your strength which knows no equal,
 Son of God, heal me so that I might live.

With your almighty hand pluck out
 the harvest of destruction
 that the various mortal illnesses,
 each dressed in its own way, produce.
 Pluck out the evil roots
 sprouted upon the field of my unruly body
 with your mighty hand
 that plows and cultivates the plots of our souls
 so they may bear the fruit of the gospel of life.

✠

And because the torments of my infirmities
 surpass even these examples,

⁹Mk. 5:5.

¹⁰Lk. 14:2.

which like a spreading cancer,
 have touched all the parts of my body,
 there is no salve as there was none for Israel,¹¹
 for my innumerable sores.
 Every part of my body from head to toe¹²
 is unhealthy and beyond the help of physicians.
 But you, merciful, beneficent, blessed,
 long-suffering, immortal king,
 hear the prayers of my embattled heart for
 mercy,
 when I cry to you, “Lord,”
 in my time of need.¹³

Prayer 19 (✠Ω)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ω

Hear, all-seeing vision of hope and goodness of
 life,
 the profuse sighs of my hurting soul,
 unreachable greatness, fearful name, living
 word,
 longed for message, delectable taste,
 worshipful calling, confessed beneficence,
 sweet perception, professed reality,
 glorious essence, blessed existence,
 Lord Christ, praised and worshiped with your
 Father
 and exalted and proclaimed with the Holy
 Spirit,
 who alone became human like us for our sakes,
 so that you might make us like you for your
 sake,
 light unto all, merciful, almighty and
 heavenly in all ways,
 I pray that with your divine miracle-working
 power,
 compassionate God, you restore this,
 my collapsing broken earthen vessel.
 And I pray that you recast the image you gave
 me,
 worn by sin,

¹¹Wis. 16:12, Is. 1:6.

¹²Is. 1:6.

¹³Jon. 2:3.



in the lightning crucible of your word.
 Cleanse the temple of my body,
 the vessel of my soul,
 the altar of your repose,
 as your dwelling place,
 I pray you, O doer of good.
 Do not repay my evil deeds with evil.
 I am drunk, in the words of the prophet,¹ but
 not
 with wine. Empty out the dregs of iniquity
 from my stupefying cup of death. And by the
 command
 of your salvation, giver of all life,
 let me with the last drop of your cup²
 be spared on the day of judgment.



You are just in your law
 and triumphant in your judgment.³
 If you hand down a death sentence,
 your action is right.
 If you reprimand before giving a stern condem-
 nation,
 your decision is just.
 If you cast me into the abyss
 or still the movement of life,
 if you silence my power of speech,
 or darken the windows of my eyes,
 if you check my joy in life,
 or impair my ability to be nourished by ordi-
 nary food,
 if you reduce the richness of my days,
 or make drops of fire fall along with the dew
 drops,
 if you starve me by your silence,⁴
 or shut the doors of my ears,
 if you cut off the bounty of your grace,
 or make the earth move under my feet,
 if you shut off the light of your countenance
 for which I yearn, or expel me from
 this world completely,
 if you terrify me with a lightening bolt,
 or condemn me to incurable pain,
 if you betray me to the demons of evil,

¹Is. 29:9, 51:21.

²Is. 51:22.

³Ps. 50:6, Rom. 3:4.

⁴Am. 8:11.

or chew me up in the jaws of beasts,
 if you blow me away in billowing anger,
 or invent some new torture,
 more evil than Tartaros,
 more severe than Gehenna,
 more vile than maggots,
 more anguishing than darkness,
 more terrifying than the abyss,
 more pitiful than nakedness,
 I will testify against myself that
 I deserve these and more.



And since the punishments always match
 the sins they are for,
 like mirror images, identical,
 parallel, emblematic of the wrong,
 it is important to confess
 and lift the veil from my face
 to one who seeks to know me.
 For as I did not tend the needs of
 my fellow man with warm charity,
 it is right that I freeze with fear
 at the first sign of danger.

And since I did not check my willful pride,
 it is fair that I should be consumed with
 unbridled disgrace.

And since I did not love the light
 of the good news, it is just
 that I should be condemned to grope
 in the darkness of ignorance and fog of perdi-
 tion.

And since I paid no heed to small faults,
 considering them harmless, it is fitting
 for me to be wounded by the stings of insects.

And since I did not lend a helping hand
 to those in danger, it is proper for me
 to be cast into a pit of filth.



But evil is not from your Godly bounty,
 source of all good, and darkness
 is not from your radiant light.
 And temptation is not



part of your protection. No, I found these myself
like a destructive child.
And the mounting sins of my iniquity have justified
your anger. As the good book warns⁵
I became the servant of the prince
of iniquity, giving him your place.

᠖

And since the scandal,
the most private secret, has been uncovered⁶
and its shamefulness leaves a mark
upon my face. I show myself, as in
the parable of the prophet, in complete
offensiveness like a naked prostitute.⁷

Rekindle your light of atonement in me,
heavenly king, so that
shaking off the dust of sin,
my soul can stand upright like the
people returning from Babylon,
having heard the voice of good tidings.
And I will be able to sit up again,
on the firm foundation of your unshakable
hope.
In the words of the prophet Isaiah,⁸
I shall be clothed in my former purity
by your mighty hand, for the sweetness
of your all-giving divinity and your great glory.
Blessed forever.
Amen.

Prayer 20 (᠖)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

᠘

Lord, O Lord, who bears no grudges,
tolerant, forgiving, compassionate, powerful,
and merciful,
behold, your actions rest on truth,

⁵Ec. 10:4.

⁶Col. 3:5.

⁷Nah. 3:5-6.

⁸Is. 52:1.

your judgment upon confessions,
your decisions upon sound testimony,
O seer of the unseen. Like the three
fortunate youths who were tested by the caustic fires
of Babylon but were unharmed,
I groan a mournful refrain,
“I have sinned. I am lawless. I have done
wrong.
I have been indicted and I have not heeded
your commandments.”¹
They being innocent of any wrong
cried out this confession, while I am rightly
condemned to death and have yet more reason
to plead even as Daniel,
the blessed holy prophet,
who was of your true lineage
and the chosen branch of the house of Judah.
To his words and prayers of commitment that
were acceptable to you, I add my cries
for punishment and humiliation.

᠙

Knowing full well what was improper,
I strayed from the path,
sinning in all ways in all things,
I fled from the balancing bounds
of your will. And this is
the characteristic profile of base
lawlessness that I practiced and
perfected till my wrongdoing knew
no limits. Is this not the very image
of criminality? You admonished
but I was shameless. You entreated
but I took no heed. Both are flagrant signs
of rebellion.

᠑᠐

You clothed yourself in righteousness,
O doer of good, and prepared
shame and humiliation for me.
For you, fitting glory,
for me, deserving insult.
For you, sweetness immemorial,
for me, vinegary bile.
For you, praise that cannot be silenced,

¹Dan. 3:29-30; 9:5.



for me, weeping laments.
 For you, songs of blessing rising with incense,
 for me, the alienation of exile.
 For you, all rights justly deserved,
 for me, every worrisome debt.
 For you, exaltation and praise beyond words,
 for me, the abject punishment of eating dust.

¶

And you, O splendid goodness beyond measure,
 you received our offering with sweet frankincense
 fitting to you, while
 I received my portion of censure compounded
 by aggravating circumstances.
 For if the innocent prayed to you in this way,
 what apology shall I weave in my guilt, I who
 have
 faltered more basely than anyone?
 I have strayed down wayward paths in my
 undisciplined mind.
 In my everyday speech I have been brazen.
 I have been obsessed by shameful deeds.
 I have become puffed up and haughty.
 I have become arrogant and conceited
 though I will soon be lowered into the earthly
 grave.
 I want to make a deal
 though I cannot even give my breath as collateral.

¶

I, breathing dust, have grown haughty.
 I, talking clay, have become presumptuous.
 I, filthy dirt, have grown proud.
 I, disgusting ashes, have risen up,
 raising my hands with my broken cup,² strutting
 like a swaggering peacock, but then
 curling back into myself, as if rejected,
 my speaking slime glowing with anger
 I grew arrogant, as if I were immortal,
 I, who face the same death as the four-legged
 creatures.
 I embraced the love of pleasure

²Jer. 51:7-8.

and instead of facing you, turned my back.
 In flights of fancy I darted into lurid thought.
 Indulging my body I wore out my soul.
 In strengthening the sinister side
 I weakened the force of my right side.
 I saw your concern for me, too deep for words,
 and paid no heed.

¶

As Hosea wrote of Ephraim,³ I rushed
 toward my former ways like a wild fowl.
 In my sanctuary I was immersed in my worldly
 preoccupations and I did not halt the meandering
 horse of my mind with the reins of rationality.
 I added to my former wrong doings with new
 inventions. Like Job,⁴ I made my heavy yoke
 even more unbearable. Like Jeremiah,⁵
 I became like a rotten cloth, and, as the
 preacher⁶ said,
 my name is erased from the book of mankind
 like a stillborn child. And as Isaiah⁷ said,
 I have become soiled like the napkin of the
 menstruating woman and I am shattered and
 unmendable like a ceramic bowl.⁸ Like the
 Edomite
 chastised by the prophet, I have prepared myself
 for a squalid end⁹ as the fourth penalty for
 my lawlessness. And it would be no lie were I
 to add
 that abandoning my inheritance in heaven I
 even built
 a tabernacle to the demon Moloch,¹⁰ even fashioned
 an idol in the form of the Babylonian Star
 of Rephan like the one the Israelites had in the
 Sinai,¹¹
 so that my legacy should be hell.

³Hos. 9:11.

⁴Job 40:21.

⁵Jer. 13:7.

⁶Ec. 6:3 - 4.

⁷Is. 64:6.

⁸Is. 30:14.

⁹Am. 1:11.

¹⁰Am. 5:25-26, Acts 7:42-43.

¹¹Am. 5:25-26, Acts 7:42-43.



Է

And now with the license of my original grace
 revoked
 I have changed, I am dispossessed, I am exiled,
 I am banished, I am separated and irreparably
 cut off.
 Now, accept me, O Lord, and renew the im-
 pression of
 your image on my soul, I who am unworthy of
 life,
 a capital felon, evil person,
 a fallen being trampled by Satan,
 a terminal patient at death's door,
 depraved and unworthy of your calling,
 defeated with one blow, wanderer, exile and
 outlaw,
 a doubter, wretch, reject, battered, shattered,
 broken, wounded, dejected, embattled soul.

Ը

And again, O compassionate Lord who loves
 mankind,
 almighty God, as you consider these words of
 pleading,
 treat them as a confession from a contrite soul
 fallen at your feet in repentance.
 And as you judge, note and weigh
 the tearful soul, the heaving sighs,
 the quivering lips, the dry tongue,
 the clenched face, the good will in the depth of
 the heart,
 you who are the salvation of humanity,
 the seer of the undone, the creator of all,
 the healer of invisible wounds,
 the defender of the hopeful and the guardian of
 all,
 to you glory forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 21 (ԻԱ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
 Heart*

Ա

Since I of my own will mortgaged myself to
 death,

never standing as a man on my own two feet,
 and never having received a rational soul,
 as the Bible says,¹

I did not turn away from my former sinful ways
 to travel the path of goodness.

Why should I not begin this chapter
 by disclosing my wayward tracks toward dark-
 ness?

So I shall adapt my writing to this purpose
 without changing my earlier testimony,
 and confess again the rest of the evil
 stains upon me.

Բ

Deserving the punishment of a foreign merce-
 nary

I joined the army of Beliar by my acts of obsti-
 nacy.

Swept off by the agile dances, gleeful stunts,
 and foolery of the slithering demons,
 ingenious deceivers, I wallowed in my sloth,
 and in the chambers of the fallen, I took com-
 fort

in secret floggings and invisible wounds in-
 stead of

warding off these outcasts with Christ's cross.

No, I willingly joined them
 with no reason other than my miserable law-
 lessness.

Your name, O Jesus, was profaned among the
 demons,

as it was among the Gentiles for the sake of Is-
 rael.

The vices I planted in myself blow by wicked
 blow

like thieves and evil spirits

ate away at the flower of my soul like corrosive
 rust.

Like caterpillars and locusts,

as the saintly prophet Joel² described

in his terrifying lament about the land of Israel.

Indeed, I cultivated rather than uprooted them,
 recruiting throngs of warriors armed
 with deadly weapons.

I collected them in my soul and

nurtured those that goaded me toward

¹Dan. 7:4.

²Jl. 1:4.



lawlessness and iniquity,
I strengthened my enemies so that they
became invincible,
I took bitterness as my portion instead of your
sweet sustenance,
always deceitful toward the Creator,
and faithful to the Deceiver.

¶

How dare I raise my voice in appeal,
considering the wretchedness of my plight,
the anguish of my peril,
the shadow of my shame,
the darkness of my humiliation?
The voice of doom is overwhelming
and the cry of my protests unbearable.
And if I could see my soul,
deformed, shriveled, wasted away,
I would sob yet more painfully in
extreme embarrassment
at the disgusting, ashen color of its baseness,
like a minion at a pagan temple.
For becoming a slave to sin is the same
as worshiping a stone idol.

¶

Since I have traveled the path of destruction
pursuing the footprints of darkness,
like the priests of Israel scolded by the prophet,
and
since I have traded your plot of paradise for
a barren desert,³
how can I call myself human,
when I have earned a place among the inhu-
man?
How can I be named a thinking being,
when I indulge in brutish ways?
How can I be called a seeing being,
when I have snuffed out my inner light?
How can I be known as cognizant,
when I have slammed the door on wisdom?
How can I aspire to incorruptible grace,
when with my own hand I have slain my soul?⁴
Indeed I lack attributes of a moving or even
breathing being,

³Jer. 12:10.

⁴Wis. 22:23.

let alone one capable of spiritual, thoughtful
life.

¶

Chipped among the set of plates,
defective among the stones of the wall,
disdained among the ranks of the called,
lowest of the tribe of the elect,
weakest among those fearful of death,
most dejected with the pain of Jerusalem,
as mournful as Jeremiah's words,⁵
"My days have been wasted in wailing,
and the course of my years in crying."
In the songs of the musician,⁶

"Like wool eaten by moths, like wood
chewed up by worms."
In the words of the wiseman,⁷
"My heart was consumed by suspicion."
In the words of the Psalmist,⁸
"I unravelled like a spiderweb,
and became useless."
In the words of the prophet,⁹
"I have disappeared, evaporated like the
morning cloud and the dew at dawn."

¶

I do not put my hope in mankind,
for I would be cursed by the evil eye¹⁰
and falter in despair.
Rather I place my faith in you, my Lord,
who loves our souls.
You, who even at the hour
you were nailed to the cross
overflowed with boundless compassion,
and beseeched your Father on high
to take mercy on your tormentors.
Now grant me hope of atonement, life and
refuge,
so that when I take my last breath
I might receive from you a healed soul.
To you with the Father and the Holy Spirit,

⁵Jer. 6:6-7.

⁶Ps. 30:11.

⁷Pr. 25:20.

⁸Ps. 38:12.

⁹Hos 13:3.

¹⁰Jer. 17:5.



all power, victory, majesty and glory forever.
Amen.

Prayer 22 (ԽԲ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

And now I continue to accuse my cursed soul
in different terms confessing all my
undisclosed evil doings so that perhaps
the all-knowing might record in my favor
these anguished words of penitence and contri-
tion.

Բ

My body, the grievous tormentor of my soul,
wounded, untreatable, beyond care or recov-
ery,¹
is like a talking horse with a callous mouth,
breaking my reins and shaking off my bit,
a surly, wild and incorrigible colt,
an untame, recalcitrant, and stubborn² heifer,
a homeless man, banished and lost,
a street urchin, roguish and impudent,
a boss, deserving mortal punishment,
unfaithful and indolent,
an intelligent person, turned beastly and un-
clean,
an abandoned olive tree, barren and dry,
a string of imperial gold coins, wasted and for-
feited,
a delinquent servant, runaway and wretched.³

Գ

I am of no use to you at all, Lord,
for I am willingly self-destructive of soul and
body,
and remain spiritually lost and mentally de-
luded,
with a twisted will⁴ and broken heart,⁵

¹Lk. 10:30.

²Gen. 12:6.

³Mt. 25: 26-30.

⁴Jg. 5:6; Wis. 2:15, 4:24, 16:30, 27:6; Sir. 4:1; Job 9:20; Is. 27:1; 1 Pet. 2:18; Phil. 2:15.

⁵2 Macc. 7:39.

absent-minded and stagnant-brained,
numb and drained,
brazen and disagreeable,
besieged by inflammations,
wracked by fatal sickness.
I pity the womb that bore me and
bemoan the breasts that fed me, asking
why was their milk not curdled with bile?
Why was the sweetness that nurtured me not
mixed with bitterness?

Դ

And because I have risen against myself
with words like a harsh prosecutor
and have even taken up the sword
of righteous anger that cannot be sheathed,
who among the earth-born will plead for me?
I shall confess every scandalous detail.
I shall submit my being to judgment.
I shall beat down the army of destruction.
I shall prosecute the marauders wounding me.
I have sinned in everything and in all ways.
Have mercy upon me, O compassionate God.
It is no new thing to find me in the fog of iniq-
uity.
I am always the same, breaking
the same commandments and appearing
before you unreformed, stumbling
in an unmendable garment.
And only you, O truly compassionate and
blessed,
with your love of mankind and your
unwavering forgiveness
can speed my escape from Satan⁶
who stands beside me.

Ե

Now, O caregiving, mighty, heavenly, kind,
creator of all out of nothing,
send the thunderbolt⁷ of wisdom in powerful
words,
upon the movements of my tongue
that it might cleanse the senses
with which you endowed me,
so that with the faculties you created and

⁶Zech. 3:1-3.

⁷Is. 6:6-7.



fixed a second time,
I might offer thanks to you
with unfailing voice and unbroken speech.
For the glory of the majesty of your Father,
our God, forever.
Amen.

Prayer 23 (ԻԳ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Lord God of all, able to do anything,
all-encompassing space, unbounded, unlimited,
close to all with your very essence,
nowhere, yet without you there are no bounds,
invisible, yet without the light of your dawn
nothing is visible,
awesome glory, incomprehensible name,
voice of majesty, sound of the infinite,
essence beyond analysis,
unreachable distance, immediate closeness,
who notes gentleness and sees distress,
stands by grief and can cure all hopeless cases,
Father of compassion who spreads mercy,
God of comfort.

Բ

Look with mercy, O Lord, on my anguish,
on the many symptoms of dread afflictions
I set out before you.
Treat me like a physician, rather than examining
me like a judge.
Indeed I am overwhelmed by anxieties
caused by vacillation and doubt.
When the body is weakened by malady,
when the soul is not fortified against evil,
when the senses are paralyzed by passion,
the members of the body wallow in desire,
the heart's wisdom is wounded by remorse,
the expectation of good is abandoned,
and despite the ability to think,
man sinks to the level of beasts.¹

¹Ps. 48:13, 21.

His existence becomes enmeshed with disgust
even while appearing outwardly whole,
his intellect frays within.
Remembering the graveness of his mistakes,
he falls into despair
tormented by past deeds and constantly worried.
The clarity of prayer becomes clouded
as he smolders in the fires of conscience.
At work, although his hand stays on the plough,
his mind keeps turning over the past.²
Walking forward, his feet drag back.
Knowing the essential, he is consumed by irrelevancies.
In battles of the mind, he is always defeated by details.
And the door of his voice box is charred by the burning of his heart.
Everywhere sunless fog rises from damp whims
enshrouding everything and blocking the grasp of hope.
His senses are branded with unbearable pain.
His mind is obsessed by the misfortune of perdition
and retribution occupies the tribunal of his thought.
His tender eye fills with anger.
Bright spirits disfavor my earthen vessel
and I am worthy of being stoned to death with stones of justice.
With terror my meager nature collides with yours
as your thundering words scatter my thought-bearing ashes.
Like a prodigal son I have wasted the talent given me,³
and like the useless servant I buried the honorable gifts received.⁴
The fruits of my labor are covered with the darkness of sloth,
and fade like the afterglow of a candle when it is taken away.
My tongue, having lost the right to respond, is dumb.

²Lk. 9:62.

³Lk. 15:11.

⁴Lk. 19:20.



My twisted lips have been justly silenced.
 My mind whirls with anxiety
 unable to concentrate
 too stupefied to weigh and choose what is right.
 The path of deliverance is blocked
 by the wreckage of evil,
 and the lamp of my soul⁵ is filled only with ash.
 The letters of my name have been scratched
 from the book of life,⁶
 and blame is written in the place of blessing.

ⲓ

If I see a soldier, I expect death,
 a messenger, punishment,
 a clerk, foreclosure,
 a jurist, condemnation,
 an evangelist, the shaking of the dust off his
 feet,⁷
 a pious person, reprimand,
 a snob, sarcasm,
 If I am put to trial by water, I will drown⁸
 If I take a remedy for my condemnation, I will
 die.
 At the mere sight of the harvest of goodness, I
 recoil remembering my evil.
 If a hand is raised, I take cover.
 At the least trifle, I tremble.
 At the slightest sound, I flinch.
 If I am invited to join in a toast, I quiver.
 If I am scolded, I cower.
 If I am called for questioning, I mumble.
 If I am interrogated, I become dumb.

ⲓ

Now, all these pitiful doubts, heaped upon each
 another,
 in the unconscious depths and inner chambers
 of my heart's being,
 stifle me, piercing my heart with invisible ar-
 rows,
 unextractable, permanently lodged in my soul,
 filling it with pus forewarning
 a dreadful death.
 With each breath I draw,

⁵Lk. 11:36.

⁶Ex. 32:33.

⁷Mt. 10:14.

⁸Num. 5:16-22.

the ulcers and rust from these buried secrets,
 locked away in iron, cause pain.
 The cry of my voice strangled by these tor-
 ments,
 I offer to heaven, mixed with tears and the sob-
 bing grief of my soul,
 O doer of good, for whom everything is possi-
 ble,
 along with the prayers of other earth-bound
 sufferers.
 With them I offer up my last sigh
 and tears here on earth,
 so that you will grant a calm peace to me,
 a pitiful laborer engaged in vain earthly pur-
 suits.
 Eternal glory to you,
 who are all in all through all.
 Amen.

Prayer 24 (ⲛⲩ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

ⲓ

What am I worthy to ask of you in prayer?

May I pray for
 paradise,¹ from which I have strayed?
 your magnificent glory, which I am denied?
 your everlasting life, from which I was re-
 jected?
 the society of angels, from which I was
 expelled?
 the company of the just, from which I am
 banished?
 the living vine, from which I have been
 ripped away?²
 the shoot of the plant of bliss, from which I
 have
 dried up?
 the grace of the flower of glory, from which
 I have fallen?
 the legacy of praise, from which I was disin-
 herited?

¹Gen. 3:23-24.

²Jn. 15:2.



the devoted fatherly embrace, from which
I have pulled away?

¶

Or may I pray
that I might be honored with clothing of light,
from which I have been stripped?
that I might hope for return to my creator,
from whom I have been estranged?³
that I might turn my desires to the light,
from which I have strayed?
that I might join the body of Christ,
from which I was rejected?⁴
that I might touch the hand of him,
from whom I am separated?
that I might seek refuge in the sanctuary,
from which I was spurned?
Or might I pray for
the renewal of salvation, from which I fell?
the reawakening of joy, from which
I was abandoned?
the rule of monastic life, from which
I have been diverted?
the edge of steadfastness, from which
I have slipped?
the bulwark of the immovable rock,
from which I have been shaken?
the procession of the faithful, from which I
strayed?
Or may I pray that I might
prosper in the city of firstborn,
from which I was taken captive? ⁵
receive my daily bread, for which
I have not worked?
be compensated for labor, for which
I have not sweat?
be showered with rewards, which
I have not earned? ⁶
be recorded in the book of life,
from which I have been erased? ⁷
remember the bounty of blessings, which
I always forget?

³Lk. 15:11-20.

⁴Eph. 5:30.

⁵Heb. 12:23, Ex. 13:14-15, Num. 18:15-16, Lk. 2:22-23.

⁶1 Cor. 9:24-27.

⁷Ex. 32:33.

¶

And now the thread of the hope of life has
snapped.

I am dominated by a plague of leprosy, dis-
eased all over.

My body has been eaten away by corruption.

Besieged, I have been made dead to God.

A small, shiny, ugly, white scar⁸
is all that remains of my earlier ambiguous
symptoms,⁹

leaving no doubt of my uncleanness.

All vestiges of pride have been snuffed.

Salvation is forsaken; the good darkened by
shadows.

Access to life is completely closed;¹⁰ comfort
removed.

The tribunal of judgment approaches.

The poisons of death quicken within me.

The malignancies reawaken.

The harbor is shut by reefs.

The path of hope is blocked.

The cloak of grace has been stripped away.

The splendor of majesty is eclipsed.

The sense of direction has been confused.

The stabs of reprimand have multiplied.

The horns of iniquity have sprouted.

The flames of hell have singed me.

The yoke of servitude weighs heavily.

The chains of slavery are strengthened.

The supporting structure has collapsed.¹¹

The base of the summit has disintegrated.

The unity of the family has fallen into the
abyss.

The Spirit of God which loves holiness is de-
jected.¹²

¶

I have embraced the bitter dregs
of torment, anguish, sorrow, spiritual distress,
pains beyond treatment,
doubt beyond steadying, shame beyond mea-
sure,

⁸Lev. 13:2; Lev. 13:19

⁹Lev. 13:5.

¹⁰Mt. 25:10.

¹¹Sir. 27:3.

¹²Eph. 4:30.



scandal beyond concealment,
 humiliation beyond brazenness,
 fleeing beyond return,
 persecution beyond human decency,
 a long, barren pilgrimage.¹³
 Whereas you are salvation, strength, and relief,
 mercy, enlightenment, atonement and life eternal,
 Lord Jesus Christ, Son of the living God,¹⁴
 creator of heaven and earth,
 who offers water to those parched from
 thirst in the desert.¹⁵
 Blessed, kind, mighty, loving,
 forbearing, caring, ingenious, visitor,
 defender without sparing, protector victorious,
 life indestructible, intercessor to heaven,
 undiminishing fullness, bliss celebrated,
 lovingly extend your right hand of mercy.
 Accept and present me, a manifold sinner,
 my sins forgiven and cleansed,
 to your Holy Spirit, equal to you in honor,
 O living Word,
 so that reconciled through you the Holy Spirit
 might return to me.
 Through you, may the almighty Holy Spirit
 cleanse me with pure will and present me to
 your Father
 so that I may with him and through him
 always be bound with grace to you
 through the breath of salutation
 inseparably united with you.
 And for these gifts, to you, the Father and
 the Holy Spirit,
 three persons, one nature and one godhead,
 glory and thanksgiving from your created be-
 ings,
 forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 25 (ԻԵ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

¹³Lk. 19:12.

¹⁴Mt. 16:16.

¹⁵Num. 20:1-11.

In describing my imprisonment and captivity,
 I have recounted some of the wicked torments
 that have afflicted me one after another,
 most unfortunate soul that I am.
 Now I change my figure of speech,
 but not the subject of my laments.

Բ

The ways of my life are like the waves of the
 sea,
 my soul tossing in this world upon countless,
 endless swells,
 riding in the shell of my body
 like the ship lost at sea, as the prophet Isaiah¹
 once said mourning the sudden destruction of
 Jerusalem and Samaria by Persian hordes.

Would I then be wrong to use similar sounds
 and
 images to describe the spiritual destruction
 that crashed upon me?
 For as I strode through life free of doubts and
 cares,
 I had no inkling of the peril lying in wait for
 me
 between work and rest.
 It arrived like the winter's blast on a summer's
 day,
 a turbulent front thrusting me into turmoil.

Wrecked by the blows of the wild waves
 of the sea,
 like a ship
 whose rudder has become unhinged,
 whose tall mast has been ripped from the deck,
 whose flapping sails are in shreds,
 whose well-built frame has lost its form,
 whose ropes have unravelled,
 whose lookout has been laid low,
 whose cable strands have snapped,
 whose anchor has come loose,
 whose joints are unjointed,
 whose guiding oar is bent,
 whose keel is submerged,
 whose helm is detached,

¹Is. 5:30.

whose steering mechanism is gone,
 whose backbone has snapped,
 whose ribs are undone,
 whose underbelly is shattered,
 whose deck burst loose,
 whose cabin has collapsed,
 whose railing has fallen,
 whose captain's chair has tipped,
 whose deck planks have split apart,
 whose fastening nails are out.

¶

This image of destruction reminds me of my misery,
 like a captain mourning his ship,
 chin in hand,² tears streaming down,
 viewing traces of the wreckage
 bobbing on the crest of the waves.
 My slain sanity sobs with pitiful grief.

I did not stray from the truth
 in selecting these words to mourn
 the shattered ark of my intellect.
 For the Good Captain with his heavenly host
 took pity on the sea of humanity in just this way.
 Indeed, our merciful Lord,
 wept like one of us mortals for the death of a friend³
 and shed tears for fallen Jerusalem and
 treacherous Judas.
 Those two, like sunken ships, were lost beyond hope,
 but the first, having hit bottom,
 was lifted up into tranquil peace,
 by the thread of hope held in the hand of our deliverer.

¶

I wonder:
 Will I ever see the battered ark of
 my body restored?
 Will I ever see my shipwrecked soul healthy again?
 Will I ever see what has been separated by

²Job 21:5.

³Jn. 11:35.

so great a chasm rejoined?
 Will I ever see the sad and tired heart of
 this grieved spirit in bliss?
 Will I ever see the defiled image of
 nature once again in full bloom?
 Will I ever see the destroyed temple of
 my miserable self standing?
 Is there hope I might see this exiled slave set
 free?
 Indeed, may one fallen from grace expect
 to be lifted once more to the light?
 Will I ever see the native splendor of
 your radiance appearing to me in mercy?
 Will I ever see the saddest aspect of my soul
 smile?
 Will I ever hear good tidings instead of bad
 news?
 Will I ever see the thousand cracks in
 my vessel mended?
 Will I see through the windows of
 my mind's eye the bond of my debt torn up?⁴
 Will I see the goodness of forgiving grace
 dawn upon the days of my anguish?
 Will you lead me again into the joyous altar of
 light?
 Will my dried bones come alive again like
 Ezekiel's
 through your life-giving breath?⁵
 Will I again set eyes upon your holy cathedral,
 I who cry forth like the prophet from
 the belly of the whale,⁶
 rejected from the light, standing
 before you in shame?
 And will morning's light ever dawn to
 dispel my gloom,
 I, who was reared in darkness?
 Will one tormented in the deep frost of
 winter ever see spring?
 Will the mist of the rain restore the green
 pasture of my soul?
 Will the lost sheep, gashed by wild beasts,
 be again counted among your flock
 through your merciful will?

¶

⁴Col. 2:14.

⁵Ezek. 37:1-11.

⁶Jon. 2:3-5.



For as Job said, the snares of evil are all around,
 from these I cannot escape.⁷
 But by your good will
 if the light of compassion should shine,
 if the door of your mercy should open,
 if the rays of your glory should spread,
 if the care of your hand should be revealed,
 if the dawning sun of life should break forth,
 if the sight of your beautiful morn
 should be unveiled,
 if the bounty of your sweetness should flow forth,
 if the stream from the maker's side should run,
 if the drops of your pure love should shower down,
 if the good news of the dawn of your
 grace should resound,
 if the tree of your gift should blossom,
 if the parts of your blessed body are distributed,
 if the dashed expectations should be reassembled,
 if the silenced sound of your beckoning voice,
 Lord,
 should again be heard,
 if your banished peace should return,
 then with this blessing
 shall the faith of steady hope be forever mine
 finding refuge in the Holy Spirit,
 who with the Father is worshiped with
 the voice of sweetness
 and together with you bathed in light too bright
 for human eyes.⁸
 Grant life, forgiveness and heavenly bliss to
 me, a sinner,
 holding your incorruptible grace, the true
 token of faith,
 as an indestructible legacy.

This we pray in the name of your awe-inspiring,
 mighty and holy oneness
 and the lordship of your three-fold person
 beyond human words and understanding
 to you, who are in essence and in existence

eternally
 exalted, crowned, clothed and
 enthroned with sweetness, mercy and benevolence.

Indeed through you, O merciful Lord,
 all things, in all ways, for all people, are possible.
 To you glory here, now and forever and in the eternity to
 come on the great day of revelation.
 Amen.

Prayer 26 (ԻԶ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

And now, truly and rightly, I join the others
 who, modulating the sobs of their voices,
 appropriately dress their writing
 with the same sound at the end of each verse,
 thereby more intensely inflaming and rending
 the heart,
 and the anguish of the pangs of its distress
 to the point of tears.
 Thus I take my place at the head of the table of
 the practitioners of this art,
 who punctuate their poetry with sobs,
 and like them sighing and exclaiming “alas,”
 I lay open the grief of my soul,
 which is not totally dead to the world,
 but is not truly alive to God,
 poetry neither especially hot, or particularly
 cold¹
 as the Evangelist wrote in the Revelations,
 thrice condemned by the Holy Trinity and
 all-knowing creator.
 Thus, the fitting manifestation of my afflictions,
 making them twice as pitiful,
 is to set forth with a single rhyme
 making them the epitome of wretchedness,
 resonating response after response.

⁷Job 18:8, 19:8, 36:8.

⁸1 Tim. 6:16.

¹Rev. 3:15-16.



Բ

Like one, who renouncing debts, incurs even more penalties, wretched person that I am, I am condemned by my unworthy acts to a double penalty and unwaivable judgment, liable before the Almighty, apprehended without any defense, in a matter of thousands of talents, but without an ear's worth of coins, held captive in bitter confinement without an intercessor to sup on sighs and pain in a prison of darkness, tormented without refuge or sustenance, I am pitiful, and chose here a different mode for my lamentations, transposing my weeping with words, arranged with regularity in the same manner, with the indivisible, mystical symbol: 20, the pure vowel sound "ee" and the number of talents returned by the industrious servant of the parable.² The flames of the furnace of spiritual poverty are fanned from all sides, around my miserable, defenseless self. My anguished heart is mortgaged and my inconstant soul, easy prey to error. Unsparingly indicted, judgment shall be demanded of me. My senses shall be wounded by the weapons of death and sin. Like a slave condemned beyond salvation, my very essence is shredded by the hacking of its sharp sword. At the mere recollection of the tribunal of my judgment, gloom without a glimmer of light envelopes my pessimistic eyes.

²This line has been the subject of a number of interpretations. Critical Edition p. 1019-20 n. 11. Avetikian is followed here, according to which the reference is to the letter ini in Armenian, which is the number twenty and also the sound in which all the lines in this prayer end starting from Part B. The vowel [i] is indivisible as a "pure sound" not a diphthong, and is mystical in that it is the number of talents returned by the industrious servant in the parable of the Three Servants, Mt. 25:14.

Helpless captive of doubt, wretch that I am, the image of heaven's consternation overwhelms me. In the severe sunless Tartaros, without cover, without refuge, singed by the flames of Gehenna, I am lost without trace, swallowed by the abyss of sin. This is my net worth of useless silver which will never be honored or acceptable for deposit in the Lord's treasury. My petitions are tainted and my hands are unclean for an offering. I am heart broken and my fingers tremble in hope of redemption. With my face to the ground, I beseech you, Mother of Jesus, intercede and pray for forgiveness for me, a sinner. You, who are the mighty savior of life, Queen of Heaven, to you we offer the blessing of our voices and the fragrance of incense and the gift of sweet oils.

Գ

Now, let me add to the lamentations already written, another part. I have offered to the grantor of grace the fruits of tears. Having been unable to find the depth of my perdition, whenever I tried to describe it in precise words, even the swift wings of my mind were not able to comprehend its essence. Because the defeat of my mental capacities by the invincible forces of sin, I have taken the cup of wrath in my hand and I drink, as a taste of death, the perplexity of doubt. And now that I have set these rhythms of transgression to song with a pitiful voice, an invisible inferno blazes within me with flames that cannot be quenched, like some invisible molten metal bubbling furiously in an blasting furnace,

like the shooting of poisoned arrows into the
 deepest chamber of my heart,
 like jabs of pain from mortal wounds piercing
 through the veins of my liver,
 like pangs of labor, pain is stuck in my blocked
 intestines unable to escape,
 like my two burning kidneys that cannot be
 cured,
 like the unbearable bitterness of bile at the back
 of my throat,
 the fading voice of a sigh of “alas” can be heard
 in my windpipe.
 The various elements of the nature of my
 essence are like
 enemies at war with each other,³
 wavering with the timidity of opinions in total
 crisis.
 Although kin, they are destroying each other in
 irreconcilable betrayal,
 neither dead nor alive, buried in the mire of
 the baseness of sin.
 And with the suspicion of a convict I gaze upon
 your benevolence,
 that I might be lifted out of the pit of this hope-
 less life into the light of our desire.

¶

May he who copies these words be crowned
 among the blissful.
 May he expecting your mercy join the ranks of
 the pure.
 May he be granted life through your benefi-
 cence for his homage to God the Word.
 May the praiseworthy blessings of your lips be
 upon the heart of him who distributes this book.
 May the aspiration of Solomon’s book of
 Proverbs be fulfilled.⁴
 Through your Spirit, exalted God, may the im-
 print of your image be incorruptibly renewed,
 for you alone are patient and forgiving,
 and to you all glory.
 Amen.

³This is the conflict between the four elements, earth,
 wind, fire and water, out of which medieval thinkers be-
 lieved all else was composed.

⁴Pr. 11:25.

Prayer 27 (ԻԷ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

As I adapted the earlier chapters to the
 wordy creations offered up in my lamenting
 voice,
 wailing and sobbing, shrieking cries,
 weeping sighs of anguish,
 again I begin my prayers
 with confession and contrition,
 revealing my dark secrets.
 And I shall place here, at
 the beginning and end of each sentence
 the same words, echoing each other
 to form a single supplication of similar litanies
 for soul-saving humility.

¶

I have sinned against your beneficence,
 disrespectful sinner that I am.
 I have sinned against the rays of your dawn,
 dark sinner that I am.
 I have sinned against the boundless benefits of
 your grace, verily I have sinned.
 I have sinned against the exalted mercy of love,
 brazenly I have sinned.
 I have sinned against the creator ex nihilo,
 truly I have sinned.
 I have sinned against the tenderness of your
 almighty embrace,
 unworthy sinner that I am.
 I have sinned against the enlightenment of your
 undiminishing light,
 deceitful sinner that I am.
 I have sinned against the eating of your ineffa-
 ble life, many times I have sinned.
 I have sinned against the talents of your
 incomprehensible gifts,
 at all times I have sinned.
 I have sinned against the praiseworthy body of
 God, mortally I have sinned.
 I have sinned against your worshipful blood,
 our creator, truly I have sinned.

¶



Indeed this “I have sinned” is a blessed phrase
in this prayer for the heart set on hope,
It has an honorable lineage, an unforgettable
image,
paternal tribute, law of our forefathers,
our common inheritance,
irrefutable argument, forceful response,
bridge of life, pleasing to Heaven,
beloved of the saints, unseverable tie,
magical words, inescapable logic, earnest re-
quest,
inviting altar, heart-rending cry,
hope for the hopeless, shield against hardship,
charter for the faithful, letter to the pagans,
rule of the ancients, birthright of Christians,
victorious creative force, mighty abyss,
terrifying separation, transcending art,
incomprehensible depth, dazzling vision,
sealed mystery that cannot be unlocked,
beyond the grasp of the quickest mind.
A fitting, miraculous sound,
which was not uttered by the outcast sinners,¹
for if it had been, perhaps at that very moment,
the just death sentence and culling of the flock²
no longer being applicable,
the eternal barrier would have been torn down.
This word is an ornament of crowning glory,
by which the Godhead himself spreads his
magnanimity among us.



For who, having sought refuge by holding the
horn of the holy altar,
did not instantly escape punishment, being
found pure?³
Or as Achan, son of Carmi,⁴ King Saul,⁵ and
Judas,⁶
were not absolved, merely by saying “I
sinned”?
This, I affirm, with God as my witness, was just
and fair,
for forced confession is not performed with

¹Mt. 25:41.

²Mt. 25:32.

³1 Kg. 2:28.

⁴Jos. 7:19.

⁵1 Sam. 15:24.

⁶Mt. 27:4.

loving
contrition and therefore cannot bring salvation.



But I again embrace this happy word,
repeating it willingly
like a kind of baptism:
I have sinned by forgetting your favor,
again I have sinned.
I have sinned by slaying my soul with my
hands of flesh, senselessly I have sinned.⁷
I have sinned by betraying the life you gave,
verily I have sinned.
I have sinned by ignoring your word,
basely I have sinned.
I have sinned by hastening the day of my death
myself, destructively I have sinned.
I have sinned by mortgaging myself to lifeless
death, mockingly I have sinned.
I have sinned by my impudence before your
greatness, annoyingly I have sinned.



Yet again I cry out my soul's ultimate lament.
For its loss and destruction came about by my
own hand,
I strayed beyond return and though treated as a
son,
I turned hostile.
I stumbled from the heights of heaven and only
gathered thorns of life.
Moreover, I cry out,
for I defiled myself and turned myself into
an altar to the Destroyer.
There is also another ache in my heart,
for they consider me to be something I am not.
Like an outwardly sparkling cup, that is really
dirty,
or a whitewashed wall, that is filthy,
or a showoff dressed in vain conceit,
that is really a light engulfed in gloom,
a miserable eye blinded not by a speck, but a
stick,⁸
or an extinguished torch of glory,
destructive in all things, in all places, in all

⁷Rom. 6:12.

⁸Mt. 7:3.



ways,
toward the providence of the Lord,
toward the manifestations of Godliness,
toward the images shaped by the creator,
toward the fearfulness of humility,
toward the one, whom I saw with my own eyes,⁹
toward this, for which I am more accountable
than for the entire Gospel.
Amazement, shock,
gnawing cares, those infeasible intentions and
calculations beyond the mind's ken,
failed escapes, faulty landings,
deserved disappointments, fair reprimand,
appropriate ridicule, just denunciation,
well-deserved curses –
such are the accusations and self-inflicted
torments of my sinful self.

Է

And since you are able to forgive all these
transgressions and cure these deadly wounds,
Lord of mercies, God of all
Christ King, Son of the exalted Father,
creator, compassionate, beneficent,
blessed, generous, bountiful,
awesome, mighty, merciful,
guardian, rescuer, bulwark,
savior, reviver, resusciator,
long-suffering, unvengeful, refuge,
physician, praised, heavenly,
ineffable, light, life,
resurrection, renewal, atonement.

Ը

If you would look upon me with that goodwill
toward mankind as you do,
then as I contemplate you, I will cry out in an-
guish.
If you would listen, I will sigh.
If you would incline your ear, I will whisper a
prayer.
If you would take note, I will beseech you.
If you would forgive, I will ask forgiveness.

⁹Commentators through the centuries have inter-
preted this as a witness to St. Gregory's sainthood and
visions. Critical Edition p. 1026, n. 14.

If you would turn toward me, I will call.
For if you turn away, I will be ruined.
And if you kick me away, I will cry.
If you do not protect my soul, I shall die.
If you show me your terrible countenance, I
will perish.
And if you scold me, I will tremble.
If you glare at me, I will shake.
If you are stern, I cringe.
If you drive me away, I whimper.
If you knock me down, I will shatter.
If you do not put out the flames of despair, I
agonize.
If you despise me, I will flee.
If you threaten me, I will collapse.
If you examine me, I will be stoned.
If you look hard at me, I will sink.
If you do not spare me, I will be rejected.
If you summon me, I will be paranoid.
If you stare at me, I will be shamed.
If you call me, I will fear.
For I have betrayed the gift of goodness,
forsaken bliss, abandoned grace, disavowed
my word,
forgotten the gift of life, lost boldness and con-
fidence,
angered the creator of my being,
trampled that grace beyond words,
deformed the image of honor.

Թ

But if you, Lord Jesus, reach out
to me in loving-kindness as I suffocate with
sighs of pain,
then, as the Scriptures promised,
“Your cure will cleanse away the greatest
sins.”¹⁰
And through your boundless kindness
I will be joined to you, with your image of light
re-imprinted upon my soul.
Atoned and re-established in your salvation,
I will reach the immortal life of the virtuous
and give glory forever to you
with the Father and Holy Spirit.
Amen.

¹⁰Ec. 10:4.

Prayer 28 (ԽԹ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Which of my sins shall I confess now?
Which shall we examine?
On which kind shall I discourse?
How much of the hidden shall I uncover?
Which shall I confess –
the present, which I am still doing?
Or the past, which I have done?
Or the future, which I fear?
The slippery places, where I stumbled?
Those faults I thought small, but which
God reckoned large,
or the insubstantial, which are not worth mentioning?
The minor, which are many,
or the few, which are grave?
The psychological passions which are destructive
or the physical ailments which are deadly?
Those that began as easy pleasures,
or those that ended in destruction?
The invisible or visible?¹
Those committed directly by the hand,
or those committed indirectly by one's breath?
The scattershot of easy marks
or the arrow shots at length?
Those whose depth is beyond measure
or those that totally cover the surface?
Multifarious prostitution
or incurable illness?
The body swollen with evil
or the soul starved of the good?
The penchant for things unpleasing to God,
or the equally frenzied tugging at the leash of restraint?
The mortal sins or my vain thoughts?

Բ

Truly, like a willfully crazed person, stripped naked,

¹Gen. 3:3-7 (sin by reaching for the fruit of the tree of knowledge vs. sin by the breath of one's voice).

I display my waywardness openly,
contradicting the wise man who said
that the clever cover up their shame.²
I who am estranged from religion,
who am expelled from the ranks,
in holiness, profane; in celibacy, unclean,
in justice, iniquitous; in piety, wicked,
in words of my mouth, close to my creator,
but in my innermost organs, distant.
By my lips offering honor, as the Prophet says,
but not with my heart.³
And if I recount my full shame here,
I would tempt fate with a worse punishment,
for I am the unreliable servant,
vacillating between two paths,
both leading to damnation.⁴
I try, but I have no success.
I press forward, but I do not arrive.
I rush, but I am late.
I strain, but I do not see.
I desire, but I am not fulfilled.
I long, but I do not meet.
I have all earthly ills and thus can serve as
an emissary offering prayers for the whole world.

Գ

Forgive these sins, generous God,
and do not focus only on them.
It is easier for you to erase them than
for me to describe my vile actions.
Therefore I write without restraint
so you may blot them out,
you, who for the sake of us sinners
became long-suffering.
My soul, like Ezra's yearning heart,
is anxious, my spirit, restless
as I list these faults,⁵
showing how I am in danger of every mortal passion,
how I am fallen into a pit of sin.
And like Job I doubt you hear me.⁶
Now, as a self-accused, self-condemned captive,

²Pr. 12:16.

³Is. 29:13.

⁴1 Kg. 18:21.

⁵1 Ezra 8:72.

⁶Job 9:16



bound by sin, I turn myself in
and block all of life's possibilities.
But by your mercy toward me
your greatness is multiplied, praiseworthy
Lord.

¶

And as advised by the good prophet,
let us try to pray with him in song,
with our firm faith in God's protection,
"Give your word," says Hosea,
"And turn away from sin and toward the Lord
our God,
and say to him, 'Would you forgive our
sins?'"⁷
that you might be restored to the good,
that your souls might enjoy bliss.
God spoke, but who listened?
He himself gave witness, but who believed?

¶

These words, weighed and judged,
these terms describing God-given conditions,
this good news, this set of purposes,
this door to what is right,
this invitation to comfort,
this genuine picture,
the undiminishing treasure,
the indelible memory,
I hereby set down in faith,
and testify with the prophet –
that you are able to forgive all our sins,
thereby magnifying, exalting yourself,
for this wretched soul.
In this you reign, providing all,
reaching everywhere,
triumphing over all violence,
crumbling all hardness,
fending off all blows,
softening all severity,
overcoming all bitterness,
sweetening sourness,
lightening the inconsolable,
forgiving all debts,
remitting all transgressions,
you, able, mighty, master of all arts,

⁷Hos. 14:2, Is. 55:3.

submerge and destroy all sins and clear them
away,
as with a flash of lightning, which takes no
space,
but penetrates the depths and is enveloped by
the universal sea.

¶

Now, Father, through prayers offered by
the readers of this book,
have mercy, for the sake of the cross and
the suffering and death of your Son,
who is the source of the lamenting voice of
the one who sends these tearful psalms.⁸
May he who prepared this remedy for
the salvation of our souls
be made whole in your name, Almighty.
Let him who showed us the true path
through confession,
be clear of all his transgression.
Let him who taught us to clip the wings of our
pride
with his message on the rule of life
be released from the evil bonds of deadly sins
–
original, final and all in between.
Through the beneficence of your Trinity,
restore us to the light and
we will deem ourselves blissful with him.

¶

Now, Father creator
awesome name, miracle maker,
shuddering voice, familiar exclamation,
embracing thought, splendid effect, severe
command,
essence beyond examination, existence beyond
words,
reality beyond measure, might beyond thought,
good will, limitless dominion,
immeasurable greatness, exalted beyond com-
prehension,
quantity beyond weighing, supremacy
beyond surpassing,

⁸Commentators suggest that this section is dedicated
to St. Gregory's teachers or parents. Critical Edition, p.
1028, n. 11.



the origin of the Son by fatherhood, and not by
priority,
by you and through your unbounded power,
banish the tormenting and demonic frenzied
fever,
which slyly entered with sin.
Banish it from man so that
frightened by the wondrous and unending
stream
of blood of your heavenly lamb,
we might be cleansed forever.

ⲉ

And now, before your wonders, in abject hu-
mility,
may Satan shrink in shame at the evil deeds
of his angels, may he be tormented and driven
away,
banished and exiled, into the outer darkness,
from the altar of your dwelling place within us.
And when you have purged them, wipe the
tears
from our faces, erase the sobbing of
our voices from our hearts.
And in memory of the blows, like thorns in the
side,
mortal and terrifying, by which the Only Be-
gotten
was nailed to the cross,
may the evil one also suffer similar pain.
And may the blow to the side by the piercing
arrow,
gravely wound him and
kill the creator of death.
And since Satan bowed his haughty head,
before he breathed his last breath, O Exalted
One,
let rebellious Beliar with his evil ways
perish totally, condemned, vanquished.
And again, since the truly immortal was con-
cealed and
buried in the womb of the earth,
let the haughty see himself bound in the dark-
ness of
the shadows on the deadly pavement of hell.
And may he remember the first irreversible
blow
by which the resistance to the poisonous snake

died
at the price of the suffering of the almighty
Savior.

ⲁ

For your glory and in praise of your Son and
through
the Holy Spirit,
I confess this, Father of mercy,
for in the deep mystery of your unity,
one does not need the least power from the
other,
rather we glorify your Word made flesh
without beginning, along with the timeless Fa-
ther.
To you alone, Holy Trinity,
from one stem, indivisible self,
blessings, thanks and strength,
and the ineffable splendor of greatness,
felicitous balance and equality forever.
Amen.

Prayer 29 (ⲁ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

ⲁ

You alone are the origin of all goodness,
mercy beyond telling, Son of the one God on
high,
who made the whole day a purgatory for our
sins,¹
and not a house of condemnation.
You are for me the expectation of good news,
instead of a day of dread.
You, physician to the ailing,
shepherd to the lost sheep,
master to the servant under your care,
pure wine for the dejected,
curative ointment for the wounded,
freedom for the captives of sin,
blessing of goodness for the rejected,
seal of grace for the despised,
the calling to anointment for the dispossessed,

¹Lk. 17:4.



restoration to uprightness for the fallen,
a mighty fortress for the stumbling,
a sublime helping hand to the disgraced,
the gate to heaven for the doubting,
stairway to bliss for the depraved,
the straight way for the confused,
forgiving king for the trespasser,
sweet hope for the abandoned,
the outstretched hand of life for the banished.

բ

You alone are great and generous in everything.
You are the definition of abundant goodness,
who pours forth constantly without measure,
more than we ask or expect,
as Paul said in gratitude.²
For you commanded that we should do good,
from dawn to dusk, in the same day,
nine times fifty, plus three, plus four times ten.³
Always attentive, forgiving with an unfettered heart,
something more than the expectation of men's prayers.
And if we place my wretchedness and disgrace beside
your glory, omnipotent and awesome power,
God of all, blessed Lord Christ,
by what measure of weight shall the balance
between
the creator and the clay be set?
You remain in these things infinite and unexam-
inable,
good in all things, having no part in the wrath
of darkness; therefore, far less are the number
of
stars than your greatness,⁴
for you called them into existence from nothing
by merely pronouncing their names.
Or take the mass of the earth floating in air,

²Eph. 3:20.

³Mt. 18:21-22. The total, 493, is greater than the forgiveness - 7 times 70, required by Jesus' commandment. Some mss. leave the "three" out. However, it has been interpreted to be a mystical number - which when factored and written in Armenian numerical notation spells out the word "five," which is the number of daily church services. Critical Edition, p. 1032-33, n. 5.

⁴Ps. 146:4

created from nothing, from which you established the dry land of earth.
These are less than the number I formulated above,
by which you taught us to be like you in forgiveness.

գ

As the radiant light of your long-suffering will dispelled all evil without trace,
like a speck of fog in the heat of the sun,
so here, our natural impulses are shown in our common behavior.
For who among mortals has sinned and not regretted?
Who has been corrupted and not been ashamed?
Who has been base and not been humiliated?
Who has faltered and not repented?
Who has been ruined and not sobbed?
Who has been scandalized and not felt compunction?
Who has been defeated and not closed his mouth?
Who has been cheated and not sighed?
Who has tasted bile and not become bitter?
Who has fallen from the heights and not been disheartened?
Who has lost greatness and not mourned?
Who has been deprived of happiness and not cried?
Who has been robbed of the grace of glory and not lamented?
Who has done harm to his soul and not been embarrassed?
Who has been banished from God's sight and not felt the loss of his gaze?
Who has heard God's warnings and not trembled?
Who has made one mistake and not sighed "alas"
a thousand times?
Who has bared himself on a winter's day and not shivered?
Who has done wrong and not pelted himself with
stones in his mind?
Who has seen the high and mighty slave and



not been vexed?
 Who has done evil and not cursed himself?
 Who has cultivated vices and not condemned
 his soul?
 Who has done shameful things and
 not made a mockery of his body?
 Who has had hard times and not cursed his life?
 Who has remembered his misdeeds and not
 stewed?
 Who has recalled secrets and not become flus-
 tered?
 Who has seen the dark side and
 not sought the perdition of death?
 Who has had visions of the invisible and
 not hung his head back to earth?
 Who has committed sins of ease and not burned
 with
 the inextinguishable flames of the furnace?
 Who has violated nature, and not been
 parched?
 Who has acted willfully and not prayed for
 his own death?
 Who has done the unspeakable and
 not become disturbed?
 Who has unbearably violated his essence and
 not grieved?
 Who has become high and mighty and
 not been worn down?
 Who has committed acts that corrupt innocence
 and
 not burned?
 Who has done things condemnable by banish-
 ment and not been anguished?
 Who has appeared with a grimy face and
 not felt deserving of the heaven's disapproval?
 Who has focused on one of his major sins and
 not been wounded by sin's weaponry?
 Who has committed a scandalous act and
 not woven the discouraging woe into
 the sighs of his voice?
 Who has been ousted from his chair in heaven
 and has not fallen down cringing?
 Who has placed dirt on his head instead of
 a splendid halo and not been tortured with a
 thousand deaths?
 Who has put on sack cloth instead of a bright
 cloak and not been sad?
 Who has lost his life and not sweat tears of

blood?
 Who has clothed himself in darkness instead of
 light and not fainted?
 Who has mourned for a loved one and not
 wilted?



These then faithfully describe me,
 the sinner deserving reprimand,
 a sad face, an extinguished ray, dried up liquid,
 shriveled lips,
 a deformed mould, a dispirited soul, a distorted
 voice,
 a twisted neck.
 It would not be wrong to classify me as
 a mind stripped of arrogance, a heart stripped
 of pride,
 a wretch afraid to ask for help, too parched to
 pray,
 self-scolding wanderer,
 starved by self-denial, hungry because of
 duly earned torment,
 struck down by just condemnation, condemned
 to death by self-incrimination,
 deservedly exiled, self-cursed outcast,
 like the Pharisee who was rejected
 and the sinful tax collector who was pleasing
 to God.⁵



And now, if the Slanderer takes credit
 as part of his day's work,
 for planting his bad seeds
 and using his evil devices on us, the wayward,
 why should you not count one by one the good
 things
 that by your will and saving care
 are planted in us to fortify our souls,
 Lord of merciful kindness, mighty and victori-
 ous,
 you who atone for our sins,
 who are salvation in all things for everything?
 If you can exchange the abyss for heaven,
 or bring the dark of night into the light,
 if you can turn the bitter bile into sweet manna,
 or the groans of extreme grief

⁵Lk. 18:9-14.



into the dancing circles at a joyful wedding,
if for you these are easy and possible,
then you can do more than these,
you who reign over all in awesome power.
To you glory forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 30 (I)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Now, let us see the truth of your words,
O merciful God of all,
who forgives and blesses the sinner,
even the sinner faltering many times a day,
if he turns back repentant,
even if the choice to turn back is made
with his last breath,
or in the very midst of sinning,¹
especially since our cruel companion,
as we try to govern ourselves,
is the always contrary, lying, cheating,
flattering Instigator,
the same who, in the words of the Proverbs,
grazes on the wind.²
My wayward body, which has been an unruly
fugitive
from you, my creator, and easy prey for the
Predator,
is like the thorns among the wheat³ endlessly
wavering
on any excuse, so often only you can keep
track.
And then comes the pitiful wail,
which follows the sinning,
hopeless and tormented, hear me sighing,
“alas”
as I come before you, Lord,
with pleas for mercy and wretched groans,
written with tears, humbled by pangs of guilt
caused
by the distress of boundless evil.

¹Mt. 18:21.

²Pr. 9:12.

³Mt. 13:24.

P

So that the repetition does not add up
to mere wordiness,
I will make my plea even more pathetic
because a sinner does not dare ask for paradise
but only reduced torment.
He does not ask to be among the immortals,
who live in the light,
but only among the feeling, breathing beings
destined for
the dark grave,
not among the resurrected,
but among broken hearted and contrite,⁴
justly deserving in death, restrained in their
merriment,
with a smiling face but an anguished mind,
cheerful demeanor but mournful eyes,
composed appearance but bitterly tearful heart.

Q

Two cups in two hands
one filled with blood, the other with milk,
two censers flickering
one with incense, the other with crisp fat,
two platters piled with delicacies,
one sweet, the other tart,
two goblets overflowing
one with tears, the other with brimstone,
two bowls at the finger tips
one with wine, the other with bile,
two windows of sight
one crying, the other erring,
two refiner's cauldrons
one heating, one cooling,
two outlooks on one face
one mildly affectionate, the other fiercely rag-
ing,
two lifted hands
one to strike, the other to shield,
two grimaces
one dejected, the other angry,
two rebukes at a time
one for now, the other for later,
two hideouts for doubt
one “at least,” the other “perhaps,”
two sighs in one mouth,

⁴Ps. 51:19



one for misfortune, the other for confusion,
 two impulses in one heart,
 one of doubtful hope, the other of certain
 doom,
 two downpours from one dark cloud,
 one of arrows, one of stones,
 two thunderous downpours
 one of hail, the other of fire,⁵
 two sorrows of a painful night,
 one disease, the other death,⁶
 two insults to sad mourning,
 one of rebuke, the other threat,
 two suns on opposite horizons
 one dark, the other blazing.⁷



And if a fist is raised, he cringes as if it is for
 him.
 If a hand bearing gifts is extended, he thinks
 it is for someone else.
 If someone swaggers, he cowers.
 If another's head is high, his hangs low.
 If evil is recalled, he sighs.
 If the saintly are remembered, he is ashamed.
 If the next life is mentioned, he trembles.
 If someone blesses him, he curses the blesser.
 If someone praises him, he puts himself down.
 If he is criticized, he agrees.
 If viciously ridiculed, he considers it just.
 If someone wishes his death, he seconds it.
 If death thunders in, he barely raises his head.
 His book of rights slammed shut,
 his hope of being heard abandoned,
 his path of action checked,
 he would not hesitate at suicide
 to gain release from this dead end,
 if that did not foreclose salvation.
 In the words of the soulful wise man,
 truly, woeful is the sinner
 standing in doubt at the fork in the road.⁸



Why don't you take pity, benevolent God,
 upon my wailing and sighing,

⁵Ex. 9:23-24.

⁶Lam. 1:2, 2 Cor. 7:10.

⁷Rev. 6:12, 7:16.

⁸Sir. 2:14.

you, whose name is exalted for saying,
 "I am the merciful Lord"?⁹
 Grant your goodness in the face of
 my slavish wickedness,
 your sweetness before my bitterness at being
 condemned to death,
 your beacon for my lost self, found again,
 your mercy upon my brazen waywardness,
 your humility before my destructive impu-
 dence,
 your right arm to protect me from peril,
 your hand to save me from drowning,
 your finger to mend my incurable wounds,¹⁰
 your spirit to defend my traumatized soul,
 your patience for my insolent ingratitude,
 your strength upon anointing a scoundrel like
 me,
 your commandments as atonement for my sins,
 your foot as a refuge for a runaway like me,
 your arm protecting a fugitive like me,
 your light guiding a wayward soul like me,
 your wisdom reassuring a doubter like me,
 your blessedness for accepting the cursed like
 me,
 your goad as encouragement for the
 disheartened like me,
 your cup as comfort for the grieving like me,
 your will as relief for the anguished like me,
 your love calling even those despised like me,
 your word to steady those wavering like me,
 your bloodshed for wounded souls like me,
 your care for my ever increasing, unseen pains,
 your mentorship for choosing me in my de-
 spair,
 your communion rejoining those cut off like
 me,¹¹
 your spark of life under death's shadow like
 me,
 your serenity for those troubled like me,
 your welcome for those harshly persecuted like
 me,
 your beckoning voice to those who have
 strayed like me,
 for you rule all with mercy.
 With you there is no darkness,

⁹Ex. 22:27.

¹⁰Mk. 7:33.

¹¹Rom. 11:23.



and without you no goodness,
and yours is the glory forever.
Amen.

Prayer 31 (II)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

And now, since I have increased
the distress of my sighing voice
with great cries and inconsolable grief,
so that you, merciful forefather
of confession of invisible secrets,¹
Son of the living God, Lord Jesus Christ,²
might look with kindness and grant atonement,
for you are indeed able and truly sufficient.
If you want, you have the means;
as much as you want, you can do,³
you, who are more enriched by giving than receiving.⁴
Your treasure increases more by sharing than gathering.
Your estate grows more by disbursing than collecting.
Your stores pile up more by distributing than hoarding.
All this gives me faith that through you
I might find the path to salvation.
I, the disgraced, believe along with the honorable.
I hope with Abraham and Anna,
one of whom believed your word,⁵
and the other listened to the words
of the high priest—and for that, in old age,
became the father of countless sons.⁶
He hoped to see the barren womb of Sarah
as the fertile and blessed field of many peoples:
saints, prophets, and chosen kings.
And the other, Anna,

¹Is. 1:18; 43:25, Mt. 9:2.

²Jn. 8:10, 20:23.

³Mt. 8:2.

⁴Acts 20:35.

⁵Gen. 17:16.

⁶1 Kg. 1:17.

with the untilled field of her womb,⁷
abounded with fruit of seven children,
a mystical number symbolizing the eternity of
Him, who is, and the unexamined bonds of
the eternity of the Godhead and the unending
abundance of children of the baptismal font,
the glorious number which is unpunctuated,
an infinite decimal,
rather it is a prime number, inherently unique
and eternal,
whose nature is eternally beyond telling
and difficult for our minds to comprehend.

P

And now count this small confession of faith in
prayer
toward the justification and salvation of
my hopeless soul.
Hear the quivering voice of the cries of my
sighing heart,
and rank me with those blessed souls just described,
so that I too might live with them and share in
their bliss.
Trusting more in your grace than my works,⁸
since grace is far more exalted and glorious,
far greater than anything that can be
measured by words—
a comfort to my distress and atonement for my
sins,
beyond the feeble reach of our minds,
for with your awe-inspiring blood
and the mother of your incarnation, worthy of
adoration,
the circle of the apostles, ranks of prophets,
host of martyrs, both cavalry and foot soldiers,
armed only with courage, wrestlers with fate,
platoons of hermits, orders of learned teachers,
assemblies of the pious, legions of heavenly
spirits on earth,
the heavenly patrol of guards, the offering of
the first fruits,
sacrifice of bulls, lighting of lanterns,
the aroma of incense, the fragrance of scented
oils,
the victorious sign of salvation,

⁷1 Kg. 2:5.

⁸Rom. 11:6.



the erection of altars where God dwells,
the hands of the priests that rest with grace.⁹

¶

The soul's every movement
is a reminder of God,
the taking of a step,
the extension of the right hand,
the raising of the arm,
with thanks for good works,
with shame for bad,
for familiar conversation
and public addresses,
in rational discourse,
in works of success,
in the fervor of virtue,
day and night,
we are guided by you
in the useful movements for our spirit,
asleep or awake,
in mortal battles or combat with demons,
in large and small struggles with heretics,
while drinking or eating,
in all that once stirred feelings,
whether pleasant or unpleasant,
with the pleasant we pray to remain,
and from the unpleasing, through your
miraculous intercession,
we pray to be free.
For you are capable of all things, as we all be-
lieve,
the suckling infants, rash youths,
immoral men, haughty outlaws,
even the actor and the motley mob,
even in the dancing
and clapping of hands that do not please
your will, Almighty,
you are not forgotten.

¶

You have created all and all is yours,
you who are all-compassionate, take mercy on
all,
and even those who sin are yours,

⁹Priests were often buried under altars with hands folded in prayer. Thanks to Prof. Abraham Terian of St. Nersess Seminary for this insight.

for they are in your accounting,
for they know your strength,
even as the Proverb teller said,¹⁰
whose prayer I echo with my wretched words,
testifying like a criminal,
I dare to say
that whoever praises your name
recognizes your existence, and though he be
tainted by the sevenfold sins,¹¹
deserving of double punishment
to set a good example, yet,
he is yours, is he not?
For sometimes in the midst of black crows
one sees a flock of white doves,
and in the middle of wild, unkempt horses,
will be a tame sheep,
in the midst of beastly dogs, a sacrificial lamb,
and mildness amid harshness,
perfection amid defects,
humility amid haughtiness,
truth amid lies,
simplicity amid cunning,
purity amid perversity,
kindness amid wickedness,
honesty amid depravity,
mercy amid cruelty,
repentance amid despair,
sweetness amid anger,
reconciliation amid hostility,
forbearance amid sarcasm,
encouragement amid insults,
blessings amid slings and arrows,
that being why I could never understand,
who among us earthly born is destined
for your inheritance, for
you alone judge fairly
and distinguish
the impious who thinks himself pure,
and the prostitute who is repentant,¹²
O only king and benefactor of all,
blessed in the highest and in all things forever.
Amen.

¹⁰Wis. 15:2.

¹¹Gen. 4:15-24.

¹²Lk. 18:10, Jn. 8:11.



Prayer 32 (LÆ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

And now, being bereft of all the virtues mentioned
and seeing myself among those who
should be punished, I pray for mercy
with the prayers of all others,
with the defeated and timid,
the weak and small,
the fallen and despised,
the banished and returned,
the doubter and the true believer,
the disgraced and the exalted,
the repressed and the upright,
the stumbling and the standing,
the rejected and the accepted,
the hated and the called,
the stupefied and the sober,
the wayward and the restrained,
the exiled and the invited,
the disowned and the beloved,
the dejected and the cheerful,
the somber and the joyful.

Æ

But here I will not recount again the sins of Jerusalem,
as Micah commanded concerning his forefathers,¹
or as Isaiah told of Jacob's iniquity,²
rather I will reveal my own transgressions,
for with the peril of death upon me, I utter,
"Alas," like the prophet Micah,³
and reproach myself like the Psalmist,
so that my full confession might find favor,
and I will not need to say "alas" again,
but might be at once cleansed completely by
your blessed command.
Now, again upon my knees, before your
sweet beneficence,
I open my soul before you,

¹Mic. 1:1-7.

²Is. 58:1.

³Mic. 7:1, Jl. 1:15.

showing how I sink like an image of death,
like the crawling beasts
lowered to the ground and covered in dust,
I, who nailed myself on the path of destruction
in
this fleeting life.
Let me lean upon you, Lord, staff of life,
body springing from the root of David,
inexplicably joined to your uncreated divinity.
I stand bowed and humbled before you, good
Lord,
with my face turned to the ground
and my eyes raised to you on high,
gazing pathetically upon you
who hears our sighing,
perfectly compassionate, thoroughly sweet,
a lake filled with tears of light,
I offer prayers of hope to your majesty.

Q

O totally generous God, whose patience never
ends,
hear me though I cause you bitterness.
You alone are the means of our salvation,
God of all, great beyond telling,
nature beyond comprehension,
truth beyond examination,
mighty power, able benefactor, unending calm,
indescribable inheritance, fitting fortune,⁴
abundant preparation, unobscured wisdom,
fervent gift, desirable offering,
longed-for bliss, peace unspoiled by sadness,
discovery beyond doubt, life that cannot be
wrenched away,
estate that cannot be sold, exaltation that
cannot be exchanged,
doctor of all arts, unshakable foundation,
who turns back the wayward, finds the lost,
gives hope to those who seek refuge, light for
those in darkness,
forgiveness for sinners, a sanctuary for run-
aways,
calm for the troubled, salvation for the dead,
who liberates the captive, frees the betrayed,
steadies the slipping,
grieves with the scandalized,

⁴Ps. 16:5-6.



suffers the doubters,
 O vision of light, sign of rejoicing, rain of blessing,
 breath of our nostrils, strength of our visage,
 covering of our head.⁵
 O mover of lips, inspirer of speech,
 helmsman of the soul, lifter of hands, extender
 of arms, who holds the reins of the heart,
 O voice of a friend, called like one of the family,
 genuine antiphon, fatherly minister of care,
 name given in confession, worshiped image,
 boundless stamp for communion wafers,⁶
 lordship before which we bow, eulogized memory,
 gateway to joy, unfailing path, door to glory,
 way of truth, ladder to heaven,
 worthy of a multitude of other praises,⁷
 of infinite forms and verses without end,
 which an earthbound mouth cannot pronounce
 and the body lacks the stamina to say
 and the soul's yearnings cannot sustain.



All eyes turn to you, O God of all.
 Incline your ear toward the prayers of
 the weeping voices of your servants and hand-
 maidens.
 Accept the dew of my woeful song, the tears of
 my sore
 eyes, upon the immaculate feet of your human-
 ity, Christ,
 as you did when the sinner Mary washed your
 feet with her hair and tears.⁸
 Let me return to you professing faith with
 the kiss of my lips upon tasting the communion
 of
 life's salvation, beneficent God,
 mercifully having received union with the same
 spirit
 and the same compassion as the sinful woman.
 I hope for the pledge of your great gifts
 in exchange for my meager faith.
 And through the compassion of your love for

⁵Gen. 2:7, Lam. 4:20.

⁶Rev. 3:5.

⁷Jn. 14:6.

⁸Lk. 7:37-50.

me,
 your servant who proclaims your cherished
 name,
 may the severe winter winds become tranquil
 air,
 the gusty storm become a pleasant breeze,
 the misgivings of fear become great confi-
 dence,
 the meting out of punishment turn into bliss,
 the perils of grief become spiritual rejoicing,
 the tossing waves calm into placid water,
 the arm-wrenching helm turn toward a safe har-
 bor,
 the harvest of heavy sin be transformed into
 a stipend of grace.



And for the myriad of good things from you,
 may your mighty name be magnified, pro-
 claimed and honored with incense.
 May the instigator of evil be embarrassed,
 rejected and persecuted.
 May the mortgage of sin be annulled,
 may the snares be cut loose, the traps removed,
 may the ties be undone, the abyss eliminated,
 may perils be lifted, deceit torn away,
 may the mortgage of sin be annulled,
 may yokes fall off, ploughs unhitched,
 and instead of the gloomy darkness of
 evil transgressions,
 and the siege of the armies of demons,
 may the sun of your glory shine forth,
 giving life, salvation and light,
 from the right and the left, the front and the
 back.
 And may the morning rays of the soul's spring-
 time shine
 upon those who await your coming.
 For you are charitable and comforting in all
 things,
 and all things are possible for you,
 you who want life and salvation for all.⁹



O hand of Jesus Christ, giver of all gifts,
 turn also toward me extending your grace.

⁹Jn. 10:10.



Dwell in me, become a part of me and do not leave
 my anguished soul, the chamber of love.
 And may your incorruptible image,
 a token of the brilliant light beckoning us
 to Christian salvation,
 stay with me to intercede for my entry
 in the book of your legacy of eternal life,
 Holy Spirit of the Gospel and heavenly creator.
 And to you who are your own sole cause,
 and to you, the only begotten of the sole cause,
 and to you who bear the sole cause,
 three persons in one Godhead,
 worthy of glory from the greatest of mortals
 and the ranks of saints,
 forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 33 (IQ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Let this offering of words, compassionate God,
 from the fruits of my soul rise to you with incense,
 mixed by you with the sweet oil
 used by the pious Mary,¹
 which you accepted with respect
 just as you also accept offerings astonishingly
 from prostitutes, fortunate to be making offerings.
 May my humble words also praise you and may you
 accept their reaching toward
 your unreachable head, God on high,
 in spite of the reproach of the Psalmist,
 "Do not let the leafy boughs of my head
 be anointed with the oil of the sinner."²

P

Let the perfume, the bouquet of this book of confessions
 be redoubled and affect multitudes.

¹Mt. 26:6-13.

²Ps. 141:5.

Let its memory be told everywhere and fill the world
 like the fragrant oil in the house of Lazarus.³
 For you are the same Lord who brought
 the sinful plotting women to their senses.⁴
 And their character you transformed in your true image,
 as in the allegory of the prophet.⁵
 By changing them you made me know
 the perfection of your grace.
 Instead of barley for livestock you provided
 the abundant wheat of the bread of life.
 Instead of tarnishing silver you presented
 your majestic image.
 Instead of the oil taken from the wanton women of old,⁶
 you anointed me with your grace.
 Instead of shredding burial bindings around the head,
 there is an incorruptible cloak.
 Instead of elaborate handcuffs, a free soaring toward
 perfect virtue according to the law and the Gospels.
 Instead of a splendid earring, the unfading memory
 of your lordly voice.
 Instead of a sparkling necklace, the bountiful inheritance
 of the sweet yoke of your righteous faith.

Q

But am I proud of these writings,
 rather than feeling shame again?
 Why change my style in this prayer book,
 in woeful song, to suit my fancy
 and earn punishment as sin's wages?
 Citing briefly the words of the prophet,
 I enter this chamber solemnly like a stern prosecutor,
 my charges prepared,
 and rather than reveling in them,
 I enter with weeping, a sighing voice in angry protest,

³Jn. 12:3, Mt. 26:13.

⁴Gen. 38, Jos. 2:1-21, 6:22-25.

⁵Hos. 1-2, 3:2-3.

⁶Gen. 38, Jos. 2:1-21, 6:22-25.



with bruising insults and grave wailing.
But your lovingkindness, O great God,
that reaches everyone,
awakened in me hope as well,
whence comes my regret, confession,
good news, gifts, visions of light,
divine encouragement, splendid visions,
the source of hope for some,
the source of despair for others,
and for me, who willingly destroyed myself,
my portion of perdition.



If Ezekiel said that under God's disguising
cloak
many people patch together idols⁷
and act like harlots –
how much more severe will my punishment be
for cloaking my unclean self in God inside and
out?

I am amazed that I am not consumed in flames.
I am astonished that I am not burning up.
I am confounded that I am not taken hostage,
tortured, abandoned, tormented, beaten,
pulverized, cracked, crushed, torn to shreds
in the jaws of the Satan our destroyer
according to Scripture.⁸

All that is left for me
is the glimmer of a memory of
hope of salvation. For the Gospel of Christ
is truly life revealed where there is
for our sins, forgiveness,
for debts, grace,
for decay, renewal,
for iniquity, atonement,
for wounds, bandages,
for distress, calm,
for punishment, pardon,
for war, peace,
for fire, rain,
for condemnation, rewards,
for the dread of dying, lenience,
for the destruction of death, the salvation of
life.



⁷Ezek. 16:16.

⁸Dt. 32:24.

How can I enumerate so many things here yet
neglect
to include what is beyond words? When speak-
ing
of the exalted Father, we must remember our
tie
to the Son, the only begotten son of the Father.
And remembering these two we must com-
mune with
the Holy Spirit, remembering also
that with the cross comes salvation,
with the word, comfort,
with God's all-knowing judgment,
the reward of good will,
with the life-giving font of baptism,
the mediation of reconciliation,
as well as all other countless blessings, be-
stowed by God:
freedom from compulsion, freedom from the
yoke,
freedom to rule oneself and not be ruled.
These are the comforting heralds of the life to
come
in the midst the bitterness of death.
For if I did not have these things,
surely I would have perished long ago,
as the Psalmist says.⁹

I do not glorify the Father by disparaging the
Son.

Nor is the Holy Spirit subordinated by
naming the Son first.

I hold the Trinity equal in glory and in creation
co-created, for there are prayers to the Holy
Spirit
to be offered before the Divine Liturgy,
when the heavenly lamb is sacrificed I pray this
way:



Almighty, beneficent God of all, who
loves mankind, maker of the visible and
invisible,
savior and creator,
defender and peacemaker, spirit of the Father
Almighty,
we beseech you with outstretched arms,

⁹Ps. 119:92.



tears and prayers,
 as we appear before you,
 you, who strike terror in our hearts,
 judge us as we approach with trembling and fear,
 presenting first this sacrificial offering of words to your power that is beyond understanding.
 You share the throne, glory and creatorship of the undiminishing honor of the Father.
 You examine our deepest secrets and mysteries.¹⁰
 O Emmanuel, who fulfill the will of your Father
 who sent you as the Savior, life-giver and creator.
 Through you he is made known to us,
 three persons in one Godhead,
 of which only you, incomprehensibly, can be known.
 By you and through you did our forefathers,
 the first generation of the patriarchal tribe,
 called prophets,
 tell of the past and the future,
 what has been and what is yet to come,
 in plain words and images.
 Spirit of God, Moses proclaimed you as the one
 who brooded on the water, an unbounded force,¹¹
 taking the new-born under your protective wing with care,
 and with lovingkindness revealing the mystery of
 the baptismal font.
 Likewise, in the pattern of the archetype,
 before fashioning the pliable substance with its final covering,¹²
 you shaped, in lordly manner, all nature,
 the full range of existence, all beings from nothing.
 Through you all that has been created shall receive

the renewal of the resurrection
 on the last day of this life
 and the first day in the land of the living.
 Christ obeyed you with unity of will as he did his Father,
 being of the same family, of the same essence as the Father.
 Being the first born son in our image,
 he announced you, true God,
 equal and consubstantial with his mighty Father,
 He preached against those who blasphemed you,
 and, as opponents of God, spoke impiously against you.

He silenced the blasphemous mouths and graced
 his own people,¹³
 he, the just and spotless, who finds all,
 who was betrayed for our sins,
 and rose from the dead to justify us.¹⁴
 Through you glory to him and praise to you,
 with the Father almighty, forever and ever.
 Amen.

✠

Again, I shall continue in this manner
 until the assurance of the miraculous light
 heralds the good news of peace.
 With all our souls
 we pray and beseech you with tearful cries,
 glorious creator, incorruptible and uncreated,
 timeless Holy Spirit of compassion.
 You are the intercessor of our silent sighs to your merciful Father.¹⁵
 You, who keep the saints, purify the sinners and
 build the temple of the living and life-giving will of the Father,
 free me now from all unclean deeds,
 which are not pleasing for your dwelling place.
 Do not extinguish the light of grace
 in us and in our minds' eye,
 for we have learned that you will join us

¹⁰1 Cor. 2:10.

¹¹Gen. 1:2, Mk. 6:48-53.

¹²Gen. 2:5-6; thanks to Prof. Abraham Terian of St Nersess Seminary for his insightful reading of this passage.

¹³Mt. 12:31.

¹⁴Rom. 4:25.

¹⁵Rom. 8:26; 1 Cor. 3:16.



through prayer and sumptuous incensing.¹⁶
 One of the Trinity is sacrificed and the other
 accepts it,
 favoring us with the reconciling blood of his
 first born
 so that you might accept our supplications.
 Prepare for us honorable lodgings
 for the partaking of your heavenly lamb,
 that we might eat life-giving manna of the new
 salvation
 and escape the punishments of condemnation.
 Our blasphemy shall be purified in the refiner's
 fire,
 as the prophet told of the live coal in the tongs
 of
 offering at the altar.¹⁷
 In all things you spread your mercy through
 the Son of God.
 Also spread the sweetness of the Father,
 as you embraced the prodigal son with
 fatherly inheritance,
 and led the prostitute to the bliss of
 the heavenly kingdom.

¶

Yes, yes, and I too am one of them.
 Receive me with them,
 as one who is needy of your great love for
 mankind,
 one who lives only by your grace, redeemed by
 the blood of Christ,
 so that your divinity might be revealed and in
 all ways glorified.
 You are honored equally with the Father,
 with one will and one rule, worthy of praise.
 For yours is compassion, ability and lov-
 ingkindness,
 might and glory forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 34 (ԼԴ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

¹⁶Mt. 18:20, 1 Cor. 6:17.

¹⁷Is. 6:6-25.

Here is my profession of faith, here,¹
 the yearnings of my wretched breath to you
 who constitute all things with your Word, God.
 What I have discoursed upon before, I set forth
 again,
 these written instructions and interpretations
 for the masses of different nations.
 I offer these prayers of intercession
 in the thanksgiving prayer below.

¶

I pray to your unchanging, almighty Spirit:
 Send the dew of your sweetness upon my soul
 to rule over the impulses of my senses.
 Send the all-filling gifts of your merciful grace
 and cultivate the reasoning fields hardened by
 my heart,
 that they might bear the fruit of your spiritual
 seeds.
 All gifts that flourish and grow with us,
 Teacher,
 come from your all-encompassing wisdom.²
 You who laid hands on the apostles,
 filled the prophets,
 taught the teachers,
 made the speechless speak,
 and opened the ears of the deaf.
 You, of the same family as the first and
 only begotten Son of your consubstantial Fa-
 ther,
 carry all this out through your mutual effort.
 You proclaimed as the co-equal of your Father,
 grant me, a sinner, to speak boldly of the life-
 giving,
 mystery of the good news of your Gospel,
 that I might follow with soaring mind,
 the infinite course of the inspired breath of
 your testament.
 And when I embark upon the solemn interpre-
 tation
 of the Word, send me first your compassion,

¹This prayer, along with parts of Prayers 34, 35, 75, 97, 92 and 93, is believed by leading commentators to be part of an earlier apologetic work that St. Gregory wrote circa 987, during a period of doctrinal tension between the Armenian and Byzantine and Georgian Churches. See, S. Boghosian, Narekatsu Hetkerov, 31.

²The next 6 lines from the Jerusalem text, since the critical edition was garbled.



and let it speak through me
 in a manner worthy, useful and pleasing to you,
 in glory and praise for your Godhead,
 and in the silence of the universal church.
 Extend over me your right hand,
 and fortify me with your grace.
 Clear my mind of the fog of forgetfulness,
 dispelling the darkness of sin,
 that I might rise above this earthly life through
 wisdom.
 May the dawn of that unobscured miracle,
 the knowledge of your Godliness,
 shine within me again, Almighty.
 To be worthy to do and teach
 and be an example of goodness for god-loving
 listeners.
 To you all glory in all things,
 with your Father almighty and
 your only begotten and benevolent Son,
 now and forever, without end. Amen.

¶

The creed of the co-existing Holy Trinity,
 the rule of life and grace of salvation,
 I taught in the following way:
 We confess and profess, honor and worship
 the shared glory and unity of the Holy Trinity,
 Godhead beyond description, always good,
 of the same substance, equal in honor,
 beyond the flight of the wings of our thought,
 higher than all examples, beyond all analogies,
 surpassing the limits on high.
 Before the creation of eternal undifferentiated
 matter
 and the categories of creatures
 with blessing that cannot be translated,
 crowned forever with the richest greatness,
 setting time in motion and all that has taken
 shape as time unfolds,
 himself the cause and shaper of everything vis-
 ible
 and invisible,
 who cannot be defined by name or denoted by
 label,
 nor likened in quality, nor weighed in quantity,
 nor formed by rules, nor known by kind,
 nor spread to exhaustion,
 nor occupying space,

nor appearing in a place.

¶

Father of compassion, God of the universe,
 creator of everything in heaven and on earth
 except the only begotten Word, through whom
 all things exist, creator and giver of breath to
 all things
 except for the consubstantial Holy Spirit,
 through whom you formed all else.

¶

One of three glorified persons equal in power
 and awe,
 who descended from on high to here below,
 who was indeed by nature indistinguishable
 from those below,
 without relinquishing the throne of glory,
 without leaving the watchful gaze of the parent
 of love,
 merely entering the vessel of the virgin womb
 purely
 and coming out joined with a body
 inseparable in essence,
 without any flaw in his humanity and lacking
 nothing in divinity,
 one and only Son of the only Father and
 the first born of the Mother of God, Virgin
 Bearer
 of the Lord,
 creator becoming a true man as originally cre-
 ated,
 not in the fallen state of mortals,
 but new and splendid with the sublime glory of
 kings,
 not seen in the ages or existing in time.
 The first born, as the Psalmist said,
 higher than all the kings of earth,³
 formed from an incorruptible combination
 like us in body,
 in the manner of the soul with body,
 and as gold with fire,
 or to put it more plainly,
 light in air, neither transformed nor separated.

¶

³Ps. 89:27.



He submitted himself willingly to the cross of death,
 like an innocent lamb led to slaughter,⁴
 and girded himself with mighty self-discipline
 for the salvation of those he created.
 He truly suffered like a mortal.
 He was placed in a tomb with no special treatment for his divinity.
 On the third day, in the hell of Tartarus,
 he preached to the
 downcast captives and showed renewal and light.
 And having carried out his providential mission of redemption,
 he came back to life as God,
 and ruled on the wings of the winds,
 rising upon the Cherubim,
 covered in an inscrutable cloud.⁵
 He ascended into heaven on high,
 sat in splendor upon the throne bequeathed to him
 from the beginning, equal with his Father,
 from whom he had never been separated,
 neither losing what had been acquired,
 nor diluting that which was his own.
 Therefore, he shall come to the judgment of retribution,
 examining the unseen with the scales of justice,
 for which we wait and pray
 with faith in his almighty Lordship over and through all,
 who truly is the only one of the only one
 in equal glory forever worshiped as one.

†

We always praise along with the Son and Father, the Holy Spirit,
 which is of the same essence,
 mighty, true, perfect and holy,
 who from nothing brought into existence everything that exists,
 who acts through itself and shares rule with the other two,
 in the same indestructible, boundless kingdom,
 who is the first cause, the awesome Word of his selfhood.

⁴Is. 53:7.

⁵Ps. 18:11

And the same exalted Holy Spirit,
 good ruler, who dispenses the gifts of the Father,
 in praise of the name and the glory of the only begotten Son,
 who acted through the Laws and inspired the Prophets,
 with the encouragement of your co-equal Son commissioned your apostles.⁶
 In the form of a dove you appeared at the River Jordan,
 for the greater glory of the one who had come,
 shone forth in the writings of the evangelists,
 created genius, strengthened the wise,
 filled the teachers, blessed the kingdom,
 assisted the kings, appointed the guardians,
 issued the decree of salvation, granted talents,
 prepared atonement,⁷
 cleansed those baptized into Christ's death that you might dwell in them
 a sacrament performed jointly by the Father and
 Son with the Holy Spirit,
 who is God, honored as Lord, in all ways in all things.

¶

Being named first among the Trinity does not make one greater than the other,
 or being named after the other, less than the rest,
 or by saying that they are one, that there is a confusion of persons,
 or by dividing into three, a separation of wills.
 For the Father would be diminished if he did not have the power of the Word
 so too if he did not have the Holy Spirit and was speechless,
 lifeless and deprived of any power to command.
 And the Word, if it were not known by the name of the Father,
 would be abandoned like some orphan or just another mortal being.
 Similarly the Holy Spirit, if not commissioned

⁶Jn. 20:22.

⁷Rom. 6:3.



by its cause,
would be vagabond, an unruly wind.⁸



But if one presumes in a refutation
to snatch the Father from his Word,
on the ground that there was a time when
the Word was not,
believing that such speculations exalt
the sublime greatness of the divine,
or if one subordinates the Spirit which pro-
ceeds forth
on the ground that it is not by nature spiritual,
thereby introducing an alien being or some
unstable mixture
into the pure and sublime unity of the Holy
Trinity,
we must reject such persons from our midst.
We must drive them away in disgrace
with our confession of faith
like a stoning of fierce demons or vicious
beasts,
and cast a curse upon their devilish lot,
shutting the gates to the church of life in their
face.
While we glorify the Holy Trinity in the same
lordship of unified equality,
in parallel praise, uniform level,
blessed on earth and in heaven,
in the congregation of the nation of
earthly thinking beings,
now and forever.
Amen.



Now, I offer to your all-hearing ears, almighty
God,
the secret thoughts in this book,
and thus equipped, I venture forth in conversa-
tion,
not with the idea that my voice could
somehow exalt you,
for before you created everything,
before the creation of the heavens
with the immortal choir of praise and
the earthly thinking beings,

⁸Wis. 2:3.

you yourself in your perfection were already
glorified,
but still you permit me, a reject, to taste
your indescribable sweetness, through
the communion of words.
And what good is it to mouth your
royal command about
“Adonai, Lord,” and not carry it out.⁹
I destroyed with my own hand
the golden tables of speech,
dedicated to your message, written by
the finger of God.¹⁰
That was true destruction.
And I, with ashen-faced sorrow,
now provide a second copy, made in its like-
ness.
But now, since I have prayed much,
in a voice of passionate and sincere praise,
hear me, compassionate God, with this
profession of faith.
May the voice of this prayer be joined with
those offered
by clean worshipers obedient to your will
so that this meager offering, a dry loaf of
unleavened bread,¹¹
might be served with oil upon your altar of
glory.



But you, beneficent and charitable in all things,
O Christ, of one God, mighty and powerful,
who surpasses all with your sweet and
caring compassion
not only humanity in general and those like me
who are susceptible to all manner of contrari-
ness,
but also the uncontaminated angels,
and even the pure and saintly, who give praise.
There was Elijah, for example,¹²
whose austere signs on Mt. Horeb were shown
in three ways:
a great earthquake, strong winds and burning
fire.
But you act in the mildness of patience and

⁹Lk. 6:46.

¹⁰Ex. 32:19.

¹¹Num. 6:15.

¹²1 Kg. 19:8.



the calm peacefulness of the sweet air,
for you alone, as the Scripture says,
are the will of mercy.¹³

And although our kind found joy in virtue
and otherwise adopted heavenly ways,
still they were earthlings, though chosen
among mankind.

You, on the contrary, are not even capable of
evil:

You are good in your very essence
and blessed in all things,
salvation for all, tranquility in all,
calm for all, cure for all disease,
the fount of life-giving water in the words of
Jeremiah.¹⁴

L

Turn toward me and have mercy upon me,
O God, who so thirsts, hungers and longs for
my salvation.

You have gone so far as to designate
a heavenly host of blessed immortals,
to act as priests and intercessors for man's sal-
vation,
so that on behalf of us earthly beings,
for the reconciliation of the wretched and
abandoned like me,
they might perpetually pray for your great
blessed mercy,
with this light-giving phrase,
"Have mercy upon Jerusalem,"
so that based upon your great revelation
places left empty by the fallen angels,
might be filled by human beings,
who have joined you, in the manner of
the earthly Jerusalem,
about which you sent us good news.¹⁵

Iu

Truly, you hear, kind God,
You listen, king.
You lent an ear, life and light.
You paid attention, heavenly one.
You respected us, almighty.

¹³Mic. 7:18.

¹⁴Jer. 2:13.

¹⁵Zech. 1:12.

You noted, knower of secrets.

You saw, keeper.

You empathized, Lord beyond telling.

You humbled yourself, exalted one.

You became meek, awesome one.

You were revealed, Lord beyond words.

You were defined, boundless one.

You were measured, unexaminable one.

You focused light, radiant one.

You became human, incorporeal one.

You became tangible, immeasurable one.

You took shape, you who are beyond quality.

You truly fulfilled the yearnings of those
who pray to you.

With the voice of the blissful,¹⁶

you were even for me, miserable soul that I am,
a kind intercessor, a living mediator,¹⁷

an immortal offering, an endless sacrifice,
a gift of purity, a priceless burnt offering,
an inexhaustible cup.

Merciful Lord, who loves mankind,

may you always show

the favor of your life-giving will and your
long-suffering patience toward me, a sinner.

To you glory forever.

Amen.

Prayer 35 (Ib)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

U

And now, Lord of hosts,
awesome majesty, unwavering vision,
all expansive will, undiminishing bounty,
how can our dances and songs of joy
do honor to even one drop of your goodness?
You earnestly strive to prepare for my salva-
tion,¹
but let me write what is greater, that it might be
told in the future.
You have not been called "angel lover,"
although the founder of their kingdom.

¹⁶1 Jn. 2:1.

¹⁷Heb. 7:25.

¹Is. 5:4.



And of the heavens with their luminaries,
 all your handiwork,
 never have you been described as loving them.
 Rather to your greater honor and praise,
 you preferred the love of mankind.
 For this reason you doubly magnified your
 name
 beyond telling,
 with frightening mystery.
 You called the heavenly host dressed in light,
 your servants and stewards of special mis-
 sions,²
 and us mortals, born below,
 you adorned with your worshipful, lordly and
 godly name,³
 exceeding again all bounds of measure and
 weight,
 by the flow of your power and exceeding good-
 ness,
 you inspired endless praise.
 And by becoming man, you, one of “the One
 who is,”
 your gifts of life, diverse talents,
 splendid divine work and miracles,
 poured down abundantly upon some who
 asked for themselves, and others who
 asked blessings for others.⁴
 Moved by the faith of his nurses,
 you cured the cripple,⁵
 though he was lacking in faith.
 How much more able, then, is your mighty
 word
 to cleanse the disease from the bodies of those
 who cry out to you in prayer?
 For truly, Lord, it is a greater miracle
 to keep a washed image pure,
 and protected against the attack of unruly dis-
 eases,
 than to cleanse a corrupt soul,
 from the first, with the favor of the grace of
 the baptismal font,
 you exalt the glory of the Father.

¶

²Heb. 1:14.

³Gen. 1:26-28.

⁴Mt. 8:2-3, 5:13.

⁵Mt. 9:2, Lk. 5:18-20.

It is you, Lord, who cleanses us,
 as you did first with your chosen, Moses.⁶
 It is you, who looked over the tribe of Jacob
 in their sin and lawlessness,
 as they became accustomed to the dark pagan
 ways
 of the land of Egypt.
 It is you, who, in the words of the Psalmist
 David,
 teaches the sinner to walk in the law of righ-
 teousness.⁷
 It is you who replaces the stubborn, hardness
 of
 stony hearts,
 with the obedient softness of flesh, receptive to
 the Word.⁸
 It is you who can guide hearts to a single way,
 respecting you with their full lives.⁹
 It is you who instill respect, fear and faith,
 to heed you, according to the voice of the
 Prophet.¹⁰

¶

Like a key to the doors of my hearing,
 may you sprinkle life-giving divine rain
 from your blessed lips that created the world.
 May you remove the poison of the cunning ser-
 pent,
 that troublemaker Satan, and heal me.¹¹
 And with your almighty hand guide
 my tongue and strengthen my voice,
 which you have freely given to all,
 that it might speak boldly,
 and teach fittingly,
 neither depriving me of hope or betraying me
 into nonsense,
 by speaking impudently like our forefather
 Adam.¹²
 Illumine again the light of my soul's darkened
 eye
 with the touch of your life-giving right hand,

⁶Lev. 10:8, Ex. 4:6-7.

⁷Ps. 25:8, 23:3.

⁸Ezek. 11:19, 36:26.

⁹Jer. 32:39.

¹⁰Jer. 32:40, Mal. 2:5.

¹¹Mk. 7:33-35.

¹²Gen. 3:9-11.



so the lamp of my boldness may not be extinguished
by the serpent's breath and be hidden under a bushel.¹³

Lift away my sins, Lord, and cast them into
the depths of the sea,
seas so small in comparison to your greatness
that
in the words of the prophet:
they can swallow up my evil.¹⁴
Restore confidence to my wrecked soul,¹⁵
so that a monument of disappointment not be
erected to my hidden faults.¹⁶
Open, almighty and merciful, the handbook of
life-giving cures,
so that the seeds sown and cultivated by
the Destroyer here below
might be cut down and uprooted with the sickle
of your will.

¶

In the manner of Peter, seeking to follow you,
God of all,¹⁷
I was swallowed by the waves of the sea of my
sinful life.
Extend your life-giving right hand to help me,
for I am foundering.
In the voice the Canaanite women, I pray from
the bottom of my heart,
like a starving dog yelping, wretched and anxious,
begging for scraps,
a few crumbs of the bread of life
from your bountiful table.
Save my physical altar, Son of bitterness,
who came to rescue me when I was lost.
For yours is majesty, victory and power.
And you are atonement and healing, renewal
and bliss.
To you all glory and praise forever.
Amen.

¹³Mt. 5:15.

¹⁴Mic. 7:18-19.

¹⁵Ezek. 9:4.

¹⁶Ezek. 16:31.

¹⁷Mt. 12:30-31.

Prayer 36 (L2)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

No matter how great the mounting debt of my
sins,
the saving grace of your trials
is greater by far.
You were nailed to the cross, the instrument of
death,
on your all-embracing creative hands, which
hold all souls,¹
so my disobedient hand might be stilled.
Out of compassion for my wantonness,
you bound the motion of your two life-giving
feet,
so they might be pawned for my miserable feet,
always racing toward brutishness.

¶

You did not order the hands of those who beat
your head to shrivel.²
You, who could uproot the fig tree without
effort.
This example gives me hope of reprieve.
You did not threaten me with the evil whipping
that was your own lot,
though you are proclaimed God.³
You who darkened the sun⁴
and grant rest with goodness to me a mortal.
You did not dry the evil mouth of those who
cursed you,
you who tinted the image of the moon with
the color of blood,
so you might strengthen my meek tongue to
praise you.
You did not rebuke the wanton insultors,
you who shook the very firmament,
so you might anoint my miserable head with
the oil of compassion.

You did not rip the jaws of the God-killer

¹Job 10:8, 12:10, Wis. 3:1.

²Mk. 11:13, 20-24.

³Mt. 27:45.

⁴Is. 14:12.



who called you a fanatic, charlatan,⁵
 you who rent the hardness of the rocky tomb,⁶
 so you might mercifully grant my soul,
 though it is incapable of goodness,
 a respite from the burden of emptiness.

You did not run the swords of the guards
 through
 their bowels,⁷
 you who condemned the snake to slither on the
 ground,⁸
 so you might preserve the bones of my tor-
 mented body,
 to be worthy of resurrection.

You flatten and thrust into the abyss,
 those who sealed the tomb upon the bearer of
 life,
 in order that you might rest the token of your
 light
 in the tomb of my soul.

You did not absolutely and for all genera-
 tions
 strike down
 those who rumored your hand perished and
 your body stolen like that of a mortal,
 so you might permit me, insignificant as I am,
 to partake of that goodness which neither
 perishes nor can be harmed,
 together with those chosen for salvation.

You did not turn into stone, as with Moab in
 days of old,⁹
 your frenzied persecutors who twice stole
 silver bribes
 from the offerings in your Father's sanctuary
 to betray and degrade you,¹⁰
 so that you might set me upon the steadfastness
 of your rock.¹¹
 Although I waver and am sold to the powers of

death,
 I am redeemed by your blood.
 You are blessed twice over and blessed again,
 praised in all things, forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 37 (LE)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Now, of all your gifts and favors I have received
 and described,
 merciful, beneficent, praised and powerful
 Lord,
 only a few have been set forth here.
 But they are all nobles of the kingdom.
 They are like freemen with rich estates,
 sons of military orders and offspring of the sub-
 lime,
 great in glory, renewed in light, honored in mir-
 acles.
 Proclaimed with the unfurling flags of victory,
 each gift
 adorned with a crowning wreath on its heads
 and
 bringing countless other dominions and estates,
 gifts
 praising, endearing, meek, happy, peaceful,
 from those regions closest to God.
 Of these the prophet prayed,
 "Awake, Lord, your heavenly forces and
 come to save us."¹
 Who is better armed to drive out sin,
 fend off hail, melt the ice of despair,
 and repel those first rebels from the heavenly
 ranks,
 whose nocturnal ways love the darkness,²
 and who from the beginning revolted against
 God?
 It is impossible to recount all the good gifts
 you have rained down on me, a weak,
 belligerent and ungrateful servant.
 But if one were to try to speak

⁵Mt. 26:65.

⁶Mt. 27:51.

⁷Mt. 26:47.

⁸Gen. 3:14.

⁹Gen. 19:26, 37.

¹⁰Mt. 26:14-15, Mt. 28:12-13.

¹¹Mt. 7:25.

¹Ps. 80:3, 7.

²Rev. 12:12.



about even the least of this abundance,
one would be at a loss,
recalling the dust we were made of.³
Like a puny weakling, one would be struck
dumb
in defeat by the greatness of the maker.

ⲡ

After writing this much I testify again
to the flawed immaturity of my soul
when compared to your perfection, O creator,
and
my waywardness in comparison to your kind-
ness.
However, the strength of your praiseworthy
creative force,
your everlasting light, generous and abundant,
defends me against the ways of the Trickster,
who
aims to harden the heart, making it
a rock of despair,
threatening to dry up the two springs⁴
of the Eden of my sentiments that were
established by the Gardener
to water and make the garden of good works
planted in me flourish.
May we not be snatched again from our
original paradise, through the evil trickery of
heretical
illusions that parch our eyes
so that when the miraculously resurrected God
stands
as a mediator among the gods,⁵
bringing his gift of grace,
all the injuries of deceit and short-sighted anx-
ieties,
will be pulverized as if dashed upon a hard
rock,
or washed away by the trickling of a stream,
or blown away like the dust.

ⲧ

And so my reprimand shall come, as Job said,
not from myself,⁶

³Gen. 2:7.

⁴Ps. 69 (Arm. 68):3.

⁵Ps. 82 (Arm. 81):1.

⁶Job 21:4.

but from your all-seeing eye,
of which I am in terror,
wrenched with anxieties, dread and fear.
But refuge for my broken spirit lies in your liv-
ing,
incorruptible, constant hope,
that looking on me with mercy,
as one condemned to perdition,
when I present myself before your heavenly
beneficence,
empty-handed and without gifts,
bringing with me the evidence of your untold
glory,
I will remind you
who never slumber in forgetfulness,
who never shut your eyes,
never ignore the sighs of grief,
that with your cross of light
you may lift away from me, I beg you, the peril
that chokes me,
with your comforting care, the vacillating sad-
ness,
with your crown of thorns, the germs of my sin,
with the lashes of the whip, the blows of death,
with the memory of the slap in the face,
the neediness of my shame,
with the spitting of your enemies, my
contemptible vileness,
with your sip of vinegar, the bitterness of my
soul.

ⲧ

For yours is all the boundless goodness,
only begotten Son of God,
together with which, I remember my wrongs,
calling your all blessed name aloud
with supplications.
Look upon my embarrassed confessions of de-
feat
and grant mercifully to this son worthy of exe-
cution,
the death of immortality,
so that on my sins, again and again,
growing by leaps and bounds,
the goodness of your mercy might be pro-
claimed
with resounding solemnity in heaven as on
earth.



And to you with the Father and Holy Spirit,
glory forever.
Amen.

Prayer 38 (ⲘⲚ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ⲙ

Now, as I wrote in the beginning of this work,¹
about the dark origins of the cardinal sins and
the workings of the bodily organs,²
by which I am dominated, human heir of death,
here, in this prayer, I recount, even if it is
a drop taken from the limitless expanse of the
sea,
a few aspects of the spiritual life
that liberate those born in the light
through our Lord Jesus.³

ⲡ

Some of these are truly splendid, and should be
placed on a high throne,
their stores of grace, filled to the brim with
kindness and wealth,
the king and his loving subjects,
the emperor and his nobles,
the crowned and their princes,
the famous and his good report,
the victor and his trumpets,
the general and his troops,
the hero and his glory,
the groom and his revelers,
the queen and her maids,
the lady in waiting and her retinue,
freedom and its benefits,
the visitation and its outstretched hand,
the promise and its atonement,
the protection and its right hand,
the gifts and their wrapping,
the seal of life and its indelibility,
the soul and its imprint,
the cloud and its shadow,

¹ See Prayer 6.

² Rom. 7:23.

³ Rom. 8:2.

art and its miracles,
the spirit and its immortality,
the word and its perfection,
the taking of the oath and its fulfillment,
the force and its order,
the baptismal font and its miraculous work,
manna and its incorruptibility,
the living rock and its stream,
the pillar of fire and its rays,
thunder and its echo,
hope and its salvation,
the tree of blessings and its fruit,
the bough and its bounty.
And so that I shall not err by saying this,
I note my omissions,
for as the eyes are blinded when looking at the
sun,
I have averted my attention from the greatest
and
presented the lesser points that are within
my meager ability.

Ⲛ

I apologize for my always miserable, wretched
soul,
because my composition mixes
the voice of good news with mournful protests,
bringing justice and judgment,
decision and penalty,
investigation and spotlights,
scolding and torches,
nakedness and embarrassment,
revelation and shame,
innocence and reward,
error and punishment.

Ⲛ

Again and again, I flinch doubly misfortunate
and wretched,
for unbearable anger is coming with a sickle
to harvest my ripened sheaves of grain,
a judge for the court,
a strongman for the tribunal,
an executioner for execution,
an arm to carry out the judgment,
a rod to reprimand,
armor for revenge,
a shepherd for sorting the flock,



for the words you said to me,
 shall judge me, the condemned, on the
 last day of judgment.⁴
 Hurry, merciful Lord, with your sweet accep-
 tance,
 attend the faint sighs of my cowardly wavering
 with the great strength of your blessed hand.
 Do not be angry, but with your characteristic
 good will,
 comfort, cure, forgive and save me,
 at my last trial.
 And to you glory, forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 39 (LΘ-)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

ⲁ

Since I abandoned my former composure,
 led by the destroyer and
 totally wasted by my own laziness,
 now I address my former self,
 recounting with heavy heart and pitiful sobs
 the scandal of my ways
 before the congregation of the multitude of na-
 tions.

ⲡ

I am a living book,
 written like the scroll in the vision of Ezekiel,
 inside and out,¹
 listing lamentations, moaning and woe.
 I am a city without walls or towers,²
 a house empty without doors for protection,³
 salt in looks but lacking taste,⁴
 sea water unfit to quench the thirst,
 land, useless for cultivation,
 field, barren and covered with briars.
 My personal acres, cared for by God,

⁴Jn. 12:48.

¹Ezek. 2:9-10.

²Jer. 50:15.

³Jer. 51:30.

⁴Mk. 9:49.

but already sown with the devices of the Slan-
 derer,
 an olive tree that is wood without fruit,
 a barren orchard to be cut down,⁵
 a hopeless, twice dead, talking plant,
 a burned out candle that cannot be lit.

ⲉ

Now again, in the same vein, I repeat
 similar pathetic images
 that await me, miserable soul, as bitter punish-
 ment for my shame.
 Gnashing of teeth and endless wailing, for the
 eyes of
 my wretched self,
 paternal anger that cannot be deflected by filial
 regret,
 unmendable corruption for my sinful body,
 new reprimands for me, an inventor of evil for
 my diseased soul,
 the anxiety of doubt for my escape as a captive,
 waiting to be visited by the heavenly host.
 Testifying I am a miserable, wounded soul,
 who deserves to be burned in the bundles of
 weeds,⁶
 with a stern voice pronouncing me, incorrigible
 refuse.

ⲉ

Truly, these are but the charming melodies of a
 harlot,
 with her harp, strolling about and beating her
 breast,⁷
 brazenly wailing, miserably and scornfully,
 as the prophet Isaiah wrote in his admonition
 to Tyre.
 If she could because of a minor misfortune (the
 loss of
 her clientele),
 protest with all manner of fake moaning and
 groaning,
 then in what kind of desperate voice should I
 cry out?
 I who wait the coming of the Lord,

⁵Lk. 13:10.

⁶Mt. 13:30.

⁷Is. 23:15-16.



and yet have been caught unprepared and naked.

᠖

Now, if I recount again the fearsome judgment, my repentance should be multiplied.

And if I present my tribulations realistically terror should seize me.

And if I describe this vision in detail my tribulations increase.

For having recognized all this in advance and not repented, even in retrospect, I am grateful that

you spared me, merciful lover of mankind, mighty doer of good,

All-giving Christ, King, blessed forever. Amen.

Prayer 40 (᠒)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

᠒

Almighty God, doer of good, creator of all, hear the sound of my sighs of distress and my terror of imagined perils to come. Save me with your strength, ridding me of my sins.

For you are capable of all things and are the key to all things¹ with your boundless greatness and infinite wisdom.

᠙

And seeing with my mind's eye in the distance the terrible vision of the life to come, I observe in advance the day of light, the hope of the saints,² and the day of darkness, the punishment of the sinful,³ from which none can escape nor find refuge, neither in the deep abyss nor in the bottomless

pits,⁴

neither on the heights of the mountains, nor in the caves in the stone, neither on the hardness of boulders, nor in the cavity of a hole, neither in the crevices of a pit, nor the waves of a flood,

neither in the labyrinth of the basement, nor the loft of the attic, neither behind the closed doors of my cell, nor in the darkness of the valley, neither in the declines of the valleys, nor on the inclines of the hills, neither in the blowing of the wind, nor in the undulation of the seas, neither in the swirling of a whirlpool, nor in the distant ends of the earth, neither in the sounds of lament, nor in the sighs of weeping, neither in the trembling of fingers, nor in the lifting of hands, neither in the prayers of the lips, nor in the cries of the tongue.

Out of this terrible inescapable lot you, Lord Christ, are the exit and respite, the ease and calm of the salvation for my ever sinning soul.

᠒

Now, look upon me besieged by overwhelming danger, you who are alone sweet to all.

Cut me loose with your victorious sword of life, the cross, and release me from the nets that have snared me, nets that assail me on all sides as the captive of death.

Please steady my shaky feet on the crooked path and heal the burning fever of my anguished heart. Turn away the demonic whisper of temptation to sin against you.

Drive away the despair of my dark soul that dwells with evil.

¹Gen. 18:14, Lk. 1:37.

²Wis. 18:1.

³Wis. 17:20.

⁴Rev. 6:15-17.



Dispel the thick smoke of sin that has infused
and obscured me.

Destroy the vile dark passions of my base
needs.

Renew the image of light revered by
the glory of your mighty name, my soul.
Fix your glowing grace upon my face and
the perception of my mind, an earthbound crea-
ture.

And cleanse my squalid sinfulness with your
purity
so that you might restore and reveal your image
in me.

With your divine, living, uncorrupted and
heavenly light that envelopes your three per-
sons.

For you alone are blessed with the Father and
Holy Spirit
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 41 (IbU)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

U

Son of the living God, blessed in all things,¹
whose awesome birth by your Father passes
all understanding,
for whom nothing is impossible,²
before the dawning of the uneclipsed rays of
the mercy of your glory
sins melt away, demons flee, transgressions are
erased,
bindings are cut and chains undone.
The dead are born again, infirmities are cured,
wounds are healed, corruption is cleansed,
sadness withdraws, sighs retreat,
darkness flees, fog departs,
twilight vanishes, darkness lifts, the night
passes,
alarm is banished, evil is destroyed, despair is
exiled.

¹Mt. 16:16.

²Lk. 1:37, Gen. 18:14.

And your omnipotent hand rules, redeemer of
all.

Ɔ

You who came not to destroy our mortal souls,
but to give them life,³
forgive my countless wrongs with your abun-
dant mercy.

For you alone are in heaven beyond words, and
on earth beyond understanding,
in the substance of existence unto the ends of
the earth,
the beginning of everything and the completion
of

everything in all ways, blessed in the highest.

Glory forever to you
with the Father and the Holy Spirit.
Amen.

Prayer 42 (IbƆ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

U

Lord God of compassion, salvation and mercy,
redemption and restoration, healing and health,
enlightenment and life, resurrection and im-
mortality,
remember me, when you go to your kingdom,
O awesome, mighty, doer of good and creator
of all,
living, praised, perfecter of all,
accessible to the sighs of all beings.

With the man who was crucified with you,
who was not captured for your sake and was
not bound,
was not hanged and was not nailed,
was not beaten in your great name and
was not disgraced,
was not tortured and was not treated with
contempt,
was not crushed and was not killed,
I beg to be worthy of the Kingdom and

³Lk. 9:56.



the most desired light that is the reward of the just.

May you, by the authority of saying the oath, “Amen,”

affirm that your gifts are unchanging and are glorified for giving the hope of salvation to those of us

that consider ourselves totally abandoned.

ⲡ

Blessed, blessed, and blessed again!

Having accepted me by that same faith, raise me up from my fallen state, doer of good, cure me of disease, merciful,

return me from the edge of death to life, life-giver,

for I am yours, same as man’s faith, my refuge.

Grant the breath of life to the body of the dead, O resurrection,

life, immortality, and inexhaustible joy,

boundless grace, unwavering forgiveness,

omnipotent right hand, all-governing hand,

all-reaching finger,

you have only to wish it, Lord, and I shall be saved,

only to think it, and by your mercy shall I be justified.

Say the word, and I will be found spotless.¹

Forget my wrongs, and I shall venture to emerge.

Cultivate me and I shall cleave to you,

you who are glorified in all things forever.

Amen.

Prayer 43 (ⲓⲱⲙ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

ⲓ

With every possible facet of the art of healing, Lord Jesus,

cause of all healthy life,

mighty heavenly king,

God of all things apprehended by the mind and

by the eye,

join me in the words of the prophet,¹

“And behold, through this union with you through these words,

your light shall break forth in me to heal my breath and body,”

you who are mighty and invincible.

ⲡ

To heal our spiritual wounds, you do not need ointments,

nor time, nor intermediaries,

nor the passing of days,

nor the changing of prescriptions,

nor amputation, nor cauterization, nor surgery

as practiced by earthly medicine,

in which there is always trial and error,

often grave error.

But for you, the creator of the soul and body,

all is illumined,

all is clear,

all is written,

all is easy,

all is possible,

wisdom leads,

promises are kept,

wishes are fulfilled.

Your testament is the gospel.

Your judgment is freedom.

Your lawbook is grace.

You are not limited by laws.

You are not bound by canons.

You are not hampered by imperfections.

You are not humbled by obedience.

You are not restricted by smallness.

You are not measured by boundaries.

You do not err out of anger.

You do not alter out of wrath.

You do not misjudge out of severity.

You do not simmer out of agitation.

You do not falter out of ignorance.

You do not waver out of soft-heartedness.

You do not diminish out of exaltation.

You do not abandon your duty of care.

You do not weaken your salvation.

You are the beginning and the end of all.

¹Mt. 8:2, 8.

¹Is. 58:5-8.

Everything is from you alone.
Therefore glory to you and worship forever.
Amen.

Prayer 44 (ԽԴ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Boundless God, genuine son of God, inexplicable,
creator of everything, Christ King,
light for the darkened hearts of the unknowing,¹
light who took human form like us,
but are in essence like him who sent you,
whose form is miraculously revealed through ours.
Blessed by your heavenly Father,
who sent you and with whom
you share glory for creation.
You care enough for my salvation, an exiled slave,
that you delivered yourself to evil men²
and without resorting to your divinity
drank from the cup of death for me, a sinner,
according to the plan of your divine economy,
with true humanity and perfect divinity.
And the Holy Ghost is also of the same essence
as you and the Father,
equal in honor with the Son and the Father,
one perfect trinity in three persons indivisible,
without beginning or time,
benefactor to all, life giver of all, peacemaker
of all,
creator of existence and shaper of all things,
glorified with one indivisible nature.

Բ

For the sake of my transgressions for which
I am condemned to death,
the merciful Father, heavenly, almighty, one of
the divine essence,
has offered the only son of his bosom.

¹2 Pet. 1:19.

²Jn. 3:16.

His beloved son, his equal in honor he did not spare,³
but willingly gave him to death by the arms of
his tormentors,
as foretold by the prophet Zechariah:
“For raise the sword upon the shepherd,
and strike down the keeper of the flock,
and the flock shall disperse.”⁴
The Old Testament also gives another example⁵
of vows at the altar and the blood of the offering in
the story of Abraham’s sacrifice,⁶
which described to me how you wished
to save the wretched.
So now, why do you grieve, my soul?⁷
You are not destroyed by God
but by your own doing.
And why am I upset,
my mind reeling with satanic despair?
I should trust in God, confess to him
and he will care for me,
as David wrote in the Psalms,
and the Prophet counseled.⁸

Գ

The ways of the creator surpass
the understanding of angels and mortals.
If I were to try ten thousand times, my words
could not capture it,
for his good works are beyond comprehension
and description.
One of the blessed trinity
sent another of the trinity
and to please the will of the sender,
he died. And the third, according to
the wishes of the other two
worked together for the same good
with the same will.
As the soul is for the living beings and
thought for the rational beings,

³Rom. 8:32.

⁴Zech. 13:7.

⁵Ex. 17:11-12.

⁶Heb. 9:19-21, Gen. 22:1-19.

⁷Ps. 42:6.

⁸Ps. 41:6-7, 12, 42:5; Is. 40:1, 31; Lam. 3:24-25; Nah. 1:7.

as radiance is for glory, and form for substance,
 as caring for life, and mindfulness for mercy,
 as giving in charity, and resolve in salvation,
 as abundance in generosity, flow in continuity,
 as fullness for perfection, richness in inexhaustibility,
 as long in forbearance, exalted in unreachableness,
 they are one perfect trinity, of three persons,
 blessed forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 45 (ԽԵ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Now, confess, my ruined soul
 with hope in your heart for salvation
 with the belt of faith tight over your kidneys,¹
 confess your thoughts to God
 as if thoughts were actions,
 as if plans were accomplishments,
 as if invisible were seen,
 as if the heart's secrets were voiced,
 as if sinful intentions were committed wrongs,
 as if words were deeds,
 as if footprints were flight from God's will,
 hands raised in anger as if they shed blood,
 abandoned laughter as if abandoned grace,
 vows both reasonable and unreasonable
 as if compacts with the devil,
 haughtiness as if it could detract
 from our creator,
 uneasiness of heart as if a lack of faith,
 cowardice as if it were defeat,
 complaints about passionate temptations
 as if betrayals of a vow to the Lord,²
 insolence as if it were impiety,
 arrogance as if precious vanity,
 pride as if fondness for evil,
 the involuntary as well as voluntary,
 the forced as well as the consenting,
 the extrinsic as well as the intrinsic,

¹Ex. 29:13, Lev. 3:4, Jer. 12:2, Job 16:13, Wis. 1:6.

²2 Cor. 1:3-6.

the lawless as well as the ungodly,
 the smallest as well as the greatest,
 the few as well as the many,
 the things I have left unspoken as if
 they were spoken by the all-knowing,
 the unwritten wrongs as if
 they were carved by the all-seeing upon a lodestone,³
 the slightest contentious thought as if
 it were the gravest of burdens,
 a hidden matter of measure as if
 it were the just demand for payment of tribute
 in the amount of four drachmae
 from the mouth of a baby whale,⁴
 buried deeds as if they were speeding to the ear
 of God.
 Compile and compound them redoubling your effort,
 and lament here again what is not, as if it were.
 Offer your vanquished soul to God
 so that you might receive the forgiveness of sins,
 like the sinner who through the Lord's grace
 was justified,
 eloquently proclaiming the merits of repentance rather than faultfinding.⁵

Բ

Now compile and condemn your soul's sins,
 reproach yourself with varied images, my soul,
 in a relentless stream of words:
 evil, disobedience, error,
 desertion, surrender,
 rage, impudence, stupidity,
 stupor, daydreaming, slumber,
 pagan thoughts, base words,
 pleasure in dissolution, dalliance,
 desire of what is hateful to God,
 impious, incorrigible, uncivilized,
 faulty, feeble, weak, stingy,
 untethered, ridiculous, lusting,⁶
 comic, scandalous, deceitful,
 brazen, quarrelsome, outlaw,
 suffocating the soul, shaking cowardice,

³Jer. 17:1.

⁴Mt. 17:24-27.

⁵Mt. 26:7, 13; Lk. 7:36-50.

⁶Jer. 5:8.



unruly branching bush,
 dishonorable indulgence, contentiousness,
 sulking,
 baseless hatred, lax titillation,
 failure to weigh small things, breach of
 promise,
 forgetfulness of vows, distortion of similarity,
 disguised by veils, extravagance of glory
 seeking,
 arrogance, roguishness, egotism,⁷
 will to power, conspiracy with criminals,⁸
 meaningless gossip, vicious behavior,
 collaboration with the conniving tempter,
 confusion, selling of life for the price of
 butchery,
 loss of tradition, betrayal of homeland,
 attractive bondage,⁹
 yoked to lawlessness like oxen,¹⁰
 living in filth, abandoning the good,
 giving in to bad impulses, worse than
 before conversion,¹¹
 new designs, untoward intentions, unstable
 will,
 pointless shouting, letter over spirit,
 lawlessness, despotic rule,
 and other things that cannot be spoken, written,
 told
 or countenanced.

q

And now, how shall you be cured, my poor
 soul,
 after suffering so many slashes of the lance?
 You are like an abandoned, exiled man, incur-
 able,
 as the Prophet wrote.¹² Anyone would be con-
 demned
 to death for the wrongs listed above, let alone
 if besieged
 by the hordes of killers and vicious execution-
 ers.
 And these descriptions fail to convey fully

⁷Is. 3:16.

⁸Mt. 23:6.

⁹Lk. 15:13.

¹⁰Is. 5:18.

¹¹2 Pet. 2:20.

¹²Jer. 22: 28-30.

the weight of my misfortune.
 Although my skin-covered vessel may look
 good from the outside, it is teeming with evil
 within
 as if swarming with scorpions that sting
 with the deadly poison in their tails.
 It is a storehouse of ruination and mass of grief,
 filled with agents of destruction and sowers of
 death.

q

And now, your store of iniquities,
 the accumulated wages of your wicked ways,
 my soul, are enough to condemn you twice to
 death.
 Seeds sown by the enemy upon the grain fields
 of the world,¹³
 which you willingly accepted in yourself,
 unclean man, dishonest and lazy, completely
 hateful,
 gluttonous lover of all that is filled with corrup-
 tion,
 for which the Apostle saved some of his most
 fearsome words of reprimand:
 “And those who know,” he said, “God’s law,
 and still
 do such things or are willing to do so,
 are deserving of death.”¹⁴
 Thus, I myself am deserving of double
 condemnation to ruination and death, but still
 I pray you, spare me, with your mercy,
 O God, compassionate, living, mighty,
 obliging, able, potent,
 blessed forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 46 (Iu2)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

u

Now I am lost, forever punishable,
 always immoral,
 condemning myself to death,

¹³Mt. 13:24-28, 37-39.

¹⁴Rom. 1:28-32.



shepherd of a flock of fetid sin, a flock of wild boars,
 a despicable mercenary,¹
 a shepherd watching a flock of desert goats.
 The image of the shepherds' tent in the Song of Songs
 aptly applies to me,²
 for I do not know or understand,
 by whom, in whose image or why I was created.

¶

Behold, you were formed like an angel,
 on two feet that take and bring you,
 as if in flight on two wings lifting you upward,
 to gaze down on my fatherland.
 O fool, why did you choose to be earthbound,
 always preoccupied with the worldliness of the here and now,³
 carrying on like wild asses in the desert?⁴
 On the lamp stand of your body, encircling your head,
 a chandelier with many arms was placed,
 so that by its light you might not stray and might
 see God and know what is everlasting.
 You were doubly endowed in the womb of reason,
 so that you might speak with an unfettered tongue
 of the victory of the good things given you.
 And you were endowed with artful hands and nimble fingers
 to carry out the practical affairs of daily life
 like the all-giving right hand of God,
 that you might be called God.⁵
 You are assembled of 360 parts and five senses,
 the number of the days of the year,
 and no aspect of your physical being remains invisible
 to your sight or unstudied by your mind.
 For some parts are thick and strong,
 some are small and others necessary,

¹Lk. 15:15.

²S. of S. 1:7.

³Col. 3:2.

⁴Job 39:5.

⁵Ps. 81:6.

some are sturdy but sensitive,
 some are sublime, important and noble,
 some are necessary but humble,
 and the explanation of the image of these things
 is engraved on you
 as on an uneraseable monument, wretched soul
 of mine,
 so that like the elements of time
 and the continuous train of days around the year
 by some inner law these parts function
 in unerring and inalterable order.

¶

And now another spiritual image,
 tied to the bonds of love uniting the church,
 is also reflected within you.⁶
 Like the yoke that mediates between the great
 and the lowly,
 the assembled body
 established in the name of Christ is sometimes
 impaired,
 as with the cutting off or loss of an unruly organ,
 infecting the body.
 Something is lost in your mortal structure,
 feeling abode of mankind,
 and the usual shape of the person undergoes
 some disfigurement.
 And now when the uniquely miraculous structure
 in the living image of God,⁷
 is completely condemned, my enslaved soul,
 that original likeness is stolen from you as
 by breaking the law in the Garden of Eden.
 But by the light of the baptismal font
 the breath of the Holy Spirit is received and
 the image is restored to God's likeness.

¶

And now, why did you give up heavenly glory
 like the original man Adam did in the earthly
 Garden of Eden? ⁸
 Why did you yourself close heaven and lock

⁶1 Cor. 12:12-27.

⁷Gen. 1:26.

⁸Gen. 3.

the door to ascent?
 Why did you mix the clean water with
 impurities of bitter tears?
 Why did you soil newly washed clothes with
 dirty work?
 Why did you put off the clothes given you
 and put on the cloak of sin?
 Why did you infect the purity of your feet
 by taking the path of the fallen?⁹
 Why did you repeat the violation of just vows
 of
 the Old Testament?
 Why did you refuse the fruit of grace, as Adam
 did
 the tree of life?
 Why did you willfully lose the unshadowed
 hope
 of eternity?
 Why did you cover your face with brazen
 shame?
 Why did you arm your enemies against you,
 repository of stupidity?
 Why did you venture into the snares of death,
 abandoning the way of faith?
 Why did you get caught on the fishhook of de-
 ception,
 you who share the body of the life giver?
 But again, relying upon him, call to him,
 the redeemer of those seeking refuge, renewer,
 savior, life maker and life giver,
 merciful, caring, lover of humanity,
 ungrudging, generously compassionate,
 blessed forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 47 (ԽԷ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

What can I be, but speechless
 before your awesome might?
 What can I be but embarrassed and silent
 my words only quiet dust in my mouth,¹

⁹S. of S. 5:3.

¹Lam. 3:29.

when I hope for virtue
 as the prophets advised?
 Even if I open my clamped lips,
 what would flow but more mournful elegies?
 Nothing but the voice of my many wounds
 pouring forth.

Բ

And now, weeping with the great sinner,
 who willingly committed mortal sin,
 I join in his cry,
 “I have sinned, Lord, I have sinned,
 and to my lawlessness I myself am witness.”²
 Weaving this cry with the words of the 50th
 Psalm,³
 I conclude that the wages of my innumerable
 sins are greater
 than the grains of sand that make up the earth
 and are scattered by the wind.
 I have sinned against heaven and you.
 Like the Prodigal Son, who though shamed,
 received his father’s forgiveness,
 I make my entreaty, prostrate before you,
 my face twisted in grief, pleading:
 Father of compassion, God of all,
 I am not worthy to be called even a worthless,
 irresponsible hireling,⁴
 let alone “son,” or even to have this word
 uttered about me.
 Still accept me, a wandering exile, defeated by
 wounds,
 faint with gnawing hunger.
 Heal me with your bread of life,
 confront me with mercy, for you are my first
 refuge.
 Clothe me, a lawless sinner, merciful and
 unvengeful God,
 with the clothes of my former innocence.
 Place, with your boundless generosity,
 the ring with your seal of courage
 on my sinful hand that lost everything by stray-
 ing in sin.
 Protect the soles of my bare feet
 with the sandals of the Gospels.⁵

²2 Chr. 33:1-20.

³Ps. 50:3-5.

⁴Lk. 15:3-32.

⁵Eph. 6:15.



Guard me from poisonous snakes.
 And even though I am wanting in virtue
 you sacrifice the fatted calf of heaven,
 your only begotten Son, out of
 love for mankind.
 Your blessed Son who is always offered and
 yet remains whole,
 who is sacrificed continuously upon innumer-
 able altars without being consumed,
 who is all in everyone and complete in all
 things,
 who is in essence of heaven and in reality of
 earth,
 who is lacking nothing in humanness and with-
 out
 defect in divinity,
 who is broken and distributed in individual
 parts,
 that all may be collected in the same body with
 him as head.⁶
 Glory to you with him, Father most merciful.
 Amen.

Prayer 48 (ԽԸ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Մ

Exalted and mighty God,
 who has no beginning, no becoming, and no
 end,
 observer with an unsleeping eye,
 parent of the only begotten, glorious and in-
 scrutable,
 before heaven and earth,
 justify granting your mercy to me to whom
 it has been denied.
 Celebrate my restoration to life.
 Announce the good news for me who is dying.
 Reveal your good will, O praiseworthy Lord,
 to all creation.
 Be true to your name, ineffable, and grant me,
 a miserable sinner, renewed salvation.
 Wipe away the mortgage of my sins.
 And commute the death sentence upon my soul

⁶Jn. 11:52, Eph. 1:22-23.

with the blood of your beloved Son.
 With his blood assure salvation for the good.
 Show the majesty of your mercy at the bridal
 feast.
 Do not shut me, a suppliant, out of the house
 of life.
 Do not bar me from your banquet table and do
 not deprive me of your bounty.¹
 Do not keep the debts of my iniquity in your
 safe.²
 Do not seal the vileness of my dissipation in
 your good purse.³
 Do not cover my diseased body with the
 wounds
 of my sins.
 Do not preserve the infectious deterioration of
 my aching body to be buried with me,⁴
 but lift away the corrupting decay with your
 mercy,
 so that I might be restored to health.
 For my grave ills, Father of compassion,
 prepare a strong balm.
 For my fatal ailments, visit goodness,
 for I am yours, Lord, lover of our souls.⁵
 And although in one step I might commit
 a thousand sins,
 still, I would not be deemed as completely sin-
 ful,
 beneficent giver of life,
 having sought refuge in the grace of your gifts.
 For to know you is complete justice,
 and to know your strength is the root of immor-
 tality.
 As the wiseman wrote in ages past,
 your sovereignty causes you to spare all.⁶
 And he is close to you; whenever you want
 you can find him.⁷

Բ

I take Solomon⁸ as the model for my prayer of
 hope.

¹Mt. 22:3-16.

²Dt. 32:34.

³Job 14:17.

⁴Ps. 37:6.

⁵Wis. 15:2-3.

⁶Wis. 12:16.

⁷Wis. 12:18.

⁸1 Kg. 2:1-8.



For no other person has matched my sinfulness.
 Once a beloved son, but later despised,
 once a peacemaker, but later the sower of discord,
 once the giver of the law, but later
 the mortgagor of death,
 trampling divine service under foot and taking
 a foreign name,
 instigator of discord, undeprived depriver,
 contented thief, pampered complainer,
 coddled fugitive, repulsive traitor, irresponsible vandal,
 sweet curser, father-hating child,
 betrayer of covenants, defamer of Moses,
 forgetter of favors,
 wise delinquent, knowing transgressor,
 shameful lamenter, wavering penitent,
 covetous idolator, sluggish convert,
 doubtful acceptance, vacillating reconciliation,
 shadow of the future, ambiguous salvation,
 uncertain discovery, trace of a remnant,
 deceitful slave, half-escaped but voluntarily
 surrendered,
 like an overindulged ruffian, an eccentric genius.
 And from the clashing of these two streams of
 words,
 more reports of pity and praise,
 with great shame and little honor,
 as on a person whose ruin is self-inflicted and
 mourning is mixed with blame,
 his copious writings have encouraged people of
 all ages toward virtue,
 but his vices bring forth moans of grief from all
 lips.



I am amazed, I faint, seized with doubt.
 If Solomon strayed this much, what will become of me?
 Why did the haughty fall?
 Why did the steady falter?
 Why did the sturdy collapse?
 Why did the follower become alienated?
 Why did the chosen son stray?
 Why did the dear one flee?
 Why did the shining tarnish?
 Why was the teacher no longer an example?

Why did the famous turn obscure?
 Why did the glorious become dishonored?
 Why was the exalted humbled?
 Why were the pious perverted?
 Why was the chosen rejected?
 Why was the covenant with heaven broken?⁹
 I am ashamed to say that he consorted with the
 Devil,
 for what business did he have with idols?
 Whence his love for graven images?
 Why did he yearn for cults?
 Did he not remember Samuel's reprimand to
 Saul –
 "Paganism is a sin"? Yet he labored and sacrificed for
 the household gods.¹⁰
 Why did he not remember the ancestral reproof?
 "Idols," it said, "are breathless, pagan demons.
 And so are their priests."¹¹
 Did not Moses scold his people with scorn,
 "Only the Lord leads them, and there is no other
 god for them but the one known to their fathers."¹²



Where is the death-bringing grotesque statue of
 Pagora?
 Where is the ugly, infamous, accursed
 female statue of the Sodomites?¹³
 Where is the embarrassing statue of a woman?
 The image which the prophets condemned as
 ungodly and bestial and the demon of intemperance.
 This woman who shoved Solomon's ancestors
 into destruction, he mistook as a sign of favor.
 Arrogance got the better of his wisdom.
 Haughtiness enslaved it.
 Pampering stupified it.
 Silver enslaved it.
 The weapons of the Destroyer deadened his
 soul,

⁹ 1 Kg. 8.

¹⁰ 1 Sam. 15:23.

¹¹ Ps. 95:9, 96:5-7.

¹² Dt. 32:12.

¹³ 1 Kg. 2:5.



and torn from the embrace of God, he strayed
to the path of iniquity.
Luxury killed him, sloth numbed him.
Intemperance poisoned him.
O, easily deceived mortal body,
with what cries shall I mourn you?
This contradiction is found not only in him,
but with all those who err, all who willfully do
wrong.
For he proves that it is wrong to take pride
in the knowledge of the body¹⁴
unless guided by God's judgment.
For even if a person is stupid,
if he places his will in the hand of God,
he shall not succumb as Solomon did.

6

In addition, Solomon has left a horrifying ac-
count
of his perversion,
filled with self-accusatory reproof for being
truly dead to worldly honor.
To learn this truth, one need only read
the book of Vanities,¹⁵
or the books of the Priests, or the writings
of Saint Silon.¹⁶
In these he describes with sorrow the torments
and
error of his ways.
Vain effort, fruitless labor,
mindless devotion, aimless wandering,
capricious activity, alien fantasies,
groundless praise, rotten harvest,
improper conjecture, trivial concept,
house built on sand, collapsed estate,
contemptible tasks, struggle against oneself,
judgment upon one's own soul,
useless sweat, dangerous attraction,
road to destruction, wayward path,
ruinous education, unwholesome practices,
flawed eyesight, garish eye painting,
whorish get up, infectious germ,
revolting color, tragic splendor,
stifling smoke, smothering steam,
easily pilfered goods, fragile temple,

¹⁴1 Cor. 1:29, 10:18.

¹⁵Ec. 1:2.

¹⁶2 Chr. 9:29.

inappropriate cries, baseless ridicule,
despicable ambition, self-incriminating writ-
ing,
destructive path, ungodly thought,
lying speech, vexing stories,
empty faultfinding, crazed inquest,
shameful display, scandalous revelations,
impending dishonor, injurious acts,
sordid story, slothful example,
hidden pit, dark prey,
deathly pit, bottomless abyss,
murderous company, foolish prattle,
bandits' hideout, dilapidated house,
shaken building, broken bridge,
fleeting phantom, deceptive flatterer, inhumane
traitor,
antagonism toward the one on high.
Ecclesiastes put these confessional thoughts
into our heads as a prod to repentance
so no one might wound either soul or friend
with the arrows of disparaging words.
For a person who looks pious but whose acts
displease God
is like a pagan under a veil.

9

As we now see, Solomon sinned as much as
he atoned for,
so let us not blame him but remember the good,
and let this be our hope as supplicants at the
Lord's feet,
so when he descends with the Spirit in undi-
vided divinity
to redeem the righteous,¹⁷
we, the living, are assured of the good news by
the example of the dead.
With Solomon whose wisdom I lack,
but whose sins I surpass,
I make this plea to your glorified greatness.
Fill my humble scribbling with his felicitous
genius.
May my supplications mingle with the prayers
of that penitent king,
and may they be answered through the inter-
cession of that sublime monarch,
whom you set as a precursor of your only be-
gotten Son,

¹⁷1 Pet. 3:19.



and by whose lineage we have partaken of the glory of your co-equal Son.

Save your servant, all powerful, almighty, and awesome.

Increase your glory as creator

by granting repentance for our unforgivable sins.

In recognition of his good counsel, redeem Solomon too,

for he preached your divinity in the Old Testament

with words of sweetness, eloquence and edifying stories,

thus leaving the church footprints toward goodness

by teaching us to turn toward you, Father, showing that except for a drop of despair that dampened his heart's fervor and spurred him toward repentance, he was not far from salvation.

ⲉ

Now remembering Solomon's goodness, let us greet him with compassion, instead of the blame with which he has been trampled and pilloried for ages.

His repentance filled the banquet hall with a torrent of tears that gushed over the roof.¹⁸

And in passionate penitence he exceeded his father.

I pray that your long-suffering forgiveness will blend

his tears with the tears of your Son, the Word, who subjected himself to our frail human condition.

May the Psalm sometimes

thought to be addressed to Solomon

rather be addressed to your Son, co-equal in glory,

thereby granting him the sweetness of salvation along with the other wretched of the earth.¹⁹

For living poets, it is ample reward for their words²⁰

to be mingled with Solomon's

¹⁸Ps. 6:7.

¹⁹Apparently a reference to Psalm 71, which is inscribed "To Solomon," see, Ps. 71:4, 13.

²⁰Sir. 47:22.

and to be offered on his behalf

in harmonious prayer to you.

My justification for this plea is this:

his work, the parable of Job, the man from Uz, is a work of miraculous talent and prophecy, that alone earns Solomon a place of honor in the ranks of God's defenders.

Hence, it is acceptable to plead for him rather than

speak ill of him.

ⲉ

Now I too, with greater confidence, hope my cries will be offered to you with his, for if you destroy us, judging us by our deeds, your glory will not be diminished, for you will be judged as just.

But if you accept us, you will be exalted as befits your majesty.

Lean then, Lord, incline yourself in sweetness with compassion and freely give the gift of love to comfort us,

who like Solomon are chronically feverish with incurable

grief and turmoil.

Lay your hand of salvation on us.

Renew us, forgive and defend us from the destruction of sin.

And to you alone, who are the beginning without beginning, the source of all beginnings, the holy Trinity and One Divinity, to you alone are due glory and dominion forever.

Amen.

Prayer 49 (ⲁⲱⲁ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

ⲁ

And now remembering the image of your royal kingdom above,

God of light for all,

do not let iniquity rule me.

Do not let the haughty rebel steal the grace



of your breath from this creature you made.¹
 Do not let sin trap and rule my mortal body,
 enslaving me.²
 No king rules my soul except you, Christ,
 who without force submits me to your easy
 yoke,³
 who lifts away my sinful passions with your
 all-powerful word,
 who redeems me with your blood and nour-
 ishes me
 with your body,
 who sets forth and establishes the unchanging
 covenant of life,
 who by setting the stamp of your spirit on
 me as your cohort,⁴
 presents me to your Father as a co-heir,⁵
 and in the name of your sacrifice and memory
 of your torment,
 emboldened me to pray to the same benevolent
 God.
 Creator of all life,
 you are the God of all souls⁶
 who made this gift of grace greater than
 all your other miracles.
 Neither the heavens with all their raiment, nor
 the angels in their brilliance,
 nor the earth and humanity and their wonders,
 nor the expanse of the seas and all in them,
 nor the abyss in its infiniteness and all in it,
 exalted you as sublimely as your sympathy to-
 ward me,
 when you said through the prophet, our hope
 of sweet goodness,
 “Who is a God like me, always pardoning sin
 and canceling the debts of iniquity?”⁷
 Behold your words are honored with incense,
 merciful God,
 and your good works proclaimed,
 glorified, deep mystery and worshiped,
 overflowing grace.

¹Gen. 2:7.²Rom. 6:12.³Mt. 11:29-30.⁴2 Cor. 1:22, Eph. 1:13.⁵Rom. 8:17.⁶Num. 27:15-16.⁷Mic. 7:18.

Indeed, no one is able to convey with human
 speech,
 even a small part of the acts of compassion
 which you have shown me, creator.
 For the power to restore what is worn-out to
 its former grandeur is greater than creating
 anew.
 And since weakness is not yours, mighty in all
 things,
 you who with but a word can carry out all
 deeds,⁸
 arise, doer of good, and be glorified,⁹
 and reclaim those whose salvation was beyond
 hope,
 so that by the exercise of the covenant,
 the voice of your blessed good news might be
 more exalted,
 and known for the grace of your forgiveness,
 more for the light of your mercy dispensed,
 than for the process of creation.
 For in one we recognize the creator,
 whereas in the other, creatorship is recalled
 as well as grace.

We recognize
 not only the one who fashioned us, but also the
 one
 who atoned for our sins,
 not only the one who invented us, but also the
 one
 who did good for us,
 not only the one who established us, but also
 the one
 who took pity on us,
 not only the one who formed us, but also the
 one
 who gave us possibilities,
 not only the one who authored, but also the
 one
 who humbled himself for us,
 not only the one who designed us, but also the
 one
 who performed miracles,
 not only the one who started us, but also the
 one
 who gave us light,

⁸Mt. 8:8, Heb. 4:12, Gen. 1:3.⁹Is. 33:10.



not only the anointed, but also the shepherd,
 not only the healer, but also the caretaker,
 not only the protector, but also the physician,
 not only a supporter, but also a commander,
 not only a victor, but also a king,
 not only a creator, but also sweetness,
 not only the giver of all gifts, but also a
 generous sponsor,
 not only always patient, but also forgiving,
 not only not angered, but also unvengeful,
 not only sharing our sorrows, but also
 reading our hearts,
 not only providing comfort, but also refuge,
 not only supremely compassionate, but also
 God,
 not only endless goodness, but also blessed in
 all things.

q

Now, as you created me, before I existed,
 and you revealed yourself as my sustenance,
 and I pray that you might reinstate my soul
 together with the tabernacle of my body in
 the spotlessness of the clean holiness of
 their former being so
 that your limitless marvels
 might be bestowed more amply, frequently
 and increasingly
 upon the ever-renewing present rather
 than upon the fading shadows of ages past.
 And when recounting my sins,
 however much the wings of my mind can
 bear to remember,
 may I be justified in your name, Almighty,¹⁰
 in confessing my own stains upon my soul, and
 may you forgive the baseness of the many sins
 I have revealed,
 Almighty, seer of secrets, savior of all, so
 that I might not, due to lack of good news,
 slide back and long for my former ways.
 Envy with the Psalmist those who have been
 saved by baptism,¹¹
 and wounded in my soul by the thorns of sin,
 may your hand not press on me again more
 heavily,¹²

¹⁰Acts 13:39

¹¹Ps. 31:1, 37:5.

¹²Job 19:21.

making the burden of my transgressions greater
 than the sweetness of your gifts.¹³

Rather, free me through your blessed Holy
 Spirit,

I pray you, Lord of all, from the laws of sin and
 death.¹⁴

Spare me from falling with weakness before
 reaching the dawn of your truth as written in
 the Scriptures.¹⁵

For wherever forgiveness reigns, sin is ban-
 ished,

and wherever your living word gives encour-
 agement, there is no despair.

And wherever your gifts abound, debts are dis-
 solved.

And the hand of God being close by,
 nothing is impossible.

Rather, everything basks in light, filled with
 strength

and invincible potency.

Yours is salvation, life, renewal, mercy,
 and at the same time,

a sweet kingdom, incorruptible and glorified
 forever.

Amen.

Prayer 50 (ϥ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
 Heart*

u

Since there is no salvation for souls without
 Christ¹

and there is no light without the sight of the
 eyes,

nor is there sweetness of the sun without
 the rays of dawn,

in the same way there is no remission of sins
 without confession of secrets and the baring of
 the soul.

For what good is purity,
 if you are judged with the Pharisees?

¹³Ps. 31:4, 37:5.

¹⁴Rom. 8:2.

¹⁵Rom. 8:3-4.

¹Acts 4:12.



Or what harm are my transgressions,
 if I am to be praised with the tax collectors? ²
 Where is it written that Joel was punished,
 for repeating three times the distress of his
 soul? ³
 Might a holy man be blamed for reminding us
 of the Last Judgment? ⁴
 Is it possible that Isaiah can be called a man of
 unclean lips, ⁵ when he stood apart from the
 deeds of
 the house of Israel?
 And how can God, who took on Adam's body
 out of
 sympathy for me, be considered blameworthy
 for
 praying to his Father like a sinner? ⁶
 How can the proverb be interpreted:
 "The heart of the wise is in the house of mourn-
 ing,
 but the heart of fools is in the house of mirth."
⁷

For he, who does not confess the error of Adam
 to his own heart, and like the fortunate king
 who took
 upon himself the sins of his ancestors, ⁸
 consider the sins of all his own ⁹
 shall lose his righteousness, like one who
 thinks our
 human nature incorruptible.
 And as it is written, a heart can not make
 a merry countenance in expectation of the good
 news ¹⁰
 if one does not, as taught by Christ's apostle
 experience sorrow and repentance. ¹¹



Now, I must memorialize
 the ancient counsel of the sage,

²Lk. 18:9-14.

³Jl. 1:15.

⁴Jl. 2:1-2, 11

⁵Is. 6:5.

⁶Heb. 5-7.

⁷Ec. 7:4.

⁸Ps. 106:6.

⁹Rom. 5:12.

¹⁰Pr. 15:12.

¹¹2 Cor. 7:10.

advice even our Lord saw fit to repeat ¹²
 when the ungodly gather,
 do not go sit at the head of the table among the
 haughty ¹³
 the place David and Jeremiah advised, ¹⁴
 as a hard and fast rule, to avoid.
 But rather sit with the contrite, those humili-
 ated by sin,
 and stricken by the fear of retribution on
 the great day of judgment,
 those who have humbled themselves willingly
 with the least of those on earth.
 With them God on high rejoices.
 And I dare to be deemed worthy of this rule
 in order to be ranked among the chosen on
 the seats of bliss and to escape the rebuke of
 the prophet, who remarked about the arrogant:
 "Do not come near me, for I am pure, and who
 can
 look upon me?" ¹⁵
 Thus drawing upon blessed David's immeasur-
 able
 humility, I say with him:
 I am like an animal, ¹⁶
 deprived of sensibility and besieged by evils. ¹⁷
 My wounds have festered and become putrid
 because of my incorrigible stupidity. ¹⁸
 And even like certain of the chosen in Assyria,
 who were
 spotless in soul, but who by their own willful
 impudence
 condemned themselves, ¹⁹
 I say with them in the words of the great priest
 Ezra,
 "I am unable even to lift up my face to you,
 God." ²⁰



I, like a mirror of mankind,
 mix with their sins my own,

¹²Pr. 25:6.

¹³Lk. 14:8.

¹⁴Ps. 1:1, Ps. 26:6, Jer. 15:17.

¹⁵Is. 65:5.

¹⁶Ps. 73:22.

¹⁷Ps. 40:12.

¹⁸Ps. 38:5.

¹⁹Dan. 3:28-30.

²⁰1 Ezra 9:6.



and doubling the bitterness of my own with theirs,
 I sigh with them.
 Although there was no need to paint in harsher tones,
 an already ugly picture,
 yet I sinned here,
 without thinking, I did what was not pleasing to you
 with many condemnable errors.
 Look upon me with compassion, Lord, for
 like Peter caught in the act of denial,²¹
 I am completely empty.
 Shed light upon me with the rays of your mercy,
 you who are benevolent in all ways,
 that I might receive your blessing, Lord,
 that I might be justified, live and be cleansed
 of my inner turmoil, not of the life with which
 you endowed me.
 I do not dare spread my sinful hands before you
 until you offer your blessed right hand
 for the renewal of my condemned self.
 Now, vanquish again my impudence with
 your meekness,
 visit upon me your lovingkindness toward hu-
 manity.
 And with your might to do all in all with all,
 forgive my wrongdoing, original, middle and last,
 Christ, king of the light of the just,
 for whom the impossible is possible.

¶

I am not worthy to mention your blessed name,
 for I am capable of dealing mortal blows to
 you, though you do only good,²²
 and to deface your seal, your grace, your breath
 of life,
 your gifts, your legacy, your talents,
 your image, your stamp, your anointing,
 your name, your son-hood, your majestic
 honor,
 your bounty, your courage, your friendship,
 your life, your light, your blessedness,
 your hope, your glory, your majesty that

²¹Lk. 22:61.

²²Lk. 22:63.

cannot be laid low,
 your incorruptible halo, your promise of se-
 crets,
 which through you, Lord Christ, was heralded
 to me in manifold ways.
 I am as impudent as a serpent or adder,
 with deaf ears, shut tight with wounds,²³
 which in the face of your ever growing good-
 ness,
 multiplied yet more my wrongdoing,
 and completely destroyed me,
 denied me life, and bound me with death,
 a slave to decadence.²⁴

¶

Now you who alone are fair and just in your
 benevolent judgment, who are blessed in com-
 passion,
 I have sinned against you. I have transgressed.
 I have been unjust.
 For these I am ruined, corrupted, guilty, de-
 based.
 I did not obey your confessed, worshiped,
 praised word.
 You who revealed yourself among us with your
 love beyond telling,
 the mere writing of which is great and the
 meaning
 of which is overwhelming,
 to you justice and glory and eternal praise,
 and for me, ashamed before you, my caretaker,
 atonement, mercy and healing,
 help and protection for heart and soul,
 praised in all forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 51 (ԾԱ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

Now, should I, a mortal who has strayed in ev-
 ery way,
 plead with another earthly being,

²³Ps. 58:5-6

²⁴2 Pet. 2:19



to whom it is vain to cry out?
 To a mere rational mortal, on whom it would
 be false to place hope of salvation?¹
 To a frail human, whose strength is as feeble
 and
 faltering as his word?
 To the princes on earthly thrones,²
 whose trappings are as transitory as their be-
 ings?
 To a blood brother,
 who likewise is needy of contentment?
 To my earthly father,
 whose care diminishes with his dwindling
 days?
 To my mother, who bore me,
 whose compassion waned with her retreating
 life?
 To the kingdoms of this world, perhaps, who
 are always more artful in killing than giving
 life?
 Or to you, beneficent God, glorified in the
 highest,
 who live and give life to all and
 who after death are able to work incorruptible
 renewal.³

¶

For if we flee, it is you who come after us.
 If we are weak, you give us strength.
 If we falter, you set us on the right and easy
 path.
 If we faint, you encourage us.
 If we are ailing in body and soul, you heal us.
 If we lie, you justify us with your truth.
 If we stumble into the abyss, you direct us to
 heaven.
 If we do not turn from our willfulness, you
 guide us.
 If we sin, you weep.
 If we are just, you smile.
 If we are estranged, you mourn.
 If we approach, you celebrate.
 If we give, you receive.
 If we become stubborn, you are patient.
 If we are ungrateful, you grant abundantly.

¹Ps. 108:12 (Arm 107:13).

²Ps. 146:3 (Arm 145:3).

³Phil. 3:21.

If we quit, you are sad.
 If we are brave, you rejoice.

¶

The blessed and wonderful Psalm One Hun-
 dred Three⁴
 comforts my failing heart,
 and heralds the good news of the hope of life.
 It is an assurance of salvation
 that triumphs over demons and the doubts of
 the Slanderer.
 It is like the Lord's cross, a sign of good for-
 tune,
 glorious and resplendent,
 unshakable in its exalted light,
 invincible in the strength on high,
 standing as an irresistible champion,
 unmovable forever
 against the immoral ways of Satan's tyranny.
 For the discerning soul, it is a treasure of spiri-
 tual goods,
 showing the defeat of death and the absolution
 of sin, plus
 double hopes for each, now and eternally.
 It promises restoration for the righteous.
 Its rules preach goodness and give life as
 written by the Spirit of God.
 The Psalms were songs of everything for
 the pure in heart:
 a testament of life, written for all people.

¶

For the Old law was a faint image of the New,⁵
 holding in its bosom good news and assurance
 of the great, blessed victory over death
 and heavenly life like that of the angels forever,
 beyond telling.
 They were passing writings and replaceable
 rules.⁶
 Their function was to condemn the frailties
 of transgressors,⁷
 and they were to be taken as earthly commit-
 ment and

⁴Arm 102.

⁵Heb. 7:18.

⁶Heb. 10:9.

⁷2 Cor. 3:7-9.



weak as an intercessor for reconciliation.⁸
 They leave undone the words of those who
 prayed.
 Although they show the salvation of Man-
 asseh,⁹
 who after so many unforgivable sins,
 in the trustworthy account of the prophet,
 guilty of spilling the blood of the righteous in
 the city of his ancestors, a city
 renowned for its miracles and dedicated to
 the great king.¹⁰
 Even the greatest of the seers, his teacher¹¹
 and the steward of the estate built by his
 forebears,
 was hacked in two by Manasseh with horrific
 torment.
 As a symbol of his revolt, cutting off the last
 hope of his salvation,
 he committed yet another brutal misdeed and
 still
 he had the arrogance to enter into unlawful
 battle with the Most High.
 Never even having respected the honor of the
 creator
 and having denied the name of him who
 dwells in the altar,
 he persecuted the spirit of God and pledged
 himself to Satan.
 And that very temple of the Lord,
 designated by God for adoration with incense,
 the most renowned gathering place,
 revered by the nations as a sacred place,
 where angelic visions and triumphant divine
 signs
 appeared in brilliant revelation.
 In that place reminiscent of heaven,
 awesome, resplendent,
 he erected the four-faced idol Kevan as
 a competing deity,¹²
 turning it into a vile cult center, a wasteland of

ruddle,
 and altar for satanic sacrifices,
 dispossessing the heavenly king of his regal
 dwelling place,
 stripping the most bountiful of his belongings.
 Transforming the landlord into a vagabond
 with
 no place to rest,
 he built a splendid tabernacle to Beelzebub,¹³
 and expelled the awesome name from there.
 Taking the legacy of the praiseworthy
 hostage,¹⁴
 wretchedly degrading the stature of the most
 merciful,
 he turned the hall of light into a small fox hole
 and for him who holds the world in his hand,
 he left not even a hut from his own creation to
 cover his head.¹⁵
 He tore down the sanctuary of the Holy of
 Holies,
 where the mysteries of blood sacrifice were
 conducted,
 and in their place installed fortune tellers.¹⁶
 He opened many ways to sinfulness.¹⁷
 Like a shepherd of destruction he led his flock
 to slaughter, a frenzied priest of waywardness.
 And all this he did, knowing full well the
 religion
 of the Laws, having as a father the great King
 Hezekiah, the likeness of David.¹⁸

6

He was so resourceful in his evil-doing that
 he blasphemed and contested God's honor
 with which he had been granted the glory
 of the kingdom.
 He butchered the multitude of the pious at
 prayer,¹⁹
 a traitor to his family, a bane to his associates,
 murderer of his intimates, killer of his com-
 panions,

⁸Heb. 10:3-8.

⁹2 Chr. 33:11-20.

¹⁰2 Kg. 21:1-16

¹¹referring to Isaiah.

¹²Am. 5:26, Ezek. 8:3, 2 Kg. 21:5. Kevan has been identified in various ways, including the Assyrian god Kiun, which Eusebius describes as having four eyes, and later is used in Arabic and Syriac to refer to the planet Saturn.

¹³2 Kg. 1:2, Mt. 12:24, name for Baal.

¹⁴This has been identified as the treasures King Hezekiah. 2 Kg. 20:13

¹⁵Mt. 8:20

¹⁶2 Kg. 21:6.

¹⁷Mt. 8:13.

¹⁸2 Kg. 18:3-6.

¹⁹2 Kg. 21:16.



he could not turn toward God, for he had rejected him.

He could not remember Abraham,
for he had become estranged.

He could not pray by Isaac, for he had cursed him.

He could not take pride in Israel, for he had been

banished from the glory of that name
of great mystery.

He could not sing a song of David,
for he had reprimanded him.

He could not approach the place of penitence,
for he had befouled it.

He could not take refuge in the tabernacle of God,

for he had replaced it with a molten idol.

He could not call to Moses, for his sins
against him were unforgivable.

He could not pray to Aaron, for he was
guilty before him.

He could not turn to the group of prophets
close at hand,

for he had killed them all.

Nevertheless, he was granted forgiveness
of sins

and regained his rule over the kingdom,²⁰

so that you, Lord who does good,

might multiply and inspire

praise beyond words that cannot be silenced,

through the peoples of all nations and

the ages of all times,

so that you might keep the gates of hope open
for entry,

for the glory of your exaltation

and as salvation for condemned people like
me, to whom

Christ gives the gift of immortality.

Praise forever.

Amen.

Prayer 52 (ԾԲ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

²⁰2 Chr. 33:13.

Ա

Blessed in holy essence,

boundless and unchangeable, truly good,
worthy of adoration, happiness professed
by all the earth,

most complete revelation of persistent hope,
compassionate and merciful,

without grudges even for the blinking of an
eye

despite the sin of many years.¹

Lord, with a new showering of grace and
streams of mercy from on high,

who delights in pouring forth enlightenment
miraculously without end,

more abundantly than upon the nations of old
and who opened and broadened those

narrow windows²

through which knowledge glimmers as
Solomon said,³

for him, and with him for me, a wretched
sinner.

You lift the screen which blocked the entry⁴

of God's freely given mercy,

the good news that was foretold

in the Old Testament obliquely, for example:

"Turn toward me and I will turn toward you,"⁵

and "when you turn and regret, then you shall
revive."⁶

Բ

For he changes the gloom of twilight

into the brightness of snow,

and people drenched in blood he washes white
as wool.⁷

In the midst of anger you still remember
mercy.⁸

The deserted cities of Israel are inhabited
anew.⁹

The overgrown byways abandoned by men

¹Ps. 103 (Arm. 102):8-10.

²1 Kg. 6:4.

³S. of S. 2:9.

⁴2 Cor. 3:8-18.

⁵Mal. 3:7, Zech. 1:3.

⁶Is. 30:15.

⁷Is. 1:18, Zech. 9:7.

⁸Hab. 3:2.

⁹Is. 6:11, Is. 44:26.



are trod again.

Those wasting from the famine of the soul are restored by your hand.

God withdrawing in anger, returns in mercy,¹⁰ granting pardon and refuge, and in the midst of reprimands grants double protection.

With his heartache, he also feels compassionate caring.

Q

The venerable voices of the prophets, foretold the liberating mission of your blessed coming, which is beyond human telling.

For the manifestations of the revelation of your good news

and the salvation of the cross, are countless and varied, faint and feeble, old and fleeting.

You raised your altars everywhere as testimony to

the blood of your new covenant, which echoes more resoundingly than the condemnation of Abel's murder.¹¹

Your victory in the battle for goodness, for a new, immortal life of grace, baptism, resurrection, and renewal,

for our kinship with you and union with your Holy Spirit,

for forgiveness, liberation, and enlightenment, for eternal purity, true bliss,

in communion with the angels, in unfading glory,

is the plea for reconciliation upon our lips voiced by

our Lord on high.

And what is more awe-inspiring,

for it is a monument to your magnanimity: the gift of

divine nature by election of your grace,¹²

uniting us with you, Creator, by partaking of your body

and sharing in your light of life,

the fulfillment of the good promise,

¹⁰Hos. 5:15, Hos. 6:1-3.

¹¹Heb. 12:24.

¹²2 Pet. 1:3.

which, in Paul's words, the Old Law did not have.¹³

You, Savior, came with your father's bounty, perfected and fulfilled in perpetuity our undiminishing hope in you, Redeemer of all.

To you glory with your Father, with praise and blessings to the Holy Spirit, forever and ever.

Amen.

Prayer 53 (ԾԳ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Lord, Lord almighty, king of all creation, blessed mercy, God of all,

who surpasses the limits of the widespread expanses,

you are the sum of all infinities,

The solid is fluid for you, and the fluid solid.¹

There is nothing impossible for you, O terrifying,

triumphant power.

Fire is a refreshing mist² and rain a consuming flame.³

You can make a stone into a speaking figure,⁴

or turn a speaking figure into a breathless statue.⁵

You honor the repentant sinner,

and the seemingly pure you scrutinize justly and condemn.⁶

Those approaching death you release with the joy of grace.⁷

And the humiliated you restore, anointing their faces with cheer.⁸

You rescue the one who has stumbled into a

¹³Heb. 7:19.

¹Num. 20:8, Ex. 14:22.

²Dan. 3:25.

³Gen. 19:24; Wis. 16:17-19.

⁴Mt. 3:9, Lk. 19:40.

⁵Gen. 19:26.

⁶Lk. 18:9-14.

⁷Acts 12:11, Dan. 13 (Arm).

⁸Mk. 5:25-34.



snare.⁹

And the one who wavers you set confidently upon a rock.¹⁰

The one who is afflicted and sighing you make happy.¹¹

And the impudent you put in his place.¹²

And when our resources are exhausted you perform the greatest miracles.

For you forgive sins and erase our iniquity; you pardon our injustices and forget our sins as the prophets Isaiah and Jeremiah predicted.¹³

¶

When I consider, deeply grateful,
the grace of your new salvation

I am dumb struck by its breadth.

For this inexhaustible favor of your light,
which you have bestowed upon a stubborn
wretch like me,

I shall pray to you with the prayer you taught,¹⁴
while continuing my writings,
filling the leaves of this book of mournful
psalms,

with grieving and sighs of the heart.

But in doing this I have, for the pleasure of the
Giver,

mixed the cure with the pain,

encouragement with disappointment,

the name of our creator with discouragement,
comfort with sadness,

the sweetness of our Savior with my bitterness,
grace with the retribution of the Law,

your liberating blessing with cursed punishments,

complete renewal with the death of the body.

¶

I believe in your almighty word, hence I bear
witness.¹⁵

Hear the silence of my heart, Lord Jesus, and

⁹Ps. 145 (Arm 144):14.

¹⁰Ps. 40 (Arm 39):2.

¹¹2 Kg. 20:1-8.

¹²2 Kg. 20:8-11.

¹³Is. 43:25, Jer. 31:34.

¹⁴Mt. 6:7-9.

¹⁵2 Cor. 4:13.

the great clamor of my voice crying perpetually
for you,

who came to share our body and our image,
who came also

as a high priest not under the Law, but throwing
off the yoke of the Law.¹⁶

Instead of animal sacrifice, you offered your
blessed body,¹⁷

perpetually sacrificed without dying and

without diminishing the pardon you grant,

not just for those of few sins,

but also for those whose expectation of life is
cut off.

With these bodies so inclined to sin,¹⁸

how could we reach salvation, even if we tried
for

ten thousand years?

But you God of all, for this reason,

willingly made yourself the sacrifice,¹⁹

and suffering death are shared in communion
for our pardon.

Not that you, O fountain of purity, are forced
to be

sacrificed daily; rather you chose it through
the Holy Spirit

and with the approval of the Father for
our reconciliation.

You are continuously sacrificed.

And you, inscrutable God of all,

taking on my nature for my sake and in my
stead,

for my salvation,

as if I were united and participating in your
very being

through your all-embracing body.

And you, benefactor, for me and those like me,
taking my sins upon you,

though you are sinless, and accepting death,

which was the punishment I, a mortal sinner,
deserved,

and on my behalf bearing guilt,

so I may suffer with you who

willingly dies but remains living.

You are offered in the divine mystery and

¹⁶Heb. 5:1-10.

¹⁷Heb. 9:11-14; 10:1-18.

¹⁸Rom. 7:23-24.

¹⁹Gal. 2:20, Eph. 5:2.

distributed in indivisible parts,
not by the hands of those who deny you,
but by the faith of those who confess to you.



A certain pagan priest who had converted
from idolatry,²⁰
once made a weighty decision,
with presumptuous expectations for a person
such as he, saying:
“I believe that with the death of my passing
body,
I will more readily attain glory and bliss
through communion
than through martyrdom or even,
through right living, wretch that I am.”
And from his paradoxical observation I con-
cluded
that he actually believed, that even the pious,
without partaking in communion,
cannot be truly fulfilled,
until they are united in spirit through this great
mystery.
When he said, “You were sacrificed twice
for me a sinner,”
he meant, “you truly became me,
exchanging my vileness with your savor,
sacrificing your material body,
through the wafer of the life of light.”
For these reasons, at the last supper in the
upper room,
at the first partaking of this grace,
as the cure for incurable diseases,
he distributed his body and blood for the
forgiveness of sins.
This he deemed higher than martyrs’ shedding
their own blood.
By this example of hope, he sought to show
God gives more weight to this sacrifice of
faith,
than through other efforts to obtain pardon,
mercy or grace.

So much greater is the force of the divine

²⁰Commentators believe this to be a reference to a Zoroastrian priest who converted after seeing the great faith of the Armenians at the battle of Vardanants in 451. Critical Edition, p. 1061, n. 13.

compared to the human,
and the willing sacrifice of the Lord’s body
united with the divine,
than the offering of animal sacrifices.²¹
the immortal, not the mortal,
the awesome light, not the shadowy darkness,
the eternal, not the passing,
the exalted, not the earthly,
the uncreated, not the created,
goodness in its essence, not corruption by
nature,
especially since his is the willing and his the
giving of life,
and he is the occasion for blessing, not a cause
for cursing.



Now, I pray you, compassionate Lord,
grant me, broken in heart and spirit,
the salve of life from heaven on high.
Come sweetly to me, ill with sin.
Pardon my debts, in your omnipotence.
And for my part, the truth and trustworthiness
of these words lie in this:
You, creator of all, dwell in the saints.²²
And in the true words of Paul, as we sow,
so shall we reap.²³
And, the infirm of sight can not bear the glare
of sun.²⁴
But you, doer of good, who created everything
from nothing,
look kindly upon those who truly have believed
in you,
deeming this enough for salvation.
You who are not limited by law,
but prevail over it, breaking loose from its le-
galism.
For all us sinners in our bewilderment,
you remain the only condition for the good
news.
To you with the Father and the Holy Spirit,
glory and power forever.
Amen.

²¹Heb. 9:11-14.

²²Ps. 22 (Arm 21):3-4.

²³Gal. 6:7-8.

²⁴Yeznik Koghbatsi, Refutation of the Sects, 1.1.

Prayer 54 (ԾԴ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

And now, in all and for all, your mercy is hope,
Lord Jesus, the first light of our eyes and our hearts,
all good deeds, life and immortality are from you.

Turn with compassion toward me
and make my soul return to you rejoicing.¹
For without you I cannot be transformed anew,
and if your will is not in sympathy with me,
I am unable to save myself since I am condemned
to death.

And if you, my guide, did not show me the way,
marking the footsteps on the path that leads to you,
I would fall into the abyss on the right and the left.

Բ

I am not proud, for I am justly scorned.
I am not arrogant, for I am blameworthy.
I am not haughty, for I am abandoned.
I do not boast, for I am reduced to silence.
I do not rebel, for I am mocked.
I do not rejoice, for I am pitiful.
I do not justify myself, for I am wicked.
A horse does not go straight without someone
at the reins,
nor does a ship sail forth without a helmsman,²
nor does a ploughshare make a furrow
without a plowman,
nor does a pair of oxen move properly without
a driver,
nor does a cloud float in the sky without the
wind,
nor do the stars appear and disappear without
a scheduler,
nor does the sun course through the zodiac
without

¹Jer. 31:18.

²Jas. 3:3-4.

the action of air.

Nor do I, like them, do anything except at the pleasure

of your commandments, doer of good.³

For you alone give life to thinking beings.

And you alone maintain order in the cycle of creatures.

And you alone are my salvation, as the Psalmist said,⁴

and you proclaim in joyous voice the good news,

which resounds in the ears of the attentive of all ages –

“Come to me, all you who labor and are heavy laden,

and I will give you rest and cleanse you of your sins.”⁵

Գ

But what does it avail me to be cleansed,

if I am only to be soiled again?⁶

And what use is taking communion,

if I am to be damned to Hell?⁷

Or why should I glory in Abraham,

if I have strayed from his deeds,⁸

I, the abominable son of an Amorite father,

and a Hittite or Canaanite mother,

in the words of the Prophet, as if written for me.⁹

I deserve to be the disinherited offspring of the Ethiopian, and not the fruit of Sarah's womb,¹⁰

in the prophet's words, apt to me.¹¹

I am the brother of Samaria and Gomorrah.¹²

I am a child unwashed and unsalted,
the unripe fruit of the unripe womb of Aholah

³Jn. 15:5.

⁴Ps. 62 (Arm 61):2.

⁵Mt. 11:28.

⁶2 Pet. 2:20-22.

⁷Heb. 6:4-6.

⁸Jn. 8:39-40.

⁹Ezek. 16:2-3, 45.

¹⁰Gen. 21:2.

¹¹Am. 9:7.

¹²Ezek. 16:46



and Ahoblibah,¹³
doubly condemned by the Prophet Ezekiel.

Դ

And like one imperiled on the high seas,
tossed by waves whipped up by the winds,
I am in terror and torment,
swept away by the wild currents,
clawing with my fingers this way and that to
hold on,
as if borne away in the torrents of a river
flooding in spring,
in an involuntary and pitiful downward course.
Gulping water, unable to breathe because of de-
bris
I have swallowed,
foul, slimy, prickly seaweed,
dragging me into the pangs of death.
Like a drowning man, carried by the flow,
I am wretched:
They speak, but I do not understand.
They call, but I do not hear.
They shout, but I do not wake up.
They clamor, but I do not budge.
They trumpet, but I do not rally.
I am wounded, but I do not feel.
Like an abominable idol,
devoid of any sense of goodness,
my true essence is more evil
than this example,
more heinous and reprehensible,
deserving to be brought before the tribunal of
Christ.

Ե

And since I leave readers this testament
recording my misdeeds along the path of no re-
turn,
that they might pray to God through my words
day by day,
may this book remain as a guide for repen-
tance,
continuously lifted in voice to you, almighty
Lord,
its letters like my body, its message like my
soul.

¹³Ezek. 23:3-4.

May it always be present before you, O bound-
less God.

Accept my pleas as from an innocent petitioner,
compassionate God, who loves mankind,
blessed through all eternity.

Amen.

Prayer 55 (ԾԵ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

Ա

On the wings of my soul I have soared
through endless generations of mankind,
weighing them in the scales of my rational
mind.
I found none my equal in sin.
Therefore, I have adopted the Psalm of David
as my theme,
like a stern reprimand delivered with the over-
seer's staff,
“Who equals me in my wrongdoing and iniq-
uity?”¹
And since these words literally apply to me,
a mortal man,
I again testify against myself under oath,
roundly condemning myself
rather than letting others be banished for my
words,
so that perhaps you might pardon me,
forgiver of my sins.²

Բ

Now, here in this book, what prayers,
what fragrant incense
shall I offer pleasing and acceptable to you,
blessed heavenly king Christ?
If not a prayer that you bless those I have
cursed,
release those I have bound, free the con-
demned,
comfort the outcast, reconcile the antagonized,
console the mournful, heal the afflicted,
care for the shunned, protect the betrayed,

¹Ps. 94 (Arm 93):16 (Armenian version).

²Mt. 6:12, 14, 15.



minister to the souls of those whose bodies are wounded.

Thus, when I greet people with blessings, hear me,
and when with curses, pay no attention,
compassionate Lord.

¶

I am most wretchedly tormented,
the least of those who pray to you with this book.

I have forgiven my debtors with all my soul,
so that you might block the cruel wishes of
my spiteful voice.

And on my knees repeatedly, I have prayed,
with all my heart, for reconciliation with those
who
have betrayed me.

I pray for them along with those who have
shown kindness.³

For as you are greater than I,
may you visit a comparable portion of mercy
upon me,
praiseworthy guardian,
you who are life for mortals like me,
strength for the frail,
might for the unsteady,
fountain of wisdom for the stupefied.
For I am always stumbling in error,
like an inexperienced diver in dark waters,
unwittingly in the snare of death,
I did not comprehend the danger.
I did not recognize the trap.

I did not see the hidden devices for capturing
the quarry.

I did not suspect camouflaged traps.

I did not sense the ambush on all sides.

I did not feel the hostage-taking fishhook net.⁴

As the Psalmist said,

“Evils visited me, and I was unable to recognize them.”⁵

¶

And as a certain foreign philosopher aptly said,
“Evil is death that comes without warning or

reason.”⁶

I shall confirm it in my own case:

Like dumb cattle,

we die, but are not terrified.

We perish, but are not astonished.

We are buried, but are not humbled.

We are shunned, but are not contrite.

We are corrupted, but are not regretful.

We are worn down, but do not care.

We are robbed, but we do not gather ourselves.

We proceed, but without precautions.

We are enslaved, but are not aware.

¶

That happy man, Job, called mortal death rest,⁷
and with that holy man I too would agree,
had I not the heavy burden of mortal deeds and
were I not on the path of the hidden traps,
where

the trapsetter is invisible,

the present is non-existent,

the past unknown, and the future questionable,

I am impatient and my nature is skeptical,

my legs shaky and my mind reeling,

my passions are unruly and my habits intemperate,

my body is laced with sin and my inclinations
toward the worldly,

my rebelliousness innate and my character contradictory,

my dwelling clay and the rain pelting,

my needs innumerable and perils on all sides,

my mind fond of evil and my desires hating the
good,⁸

my life ephemeral and my joys rare,

my delusion stupefying and my pastimes childish,

my work vain and my pleasures illusory,

my hoarding is of nothing and my storehouse
filled with the wind,

my likeness is of a shadow and my image

³Mt. 5:44.

⁴Ps. 140 (Arm 139):5.

⁵Ps. 40 (Arm 39):12.

⁶Commentators differ on the identity of this reference. Some cite evidence from Davit Anghaght that these lines refer to Plato and his dialogue Phaedo. Others believe it is based on a citation from Eghishe, History of the War of Vartan, p. 14). Critical Edition, p. 1063, n. 4.

⁷Job 3:22.

⁸Gen. 8:21.



ridiculous.
 For when the command came,⁹
 as St. Paul wrote,
 it found me unprepared.
 Sin came alive when confronted by justice
 and I died for life and came alive for death.

9

As the Good Book foretold¹⁰
 alien, evil forces, stole the wise treasure of my
 heart.
 Wisdom waned in me, as the Proverb teller
 says,
 and evil impulses waxed.¹¹
 I did not fix the eye of my soul on the head of
 my life, Christ,
 who would have led me down the straight path.
 For in trying to run too quickly, I dug myself in
 deeper.
 In trying to reach the unreachable, I failed to
 reach my own level.
 In pretending to greatness, I slipped from
 where I was.
 From the heavenly path, I sank to the abyss.¹²
 Trying to avoid harm, I was permanently debil-
 itated.
 Trying to be completely pure, I was
 corrupted completely.
 I dodged to the left, and left myself open from
 the right.
 Chasing the second, I lost the first.
 Seeking the insignificant, I forfeited the impor-
 tant.
 Keeping the small vow, I broke the covenant.
 Trying to break a habit, I picked up a vice.
 Avoiding the petty, I fell prey to the weighty.
 What I did, I did to myself,
 which is the worst testimony against me.
 Only you are able to deliver me, a captive slave,
 from these things,
 restoring to life a soul devoted to death.
 For you alone, Lord Christ, revered doer of
 good,
 with the boundless glory of the Father and

the Holy Spirit are
 blessed forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 56 (ԾԶ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

As for the agents of death,
 the roots of the bitter fruit of the tree of damna-
 tion,
 hostile kin, intimate adversaries, traitorous
 sons, I now
 shall describe them in detail by name.
 They are
 my sinister heart,
 my gossiping mouth,
 my lustful eyes,
 my wanton ears,
 my murderous hands,¹
 my weak kidneys,
 my wayward feet,
 my swaggering gait,
 crooked footprints,
 polluted breath,
 dark inclinations,
 dried innards,
 mushy mind,
 inconstant will,
 incorrigible depravity,
 wavering virtue,
 banished soul,
 dissipated legacy,
 wounded beast,
 arrow-struck bird,
 fugitive on the precipice,
 apprehended criminal,
 drowning pirate,
 treasonous soldier,
 reluctant fighter,
 undisciplined warrior,
 slovenly laborer,
 faithless worshiper,
 worldly cleric,

⁹Rom. 7:9-11.

¹⁰Job 17:2 (Armenian version).

¹¹Pr. 30:2-3.

¹²Is. 14:13-15.

¹Is. 1:15.



impious priest,
 officious minister,
 haughty clerk,
 deranged sage,
 grotesque rhetorician,
 immodest manner,
 shameless countenance,
 insolent grimace,
 repulsive tone,
 subhuman mold,
 lurid beauty,
 rotting meat,
 sickening flavor,
 weed-choked orchard,
 worm-eaten vine,²
 garden of briars,
 rusted ear of corn,
 mouse-infested honey,
 threadbare outcast,
 haughty desperado,
 closed-minded heretic,
 irreconcilable sectarian,
 fast-talking charlatan,
 herd mentality blowhard,
 brutishly wicked, hellishly greedy,
 unashamedly arrogant,
 frenzied atheist, assassin ready to strike,
 sower of thorns, woeful contentment,
 debased majesty, defiled splendor, wasted ability,
 humbled greatness, trampled glory,
 persistent disobedience, willful error,
 negligent steward, treacherous adviser, alienated friend,
 corrupt official, covetous associate,
 stingy boss, crooked supervisor,
 soul without compassion, wish without charity,
 hateful habit, insatiable appetite,³
 imprudent actions, invisible damage,
 secret curses, antagonizing events,
 careless merchant, gluttonous exploiter,
 drunken official, duplicitous treasure warden,⁴
 dissension sowing emissary, sleeping doorman,
 proud beggar, rich ingrate,⁵

²Dt. 28:39.

³Pr. 12:10; Rom. 1:30.

⁴Lk. 12:45.

⁵Sir. 25:2.

dishonest secretary, untrustworthy custodian,
 back-biting relatives,⁶
 tardy messenger, wayward courier,
 vexing envoy, foolish mediator,⁷
 banished ruler, feeble king, broken-spirited emperor,
 rogue prince, plundering general,
 biased judge, capricious rabble,
 for enemies – cause for snickering,
 for friends – cause for tears,
 for writers – cause for reproach,
 for adversaries – cause for accusation.
 For though I was indeed called by the highest names,
 by my works I earned the worst of these descriptions.⁸
 Thus, these are the multitude of seductive devices,
 which I allowed to deceive me in my naiveté? or
 I allowed to prevail over me in my weakness,
 condemning myself willfully to death.

¶

Now, which of the things listed above,
 abhorrent to you and devastating for me,
 shall I offer in service to you?
 Which of these things wrapped in corruption
 shall I present before your holy majesty?
 For how long will your patience
 bear this many sins?
 How much will you forgive?
 How will you remain silent?
 How will you even bear to listen?
 How can you spare the rod
 when I am worthy of being beaten to death?
 But you visit the mercy of your light
 in the pitch blackness of the dark side of the soul,
 to cure, pardon and give us life.
 O force that cannot be deterred,
 to you glory in all things,
 Amen.

⁶Ps. 50 (Arm 49):20.

⁷Acts 15:24.

⁸From the General Confession, “I was called to the profession of Christianity, but was found unworthy of it by my deeds.”

Prayer 57 (ԾԷ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Christ God, awe-inspiring name, vision of majesty,¹
 inscrutable image of sublimity, infinite force,²
 model of the light of salvation, defender of life,³
 gate to the kingdom of heavenly rest,⁴
 path of tranquility,⁵
 refuge of renewal that ends sadness,⁶
 almighty sovereign of all being,⁷
 call to blessing,
 voice of good news,
 proclamation of bliss,
 salve of immortality,
 indescribable son of the one and only God.
 What is impossible for me is easy for you.⁸
 What is beyond my reach was put there by you.
 What is inaccessible for me is close to you.
 What is hidden from me in my fallen state
 is within view for your beatitude.
 What is impossible for me is done by you.
 What is incalculable for me is already tallied
 by you, who are beyond telling.⁹
 What is despair for me is consoling for you.
 What is incurable for me is harmless for you.¹⁰
 What is sighing for me is rejoicing for you.
 What is heavy for me is light for you.
 What effaces me is written for your power.
 What is lost for me is conquered for you.
 What is inexpressible for me is comprehensible
 for you.
 What is gloom for me is radiance for you.
 What is infinite for me you hold in the palm of
 your blessed hand.¹¹

¹Jn. 12:45, 14:9.

²Col. 1:15.

³Jn. 8:12.

⁴Jn. 10:9.

⁵Jn. 14:6.

⁶Rev. 21:4.

⁷Col. 1:16.

⁸Mk. 10:27.

⁹Is. 40:12.

¹⁰2 Cor. 12:9.

¹¹cf. Is. 40:12.

What is somber for me is refreshing for you.
 What sets me to flight, you withstand.
 What holds me in check, you handily turn back.
 What is fatal for me is nothing before your
 almighty essence.

Բ

But you, merciful God of all, Lord Christ Jesus,
 if you take pity on me, you can instantly find a
 way out of my predicament.
 For the sake of the name of the majestic glory
 of your blessed Father,
 for the sake of the compassionate will of your
 Holy Spirit,
 look with favor upon this relentless expression
 of
 contrition for my wrongdoing
 and the reproach I heap upon myself from the
 depth of my heart.¹²
 Look upon the distracted unreadiness of my na-
 ture.
 Grant healing for my wounds,
 and a way out for me, for I am lost,
 deliverance from my multiple symptoms of
 impending death,
 and the path of life, for I am wayward,
 renewal for me who am corrupt,
 and entry into the light for me who am impi-
 ous.
 And if I have displayed unprecedented will,
 how much more will you show your
 characteristic goodness?
 And if a sweet fruit came forth from a thorn
 bush,
 how much sweeter is the taste of immortality
 from
 the tree of life?
 If I begged for mercy for those who hate me,
 how would you not grant me, one of yours,
 a second portion, Almighty, of your
 undiminishing abundance?

Գ

Now, look at your greatness, Lord most high,
 and then look at my smallness.

¹²Ps. 51 (Arm 50):17.



Accept this meager confession of my innumerable sins,
 you who see everything in its totality.
 And as you overlooked the fall of the Rock,¹³
 may you ignore my vacillation, a small grain of sand.
 And as you immediately pardoned him for his sins,
 when David said "I have sinned,"¹⁴
 may you do the same with your long-suffering forbearance for the voice of my sighing heart,
 which you grant to all generously and fairly,¹⁵
 merciful creator of all.
 Like a good and judicious conqueror,
 who does not disdain me, the least of your captives,¹⁶
 you did not destroy me, but renewed me,
 who am sustained by your blood, compassionate Lord.¹⁷
 For yours is salvation, from you is pardon,
 and to you is befitting glory in all things forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 58 (ԾԼ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Lord Jesus, blessed with the Father,
 by favor of your Holy Spirit and
 all who are blessed through your blessedness,¹
 blessed only son of the blessed,
 no other king other than you, Christ, rules
 over my breath.
 As the prophet Isaiah said,
 the blessing of Jacob will come when I
 lift away his sins.²

¹³Mt. 26:69-75.

¹⁴2 Sam. 12:13.

¹⁵Rom. 2:11.

¹⁶cf. Paul, a prisoner of Christ: Eph. 3:1, Philem. 1:1; 1:9.

¹⁷Some mss. "and nourished by your bosom."

¹Gen. 22:18.

²Is. 27:9.

Now, have mercy upon me, Lord, with lovingkindness,
 as you did in the past
 and bless me, your speaking, thinking vessel,
 as you did the voice of David and Moses,³
 by the visitation of your word of salvation.
 May I receive pardon with your blessing.
 Merciful heavenly ruler,
 work a miracle upon me divinely,
 as you did for those gathered in the hall in Bethesda,⁴
 who were bedridden for many years.
 Among them was a person,⁵
 a paralytic who had been stricken for thirty-eight years,
 whom you did not refuse to heal by laying on of hands,
 even when knowing of the incurable malice
 that awaited you on the day of your betrayal,⁶
 on the bitter night of the battle against the Lord,
 our assurance, great and beneficent.

Բ

Lord, though you admonished him,
 "Do not sin so that nothing worse befalls you."⁷
 But that did not deter him from being one of the first
 of the cruel accusers to condemn you to the cross.
 And for such a crippled, bewitched, ill-fated man,
 brought to his knees by death, you took pity.
 Lord, you are goodness beyond telling,
 wonder-filled human kindness,
 astonishing forgiveness, perplexing forbearance,
 unending sweetness, glorious mildness.
 You, over whom compassion prevails, but
 do not feel restrained.
 You are overwhelmed by mercy, but are not blamed.
 You are constrained by human kindness, but
 are not disdained.

³Ps. 67 (Arm 66):2, Num. 6:24.

⁴Jn. 5:3.

⁵Jn. 5:15.

⁶Jn. 5:3.

⁷Jn. 5:14.



You are compelled by goodness, but are not cursed.
 You act out of love, but are not ridiculed.
 You seek my return to you, but do not grow weary.
 You run after me in my obstinacy, but do not give up.
 You call out to me though I do not listen, but do not lose patience.
 You rush after me in my sloth and are not stopped.
 In the face of my evil, you are good.
 In the face of my total indebtedness, you are forgiving.
 In the face of my sinfulness, you are indulgent.
 In the face of my darkness, you are light.
 In the face of my mortality, you are life.

q

This is the message of all the books inspired for our benefit,
 which often bear heavenly fruits, indescribable and amazing.⁸
 Say to me also, wretched soul that I am, Lord, blessed and revered in all ways,
 “Arise, take the bed of your infirmity, the place of
 your destruction, and go to the tranquil repose of
 the life without toil.”⁹
 Sever, with the omnipotent sword of your commanding word,
 the wrappings of the grave that hold me in the bonds of the underworld.¹⁰
 Release me from the strangling noose that brutally demands my soul.
 Deliver those deserving death to the liberation of
 unending bliss on high
 by your life-giving and divine word.
 Do not hesitate, do not delay day by day,
 so the heavy burden of sin does not break my back,
 and destroy me, bend me downward, looking

⁸2 Tim. 3:16.

⁹Lk. 5:18-24, Jn. 5:8.

¹⁰Jn. 11:43-44.

to hell,¹¹
 so that the haughty one with tyrannical violence
 disarms my spiritual defenses and turns me into a slave of death.
 Come to my aid, good Lord who suffered with us the pangs of death’s torment.¹²
 Having lifted from me the cross of perdition, as you did once from the shoulder of the guard,¹³
 to erect the fitting monument to your courageous might,
 with steadfast faith and unshakable hope to be nailed to you inseparably.
 To you with the Father and the Holy Spirit, glory and dominion, forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 59 (ԾԹ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

u

I believe and bear witness in sound mind,
 through the insights of my soul and
 the visions of my conscience inspired by you,
 that for you, doer of good, the prayers of a sinner are
 more desirable than the petitions of the just.
 For the first, baring the defeated soul, awaits your grace
 and being well acquainted with the limits of human nature,
 rises up like a stern accuser,
 a combatant bent on self-mortification,
 a bitter critic and prosecutor who sees secrets.¹
 Whereas the second, looking upon his good works,
 places the hand of confidence on his soul,
 forgets the limitations of his nature
 and awaits rewards, rather than mercy.²

¹¹Lk. 13:10-17.

¹²Heb. 4:15.

¹³Mt. 27:32.

¹Lk. 18:13.

²Lk. 18:9, 11.



For that reason, the first is the subject of
innumerable accounts trumpeting your mercy,
and the second has been passed over in silence,
O inscrutable, awesome, and all-caring Lord!
I shudder at the thought that my accounts,
the accounts of a mere mortal go too far.³
So come Lord, do not let the gestures of a hu-
man hand
seem grander than yours.
Do not let your mercies be meted out in mortal
measure.

ⲡ

But those who have healthy organs are not in
need of
a physician's care,⁴
and those who with good vision have no need
of a guide,
and those who are well off do not beg at
the doors of the wealthy,
and those who are well fed do not wait for
crumbs of bread from the table,⁵
and those who lead a saintly life are not needy
of mercy,
so heavenly Lord almighty on high, take mercy
on me,
a tormented wretch,
for if I were like Job,
I would say my soul was upright and pure like
his.⁶
And if I were like Moses,
I would confidently say with him,
"The Lord recognizes his own."⁷
And if I were like David, I would say,
"I have done judgment and justice."⁸
And again in words that exceed our physical
nature:
"If I see sin in my heart, may the Lord not hear
me."⁹
If I were like Elijah, I would call myself a man
of God.¹⁰

³Lk. 18:12.

⁴Mk. 2:17.

⁵Mt. 15:27.

⁶Job 33:9.

⁷Num. 16:5.

⁸Ps. 119 (Arm 118):121.

⁹Ps. 66 (Arm 65):18.

¹⁰2 Kg. 1:9-10.

If I were like Jeremiah, I would emulate your
truth
in my soul.¹¹ If I were like Hezekiah, I would
proudly
say, with justification, "I walked before you
with righteousness."¹²
Or if I were like Paul, I would call myself
the dwelling place, oracle and receiver of
God's word.¹³

ⲓ

But I, lawless despite knowing the law,
not only cannot present my soul to you,
with respectful words like them, I cannot even
mention myself, who am totally corrupt,
to you in the same breath as these good souls,
for my impious tongue is not worthy to utter
your name
praised by all creation.
But you, who are capable of everything,
grant me the spirit of salvation,
the sheltering right arm,
the helping hand,
the command of goodness,
the light of mercy,
the word of renewal,
the cause of pardon,
and help of the staff of life.
For you are the hope of refuge, Lord Jesus
Christ,
blessed with the Father and Holy Spirit,
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 60 (Ⲯ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

Ⲯ

Long ago I learned that blessings
should not come from the mouth of a sinner,¹

¹¹Jer. 11:19 (Jeremiah is depicted as a lamb led to
slaughter, in the manner of Christ).

¹²2 Kg. 20:3, Is. 38:3.

¹³Gal. 2:20.

¹Ps. 50 (Arm 49):16.



therefore, how can I, even regretfully,
continue saying Psalms in worship
that earn only scorn for me?

How shall I praise my injuries and build
monuments
to my disgrace while gathering thorns in my
bare chest
instead of lilies?

How shall I dare to say with David:
“You have broken the teeth of the ungodly.”²
Or “The wicked shall dwell before your eyes.”³
Or “Judge me, Lord, according to your righteousness,
according to the integrity that is in me.”⁴
Or “Let wickedness be visited upon the sinful.”⁵
Or “Break the arms of the sinner and wicked,”⁶
and all that follows.
Or “Upon the wicked he shall rain snares,
fire and brimstone.”⁷
Or “The Lord shall cut off flattering lips and
the boasting tongue.”⁸
Or “You have tested my heart and found no
iniquity.”⁹
Or the next verse, “My steps have held fast
to your path.”¹⁰
Or “I shall behold thy face in righteousness.”¹¹
Or “I was upright before him.”
Or the next verse, “The Lord paid me according
to my righteousness and the cleanness of
my hands.”¹²
Or how can I cover up my lies, yet say with the
holy,

²Ps. 3:7.

³Ps. 5:4.

⁴Ps. 7:9 (note that St. Gregory writes “your righteousness,” whereas the KJV reads: “my righteousness.”)

⁵Ps. 7:10 (according to the Armenian version, whereas the KJV states “let the wickedness of the wicked come to an end.”)

⁶Ps. 10:15.

⁷Ps. 11:6.

⁸Ps. 12 (Arm 11):4.

⁹Ps. 17 (Arm 16):3.

¹⁰Ps. 17 (Arm 16):4.

¹¹Ps. 17 (Arm 16):15.

¹²Ps. 18 (Arm 17):23-24.

“I wash my hands in innocence.”¹³

Or wallowing in baseness brag, “I do not
consort

with the impious.”¹⁴

Or proudly put on a happy face, pathetic
though I am, and say, “Vindicate me, Lord, for
I have

walked in integrity.”¹⁵

Or I, the stranger to goodness, beg you,
knower of secrets,

“Do not count my soul among the wicked.”¹⁶

Or when cursing others although I deserve
cursing,

I dare say, “Requite them, Lord, according
to their works.”¹⁷

And shall I dare continue?

¶

If I should add to the previous verses,
my grief would double, my bitterness multiply.
My tears dammed up within me, daily seek
the comfort of the familiar scolding voice of
the Psalms, accusing me.

If I add the last part of Psalm 50,¹⁸
which dooms me as abominable,
gags my speech and exposes my guilty soul
to the prosecuting voice of God,
hope of life is lost.

I am pelted from the ramparts by deadly
missiles.

It is a misfortune to be cursed by others, but
it is worse to curse oneself. And if it is hard to
be
reproached by friends, how much more chilling,¹⁹

alarming and tormenting to be exposed before
the one who sees all.

But if one surrenders to humiliation and
lashes

¹³Ps. 26 (Arm 25):6.

¹⁴Ps. 26 (Arm 25):4.

¹⁵Ps. 26 (Arm 25):1.

¹⁶Ps. 28 (Arm 27):3.

¹⁷Ps. 28 (Arm 27):4.

¹⁸Ps. 50 (Arm 49):22.

¹⁹Ec. 7:21.



one's soul with the reproaches of one's own tongue,
one earns the blessings of the glorious and all-powerful

Lord for expressing one's return to him without covering the traces of the past, for the sake of love he cut the root of our²⁰ transgressions, undeterred by nay-sayers. The sheep of Christ's flock have found the cure, the balm for their inner wounds.

Yet amidst green pastures blooming with life-giving counsel, intelligent beings irrationally and willfully choose to graze in poisonous fields of delusion.

9.

And now, since this reprimand suits me exactly and describes the evil situation where I myself fuel the consuming fire poured from on high upon my head, the organ of thought.

What did I profit from the Psalms, when I remained fruitless despite my repeated chants, failing to sing with my soul as instructed by Paul?²¹

How shall I mix our Lord's words with those of the Prophet?

How can I, the greatest of sinners, the pinnacle of neediness, say with the Saint, "Get away, you workers of iniquity"?²²

Or how shall I, who has not fulfilled any of the multitude of commandments relating to grace or the law, cry with the happy man who has practiced all he preached, saying, "For I, your servant, have kept these commandments" and the words that follow?²³

²⁰Lk. 7:47.

²¹1 Cor. 14:15.

²²Ps. 6:8, Mt. 7:23.

²³Ps. 19 (Arm 18):11.

How shall I, who am devoid of life's wisdom, praise the Lord with the God-fearing?²⁴

And how shall I add my prayer to that of the great one, who said, "I sought but one thing from the Lord, to behold his splendor and to serve in his temple"?²⁵

How shall I seek what I am deprived of, when I hear, "It is fitting to bless the upright"?²⁶

How shall I curse my soul with my own lips, saying, among other things, "The gaze of the Lord is upon evil doers, whose memory shall be wiped from the face of the earth"?²⁷

Or again in another verse, "The evil soon shall perish"?²⁸

Or as in my case, "The arms of the wicked shall be stricken"?²⁹

Or how can I pray for my destruction, "Behold how the sinners perish"?³⁰

How shall I utter these blessed words with my unruly tongue: "I shall guard my way so that I do not sin with my tongue"?³¹

How shall I boast with the innocent when I choke on thorns of sin: "But you have upheld me because of my integrity"?³²

²⁴Ps. 22 (Arm 21):23.

²⁵Ps. 27 (Arm 26):4.

²⁶Ps. 33 (Arm 32):1.

²⁷Ps. 34 (Arm 33):16.

²⁸Ps. 37 (Arm 36):9.

²⁹Ps. 37 (Arm 36):17.

³⁰Ps. 37 (Arm 36):20.

³¹Ps. 39 (Arm 38):1.

³²Ps. 41 (Arm 39):12.



How shall I, a sinner deserving double punishment,
complain: “Deliver me, O God, from deceitful and
unjust men”?³³

ⲁ

How shall I dare say with David,
as if I am not a hypocrite and idolator,
“Have we forgotten the name of our God,
or spread our hands in prayer to a strange
god”?³⁴
For only one laid low in the baseness of sin,
erects bestial statues and images,
inciting infidelity and harlotry such as the
statues to
female Ashtoreth, Chemosh, the male Mil-
com,³⁵ and
the vile Tharahad,³⁶ with lewd, naked parts
like donkeys.³⁷

How then shall I not be ashamed to pray
with the martyr
who always held fast to the good:
“For your sake we are slain all day long,”³⁸
and the rest of this psalm?

How can I, the most foolish and perverse
of humans,
say: “My mouth shall utter wisdom,
and my heart, understanding”?³⁹

How can I, a flattering hypocrite, wish
for the bones of sycophants to be scattered?⁴⁰

How shall I recall the twice-repeated blessing

³³Ps. 43 (Arm 42):1

³⁴Ps. 44 (Arm 43):20.

³⁵1 Kg. 11:4-8.

³⁶See Movses Khorenatsi, Book II, ch. 27, where he lists statue to Tarata, an Assyrian god, among the idols removed by King Abgar from Edessa upon conversion to Christianity. Some scholars link Tarahat with Molech of the Old Testament.

³⁷Ez. 23:20.

³⁸Ps. 44 (Arm 43):22.

³⁹Ps. 49 (Arm 48):3.

⁴⁰Ps. 53 (Arm 52):5.

of the Psalmist: “May I walk before God in the
land of the living”?⁴¹

How shall I with my countless sins say:
“I have no sin or transgressions,
I walk without sin and am upright”?⁴²

Or how shall I condemn myself by say-
ing:
“Spare none of those who treacherously plot
evil”?⁴³

How shall I say: “Like candle wax melts
in the fire,
so sinners, before the face of God”?⁴⁴

Ⲃ

How shall I, who have indulged in mortal
vices, utter:
“I have humbled myself with fasting,”⁴⁵
or in the similar, “When they were sick, I wore
sackcloth,
and bowed down as in mourning and grief”?⁴⁶

How shall I remain calm,
when the punishment facing my ilk looms
before me:
“All wicked of the earth shall drink it
down to the dregs of God’s unceasing wrath,”⁴⁷
and “He will cut off the horns of the
wicked”?⁴⁸

How shall I mock Jacob’s ingratitude,⁴⁹
when I myself embrace shadows as the truth
and succumbing to their charms,

⁴¹Ps. 56 (Arm 55): 13, Ps. 116 (114-115):9.

⁴²Ps. 59 (Arm 58):4-6 (pursuant to the Armenian ver-
sion).

⁴³Ps. 59 (Arm 58):5.

⁴⁴Ps. 68 (Arm 67):2.

⁴⁵Ps. 35 (Arm 34):13

⁴⁶Ps. 35 (Arm 34):14.

⁴⁷Ps. 75 (Arm 74):9 (pursuant to the Armenian ver-
sion).

⁴⁸Ps. 75 (Arm 74):11.

⁴⁹This verse refers to Jacob’s unwillingness to follow
Moses to the promised land and to his unwillingness to
recognize the miraculous power of the rod of Moses.



forget Christ's salvation through the divine
miracle of the cross, this being more con-
demnable
than failing to recognize the miraculous power
of
the Moses' rod,
given us as assurance of divine providence?⁵⁰

How shall I point to the perils of attack-
ing demons,
as if they are foreign barbarians, saying:
"They have given the bodies of the righteous
among us
as food to the birds,"⁵¹ that is, to the demons
of the air?

How can I claim that the alliance of my
will with evil
can be holy, when it is "like the seed of the
word
fallen by the wayside"?⁵²

How can I name those holy who pursue
the hostile path
of wickedness, namely the rebellious conflicts
of my
camouflaged mind, in collaboration with the
devices of
the Slanderer?

And for these reasons I cannot pray, "God, be
not silent,
do not hold your peace," or "They have plotted
against
your holy people and said . . ."?⁵³

For it is quite proper that through these
words
we recognize the virulence of demons and
their cohorts,
causing trouble at every turn.

2

⁵⁰Ex. 4:2-5.

⁵¹Ps. 79 (Arm 78):2.

⁵²Mt. 13:4.

⁵³Ps. 83 (Arm 82):1-3 (pursuant to the Armenian ver-
sion).

Protect us, Lord Christ, exalted son of great
God.

Fortify and surround us with your heavenly
host,
defend us from the gusting winds of the De-
ceiver
with your cross of light.

For although any number of offenses may be
found

in me, blasphemy is not among them.

For you were not gratified by
the destruction of the impious likes of me.

Rather with melancholy tenderness,
you are doubly aggrieved by the destruction
of the iniquitous in the flood,
considering their death intolerable and repug-
nant,

and saying in your heart the amazing words:

"I shall never again curse the earth because of
the

deeds of man."⁵⁴

And you are greatly consoled and rejoice in
the deliverance of unclean men worthy of de-
struction,

as in the parable of the plant that shaded
Jonah,⁵⁵

where you spared those deserving of destruc-
tion, O merciful Lord.

And in another instance how greatly were you
annoyed⁵⁶

by the delay of the rain which would salvage
those who denied you.

And in your last days you did great deeds
beyond telling, worthy of celebration,
commanding your disciples to spread your
sweet

gospel of peace to the Gentiles and all peoples
far and wide.⁵⁷

Sprinkle upon me the dew of your compassion-
ate

fatherly love, living God, so I too may find sal-
vation

⁵⁴Gen. 8:21.

⁵⁵Jon 4:6-8 (the castor oil plant, in Armenian – a
pumpkin vine).

⁵⁶1 Kg. 17:1, 18:1 (delay of the rain on account of
Elijah).

⁵⁷Mt. 28:19-20.



through the pardoning of my sins by your abundant mercy.

And to you, with the Father through the Holy Spirit,
glory forever.
Amen.

Prayer 61 (ԿԱ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

To what end should I recite the Psalms,
to what purpose sing them daily
with the harp of my voice when
in unison they condemn and curse me?

How can I adopt the persona of
the happy Psalmist, to say with him,
when I am doomed, “let perverseness
be far removed from my heart”? ¹

How disconcerting are the many virtues
ascribed to kings, militant prophets
and commanders of the Old Law,
described in terms befitting the angels?

How can I recite them without
despondence at my life,
I the preacher of the good news,
I disciple of the New Covenant,
when I am devoid of those virtues?

How can I, in the manner of the righteous,
“Be armed to destroy the wicked at dawn,” ²
and always be ready and vigilant ³ as told in
the parable,
when I have not tamed and disciplined my own
body?

How can I emulate the great valor of David

and cleanse the Lord’s city of the unrighteous,
when I have not uprooted the shortcomings
from
my own soul?

How can I lie to one who writes what has
not yet been
revealed, saying “I have eaten ashes like
bread”? ⁴
How can I who have not mixed one tainted
drop
of my remorse with the pure springs of the
Psalmist’s eyes, say with him, “I have mingled
my drink
with tears” ⁵ and “I have drenched my bed
with tears”? ⁶

How can I confess my mortal sins,
when he who loved God with all his heart,
assumed the sins of his forefathers as his own,
saying, “We have sinned with our fathers
and have done wickedly,” ⁷
while all that follows is more rightly written
for me than for Israel.

How can I be counted among the good,
when I have not used those remedies
considered effective by human lights—
fasting to the point of death,
and frequent mortification of the flesh until the
body is spent—as practiced even by the Jews
and the
pagans according to their religions?

Why then should “my righteousness en-
dure forever,” ⁸
when I have done nothing to attain it?

Բ

But so that I do not become tedious and
long-winded,
let me compress my words,
words I say echoing the blessed David

¹Ps. 101 (Arm 100):4.

²Ps. 101 (Arm 100):8.

³Mt. 25:1-13 (Parable of the Oil-bearing women),
also possibly a reference to St. Gregory’s name, since
Gregorios means ‘vigilant’ in Greek.

⁴Ps. 102 (Arm 101):9.

⁵Ps. 102 (Arm 101):9.

⁶Ps. 6:7.

⁷Ps. 106 (Arm 105):6.

⁸Ps. 112 (Arm 111):9.



in his inspired voice, “I seek you with all my heart.”⁹

How shall I say with him something greater than this,
“I hold back my feet from every evil way”?¹⁰

How shall I add this to what has already been said, “I
have laid up your word in my heart so that I might not
sin against you”?¹¹

How shall I express my emptiness as if it were fullness
along with the saints, saying, “Through your precepts I
get understanding; therefore I hate every false way”?¹²

How shall I place my lies beside the true vows
of the meek, pledging fidelity, saying, “I have sworn
to observe your righteous ordinances”?¹³

How can I repeat the verdict of the angel of death,
“Salvation is far from the wicked”?¹⁴

How shall I, who am truly wicked, put myself
among the good, who receive their just reward from the
Lord, repeating, “Do good, O Lord, to those who are
upright in their hearts”?¹⁵

How shall I, who have strayed, sentence myself justly,
“But those who go off on their crooked ways,

the Lord will lead away with evildoers”?¹⁶

How shall I so ashamed, cloak myself in pious dignity,
saying, “O Lord, my heart is not lifted up, my eyes are not raised too high,”¹⁶
and the verses that follow?

And how shall I, who has laid up my treasure in hell,
take words beyond human understanding as a sign of encouragement to the weary,
and say with the anointed of God,

“Even before a word was on my tongue you knew,
O Lord, there was no cunning in it,”¹⁷
and the rest of this psalm from its first letter to the last?

How shall I, who conspire with miscreants,
a condemned man and depraved son, call out,
“Do I not hate them that hate you, Lord,”¹⁸
and the verses that follow?

How shall you, my soul, the most pitiful in the world,
with the confidences of that sublime soul, offer your spirit without condemnation
and presume to boast with him who has earned his halo, saying, “Test me, Lord, and see if
there is any iniquity upon my hands,”¹⁹ and all that follows?

How shall I, being what I am, pray to be
delivered from evil and join my voice with those who
hope in God, saying, “Guard me, Lord, from the hands

⁹Ps. 119 (Arm 118):10.

¹⁰Ps. 119 (Arm 118):101.

¹¹Ps. 119 (Arm 118):11.

¹²Ps. 119 (Arm 118):104.

¹³Ps. 119 (Arm 118):106.

¹⁴Ps. 119 (Arm 118):155.

¹⁵Ps. 125 (Arm 124):4-5.

¹⁶Ps. 131 (Arm 130):1.

¹⁷Ps. 139 (Arm 138):4 (pursuant to the Armenian version).

¹⁸Ps. 139 (Arm 138):21.

¹⁹Ps. 139 (Arm 138):23-24 (pursuant to the Armenian version).



of the wicked and preserve me from violent men"? ²⁰

How shall I arise to pray with worthy David saying,
"You are my refuge and my portion in the land of the living"? ²¹

How shall I pray as if I had been in combat with evil,
to offer the prize of victory to God the king,
repeating these unreasonable expectations,
"The righteous will surround me;
for you will deal bountifully with me"? ²²



How blessed is the spiritual message of the Psalmist,
which recalls our Lord's own act of rebuffing his tempter,
despising all others and preferring only the first cause of
all creation, saying, "Happy the people whose God is the Lord!" ²³
How sublime the exaltation of grace
expressed with prudent forthrightness, inspired by
heavenly goodness, "Your saints shall bless you!" ²⁴

How great the desire for the intimate kinship
of spiritual communion
to hope in God and built upon him
in the joyous words of the psalm,
"The Lord fulfills the desire of all who fear him,"
from which the Psalmist concludes:
"The Lord preserves all who love him,
but the wicked he will destroy." ²⁵

²⁰Ps. 140 (Arm 139):4.

²¹Ps. 142 (Arm 141):6.

²²Ps. 142 (Arm 141):7.

²³Ps. 144 (Arm 143):15.

²⁴Ps. 145 (Arm 144):10.

²⁵Ps. 145 (Arm 144):19-20.

Thus, in the last chapters of songs of praise,
the Psalmist puts the just and unjust
on notice of their fates, repeating
the themes that grow out of and resonate with
each other:

"The Lord lifts up the downtrodden,
he casts the haughty to the ground." ²⁶

What calamity, then, awaits me
if, "the Lord takes pleasure in his holy people,
and adorns the humble with victory." ²⁷
Where shall I stand?

And if "God is blessed among the saints
as Lord,"
where do I fit, a stranger to saintliness?
And if next to those other warnings
I set the reminder,
"Love the Lord, all you his saints!
The Lord preserves the faithful,
but punishes the haughty." ²⁸
In what camp do I find myself,
captivated by the clever inventor of evil?



For like the leaves of the cedar tree
waving in the tempest, which stream down
in the battering winds,
so too the evil spirit tries to break
the fruitful branches of my life's upward
striving,
shaped by your nurturing hand, O uncreated
God.

Restore these broken branches and
let them take root in the field of life
under the care of your good will,
with a new fruitful innocence.
O Christ King, who
bestows all good gifts,
blessed forever.
Amen.

²⁶Ps. 147 (Arm 146):6 (pursuant to the Armenian).

²⁷Ps. 149:4 (pursuant to the text).

²⁸Ps. 31 (Arm 30):23 (pursuant to the Armenian).



Prayer 62 (ԿԲ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Now, why should I not add to the Psalms I have quoted
passages from the Prophets?
But what pleasure is there from nourishment
if my sense of taste is numbed by pain as I eat?
And what advantage can I derive from the Psalms
if I cannot take them to heart?
For I curse myself with them, but I do not know it.
I am cleansed, but I do not glisten.
The sun dawns, but I am not enlightened.
I eat honey but am not sweetened.
I am filled with balm but am not cured.
I rise early for prayers each day and return empty handed.
I am mocked endlessly but never learn.
I am warned but do not come to my senses.

Բ

Truly, my sin and lawlessness dwell in me
and I am worn away by them,
as the Prophet said of the transgressors,¹
and the Lord taught in the parable
of the new wine in old casks.²
For as Isaiah foretold,
“Rebels and sinners shall be destroyed together.”³
And the same is in store for me, wretch that I am,
for I recite the psalm, “The Lord abundantly requites
those who act haughtily,”⁴
to which I link the prophecy,
“The Lord has a day against all who are proud
and haughty,”⁵ when I recite,

¹Is. 59:12.

²Mt. 9:17.

³Is. 1:28.

⁴Ps. 31 (Arm 30): 23.

⁵Is. 2:12.

“The wicked go astray from the womb . . .”⁶
and I add, “Let the wicked of the earth be destroyed”
and “the haughty be wiped from the earth”⁷
and “the unjust shall be uprooted from the earth.”⁸

Գ

Weep for me when you read,
“As the tongue of fire devours the dry grass,
so shall sinners be consumed in the furious flames.”⁹
Weep for me also at the psalm, saying,
“Let burning coals fall upon them.”¹⁰
And pray I might be pardoned from divine judgment,
foretold by the Prophet, “If you refuse to heed me,
you shall be devoured by the sword.”¹¹

Weep at this psalm:
“Death shall be their shepherd.”¹²
Prepare salty tears mixed with the sighs of my heart,
when the Lord on high says to me, along
with Israel, “My people did not listen to me.”¹³

Sigh “alas!” for me, when another Prophet says the same:
“Woe to them, for they have strayed from me!”¹⁴

Trumpet the words of the heart, heavy before crying,
when God who sees all puts me to shame,
reprimanding me with the insolent house of Jacob,
“Look, you, wicked nations, and see; wonder and

⁶Ps. 58 (Arm 57):3.

⁷Is. 16:10, Ps. 104 (Arm 103):35.

⁸Pr. 2:22.

⁹Is. 5:24.

¹⁰Ps. 140 (Arm 139): 10.

¹¹Is. 1:20.

¹²Ps. 49 (Arm 48): 15.

¹³Ps. 81 (Arm 80): 11.

¹⁴Hos. 7:13.

be astounded.”¹⁵

✠

O great God, reconsider and withhold the terrible sword of your righteous anger, menacingly raised over me.
I am fear-stricken before you as you extend the bounteous care of your right hand over me.
Bestow the anointing oil of life upon your supplicant. And glory to you in heaven on high, and from mortals on earth below, throughout all the nations and reaches of the earth, forever,
Amen.

Prayer 63 (ԿԳ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

One and only king, compassionate, long-suffering,
doer of good who loves mankind,
honored with your Father and praised as the Lord of all,
Son of the living God,¹ never the cause of my destruction,²
who is not tempted by evil,³
who does not seek the death of a sinner,⁴
who offers salvation by your will,
who turns the storm of sin into the breeze of pardon,⁵
and transforms the fire of anger into rain,⁶

who turned the woman that looked back from

¹⁵Hab. 1:20.

¹Mt. 16:16.

²Lk. 9:56.

³Jas. 1:13.

⁴Ezek. 18:32, 33:11.

⁵1 Kg. 19:11-12.

⁶Dan. 3:17-26 (Arm version 3:50).

your goodness,⁷ into a single statue with two natures,⁸
placing her neither with the just nor unjust,

who transformed the liquidity of the sea, into a wall of stone,⁹

who caused a stream to spring and flow like a waterfall from the hard rocks of the desert,¹⁰

who stopped the rushing waters of the Jordan into a pool for cleansing the pagans¹¹ and fortified the walls of Jericho symbolizing the destruction of Satan's tyranny, demolished by you as if it were straw,¹²

who sweetened the poisonous waters with miraculous salts, as a metaphor for the conversion of evil to good, that is, the salvation of the Canaanites,¹³

who turned the bitter waters of Marah, the symbol of disbelief, into drinkable water with the staff of life that you shouldered,¹⁴

who took colorless water from the river and made it red as blood,

who transformed the rod into a serpent to prefigure your taking of our nature and to show how Gentiles might join the elect,

who with the blessed right hand of Moses foretold both your incarnation,
O Lord on high, and through your grace, the cleansing of my corrupt body

⁷Gen. 19:17, 26.

⁸Rocksalt is neither salt, like the just (Lot and his daughters), nor rock, like the unjust (Sodom and Gomorrah)

⁹Ex. 14:21-22.

¹⁰Ex. 17:6.

¹¹Jos. 3:15-16.

¹²Jos. 6:20.

¹³2 Kg. 2:21.

¹⁴Ex 15:23-25.



through an immutable transformation,¹⁵

by these great signs, you have foretold
the rescue of long lost sinners
by the caring art of your love,
blessed and compassionate Lord.

ⲡ

Almighty Lord, you who make the lifeless
seed sprout green from the earth,¹⁶
who make the roots of the immobile tree move,
who call those born of the unexalted womb,
in your image,
who give children teeth to chew,
who make the beard grow,
who turn the black foliage of hair into snow,¹⁷
showing that you reign over all.

You who transform the natural movements of
the lips,
in the words of Job, into meaningful expres-
sions,¹⁸
who shake the earth and its pillars from
their foundations,¹⁹ showing that through all
creation,
only you are indestructible.

You who vary the elements in their pass-
ing states
and combine them in stable compounds,
showing that for the multitude of sins
you are likewise able to remember and forgive.

You train the inanimate dawning sun as if
in a bridle,
showing you can, if you wish, tame
the evil impulses of nature.

And you regulate the speechless globe of
the moon
so that it is empty or full,
providing illuminating hope to on-lookers
that you are able to restore a sinful body

¹⁵Ex. 4:2-9.

¹⁶Ps. 104 (Arm 103):14, Jn. 12:24.

¹⁷Mt. 5:36.

¹⁸Job 12:20.

¹⁹Job 9:6.

depleted of goodness
to its original state of innocent fullness.

You who gather and scatter the speech-
less constellations,
like a flock of sheep, symbolic of the hope
of life that you, Lord, with your sweet provi-
dence
dispense in your abundant mercy
even to the slow of tongue who do not petition
you.

ⲧ

You who chart the safe path on the sea²⁰
between death and life, testifying that even
in that perilous place we are protected through
you.

You who, when the water is boiling in
the cauldron
like a furious storm of sin, calm it with the
word
of your will.

You, whose mere glance toward the earth
causes tremors,²¹ rouse the animals to alert
the thinking beings.

You who shake the limitless density of
the land
like a small sailboat tossing on the waves,
by which you put all creatures on notice
that you are decisively in control,
holding the whole world in your hand.

You who sow dead bodies in the earth,
keep them whole and bring them to life again,
receiving the perishable create the eternal,
who join the spark of life with mortal matter,
who with but an utterance created the entire
universe
in an instant and adorned its barrenness in
every way.²²

Yours is the strength and the power,
that varies the seasons of the year,

²⁰Wis. 14:3.

²¹Ps. 104 (Arm 103):32.

²²Gen. 1:2, Ps. 148:5.



each with its fitting splendor.

You who command the unspeaking things
as if
they were alive,²³
you who by merely giving the signal set them
into motion,²⁴
you alone weave the daylight and darkness
with your creative art that is beyond telling.²⁵
You who after the first order of creation
still performed miracles to the amazement
of blessed Job.
You fashioned yet more permanent creations,
and during your incarnation performed other
celebrated acts without number.

✠

You who took our transgressions upon your-
self,²⁶
you who graced us with your righteousness,²⁷
you who offered yourself as the ransom of
our reconciliation,²⁸
you who never abandoned mercy,²⁹
turn the impious toward good, God-fearing
works,
the stupefied toward the sobriety of a vigilant
heart,
the impure toward the holiness of shining char-
acter,
the sinners toward the purity of the tranquil
saintly nature,
the broken toward wholeness impervious to ac-
cidents,
the weeping toward the joy of unclouded
bliss,³⁰
the hopeless toward the love of union,
the embarrassed toward firmness,
the people who live in darkness toward the light
of
endless joy,³¹

²³Ps. 147 (Arm 146-147):5.

²⁴Bar. 4:33-35.

²⁵Am. 4:13.

²⁶Is. 53:4-5, Jn. 1:29.

²⁷Rom. 5:17-21.

²⁸Jn. 19:17.

²⁹Ps. 103 (Arm 102):8.

³⁰Mt. 5:5.

³¹Lk. 1:79.

the captives of death toward life incorruptible.
For your name is glorified, Lord Jesus,
professed in all ways with the Father and the
Holy Spirit,
in heaven on high and on earth below
among all the inhabitants therein,
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 64 (ԿԴ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

In everything and toward everything you are
upright,
O God.
You judge justly and weigh fairly.
You measure truly and dispense blessings.
You act with goodness and uphold steadfast-
ness.
You seek clarity and embrace enlightenment.
You admonish with experience and examine
with forbearance.
You are without guile and arrogance,
but in all things show gentleness, tranquility
and compassion.

Բ

You showed your justice, heavenly wisdom of
the Father's unchanging genius,
which those adopted by grace confirm through
the witness of their unstinting praise.
As told in the holy sayings of the Gospel,
"They wailed, but I did not mourn,
they played their flutes, but I did not dance."¹

You advised me in my lawlessness, "Do
not
break the law," but I persisted in errant ways.

To me a sinner, you said, "Do not lift
your horn,"²

¹Mt. 11:16-19.

²Ps. 75 (Arm 74):4-5 (pursuant to the Armenian ver-
sion of the Psalms).



but I opposed you. Oblivious and wayward,
I never noticed that you lift and lower the
royal trumpets, as told by Habakkuk,³
David⁴ and Zechariah.⁵
You wanted blessings for me, merciful Lord,
but I lean toward the damnation I deserved.
I preferred anger to calm,
groping in darkness without light,
as the Scripture says,⁶
I answered your compassionate voice with
impudence.

Through Isaiah you said, “Even the worm
is immortal,
the fire unquenchable,”⁷ the condemnation
unending,
the place eternal, the image terrifying.
As in the words of the Psalmist, I neither
heeded
nor understood, but walked in the darkness of
intellectual blindness.⁸



Through prophecy you revealed, “he who
upholds
the law shall be blessed,”⁹
while I was quick to cut corners.
Lord Jesus, you raised David with his writing,
as a spiritual monument, a rock inscribed by
you,
while he, one of the elect, said,
“I shall keep your law at all times,”¹⁰
and repeated, “forever and ever” for good
measure.
But I, despite these words of warning and
encouragement, was unmoved.
I rushed to worship Baal instead of God,
as Elijah said in his satirical admonition,¹¹
I stumbled along the path of doubt,

³Hab. 3:4 (pursuant to the Armenian version).

⁴Ps. 75 (Arm 74):11.

⁵Zech. 1:21.

⁶Job 12:25.

⁷Is. 66:24.

⁸Ps. 82 (Arm 81):5.

⁹Ps. 84 (Arm 83):8 (pursuant to the Armenian).

¹⁰Ps. 119 (Arm 118):44 (the Armenian version, says
“kept the law”).

¹¹1 Kg. 18:21.

being of two inclinations, then
I abandoned the right.
I have the example of Moses with his laws
returning from the dead and I have the
letters of the prophets, written on the tablet of
my heart
and the books of the apostles as bindings on
my fingers.¹²

And you, Lord of all, through your good
news,
you raised countless dead from the grave,¹³
still I remained on the blacksmith’s anvil,
inert, with a heart of stone,¹⁴
more disbelieving than the five brothers of¹⁵
that rich man, who in that apt parable,
were as numb with gluttony as Belial,
yet I was unrepentant.¹⁶



But grant your mercy nevertheless upon
my forsaken self, good king, who inspires awe,
loves humanity and cares for his people,
living and holy Lord who always
enlightens us by the power of the mystery of
your exalted cross.
In my barren fields, hardened by sin,
filled with folly, with fruitless heart,
I am still sustained by your compassion,
Almighty.
My soul shall be refreshed with springs of wa-
ter
and my sore eyes quenched with streams of
tears,
offered for purification and salvation and re-
leased
by your acceptance, all-giving Lord, who is
glorified forever.
Amen.

¹²Pr. 7:3.

¹³Mt. 27:52.

¹⁴Mk. 8:17, 10:5, 16:14.

¹⁵Lk. 16:28-30.

¹⁶Satan, the rebellious angel; 2 Cor. 6:15.



Prayer 65 (ԿԵ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Now, I foremost among the impious and
chief among sinners, the leader among the
unjust,
the first among debtors, the epitome of a
criminal,
the Attica of vice, not of virtue,
have dared to say what is unspeakable:
I have boasted of my humiliation,
I have exposed my secrets,
disclosed what I have covered up,
shown what I have hidden,
spread what I have stored up,
splattered the gall of my bitterness,
divulged my collaboration with the evil one,
squeezed my pus-filled wound,
acknowledged the abyss of my sins,
put on the mask of hypocrisy,
lifted the veil from ugliness,
stripped away the clothes from shamefulness,
laid open my baseness,
thrown up the dregs of death,
revealed the abscessed wounds of my soul to
you, Christ high priest.

Not sparing my soul from peril,
not conceding to the love of my body,
I examined down to the oldest roots.
Showing no leniency for the human condition,
cutting my tie with the brotherhood,
destroying the castle of my heart,
I struggled with the stalking of my desires, as if
ambushed by death, laying open the storehouse
of secrets,
setting forth before great God this hoarded
treasure,
appearing before the judge as a prosecutor,
foreseeing the ominous things to come,
breaking my pact with the Devil,
I recanted my vows to the Deceiver.
I took refuge in you, Lord Jesus, for a victori-
ous end to

this battle, marshalling the troops for war,
placing my hope in the word of God to fend
off attacks,
I delivered the forces of darkness to those
armed with light.

Բ

And now, Christ, maker of all creation,
Son of God on high,
I have been blamed with these words,
and struck with these blows,
please do not reproach me again at the Last
Judgment,
you, who are our immortal, almighty king,
who does good in ways we cannot understand
or express.
Do not reproach me with my self-abasement
and
self-accusatory humiliation,
by which I of my own volition condemned
myself relentlessly,
and through this book of psalms confront the
face of Satan with his shame,
and strengthen the stamp of your cross upon
my face, wretch that I am.

Let the glow of your seal add luster to
my countenance,
the sign of your steadfastness be stamped upon
my face,
the shape of your cross be fixed upon my
cheeks,
the glory of your miraculous work be marked
upon my forehead,
the luster of your seal not be taken from me,
the radiance of your blessing not fade from the
sight of my eyes,
the token of your assurance not be removed
from my head,
the glory of your scripture not waver upon the
firm threshold of my mouth,
your praiseworthy armor shield the sentiments
of my heart,
your four-winged radiance spread through the
four
elements of my being,
the power of your cross of salvation come to
the aid of my outstretched hand, and



may the sanctity of your valor realize the
goodness
of the offering for which my hands were made.

¶

When I depart this life, may holiness not
abandon me.
When I am wrapped in shrouds may your
honor
not leave me.
May my soul not reject your unwavering
salvation.
May your image engraved upon my soul, Giver
of life, not be effaced.
May the mark of your blood not be erased
from my soul's altar bearing your seal.
May it dwell with me in my grave.
When my miserable body is worn out may your
anointing grace stay with me,
that I might on the day of renewal meet you,
groom of glory,
that I may be known as one of yours,
that I may be clothed with your accomplish-
ments,
that I may be honored by the assurances of
your greatness,
that I may be adorned with the robe of your
baptism and pardoned with mercy.

Give me, O compassionate Lord, your
cloak
of incorruptibility,
you who suffer with the sins of my body.
Do not let the Blasphemer gain control over
your people.
May the one who wears out my soul waste
away.
May the tricks of those who live on the dark
side not haunt me.
May the abyss of my final rest be blessed in
your name, O merciful Lord.
May the cell of my captivity be filled with your
mercy.
May the place of my torture be broken open
through you.
May tranquility reign, my keeper, in my prison
of terror.

May that dark womb nourish me toward
resurrection.

May your hope preserve me that chamber of
anxiety.

May your hand protect me upon the cot of my
torment.

May your wings shield me in the house of
anguish.

Stay with me, Lord most praised, in my room
of peril.

A thousand woes upon me,
for once I was angelic, but now I am in the
abyss,
once I was celebrated, but now I am pitiful.

¶

Now again, you who are blessed by all cre-
ation,
by the heavenly and the earthly,
and by the denizens of Hades,
you who were banished for me for no reason,
for it was I who strayed and was estranged,
I who was stupid, lost, and found worthless.
I was abandoned, extinguished and destroyed.
I erred, I was caught, I was rejected.
I was alienated, enslaved, and degraded.
I was cursed, I became wretched, drunken and
wasted.
I was swallowed up, I was deceived, I rebelled.
I was corrupted, died and destroyed com-
pletely.
You had no hand in this evil,
for you are only unchanging good.

¶

Now, when your will is upon me, darkness be-
comes
light for me.

When your lamp of hope is there, night is like
the dawn.

When your body is taken during communion, I
live down my shame.

But I do not consider my soul living,
for death is inevitable.

Nor do I consider it dead,
for renewal is not doubted.

And though I see the path to life closed before
me



because of my unpardonable sins
 still paradise is open before me
 because of the good news of salvation.
 For the discouragement of bad news makes me
 less anxious than the encouragement of your
 hand
 extending salvation.
 Therefore, grant mercy, O Lord,
 for all those who raise voices in thanks,
 Lord blessed forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 66 (ԿԶ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Now, whoever believes in the healing prayers
 in this humble book, praying sincerely
 even if he be one of the sinful,
 I too join him with my words.
 For if he is among the just,
 may we find mercy together through these
 prayers.
 And if he finds happiness,
 leaving misery to me alone,
 I shall nevertheless bear witness for him.
 But may he remember Solomon and his
 inspired words:
 “Who can say, I have a pure heart,
 or boast of being clean of sin?”¹
 For no man born on earth is free of sin.²
 And not one of us is special because of our
 swiftness,³
 not even if wings carry us to the heights.
 Therefore, we should be careful, think twice,
 for if we are on a pedestal, as Paul taught,
 we may fall to the ground,⁴
 like the just judge who formulated this rule.⁵

¹Pr. 20:9, Job 4:14.

²1 Kg. 8:46.

³Ec. 9:11.

⁴Ps. 40 (Arm 39):2, 1 Cor. 10:12.

⁵The reference is to Solomon, who though just,
 sinned greatly.

But let the righteous take this warning as
 a crown,
 so as not to fall from the unreachable heights.
 And may the condemned see this as hope of
 salvation.
 by which to rise from the perdition of spiritual
 death,
 and live in hope.
 As for me may this message be like words
 engraved on a monument never to be effaced
 a token of my wretched mortal soul
 crying out forever, unsilenced,
 with the echoes of uninterrupted sighing.

May my bones, undone
 in the earthen cloak of the tomb,
 confess this with a soundless voice,
 and my body turned to dust
 deliver these prayers to you
 with an indiscernible cry, seer of secrets.

Բ

Lord of compassion, fount of mercies,
 bounty of goodness,
 Son of the one on high, Lord Jesus Christ,
 have mercy, save us, and love us humans.
 Look upon my peril. Gaze upon my broken
 heart.
 Attend to my misery.
 See the confusion of my unending anxiety.
 Come to my aid in my time of mortal torment.
 Touch me, curing my most wretched infirmi-
 ties.
 Lend a kind ear to my pitiful sighs.
 Listen to the silent cries from the depths of
 the abysmal grave.
 May the voice of my failing body in prayer
 reach your all-hearing ears
 and since the pledge for my life's redemption
 is imperishable,
 so too let your love be also constant.
 Gently help me, enfeebled with infirmity as I
 am.

Գ

Do not hold a grudge against me, the image of
 death.
 Do not berate my breathless figure.



Do not strike me while I am suffering the pangs of death.⁶
 Do not deal harshly with the cracked clay vessel
 of my existence.⁷
 Do not double your wrath: I am crushed by your sentence.
 Do not condemn to destruction my already dilapidated structure.
 Do not throw stones at me: I am already like a dead dog.
 Do not fulminate at me sternly: I am like a crushed flea.⁸
 Do not roar at me mightily, as if upon some braggart:
 I am lower than dirt.⁹
 Do not summon me for trial by ordeal:
 I am but cast away ash.
 Do not view me, who am but vanishing dust, as your opponent.
 Do not deem me, who am loathsome sediment, to be your foe.
 Do not ward me off, a contemptible abomination,
 as if I am a warrior.
 Do not set me aside as material for hell:
 I am worthless refuse.
 Do not scold me again, who by this multitude of words already
 has been admonished many times over.



So these are the fruits of my broken and contrite heart
 offered in prayer from my wretched tomb shrouded
 in darkness.
 Establish your blessed word in me indelibly¹⁰
 according to the yearnings of my heart.
 For although I speak among the living,
 I am dead to you, who are beyond reach,
 yet on the day I succumb to death's destruction,

⁶1 Sam. 31:8-9.

⁷Is. 30:14.

⁸1 Sam. 24:14.

⁹Sir. 10:9.

¹⁰Jn. 11:25.

may I be saved through my faith in your all-powerful orders.

Now, I pray you, Lord Jesus Christ,
 look upon me with compassion
 and do not let me be the cohort of Satan.
 At the time of my pitiful burial, in the lifeless sepulchre,
 echoing with death, attend to the voice of my sighing
 heart lifted in reconciliation,
 Lord, our sole benefactor, who cherishes our spirits,
 almighty God, who loves mankind.
 May your kind Spirit dwell with me,
 shedding light upon me in the darkness.¹¹
 May the venerated, life-giving relics of your passion
 stay with me,
 like a treasure deposited with you,
 so they may bestow the gift of renewed life.
 With these inexhaustible weapons I am equipped
 as stones of a slingshot made of the spirit,
 to ward off the legions of evil.
 With you on my side Lord,
 the battle waged against me shall be checked,
 when enemies rise up and attack me,
 thinking that the citadel has no troops,
 and the alarms make no sounds.
 But I have you, Lord, as my eternal keeper
 who slumbers not, nor sleeps.¹²



For even now, if the evil one in anticipation of the
 Day of Judgment
 rushes to prepare a prison without escape for me,¹³
 I will deliver the Lord's prayer like a death-blow.
 If he tries to deter me as I kneel before my creator,¹⁴
 if he tries to bow my face to the dust,

¹¹Ps. 18:28.

¹²Ps. 121 (Arm 120):4.

¹³Rev. 2:10.

¹⁴Lk. 22:41.



may my bowing down to God turn him back.¹⁵
 If he tries to torment me with pain,
 may the abundant sweat mixed with the blood
 of our Savior of the world frustrate him.¹⁶
 And if he takes my breath hostage
 so I cannot travel the path to goodness,
 may the bindings of the creator of the universe
 free me.¹⁷
 If he forces me to renounce the gifts of the
 light,
 may your patience in the face of mockery by
 the enemies of God,
 silence them, just as you did.¹⁸
 If he should barrage me with secret arrows,
 may the arrowheads from the Father's glorious
 quiver befall him.¹⁹
 If the veil of darkness should make my eye
 shameless,
 may the blow to his blindfolded head²⁰
 by the creator knock him down.
 If he ventures to bind up my firm hands,²¹
 may the reed offered by the right hand of the
 creator silence him.
 If with jeering mockery he toys with me,
 may the Almighty's fortitude in the face of
 ridicule
 mock him back.²²
 If he conjures a spell upon me,
 may he be foiled by the Almighty's slap to his
 face.²³
 If at twilight he attacks shamelessly under
 cover of darkness,
 may he be confounded by the radiance of the
 light of your revelation, Lord.
 If in the heat of noonday he thinks he can dry
 my roots
 with scorching blasts of the sun's furnace,
 may he be uprooted and dried by the power of
 your sign of light.
 If he plots to deprive me of the grace of your

breath,
 may he be humiliated by the spit, which the
 Lord of the cherubim endured for me, a sinner.

9

If he dares show his biting teeth,
 may the silence of the mouth of our heavenly
 Lord shut it.²⁴
 If he causes desires to gnaw at my soul,
 may the nails that pierced the creator hurt him.
 If he tries to lead me astray along the path of
 unjust thoughts,
 may the nails in the feet of our Lord, beyond
 understanding, hold him fast.²⁵
 If he tries to make me drink a vile potion,
 may the vinegar mixed with bile that was given
 our Savior to drink, embitter him.
 If he lures me into eating from the first wood,
 the tree of the forbidden fruit,²⁶
 may the terrible spectacle of the second wood
 seize and completely vanquish him.
 If he tries to teach me to rebel against
 God's commandments,
 may the nod of the infinite Godhead destroy
 him.
 If he tries to kill me by wounding and persecut-
 ing me,
 may the lance that pierced the side of the cre-
 ator of Adam cut him down.²⁷
 If he envelops me in the pangs of hellish pain,
 may the burial shrouds of the Lord who holds
 all
 creation, wrap him up.
 If he tricks me into gazing into the abyss of
 death,
 may the living God who survived the stone
 tomb kill him.
 If he takes joy in my mortal errors,
 may he, with his crooked will, die again,
 when the immortal God, resurrected in glory,
 renews all mortals.
 If he is cheered by the prospect of release
 from these small bindings after a thousand
 years,

¹⁵Mt. 26:39.

¹⁶Lk. 22:44.

¹⁷Jn. 18:22.

¹⁸Mk. 15:29-32.

¹⁹Is. 49:2.

²⁰Lk. 22:64.

²¹Mk. 15:16-20.

²²Mt. 27:29.

²³Jn. 18:22.

²⁴Mat. 26:63, 27:12, Lk. 23:9.

²⁵Jn. 20:27

²⁶Gen. 3:6.

²⁷Jn. 19:34.



may he tremble again for the later chains that will
bind him forever
in the place of unrelenting torment without end.²⁸
If the first blow is bad news for him,
wait till he finds out about the inextinguishable
fires of hell that await him and
his angels at the Last Judgment.

Է

And for me, who has sought refuge in you,
Lord Jesus,
our only king, absolute and mighty,
creator of heaven and earth
and every beauty in it,
I await your coming with anticipation
and hope in the mercy of your cross.
I fall at your feet and kiss the traces of your
footsteps.
I confess my sin and publish my wrongdoing.
I beat myself up and entomb my heart in sighs.
I am wounded by pangs of conscience and
smolder with fiery breath.
I burn with the salty dew of tears and my in-
sides are on fire with grief.
I am parched by winds of despair and suffo-
cated by the foul fumes.
I am weak with words of grief and shaking with
wretched cries.
I suffer with sorrowful afflictions and my soul
shakes in alarm.
I am tossed on the waves of the storm and jolted
by the crashing of the waves.
I shudder at the news and am devastated by the
memory of terror.
I melt at the sight of the tribunal and am morti-
fied by your threats, great Lord.
Hear me, compassionate Lord, who pardons us,
who loves mankind,
who is patient with us, sweet beyond words,
good day, dawn of our longing,
for you are capable of all things
and when I give up the spirit, you will be my
great salvation.
To you with the Father and the Holy Spirit,

²⁸Rev. 20:3-10.

glory forever.
Amen.

Prayer 67 (ԿԷ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

But since your judgment, Christ God,
is much more lenient toward me
than toward Satan the forefather of evil,¹
and because of him, “the Son of God was
revealed among us that he might destroy the
works
of the devil,”²
whereas for me, he came to restore my
worn-out image,³
taking our image in its essence,
he united in himself the image of great God
in indisputable unity.
He graced Satan with none of this bounty,
and upon me he poured forth everything
in abundance.⁴
He did not suffer on the cross for Satan,
but for me he is continuously sacrificed.
Satan does not partake in life,
but I am eternally favored with salvation.
Satan is not protected by the cross,
but I am fortified by this sign.
He is banished from the light,
but I am joined with glory.
God did not promise him peace even on earth,⁵
but he made me an owner of heaven.⁶
God cut off his guarantee of hope,
but continued mine forever.⁷
God confined him to a herd of pigs,⁸
but in me God dwells more firmly.⁹

¹Lk. 12:48.

²1 Jn. 3:8.

³Phil. 3:21.

⁴Jl. 2:28.

⁵Mt. 8:29

⁶1 Cor. 2:9.

⁷2 Cor. 1:21-22.

⁸Mt. 8:31-32.

⁹Jn. 17:23.



God compared him to a scorpion,¹⁰
and he called me the light of the world.¹¹
God made him resemble a snake,¹²
but he placed the seal of his name upon me.¹³

ⲡ

But I abandoned the favors of God,
who created so many good things, and I
gave in to my inclination toward evil,
gazing downward with him at the bottom of
the abyss:

Look at me,
I am
unworthy of good, undeserving of favor,
incapable of love, drawn in by the strands of
sin,
wounded in the depth of my inner organs,
a broken palm tree,
spilled wine,
damp wheat,
breached mortgage,
ripped up verdict,
counterfeit seal,
deformed image,
singed garment,
lost goblet,
sunken ship,
crushed pearl,
buried gem,
dried up plant,
broken beam,
rotten wood,
mutilated mandrake,
collapsed roof,
dilapidated altar,
uprooted plant,
oily filth on the street,
milk flowing through ash,
a dead man in the battalion of the brave.

ⲓ

My pitiful soul, though you heard the warnings
from Jerusalem

¹⁰Lk. 10:19.

¹¹Mt. 5:14.

¹²Lk. 10:19.

¹³Mt. 28:19.

and were told parables about Babylon by the
prophet,
you did not listen, leaving me
ridiculous on the one hand,
and scandalized on the other;
here accused, there reprimanded;
here mocked, there insulted;
here scorned, there opposed;
here confused, there abandoned;
here weeping, there sobbing;
here doubt, there finality;
here grief, there chastisement;
here calamity, there the court of judgment.

Here I am,
with no right to speak, nor opportunity to plea,
where days are without number and time has
no end,
where there is no bridge of hope, nor door of
mercy,
no protecting right hand, nor helping hand
extended.

ⲓ

But you are refuge and you yourself are salva-
tion,
you are rescue and you are pardon,
you are bliss and through you is blessing and
mercy,
O Lord, who alone is mighty, living, and be-
yond words.
Lord Jesus Christ, God who does good, be
blessed, blessed and blessed again,
with your Holy Spirit exalted forever,
in the glory of your great Father's essence,
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 68 (ⲫⲗ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

ⲓ

And now, recalling the stern wrath described
above,
that awaits me from God,



how can I stop these new laments
and how can the flow of tears from my eyes be
dried?

Were I to take the rushing streams of the
four rivers¹
that water Eden and the rest of the earth to its
farthest reaches and direct them to the
springs of my eyes,
they would not cool the flames
of my soul's mortal sins.

Or were the prophet's wishes to come
true for me²
and my head were inundated with water
and upon my light of vision, fountains of tears
were to gush, still it would not suffice to
measure the
pain of my broken soul.

And were the tragic cries of a wailing
woman,
heart and soul pierced with pain, joined
together,
they would not suffice to incant the melody
or the harmony of the lament of my soul's
devastation.

¶

The day of my birth was cursed,
and not that of Job³ or Jeremiah,⁴
for their birthdays are to be celebrated and not
erased,
since the world is not worth even one of them.⁵

But looking at me, who does not deserve
the light
or any portion of goodness, they should curse
the day
I was born, I,
a destructive child, deadly neighbor, sower of
sin and satellite of iniquity.

¹Gen. 2:10.

²Jer. 9:1 (Arm. 8:23).

³Job 3:3.

⁴Jer. 20:14.

⁵Heb. 11:38.

I, who did not honor the covenant of life
that you established, God, doer of good,
and did not walk in the path of your life-giving
salvation.

I did not gather the harvest of grain,⁶
to store for my sustenance
when snowy days of trouble come.

I did not build firm walls
and did not put a roof on my house
to protect from the stormy gusts of air.

I did not lay aside a store of sacramental
wafers
for the endless journey to cure the turmoil of
my hunger.

I did not address you with prayers of supplica-
tion,
so that I might have the audacity to stand
before you.

I did not amass the reward of salvation
through
good works to assure the renewal of my soul.

¶

On my life's journey I did not settle accounts
with
my adversaries, so that I might here and now
escape
the stern hand of the judge.⁷
I did not approach with hands filled with bless-
ings and
in hope of exoneration with the lawgiver.⁸
I did not look forward,
nor did I protect my back,
nor was I armed to the right,
nor was I shielded from the left,
to be spared harm in the battle.
I did not dress my cavalry in armor
nor did I equip my footsoldiers with arms
that I might send them to the front.
I did not gather the early fruit,

⁶Pr. 6:6-8.

⁷Mt. 5:25.

⁸Ex. 23:15.



nor act in time for the late harvest,⁹
and now I am in limbo, bereft of goodness.
I do not have the flower of innocence,
nor the oil of mercy.
Here, in the darkness of the night, without a
flicker of light, I doze in the stupor of mortal-
ity,¹⁰
while the trumpet call summons me.
Once again I have arrived without wedding
clothes,
and have left the oil of good works behind.
And the door to the wedding feast has closed
before me.¹¹



How shall I find comfort for this much grief?
How much of the light of hope can I mix
with the darkness of doubt?
Where should I dig in my heels?
On what shall I fix my eyes?
What calm can I await?
To what peace shall I lift my hands?

Should I look for the vault of the heaven
from where
the fiery rain fell on Sodom, as written?¹²

Or where earth
opened its voracious throat
to swallow Dathan with the army of Abiram?¹³

Dare I flee my keeper
to be captured by terrible leviathan?¹⁴

Or should I travel among those beasts,
who
would be quicker to ask vengeance from the
creator
than Elisha did against
the pagan youth of Bethel?¹⁵

⁹Jas. 5:7.

¹⁰Mt. 25:3-8

¹¹Mt. 22:11.

¹²Gen. 19:24.

¹³Num 16:31-32.

¹⁴Jon. 1.

¹⁵2 Kg. 2:22-24.

Or shall I turn to the expanse of clear
skies
covering the Egyptians in thick darkness?¹⁶

Look to the birds on high
that feed like vultures on bloody carrion?¹⁷



What good is it to be brave as
a lion among the weak
and then be devoured by wasps?¹⁸

Or to be delivered from the bears' claws,¹⁹
only to be engulfed in blood-sucking flies?²⁰

If I sit down to rest, impudent flees swarm
around me
like flecks of flaming ash from a fire.

If I escape being impaled on the horn of
a unicorn,
my flesh will crawl with the chewing of little
worms.

And even huddled in the darkest corners
of my closet,
I could be accosted by the foulness, like heaps
of dead
frogs, to disgust me.²¹

If stand in the middle of a field,
I can be surrounded by swarms of locusts.²²

But let me leave aside the grasshoppers
and caterpillars,
a mighty army, together with the palmerworm
and
seemingly lifeless canker,²³ and the hardened
water pellets of hail and the destructive
frosts,²⁴

¹⁶Ex. 10:21.

¹⁷Ezek. 29:17-20.

¹⁸Ex. 8:16-28.

¹⁹2 Kg. 2:23-25.

²⁰Ex. 8:21-24.

²¹Ex. 8:11-14.

²²Ex. 10:4.

²³Jl. 1:4, 2:25.

²⁴Ex. 9:25.



which may to the eye seem less destructive,
but when wielded by God with his eternal
wrath and
strength have struck down, laid low, and
driven out the high and mighty Pharaoh
with his rod of violent repression, vanquishing
him.

These then are the visible manifestations
of the
hidden afflictions, the spiritual chastisements
and unseen inner torment,
suffered by the Egyptians for their injustice.

9

But you, almighty creator of everything, Lord
of all,
who rise up again at my enemies and scatter
them,²⁵
have mercy on me, with compassion.

Extend your hand of salvation to me,
perplexed, weary, wayward, and worthy of
death.

For you alone are known as God,
glorified forever, with the Father and your
Holy Spirit
unto the ages of ages.
Amen.

Prayer 69 (ԿԹ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

10

And now, by your hand, great Lord and God,
artist who with infinite ingenuity shaped my
being
in the crucible of your love where
I am daily refined but never purified,
continuously stirred but never smooth.
It is in vain, O silversmith, my heavenly
architect,
that you squander effort working on me.

²⁵Ps. 68:1 (Arm. 67:2).

As the prophet said in his well known parable,
my wickedness does not melt away.¹

Because I am woefully misguided
I dare speak out of turn
like some pathetic, possessed maniac,
increasing the burden of my sin
instead of finding a means of reconciliation.

And so that the punishment awaiting me
in the next life
does not come as a shock,
extraordinary event, or unprecedented
calamity,
he planted as a reminder here in my body
the token of that first curse,
that through this small insignificant speck the
larger
illness might be examined.

11

For in the womb are born and spontaneously
multiply
all manner of squirming worms,
intestinal worms gnawing in secret,
burning tumors, stinging ulcers, abnormal
growths,
and host of other sweaty, noisome, disgusting,
annoying, itching conditions.
Plus other savage marauders,
like demons attacking in the night,
barbarous mercenaries from the legions of
darkness,
with the ferocity of Arabian wolves,
stalking with their head curved down, their
melancholy color,
their crooked, hooked jaw,
resembling that of a scorpion,
piercing with crude thorns,
sucking, drawing blood,
to turn the bed of rest into an instrument of
punishment.

And when one lifts one's hand to give
them their due,
they sense the danger in advance that man

¹Jer. 6:29.



poses
and immediately take flight
with their hairless bodies and dwarfed size,
and hopping this way and that like grasshoppers
they scatter,
and with the slyness of foxes conspire against
the good,
escaping through secret places, as if they have
found deliverance from death.

And such vile and miserable beings,
not only pursue the vulgar and motley mob,
but also powerful and fearsome kings,
driving them to the attic of their habitations,
or even forcing them to live outside.

Courageous and brave men, who rule crowds
and govern peoples and take cities of nations,
have witnessed defeat at the hands of this
virulent
force, saying
“We were not able to resist these tyrants,
stronger
than ourselves;
therefore we took flight and reached this
point.”

¶

And why have I discoursed about
such miniscule and abject things worthy of
ridicule?
Only because they are the most powerful and
irrefutable advocates for the Divinity,
reminding me of what awaits me in the next
life, these bitter fruits
of my unruly body.
And even so deadly diseases happen upon us
and
eat away relentlessly.
From these there is no riddance
other than through physical pains which fore-
tell
the punishment that is to come.
And there is no place to seek refuge,
to escape them by fleeing.
For without the signal of your will,
human efforts and methods fail.

But you, who do good, hold in ample measure
the
life-giving cure for everything.
You have but to will it, in order to save, renew,
pardon, cure and give life.
To you glory forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 70 (Σ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

Now let me lift this discussion
from the lowly things of earth
unworthy of being considered part of creation
to the higher things.
Let me speak of God’s serious and stern Last
Judgment
from which there is no escape.
Even those the closest to God such as the Patri-
archs
or the most saintly such as the Prophets,
or the most spotless such as the Apostles,
or the truly chosen such as the martyrs,
if you did not grace them with your love
toward mankind,
with your undiminishing goodness,
unchanging providence
and unending mercy, they would be no use for
my salvation.

¶

For even if I were to call to Abraham himself
with a parched mouth, as taught by
the parable of the rich man,¹
Abraham would not provide so much as a drop
of water,
since he too is bound by our common human-
ity.

And if I were to call to Moses, also a
captive of
human frailty,

¹Lk. 6:19-31.



it would be useless for he could not save even
the man
gathering branches on the Sabbath.²

And as for Aaron, he himself needed an
intercessor.³

And David, he too was blamed despite his
abundant good deeds.⁴

Then there are Noah, and Job and Daniel,
as the prophet Ezekiel explained, inspired by
God:

“As I live, said the Lord God, they shall deliver
neither
sons nor daughters from the fury to come, only
they
themselves shall be saved.”⁵

As for Peter, the rock of faith,
no sooner was he out of your providential care
than he succumbed to human anxieties.⁶
I leave unmentioned multitudes of others
humbled by various human frailties
who are, nevertheless, among the eternally
blessed,
for example, the prophet Josiah who blas-
phemed even
at the altar during the divine liturgy.
Like these there are many more making up
an inexplicable mystery
susceptible to various interpretations.



And since human power to reach salvation is
finite,
we are objects of your mercy, beneficent God,
and fortified by you, Almighty,
called by you, God protector,
and pardoned by you, God for whom every-
thing
is possible,⁷
graced by you, God our liberator,
and cured by you, God our healer,

²Num. 15:32-36.

³Ex. 32:25-35.

⁴2 Sam. 12:1-12.

⁵Ezek. 14:14, 16, 18-20.

⁶Mt. 14:30, Mk. 14:71.

⁷Lk. 1:37.

granted life by you, God incorruptible,
and granted light by you, God our renewer.

Therefore, acknowledging the limitations
of my earth-born nature,
but taking courage from those you have com-
forted,

I petition only you, Son of the living God,
Christ blessed in all things.

What is written above is further justified
when we recall the wisdom written
in the same spirit as this prayer:
“It is better for a happy wise man
to fall into the hands of the Lord,
than to fall into the hands of men,
for the greater the power, the greater the
mercy.”⁸

These words also suit David,
who when faced with three penalties posed by
God⁹
willingly chose a horrible death, displaying
faith
reminiscent of the living Christ,
preferring death to the two lesser penalties
that involved torment without mercy.

And if I apply these words to myself
searching to sustain my lost soul,
it would not be stretching the truth.
For in this book of lamentations
I seek not to disparage
those who have been rescued,
for without them how would we approach the
Lord?
Instead I aim to glorify the name of our Savior,
and praise his grace before all people,
proclaiming those who have
been raised by high deeds
through the forever coveted salve of compas-
sion.



Even as you are life, you are salvation,
you are the cure, you are immortality,

⁸Sir. 2:18.

⁹2 Sam. 24:10-17.



you are bliss, you are enlightenment.
 Grant me peace from the torment of my sins,
 so that you might also have rest
 from my incessant, whining self-reproaches,
 you who thrive on nothing but the salvation
 of us humans.
 Blessed forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 71 (ՏԱ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Now let us turn to the happy and glorified
 ranks
 of the saints,
 some of whom stumbled slightly but were
 steadied,
 some who doubted a bit but were enlightened
 by the radiant purity of the Holy Spirit,
 thus exhibiting the faults of the ordinary
 humans
 on the one hand, while on the other,
 the ways and virtues of angels,
 transcending the laws of nature.

And now, those who are blessed
 by the divine mouth of our Father Christ,¹
 commanding all alike, the chosen, celebrated,
 adored, and praised,
 who are worshiped as members of the body of
 Christ
 and who are prepared as temples of the Holy
 Spirit,²
 in whom there is no hint of darkness,
 but who are instead completely guileless
 and glow with righteousness
 and are godly as much as humans can be:
 their faces are open and unashamed,
 their piety uplifting and intrepid,
 their lives sober and irreproachable,
 their worship stalwart and unwavering,
 their ways courageous and unflagging,

¹Mt. 25:34.

²1 Cor. 6:15-20.

their truth uniform and unshakable,
 their valor strong and indomitable,
 their vision is bright and unconfused,
 their wisdom is heavenly and invincible,
 their image is clean and incorruptible.
 By their examples and in the memory of their
 names
 God taught us to pray and³
 through them find help amid troubles,
 as your word, Creator, teaches.⁴

Բ

But I am unworthy in all things,
 and fail, as much as I try.
 Although I am awake, I dream.
 Although I seem alert, I am dazed.
 While worshiping, I blaspheme.
 While praying I err.
 In my work I balk.
 While seeking forgiveness I sin.
 In my resting, I am restless,
 While advancing, I retreat.⁵
 When I walk, I walk backwards.⁶
 To the light, I bring darkness.⁷
 To sweet flavors, I add the bitterness of ab-
 sinthe.
 Into the warp of goodness, I weave the woof of
 evil.
 After being lifted up, I stumble again.
 I blossom, but do not bear fruit.
 I speak and do not act.⁸
 I promise but do not perform.
 I make vows I do not fulfill.
 I reach out but pull back.
 I display but do not offer.
 I bring forth but do not give.
 While tending my wounds I reopen them.⁹
 While reconciling I cause friction.
 I complain without cause and am justly con-
 demned.
 I am enrolled and immediately removed.

³Gen. 20:7

⁴Job 42:8.

⁵Phil. 3:13.

⁶Lk. 9:62.

⁷Lk. 11:35.

⁸Lk. 23:3.

⁹2 Kg. 8:8-10.



I set sail and immediately lose course.
 I set out and do not reach the harbor.
 I poise myself and yet I fall.
 I am filled and yet drained dry.
 I am put in order here and fall apart there.
 I am gathered here and set afire there.¹⁰
 I lay a foundation but do not finish building.¹¹
 I gain little and waste thousands.
 I save almost nothing and spend without end.
 I give others advice I do not practice.
 I study constantly but never learn the truth.¹²
 Even when the evil is extinguished I keep stoking it.
 I take heart a bit, then feel yet more abandoned.
 I gear up and then as quickly slacken.
 I patch this and rip that.
 I pull up nettles and sow thorns.
 I try to ascend and am dragged down.
 I go to the nest as a dove and come out a crow.
 I arrive almost white and leave totally black.
 I pledge myself to you and then dedicate myself
 to an assassin.
 I face forward but turn back.¹³

¶

I am cleansed but am covered with soot.
 I am washed but am soiled just the same.
 I pretend to be David and act like Saul.
 I mouth truths and lie in my heart.¹⁴
 I give with my right hand but steal with my left.
 I cultivate wheat but sow tares.¹⁵
 I have retreated from the heights of wisdom
 and become as I was.
 I put on the face of an angel but have the mind
 of a devil.
 I am steady on my feet but wavering in my mind.
 I confess my shortcomings falsely but really err.
 I feign righteousness but am truly false.

¹⁰Jn. 15:6.

¹¹Lk. 14:29.

¹²2 Tim. 3:7.

¹³Jer. 2:27.

¹⁴Is. 29:18.

¹⁵Mt. 13:25.

I pretend to be in the choir of the meek but strut
 with the demons.
 I am praised by humans but reproached by you,
 all-seeing God.
 I am blessed among the earthly but pitiful among the children of light.
 I am pleasing to the most vulgar but have fallen
 from your eyes, great king.
 I flee your just tribunal but plea before the impious.
 I reject the noble but cavort with the repulsive.
 I dress my body up with finery
 but my soul in spotted feathers of a jay.¹⁶
 I approach to make a pact but I am rejected as a traitor.
 Today I am pure and filled with the Spirit
 but tomorrow I am a crazed fool.
 I disobeyed the Lord's commandments but followed the serpent's suggestions.¹⁷
 I became high and mighty but submitted like a weakling.
 I bear the burdens of the day but leave
 without my portion at pay time.¹⁸
 I talk big at a distance but am nonplussed when called to account.
 At sunrise I appear prosperous and at sunset I loiter empty-handed.
 I sit upon the elder's chair but take counsel from fools.¹⁹
 I fall asleep complaining and awake in terror.
 I plough the fields of my desires with special care for evil.

I who am
 ever the prodigal son,
 banished forever, unrepentant, wayward,
 inconsolably dejected, in self-imposed captivity,

¹⁶Based on a fable about a bird that donned bright feathers for a ceremony only to be unmasked and recognized for the plain bird that it really was. Critical Edition, 1083, n. 7.

¹⁷Gen. 2:17, 3:1-6.

¹⁸Mt. 20:12.

¹⁹1 Kg. 12:6-11.



servant of death and corruption,
mercilessly tormented, condemned
beyond salvation,
cut off beyond rejoining, extinguished
beyond resuscitation,
bruised beyond healing, destroyed
beyond hope of the next life.
And if sterner reproaches than these are needed
against my unruly soul,
I hereby commit them to writing,
I heap them like kindling
to fuel the flames of Hell.²⁰

I am the jealous offspring of the new heavenly
Adam
as Cain was in the first instance toward the old
and earthly Adam.
And in this world I bear upon my soul the
mark of blame,²¹ not with the respiration of
breath, but
through the wordy torment of my conscience.



And where is salvation now?
Now when the father of faith, Abraham, in our
desperate damnation, turns my cruelty in life
back
on my soul after death? ²²
When the great prophets stone me with the
harsh words? ²³
When the brave one adorned in glory, kills me
with the thrust of a javelin? ²⁴
When the image of the true Lord wipes me
from
the face of the earth with Achor? ²⁵
When the most sublime of God's chosen
delivers me
to the vengeance of the Gibeonites? ²⁶
When the seer born of the prophet slays me
before the Lord with the Amalakites? ²⁷
When the zealot of God lays waste

²⁰Jn. 15:6.

²¹Gen. 4:4-15.

²²Lk. 16:19-25.

²³Ex. 32:21-29, referring to Moses.

²⁴Num. 25:7-8, referring to Phineas.

²⁵Jos. 7:23-26, referring to Joshua.

²⁶2 Sam. 21:8-9, referring to David.

²⁷1 Sam. 15:32-35, referring to Samuel.

with fire from heaven?
When the consummation of the dim images
of the old covenant and the herald of the new
covenant
pours upon us the winnowing of the chaff? ²⁸
When the chief of the disciples takes my life
with Sapphira's? ²⁹
When the one judged admirable by the Holy
Spirit
mixes the savor of death with teaching of life?
³⁰
Meanwhile, the assembly of the blessed are
indifferent to me, both angel and human,
those valiant forces poised to obey God's
command,
the universe of the world, and the elements,
the inanimate and the living,
by whom I am forever scolded and condemned
and reminded of terrors to come
unsettling the tranquility and stability of my
life
like waves whipped by storms.

And if one were to study with wisdom
the diverse sea creatures
from the smallest to the largest,
countless without number
swarming in infinite schools, bustling
and gliding this way and that through
the sea of my body, the truth of all
I have written would be confirmed.



But you yourself blessed, immortal king,
kind, heavenly Christ, who loves mankind,
only-begotten Son of the living God,
almighty exalted beyond understanding,
beyond telling, who pardons us, awesome
God,
scold the undulating agitation of my soul
whipped up by the winter tempest,
calm the uncontrollable commotion in my
troubled heart,
whip in the reins and subdue the wild urges of

²⁸Mt. 3:11-12, referring to John the Baptist; Is. 40:3,
Mal. 3:1.

²⁹Acts 5:10, referring to Peter.

³⁰2 Cor. 2:15-16, referring to Paul.



my mind.

By the grace of your command, O great God,
may the storm that constantly pelts me with icy gusts be calmed.³¹
Put to rest and banish forever
the multi-headed ghosts of secret shame
which attack like pirates in their vulgar ways.
Consider my constant prayer
whose letters are written with ever renewed compunction in this book of the sighs of my grieving heart.
Lift me out of the abyss of death's depths and grant me miraculous life among the redeemed prophets.³²
Receive my repentance, my self-reproaches offered with savory smoke.
Console me, for I am out of hope, and ease my afflictions and sighs.
To you with the Father and the Holy Spirit, glory, honor and dominion forever.
Amen.

Prayer 72 (ՏԲ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Now to you, monastic brothers,
communities of disciples,
you who, bared-handed, have enlisted
as the Lord's soldiers, in expectation
and hope of infinite good gifts,
for you I set this table with
my burnt sacrifice of words.

Accept this testament of confession
for the edification and salvation of your souls.
Know through it the frailty of the body.
Remember the warning words of the prophet and the apostle: "No flesh should exult before God." And, "No one, not a single person, is just."¹

³¹Mt. 8:26.

³²Jon. 2:10.

¹Jer. 9:22, 1 Cor. 1:29.

Do not forget the word of the Lord:
"Even when you have done the things commanded,
admit, we are useless servants."²
Do not permit yourselves to become the prey of the Deceiver. Take heed from the scriptures.
"The chosen are also Devil's food."³
For even I, who nourish you with these meager fruits,
willingly blaming myself
with myriad accounts of all the incurable sins,
from our first forefather through the end of his generations in all eternity,
I charge myself with all these, voluntarily,
taking the debt of all your wrongdoing upon me.⁴

Բ

I heard an innocent person once speak
in a most unfitting manner to the One
before whom no earthly being can be justified,⁵
and it was not pleasing as he boasted,
"I have never committed adultery
or fornication or tasted any other mortal pleasures
of this world." Saying this is no less impious
than those deeds. May God forgive him,
for even if what he said were true
by bragging he shows he has not progressed
as far as he has fallen.
Repeating Zechariah's words to the people of Israel:
"Praise the Lord that we are great,"⁶
echoing the voice of the Pharisee who exalted himself.⁷

Գ

But since I am condemned before the all-knowing God,⁸
who has placed the unseen passions of the mind
onto the scale of justice, and seeks to judge me

²Lk. 17:10.

³Hab. 1:16.

⁴Rom. 5:12.

⁵Ps. 143 (142):2.

⁶Zech. 11:5.

⁷Lk. 18:11-12.

⁸Mt. 5:28.



by these in the most just way, I shall not
pretend before the all-seeing,
deceive the one who scrutinizes everything,
lie to the one who counts faults when con-
ceived, not
when committed,
use trickery to favorably impress the Great
One,
mask my unruly debauchery with the appear-
ance of
a good person,
take on airs of self-discipline while being
forever weak,
dress in other's costumes,
bask in other's splendor,
put on finery to cover the ugliness of my body.
No one is so sinful as I,
so unruly, so impious,
so unjust, so evil,
so feeble, so misguided,
so foolish, so crafty,
so mired, so embarrassed, so blameworthy.
I alone, and no one else,
I in all, and all in me,
not the pagans, for they did not know,
not the Jews, for they were blind,
not the ignorant, for they were confused and
lacking wisdom.



I was dubbed, "Master," which testifies against
me.⁹
I was called, "Teacher, teacher,"
detracting from the praise of God.
I was said to be good because of my miserable
plight.¹⁰
I was considered a saint by men,
though I am unclean before God.
I was proclaimed just, though by all accounts
I am ungodly.
I reveled in the praise of men,
thus becoming a mockery before the tribunal of
Christ.
I was called, "Awake" at the baptismal font,¹¹

⁹Mt. 23:7, 8, 10.

¹⁰Mk. 10:18.

¹¹A reference to St. Gregory's baptismal name: Gre-
gorios means "Awake" in Greek.

but I slumber in the sleep of mortality.
On the day of salvation I was named "Vigilant,"
but I closed my eyes to vigilance.
So here are judgment and blame,
new reprimands and old sentences,
shame to my face and turmoil to my soul,
pleas about seemingly small things and very
grave matters.



But you alone, Lord God, who loves mankind
without
revenge and with forbearing,
on the day of the terrible last judgment
when my sinful soul is judged, take into
account
these heart-rending words of self-reproach
and contrition that I myself have written
instead
of waiting to hear them from you, God of
compassion.

Now lift away and annul the instances of
my unruliness
for I am bound to you with all of the desires of
my soul.
Take away the reproaches of shame and
scandal.¹²
Cover the ugly appearance of my naked body
with your mighty right hand. Lead me to your
rest,
for I am worn by the burden of sin.¹³
Set me on the path of goodness toward you,
refuge and life. Remember me in mercy
even after death, O perfect life.¹⁴
Blessed in heaven and honored on earth,
praised always in all things forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 73 (ՏԳ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*



¹²Ps. 119 (Arm. 118):39.

¹³Mt. 11:28.

¹⁴Lk. 23:42.



King on high, mighty and awesome,
blessed Lord Jesus Christ,
for someone like me who despairs of salvation
only you can change the curse of mortality
into the blessing of life.

Only you can turn the discouragement of blame
into joyous praise,
shame into resilience,
humility into honor,
banishment into the hope of goodness,
separation into the expectation of reunion,
menacing words into compassionate comfort,
final condemnation into a second chance
at deliverance.

ⲡ

Lord, have mercy on me, for I am condemned
to death
on the day of my life-breath's release,
while I implore on high with my eyes' pitiful
gaze
fixed the perils ahead on that unavoidable
journey,
with danger on all sides in my terrified imagi-
nation.
And while gazing at my cell's ceiling where I
will start
my outward journey, wretched and half dead
with
a twisted face, with shaking fingers, muffled
sighs,
failing cries, a thin voice, my grieving soul
shaken by a panoply of
doubts, I shall lament from the bottom of
my invisible soul the sins I have committed.

You are able, compassionate God, to per-
form a miracle
with your everlasting might saying,
"Be healed of your soul's torment,"¹
or "May your sins be forgiven,"²
or "Go in peace. You are cleansed of sin."³
And whatever I do not manage to say at that
hour
receive from me today in your love for

¹Mk. 5:34.

²Mt. 9:2, Lk. 7:48.

³Lk. 7:50.

mankind,
O long-suffering, generous God, who gives
life to all.

ⲧ

When I, so eloquent now with my haughty
voice
and strutting stiff-necked ways,
am laid out a lifeless cadaver, dispossessed
of speech, hands bound, limbs atrophied,
lips sealed, eyes shut, as still as
a board, a half-burnt log,
inert statue, speechless image, breathless
being,
pitiful spectacle, deplorable sight,
lamentable form, miserable face,
tear-causing likeness, silenced tongue,
parched grass, petal-less flower,
run-down beauty, extinguished lamp,
deserted throat, devastated heart,
muted trumpet, dry well, wilted body,
festering womb, collapsed tent, broken branch,
separated joint, chopped tree, sawed off root,
abandoned house, harvested field, uprooted
plant,
alienated friend, forgotten supplies,
buried filth, cast away trash,
brushed aside clutter, contemptible skeleton,
like some useless thing trodden under foot.

I am needy of the prayers of others,
which rise to you, compassionate doer of good,
with the dew of tears amplifying
the sighs of the faith-filled pleas
of my wretched voice.
Joining in my prayer, they chant
the responsive hymn to you, whom I praise,
the sign of your cross of salvation, which I
worship,
the truth of your resurrection, which I believe,⁴
the revelation of your glory, which I praise,⁵
the sternness of your judgment, which I
confess,
the reprimand of your words, which I fear,⁶
the guiding companionship of your Holy

⁴1 Th. 4:14.

⁵Tit. 2:13.

⁶Mt. 7:23, 25:41.

Spirit,
 which I revere,
 the anointing seal of the Lord at last unction,
 which I embrace,
 the reigning with you, Lord Jesus,
 for which I pray.⁷
 And though it was abandoned, rejected, cast
 away,
 broken, though it fled, flew, gave way in the
 tumult of life,
 your hope, which is a gift from you,
 perseveres as a permanent and indelible
 reminder.

✠

Look with mercy upon me in my doubts and
 perils,
 glorified Son of God, who alone are compas-
 sionate
 and will pardon, heal, save, protect, renew, re-
 store,
 lift up, support,
 and create me again in blissful purity.⁸
 Yours is the power, yours is the salvation, and
 yours the mercy.
 Nothing is impossible for you.⁹
 Yours is might, exaltation, dominion
 and kingdom without end, true essence and
 selfhood,
 all-encompassing absolute being,
 goodness and light, glorified as Lord,
 to which nothing can be added or taken away,
 adored in the Holy Trinity with inexplicable
 mystery
 and given thanks forever also in the Holy Trin-
 ity
 in the same act of worship equally with the
 same honor,
 yesterday, today and forever.¹⁰
 Amen.

⁷2 Tim. 2:12.

⁸Ps. 51 (Arm. 50):10.

⁹Lk. 1:37, Gen. 18:14.

¹⁰Heb. 13:8.

Prayer 74 (ՏԴ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Heavenly king, Lord of all,
 patient toward all in all things,
 Son of the living God, beyond our understand-
 ing,
 your true mercy is manifest when
 the expectation of reward is cut off.
 Your benevolence is displayed when the mind's
 vision is blocked.
 Your love of mankind is expressed at the hour
 when weakness lays siege from without and
 within.
 The divine healing of your hand is manifest
 when life departs completely from our bodies.¹
 You visit where there is no exit.
 Your greatness is clear when you cure the
 wound of despair.
 Your genuine humanity shared with us is re-
 vealed
 when at unexpected times you dispense salva-
 tion.
 Your victory is obvious
 when you open the closed door of life
 at my last breath.
 Your magnificent grace is there
 when you forget my wrongs and
 remember your goodness.
 Your ungrudging generosity is manifest
 when you include me in your care,
 ingrate that I am, along with the grateful.
 I know and recognize
 that you look upon this offering of words with
 your former compassion as you lift away my
 sinful habits.

Բ

For hymns rise up and chants are sung
 when the Lord in his kindness rewards the bad
 servant
 with goodness.²

¹Mt. 8:3.

²Mt. 18:27.



When he grants rest in the royal palace to one
who should be imprisoned.³
When he seats on the tufts of the sumptuous
throne
one who belongs in the dust bin.⁴
When he lifts toward the heights of happiness
the eyes of one expecting them gouged.⁵
When he places the ring of royalty on the hand
of him who expects his fingers cut off.
When he draws into his comforting embrace
one expecting lashes of a whip.
When in plain view of all he rescues
someone poised for destruction.
When he bestows glory as well as life
to him waiting for death's devastation.
When he decorates with laurels
the head of one expecting beheading.
These are the blessed fruits of your magnificent
vine,
compassionate Lord. This is the living harvest
of your creative commandments.
These are the yearning thoughts inspired by
fervor for you.
These are the rays of light of your
all-encompassing radiance.
This is the pleasurable taste of your glorious
sweetness.

¶

These are yours alone, Lord,
and by you was I moved to write them.
I pray, blessed Lord, for those gifts uniquely
yours to give,
Grant them, I pray you.
Open, Lord, the treasures of your good things,
according to the prayer of the Proverbs.⁶
Do not mix my wrongdoing in the storehouse
of
your good things.
Do not store up vengeance and anger, which
are
hateful to you, with compassion and mercy,
which you love.
Do not keep in your venerable creation the

³2 Sam. 19:28.

⁴Wis. 10:13-14, Ps. 113 (Arm. 112):7.

⁵1 Sam. 11:2.

⁶Pr. 8:21.

darkness and cruelty displeasing to you
or the sin and misery harmful to me.
Do not record with your blessed right hand
into the book of life
the mortgage of my damning debts.
Rather bring to pass the seemingly impossible,
exalt your name yet again, Lord, by showing
how simple and easy these are for you.⁷

¶

My debts are too numerous to count,
but not so marvelous as your mercy.
My sins are many,
but small compared to your forgiveness.
My transgressions are frequent,
but your love for mankind vanquishes them all,
powerful and almighty,
The stains on my soul are too numerous for me
to count,
but for you they are very limited.
The weapons of sin produced by a miserable
wretch like
me are not so strong against life as the memory
of your
death, living Lord, for fending off the De-
stroyer.
What effect can a small shadow have on the
light of
your day, God?
How can the dusk withstand your radiance,
great God?
How can my unruly frail body be placed on the
scales
with the cross of your suffering?
How does the mass of all the sins of the uni-
verse appear
to your eye, Almighty, who made everything in
abundance? Are they not for you but a clump
of earth
that easily crumbles or a drop of rain that splat-
ters in all
directions and disappears at your command?

¶

How long would it take your omnipotent
power to

⁷Mt. 19:26.

pardon my transgressions?
 Not even the batting of the eye,
 not the fleeting side glance,
 not the quick glaring flash,
 not the slightest hesitation,
 not the hurried footstep,
 not the raindrop's coursing a cubit,
 not the grasp of a line by the mind,
 not the speed of light,
 not the taking of a breath.

None of these insubstantial, fleeting events or
 ephemeral states is so short or instantaneous as
 the disintegration, destruction and melting of
 the
 glacier of my sins by your power God, Lord of
 all,
 Jesus Christ, Son of the living God, beyond
 human understanding.
 You grant the sun of sweetness to the evil as
 well as the good, and make it rain upon both.⁸
 You mete out fairly the vicissitudes of life.
 Those who find contentment in the expectation
 of rewards, you pay with the spurs of tempta-
 tion
 for their few sins.
 And those who have chosen the worldly life,
 you forgive with mercy
 ministering your care to both alike,
 awaiting their return to you.
 To you glory, Almighty, for the miraculous
 work
 of your patient loving care,
 blessed forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 75 (ՏԵ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

And now, engulfed, entranced and over-
 whelmed
 by the magnitude, multitude and frequency

⁸Mt. 5:45.

of your gifts that overflow infinitely with abun-
 dant,
 undiminishing plenty, on the left and right,
 to the front and back,¹
 I approach to offer again, great God, a testa-
 ment in praise of the true faith,
 for although at times
 I was ensnared and lured away
 and expelled from Paradise²
 by heretical doctrines, devices of the Deceiver,
 now by this true doctrine in upright purity,
 as a token of true grace³
 again on wings of light
 I ascend in pursuit of heaven.
 And as I was conceived and born in the
 womb of the Church,
 with pangs of spiritual labor,
 remembering the profession of faith
 and the doctrine of the Holy Trinity,
 I now should address the great
 and favored immaculate queen,
 true maiden of all virgins, my glorious mother,
 worthy of praise, so she may be known
 and proclaimed and the extent of her venerable
 glory might be told to the nations in the future,
 worthy of honor
 and reverence as a pure body
 headed by the incarnate Word of God.

¶

And now, in the manner of this word picture
 drawn by the Spirit,
 this icon upon the altar of light,
 accept me, O compassionate and blessed God,
 and let me be pardoned and cleansed through
 it.
 Remove the sinful stains upon my soul.

¹Here, based on certain manuscripts, the Jerusalem Narek has a sub-caption that reads: "Again for a second time the traditional doctrine established by the Apostles under the inspiration of the Divine Spirit is set forth here to shed light on the doctrine of the church and interpret the blessed image beyond words that the inanimate physical church represents." Some commentators believe Prayer 75 to be a continuation of Prayer 34, where St. Gregory sets forth the confession of faith, without addressing the Church.

²Gen. 3.

³1 Tim. 6:20.



Seat me with the innocent and the pure under
 its shadow.
 Gather me up, the weakest of the house of
 David,⁴
 and move me from there to the house of God,
 as the Prophet said, referring to you, Jesus.⁵
 Do not render my comings and goings from the
 chapel vain and useless.
 Do not find the fervor of my faith cold.
 Do not consider the embrace of my greeting out
 of place.
 Do not deem my service without grace.
 Do not leave my worship without inspiration.
 May the vision of your image not be fruitless.
 May this model of paradise not be lusterless.
 May the fireless burnt offering not be over-
 looked.
 May the sacrifice of this vow in words not be
 cast away.
 May the taste of your light not be my death.
 May the cup of the blood from your wounded
 side
 not be my condemnation.⁶

✠

To you, Lord Jesus, one of the divine essence,
 whom we tasted, thereby coming to know the
 Father
 and Holy Spirit,
 to you, teacher who taught us
 the all-rewarding ways of the church,
 to you who dwell in this light-filled house of
 prayer
 dedicated to the salvation of good souls
 to you, ruler of all, Holy Trinity
 with hearts spread forth and hands out-
 stretched,
 we offer this incense of words
 forever, with grace and thanksgiving.⁷

✠

We glorify you chanting hymns of praise,
 believing in the efficacy of the ministry of the

⁴That is, the Church.

⁵Zech 12:8.

⁶1 Cor. 11:27.

⁷Here, some versions have another subtitle: "Another meditation on the Creed and Confession of Faith adopted at the Council of Nicea" (AD 325).

Word,⁸

O good commanding cause of all being,
 Holy Trinity without beginning, peerless high-
 ness,
 unfathomable mystery, incomprehensible for
 our minds,
 unexaminable by our senses, beyond the capac-
 ity
 of all creation, whose greatness encompasses
 the heavens on high and the limitless depths be-
 low,
 end of all ends and beginning of all beginnings,
 one from three distinct persons,
 three from one indivisible Godhead,
 beyond the understanding of the unfettered
 mind
 traversing all dimensions, unchanging good,
 unshakable uprightness, unadulterated image
 of love,
 greatness beyond which there is nothing,
 height which cannot be lowered,
 vision that cannot be marred,
 undiminishing beneficence, steadfast will,
 living commandment, sign of salvation, true
 blessing,
 expectation of faith, unfeignable promise,
 generous inheritance, trustworthy good news,
 sublime beyond reach.
 One Father of the only Son, honored by the sin-
 gular Holy Spirit,
 with the richest goodness, completely devoid
 of evil,
 with thanksgiving offered in a voice of bless-
 ing,
 exalted with hymns of praise beyond our un-
 derstanding.

✠

One of the exalted, the awesome name
 partaker of the same honor,
 the same ineffable nature,
 the same substance of three conjoined lights,
 perfection to which nothing can be added,
 of his own free will reverently loving the
 Father,
 whose likeness he bears,

⁸Acts 6:4.



with the aid of the Spirit of Holiness,⁹
 who humbled itself and descended to earth,
 without diminishing its inherent glory,
 to enter the maternal womb of the immaculate
 Virgin,
 Mother of God, in whom he grew the seeds of
 blessings
 in that radiant field of purity,¹⁰
 combining with the most perfect divine
 essence
 in an unfathomable unity,
 in a permeating union,
 he miraculously combined into his divinity
 the breath of our existence.

In this way, with the irresistible reins
 of his guiding bridle, he calmed my unruliness
 and willingly submitting to the cross.
 He rose like the flower of the
 fruit-bearing tree of life
 upon the stem of immortality.¹¹
 He was wounded, died
 without separating his divinity from
 the flesh that is the same as ours
 and suffering forever with his physical body,
 inseparable from the essence of the creatorship
 within him he brought life out of the
 instrument of defeat.

Descending into the dark regions of hell,
 he delivered the kidnapped beings of his
 creation
 from the bonds of the alienating serpent,¹²
 and as if shaking off the stupor of sleep,
 he forced death's assault on him to retreat,
 and arose and came to life divinely
 ascending from earth as the bread of life,
 shepherding the flock of thinking souls.¹³
 The world had faith in him and¹⁴
 he appeared again to his disciples as he was
 in no way diminished, for he
 had come back whole and ascended

in his entirety to sit upon
 the exalted throne with the glory
 of his creatorship as simply
 as it had been formerly.
 We confess him as God, doer of good
 and Lord of all who judges
 all the earth with justice on the great day,
 who himself is the beginning and himself
 is the end, the first and the last,
 who rules with his undiminished wholeness
 in light too bright to approach.

2

We praise with the Father and the Son
 the Lord Holy Spirit, which springs insepara-
 bly
 forth from them sharing their glory,
 the Spirit that created everything and gave life
 to all,
 that Spirit which from the very beginning,
 when the universe was completely enveloped
 in misty darkness, brooded, designed and
 shaped¹⁵
 the sea which covered the earth with
 its infinite, all-powerful waters,
 an act symbolic of the true mystery
 of the holy baptismal font of light.
 First he created and now he acts.
 He brought into existence and constantly
 performs his handiwork, splendid miracles,
 foretold through the visions of saintly,
 divine signs, amazing miracles,
 prophets, apostles, scholars,
 learned in the teaching of wisdom.

He prepared the sanctuary for the offer-
 ing
 of Christ's blood. With mercy he ordered
 the pardoning of souls and the healing of
 bodies in the manner of Christ.
 He baptized with that which is greater than
 water
 and he renewed and enlightened through
 himself.¹⁶
 He daily grows stronger by his good works.
 He bore witness to the only begotten of God

⁹Mt. 1:18-20, Lk. 1:35.

¹⁰Gen. 22:18, Lk. 1:42.

¹¹Is. 11:1.

¹²1 Pet. 3:18-19, Eph. 4:8.

¹³Jn. 6:35, Heb. 13:20.

¹⁴1 Tim. 3:16.

¹⁵Gen. 1:2.

¹⁶Acts 10:44.



at the flowing waters of the Jordan.¹⁷
 With the voice of the Father in the shape of a cloud
 he appeared on Mount Tabor.¹⁸
 In the same form he protected the house of Jacob
 in its exodus from Egypt.¹⁹
 On the march led by Moses,
 he engulfed Pharaoh with terrible winds.²⁰
 He creates priests.
 He shapes sages.
 He strengthens kings.
 He accords pardon.
 He grants life to the dead in the renewal of the resurrection.
 He himself is the anointing of God made man,
 forever equally worshiped with the Father
 for the honor of greatness of the Son,
 with boundless glory praised forever,
 Amen.

Է²¹

We profess the true faith, unerring and pure,
 with the kiss of our lips we greet the altar
 built of lifeless stone, the body of the church
 as the dwelling place of God
 more exalted than the most splendid heights of heaven
 and founded upon the congregation of the apostles,
 and revered by the disciples of the one on high,
 as the place where the servants of the Word
 worshiped.
 This treasure of life had its beginning in
 the upper room, the place where the miracle²²
 happened on the great day of Pentecost.
 The spirit of God radiant with power,²³
 filled that beautiful house,
 breathing upon it as a sign of the pre-eminence

¹⁷Mt. 3:16.

¹⁸Mt. 17:5.

¹⁹Ex. 13:21.

²⁰Ex. 14:28.

²¹In some versions this section is preceded by a sub-heading: "The prayer of St. Gregory on the mysteries of the Holy Church against the impious sect of the Tondrakians, the new Manicheans."

²²Mt. 26:26-28, Luke 22:19-20.

²³Acts 2:1-4.

of the church,
 then sanctifying it through this act of grace,
 then endowing it and those within with glorious
 renewing light. Thus the blood of the almighty
 God
 distributed and offered forever
 is greater than Abel's.²⁴
 For Abel's cries only the message of death
 but this blood shouts with a blissful voice
 proclaiming life immortal.²⁵
 No one has the power under heaven
 or before the sun to celebrate this awesome
 mystery
 except under the protective wing of the church,
 for heaven is not pleased with a gift of the
 Lord's body,
 except when offered under the auspices
 of this blessed roof, and for this reason,
 according to the Law, there is a curse of death
 upon one who makes the divine offering,
 except at the altar of communal sacrifice.
 Moreover, one who makes this offering,
 the image of the soul, at a place other than the
 altar,
 shall be branded with blood guilt.

In the church, there is but one baptism
 into the
 death of Christ,²⁶
 so that his divinity might not unwittingly suffer
 sacrificed a second time to purify someone
 already cleansed by his light.²⁷
 There is but one laying on of hands
 to be anointed with light so that deceit
 might not be mixed with truth.
 There is but one pardon,
 more through grace than penance,²⁸
 so that the reality might not
 be confused with appearances.
 There is but one doctrine about the trial to
 come,²⁹

²⁴Gen. 4:10.

²⁵Heb. 12:24.

²⁶Rom. 6:2-3, Eph. 4:5.

²⁷Heb. 6:4-5.

²⁸Justification by grace, not works.

²⁹Eph. 4:5, Mt. 25:31-46.

so that the threat of punishment might not seem like mere talk about some stranger.³⁰
 There is but one just warning for both of the elements
 of our nature, so that in the immortal power
 of the adoption into the kingdom of heaven³¹
 the recompense for good and evil
 does not appear solely for the inner soul, but
 for the outer man too, so the true magnificence
 of the kingdom might be manifest
 through our earthly nature as well.
 There is but one hope of life with the incorruptible saints,
 so that the certitude of things promised,
 as revealed to the minds of those who listen,
 might be believed.

¶

The inanimate church, venerable queen,
 gives life and rules over death,
 like the fruit that Adam was said to have eaten.³²
 But this church surpasses all animate beings,
 for though inanimate, it performs miracles,
 even undertaking to perfect and renew us,
 by etching the image of the glorious light upon us.
 It is written that the church shares the vault
 of heaven's grandeur, before the hosts
 of spiritual beings that live there.
 She uplifts bodies to soar again with
 the lightness of the soul, endowing
 the baser element with dignity.
 She is not debased by her own faults,
 but by being trampled by evil or faithless people.³³
 She is an amazing sign, overwhelming our
 mind's understanding,
 this unthinking thing, created by thinking creatures,
 that helps them as a superior helps its subordinate.
 She is greater than man,
 as the invincible rod was greater than

³⁰Acts 17:19-20.

³¹Lk. 20:36.

³²Gen. 3:9-10.

³³Ps. 79 (Arm 78):1.

God's chosen Moses.³⁴
 She surpasses the speaking beings
 as the miraculously blooming rod was
 greater than Aaron.³⁵
 She exceeds the thinking beings just as
 the splendid cloak
 that parted the rivers is greater than
 Elijah and Elisha.³⁶
 She delivers assistance again and again with
 hands
 more saintly than militant, for her body³⁷
 of stone and mortar shares the same substance
 as the feeling beings and the saints.
 Like an immortal rock, she lives in the falling
 and rising of many.³⁸
 Like the judge of all souls, she comes forth
 with miraculous signs
 through curses and blessings.³⁹
 Like one who sees the unseen she exposes
 some,
 shelters others.
 Like the commander-in-chief she summons
 all by name.⁴⁰
 Like an eternal mountain she resists attack.⁴¹
 Like a net cast by God she catches souls.⁴²
 Sinless, unerring, she proceeds in the
 footsteps of Christ.⁴³
 Like the praiseworthy, she lifts up her head in
 sublime magnificence, boldly and without
 shame.

¶

The church has such great sanctity that her
 canons
 make distinctions among the creatures made
 in God's image.
 If, despite care, an improper person
 ventures through her portal,
 she is not desecrated,

³⁴Ex. 4:1-5.

³⁵Num. 17:8.

³⁶2 Kg. 2:8, 14.

³⁷Ex. 17:22.

³⁸1 Pet. 2:4-5, Lk. 2:34.

³⁹Mt. 25:24, 41.

⁴⁰Ps. 147 (Arm. 146-7):4.

⁴¹Ps. 125 (Arm. 124):1.

⁴²Mt. 13:37.

⁴³Eph. 5:24-27.



but rather distressed by this carelessness.
 She is not cursed, but pardons those who do not
 understand her sanctity.
 She is not abandoned as if she caused the short-
 comings,
 but is tarnished by our deeds.
 She does not permit a second approach to re-
 ceive
 the mystery of the Lord at the feet of the
 life-giving God.⁴⁴
 She does not permit that sacrament to be of-
 fered twice
 in one day so that this gift is not debased by
 indiscriminate use.
 She has compassion for our frailties,⁴⁵
 the same as one immune from passion's cor-
 ruption.
 Without a word she judges with lordly author-
 ity.



For she is an ark of purity,⁴⁶
 a second cause of rejoicing
 who saves us from drowning
 in the tumult of our worldly lives.
 She does not gather all sorts of beasts and just
 a few humans, but rather gathers the heavenly
 host together with us mortals.
 She is not tossed about on waves of agitation,⁴⁷
 but rises above it to the heavenly heights.
 As a disciple under the command of the
 Holy Spirit of God
 she avoids iniquity.⁴⁸
 She does not demand a death blow to the flesh
 but rather guides those in her care to the
 good news of life.
 She is not built by the hand of Noah,
 but is built by the command of the creator.⁴⁹
 She is not adorned by Moses with the crafts-
 man Bezaleel,⁵⁰ but by the only begotten Son
 of God

⁴⁴Mt. 28:9; Jn. 20:17.

⁴⁵Heb. 4:15.

⁴⁶Gen. 6:14.

⁴⁷Gen. 7:1-18.

⁴⁸Wis. 1:5.

⁴⁹Gen. 6:14.

⁵⁰Ex. 31:1-11.

with the Holy Spirit.
 She is not in perpetual motion, constantly
 changing
 but is established permanently upon an
 unshakable foundation.
 Like the ark made of wooden planks,⁵¹
 lacking the ability to speak and the sense of
 sight,
 still she guides us anew.
 In the image of the creator's infinite plenitude
 she goes ahead to prepare for us a place in
 the light of life.⁵²
 She strikes one dead on the spot, like Uzzah,⁵³
 if she is not shouldered like the cross in the
 soul.
 She kills without pause or trace
 if she is carried off like some man-made vessel
 on a cart harnessed to beasts in earthly de-
 sires.⁵⁴
 She speaks not with the tongues of men,
 but with the language of angels.⁵⁵
 She does not listen with physical ears
 but comprehends directly with her mind.⁵⁶
 She does not proclaim with articulated sounds
 but tells the message of Jesus' works to all
 nations.⁵⁷
 She does not have vocal cords but expresses
 herself with the breath of the living God.
 She does not have joints of bones and nerves
 but just as the armed throngs of Israelites
 though the chosen army of God on high,
 were made to stand two thousand cubits from
 the ark of the covenant⁵⁸ because of their
 impiety, she still keeps her distance from those
 infected with sin
 even though they were delivered from the toil
 of brick-making in Egypt.⁵⁹
 Even the essence of God incarnate was
 called the "rock,"⁶⁰

⁵¹Ex. 25:10, Num. 11:33.

⁵²Jn. 14:2-3.

⁵³2 Sam. 6:6-7.

⁵⁴2 Sam. 6:3-7.

⁵⁵Ex. 25:22, 1 Cor. 11:10.

⁵⁶1 Kg. 8:28-30.

⁵⁷Rom. 10:18.

⁵⁸Jos. 3:1-6.

⁵⁹Ex. 5:6-18.

⁶⁰1 Cor. 10:4, Is. 28:16, Dan. 2:45, Zech. 3:9.



for the thirst of the many was quenched by
the piercing of his side.⁶¹

It is not the flow of blood through veins
but the rays of light from on high
penetrating and becoming one with it
that give the Church life and renewal.
It is not masterful art of Solomon or Zuraba-
bel,⁶²

but the wisdom of God who holds all in his
hands
that designs the Church.

It is not with the unconsecrated and common
oil of Jacob
that is applied to it, but with the awesome
blood and glory of the great God that it is
anointed.⁶³

It is not a house made with the things of
earth,⁶⁴
but rather the body of the heavenly light of
God

where he baptizes and ordains its children.

The Church nurtures not those born to the
ways of the world,⁶⁵

but rather those who are heirs to the
heavenly kingdom,⁶⁶

so that she might offer to the bosom of Abra-
ham

those raised in her care.⁶⁷

The bridegroom of her wedding day is the
Son of the living God.

And the rejoicing entourage of bride's maids
are the
assembly of patriarchs.⁶⁸

She makes us forget the high places of pagan
worship where demons dwell, so that only God
in heaven might be worshiped.

She is the complete refutation of the images
of pagan gods for in her every stone Christ is

exalted.⁶⁹

She is the open destruction of the self-
indulgent
nymph cults of the forest, so that above all
other trees
of this world, the Lord might be offered,
like the tree of life, in the Church.⁷⁰

She undermines all the false, magical,
fertility idols
because in her and with her the adored rock
is established, set in light-giving rubies and
living stones.⁷¹

h

This graceful, God-pleasing house is free of all
servility.⁷²

It is not the image of Zion on high, but rather
the true Zion as experienced in reality.

It is not a pagan fire altar or

a place of penance under the yoke of the Law,⁷³
but rather the Lord's table which we kiss offer-
ing thanks

for his loving-kindness. It is unshakable,
never taking on a different image but rather
grows ever greater in the same radiant glory,
proclaiming the heavens and representing
heaven on earth in brilliant light.

Just as without the Father, there is no Christ,
so without the womb of the mother Church,
the soul cannot be fulfilled.⁷⁴

The infinite God would wander were it not for
the shelter of the tabernacle of this house of
prayer.⁷⁵

The Lord of all would have no place to rest his
head,⁷⁶

⁶¹Jn. 19:34, Ex. 17:6. The piercing of Christ side on the Cross may be being compared the quenching of the thirst of the Israelites, when Moses struck the rock with his staff at Horeb.

⁶²1 Kg. 6:15-32, 1 Esd. 5:56-58.

⁶³Gen. 28:18.

⁶⁴Not "Beth-El," Gen. 28:19.

⁶⁵Jn. 1:13.

⁶⁶Jas. 2:5.

⁶⁷Lk. 16:22.

⁶⁸Rev. 21:2, 9-14.

⁶⁹Is. 54:11, Rev. 21:10, 19-20, Lk. 19:40.

⁷⁰Gen. 2:9.

⁷¹Rev. 21:9-21. Christ dwells in the Apostles and saints of the Church.

⁷²Gal. 3:26.

⁷³Num. 16:16-35.

⁷⁴Jn. 3:1-12. K?chichian, p. 407, n. 2, cites a parallel in St. Cyprian (d. 258) "Habere non potest Deum Patrem, qui Ecclesiam non habet matrem" (De Catholicae Ecclesiae Unitate, c. 6).

⁷⁵2 Sam. 7:6.

⁷⁶Mt. 8:20.



if he did not lodge at this inn of life.
 He is more honored in this material dwelling
 place
 than in the vault of heaven on high.
 The infinity of the divine light
 that covered the face of the prophet and those
 with him⁷⁷ caused people to flee because the
 glorious
 radiance was overwhelming, whereas here in
 the Church,
 while celebrating those very prophets,
 they approach the light and sing praise with
 the host of angels. Here in the Church, God's
 good will
 and repeated blessings exceed the splendor of
 paradise.

I

This spiritual, heavenly mother of light
 cared for me as a son more than a earthly,
 breathing, physical mother could.
 The milk of her bosom was the blood of Christ.
 If one were to consider her the image of the
 Mother
 of God, it would not be impious.
 Like the sign of the cross of salvation with
 amazing
 powers and handiwork, it performs miracles.
 The terrifying tribunal of the last judgment
 is established there visibly.
 Through her the babbling mouths of immoral
 heretics
 are silenced.
 She also has intelligent, speaking stones,
 by which she chases away the beastly and un-
 clean.⁷⁸
 She gives birth to godly mortals,⁷⁹
 saints in the image of the sole God, Christ.⁸⁰
 She faces east, our first place of habitation.⁸¹
 She points the way to the second coming of
 God,
 and making us face east guides us toward
 the Lord's brilliant light.⁸²

⁷⁷Ex. 34:29-35, 40:34-35.

⁷⁸Ex. 19:13, Heb. 12:20, 2 Macc. 1:16, 3:24-40.

⁷⁹Jn. 1:12, 10:34-35.

⁸⁰Rom. 8:29, 2 Cor. 3:18.

⁸¹Gen. 2:8

⁸²Mt. 24:27.

The dawn and rising of the sun foreshadow
 for the creatures of earth the vision of Christ
 on the day of the last judgment.
 She drives away pain, heals the infirm, over-
 comes
 the tyranny of demons.
 Like a jubilant bridal party the twelve apostles
 encircle her the life-giving fountain, the womb
 of life.
 So much have her blessings and bliss increased
 and flourished that she has been called by the
 name of
 the Savior himself⁸³
 and by those close to the only begotten Son,
 she was consecrated in the name the radiant
 Mother of God.
 For sinners tossing about on the sea, she is a
 safe harbor;
 for the heavenly choirs, a place of jubilation.
 For the perplexed mortal, a place of sure heal-
 ing.
 The Holy Trinity, beyond telling, is glorified in
 her,
 the blessed in all.

Iu

And woe to him who raises a hand in malice
 against the heavenly kingdom as if
 the doctrine of the church made by hands,
 were some physical invention
 or human artifact or earthly handiwork,
 and not the gift of life and reflection of the
 divine,⁸⁴
 a foreshadow of the renewing light revealed by
 the Holy Spirit, and the abundant gifts of God
 on high,
 the altar honoring the mystery of the will of
 the creator.
 and the institution founded with wisdom by
 the right
 hand of the apostles, in a word, the gate of
 heaven,⁸⁵
 the city of the living God,⁸⁶

⁸³A reference to churches named, for example, Sb. Amenaprkich – Holy Savior, or Sb. Astvatsatsin, or Sb. Etchmiadzin, the Mother See of the Armenian Church.

⁸⁴Some versions have “expectation of the divine.”

⁸⁵Gen. 28:17.

⁸⁶Heb. 12:22.



the mother of all living things, free of all sin,⁸⁷
and the true model of our visible, thinking
being.

Her intellectual part is the mystery of our
souls.

Her palpable part is the image of our bodies.
And a new holiness surpassing the holiness of
old⁸⁸

and crowned with the brilliantly glorious sign
of Christ.

Those who do not confess this
are expelled from the Almighty's presence
by the hand of his consubstantial Word,
depriving them of the inheritance of grace
from the co-glorified Holy Spirit,
and closing before them the doors to the
bridal chamber of life.

And we who have written this bear witness to
it

and believe in what we have composed here,⁸⁹
in the name of and for the glory of the almighty
Trinity

and of the one Godhead,
forever and ever.

Amen.

The first prayer was my credo to the Holy
Trinity⁹⁰ and this prayer my avowed profession
of faith to my Mother Church glorified with
light.

Prayer 76 (ՏԶ)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

U

God whose mercies are diverse and abundant,
mighty and awesome God who loves mankind,
blessed living God beyond description
whose mere word can make anything possible
and for whose mind nothing is unthinkable.¹

⁸⁷Gal. 4:26.

⁸⁸Heb. 9:1-5.

⁸⁹2 Cor. 4:13, Ps. 116 (Arm. 114-115):10.

⁹⁰St. Gregory appears to be referring to Prayer 34
above.

¹Mt. 19:26.

You alone can repay the severity of thorns
with sweetness of fruit.

You who are the author of that new and
amazing law of life:

to do good to those who hate

and pray for those who persecute

and to seek salvation for those who wound

and ask forgiveness for those who murder.

These are the miraculous fruits you bestow,²
with sweetness beyond compare

made delectable by your divine will

and savory by your praiseworthy lips,

Lord Christ, blessed on high

breath of our nostrils,³

and the strength of our dignity.⁴

Yet still, human beings, earth-born prone
to err

render evil to the hand offering good,⁵

but you, light and giver of light,

do not heed the blasphemy, take no pleasure

in evil, do not want their destruction and

do not wish these sinners' death.⁶

Neither are you vexed or agitated,

nor do you succumb to anger.

Nor do you act rashly.

Nor do you wane in love.

Nor do you waver in compassion.

Nor do you change in goodness.

Neither do you turn your back

or turn your face away.⁷

Rather you are light on all paths

with the sole aim of salvation.

¶

If you wish to pardon, you are able.

If to heal, you have the power.

To give life, you have the means.

To bestow, you are generous.

To make whole, you are able.

To grant, you are most bountiful.

To justify, you are most resourceful.

²Mt. 5:44.

³Lam. 4:20.

⁴Ps. 28 (Arm. 29):8.

⁵Ps. 38 (Arm. 37):21.

⁶Wis. 1:13, Ez. 18:32.

⁷Jer. 2:27.



To comfort, you are all powerful.
 To renew, you are all capable.
 To perform a miracle, you are king of all.
 To establish anew, you are the creator.
 To re-create, you are God.
 To care for us, you are Lord of all.
 To rid us of sin, you are a guardian.
 To aid us, though unworthy, you are blessed.
 To rescue from the hunter, you are our savior.
 To pour yours upon us, you are rich.
 To reach us before we ask, you lack nothing.
 To widen the narrow places, you are a comfort.
 To call me who am last, you are a protector.
 To steady me who wavers, you are a rock.
 To give me a drink when parched,
 you are a fountain.
 To reveal to me what is covered, you are light.
 To teach me what is useful, you are kind.
 To overlook my faults, you are long-suffering.
 To refrain from judging my minor transgressions,
 you are exalted.
 To lend a hand to a servant like me,
 you are good master.
 To shelter with your right hand, you are a provider.
 To offer a remedy to me who am infirm,
 you are a restorer.
 To fill me when ignorant, you are a teacher.⁸
 To accept me when I petition, you are a refuge.

¶

Indeed, all these are yours, Lord of mercy,
 not just in words, but also in reality,
 especially are you foremost among
 the martyrs in your patient suffering,
 you, who for my salvation
 came to the battlefield in force to soften
 the stiff-necked unruliness of my haughty body
 with the tempering instruction of tormenting
 tribulation
 and taking our nature, bore on your blameless
 body
 the penalty of grievous torment
 in order to teach by your example
 the mercy you have for us.

⁸Lk. 11:1.

Ever blessed.
 Amen.

Prayer 77 (ՏԷ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

Since today is a blessed day,
 when morning came twice dividing day into
 equal parts,¹
 when the passing creatures of the earth
 were transformed into a different and heavenly
 immutable beings,²
 when the high were laid low and the
 humble raised up,³
 making this the most awesome day of Lent,
 Holy Friday,
 when it is fitting for me to write
 this prayer voicing joy mixed with terror, there-
 fore
 I think it appropriate to speak now of
 the suffering you endured for me, God of all.

¶

You stood, with my nature, before a tribunal of
 your creatures,⁴ and did not speak, giver of
 speech.
 You did not utter a word, creator of tongues.
 You did not release your voice, shaker of the
 world.
 You did not make a sound, trumpet of majesty.
 You did not answer back with accounts of
 your good deeds.
 You did not silence them with their wrongs.
 You did not deliver your betrayer to death.
 You did not struggle when bound.
 You did not squirm when whipped.
 You did not fight back when spat upon.
 You did not resist when beaten.
 You did not take affront when mocked.
 You did not frown when ridiculed.

¹Zech. 14:7, Mk. 15:33.

²Mt. 27:51-52.

³Rev. 21:1.

⁴Mt. 26:57-66, 27:11-26, Lk. 23:8-12.



They stripped you of your cloak, as from a weakling,
and dressed you like a condemned prisoner.⁵
If my Lord had not been forced twice to drink vinegar and gall,⁶ he would not have been able to cleanse me of the accumulated bile of our forefathers.⁷
He tasted heartbreak and did not waver.
They dragged him violently and brought him back disrespectfully.
They condemned him, humiliated him by flogging
before a motley crowd.
They knelt before him in ridicule
and put a crown of disdain upon his head.



They gave you no rest, Life-giver,
even forcing you to bear the instrument of your death.
You accepted with forbearance.
You received it with sweetness.
You bore it with patience.
You submitted to the wooden cross of grief,
like one condemned.
Like a lily of the field, you shouldered the weapon of life,⁸
so that your throne in my body might be protected
against the terrors of the night⁹
turning the last judgment into a joyful banquet.
They led him out like a sacrificial lamb.
They hung him like Isaac's ram whose horns were caught in the thicket.¹⁰
They spread him on the table of the cross like a sacrifice.
They nailed him like a common criminal.

⁵Mt. 27:28-31, Mk. 15:20.

⁶Mt. 27:34, Mk. 15:23, Mt. 27:48, Jn. 19:29; St. Gregory changes to the third person singular here, after addressing the first part of his prayer in the second person to Christ.

⁷Cf. Adam's original sin.

⁸S. of S. 2:1, Mt. 6:28.

⁹Sleep is the analog of death upon which there is judgment.

¹⁰Gen. 22:13.

They persecuted you, like an outlaw, treating you in your serenity, like a bandit,¹¹
you in your majesty, like a miserable wretch,
you who are adored by cherubim,
like a despised man,¹²
you who are the definition of life, like one deserving of a slaughter,
you, the author of the Gospels, like one who blasphemed the Law,¹³
you, the Lord and the fulfillment of the prophets,
like one who cut the Scriptures,¹⁴
you, the radiance of glory and the image of the mystery of the Father, beyond mortal understanding, as if you are the adversary of the will of him who bore you,¹⁵
you who are blessed, like someone banished,
you who came to release the bonds of the Law,
like a heretic,¹⁶
you, the consuming fire, like a condemned prisoner,¹⁷
you who inspire awe in heaven and earth,
like one deserving punishment,¹⁸
you, covered in unapproachable light, like some earthly quarry.¹⁹



O, sweet Lord,
forbearing doer of good, merciful and compassionate,
Lord of all, who for the sake of infirm and unruly
servants like me submitted to everything willingly
according to your plan
together with your perfectly human body,
submitted even to the sleepy tomb of the sepulchre,
who lack nothing of divine perfection, being identical with

¹¹Mt. 26:55.

¹²Is. 53:3.

¹³Mt. 26:65-66.

¹⁴Mt. 5:17.

¹⁵Heb. 1:3.

¹⁶Gal. 3:13.

¹⁷Dt. 4:24.

¹⁸Is. 53:4.

¹⁹1 Tim. 6:16.



God who is beyond human understanding,
yet bore human indignity with patience beyond
words,
you rose with your body, alive and of your own
power,
in exalted light, with undiminished humanity
and flawless divinity.
You are blessed for your glory
praised for your compassion,
and always exalted for your mercy,
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 78 (ՏԸ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

And now, fallen down upon my face with my
earthly nature, humbly on my knees in wor-
ship,
I kiss the life-giving feet of your mercifulness,
doer of good.¹
Offering this to your majesty,
I pray you, my sole keeper, who loves
mankind,
compassionate, giver of life, mighty God, who
rescues and protects us.

May your suffering for our salvation not
be in vain,
God, who became man for my sake.
May the sweat mixed with blood on the night
of your
betrayal not be without purpose.²
May the gifts of your light not be eclipsed,
gifts
that you have given freely and without com-
pensation to
a wretch like me.
May the good news of your grace renewed by
the blood
drops from your side not be erased.³

¹Lk. 7:38.

²Lk. 22:44.

³Jn. 19:34.

May the fruit of your suffering, offered for my
neediness,
not be senseless.
May the banished Deceiver not dare
to possess me, whom you have made.

Բ

Indeed, you vanquish the desires of the Evil
One
by your will.
You confound anew the one whom you once
cast out
and again defeat completely the one con-
demned.⁴
Do not hold back your words of salvation,
which being offered to you
return your own creatures to you.

You have done good works beyond telling
at the unexpected moment of despair,
when all movement of life had ceased and
disappeared,
you who are immortal died and brought the
dead
back to life.⁵
If you changed the Old Testament rule of
“an eye for an eye,”⁶ do not now block the
easier,
more flexible and yet more
feasible rule,
O source of mercy, compassionate, blessed and
forbearing King.
Say the word, by which with almighty force,
you brought light into existence on the first
day,⁷
and I will immediately be made well.⁸
And though I have failed to follow your light,
may you visit me anyway in the form of your
Father’s
radiant dawn,⁹ and may I, an unworthy servant,
be su-
moned before you for your mercy and grace.

⁴Rev. 20:10.

⁵Lk. 7:14, Mk. 5:41, Jn. 11:43.

⁶Mt. 5:38-43.

⁷Gen. 1:3.

⁸Mt. 8:2.

⁹Heb. 1:3.



The time has run out for paying my debts,
so turn your face toward me, when I am in
pain,
you who lighten the darkness for the disheart-
ened.¹⁰

Block and seal the escape routes
through which your good things drain away
from my memory.
Preserve in me the grace of your permanently
sparkling treasure by which I might be found
worthy
to be called yours
and be protected by your boundless goodness.

q.

Have mercy upon me, compassionate Lord, I
pray you.
Have mercy upon me, almighty Lord, again
have mercy.
Do not repay my wrongdoing with pain, O
Lord who is good in all ways.
Do not take from me the grace you have given.
Do not snatch away the breath of the all-
blessed
Holy Spirit.
Do not erase the venerable stamp of your ma-
jestic image.
Do not raise the thorns of sin in the purity of
my mind.¹¹
Do not cut the tie that binds me to you with
steadfast love.
Do not deprive me of the powerful art of
speech.
Do not weaken the ability of my right hand
to distribute the parcels of your light.¹²
Do not enter my death sentence in your book
of life.¹³
Do not record my sins and assess them to me.
Do not recollect them and do not embarrass
me with them.
Do not blame me and do not trample me.
Do not register my infirmity.
Do not gather my destructive acts.

¹⁰Jn. 1:5.

¹¹Is. 5:6, 1 Macc. 4:36.

¹²The Eucharist, or perhaps his writings.

¹³Rev. 20:12.

Do not accuse me like some criminal.
Do not let the tree of damnation grow within
me.
Do not unleash in me the branches of destruc-
tion.
Do not let the buds of my sins blossom.
Do not demand payment on my debt note.
Do not permit these sins to mature into evil
fruits.
Do not count my prolific misdeeds on the tree
branches,
the fingers of the earth you created.
Do not pronounce your awesome word to con-
front me with my iniquity.¹⁴
Do not permit my willfulness to betray my soul
into slavery.
Do not honor me here, only to condemn me in
the hereafter.
Do not let the lesser, passing things of this
world
diminish my eternal good.
Do not measure the endless glory to come by
the meager intervals of the here and now.
Do not pawn the incorruptible life for the val-
ley
of sighing grief.
Do not exchange your light beyond words for
the
shadows of the darkness here.
Do not drop the reins of my soul to follow my
wayward tracks.
Do not deem the bridge of my passing life as
sufficient repose for me.
Do not keep the well of my mind in the shad-
ows
only to be cleared when it is too late in the
life to come.
If you were to add all of my innumerable mis-
deeds,
I would be the living dead.
If you were to take this all to heart,
I would be spontaneously consumed in flame-
less fire.
If you were to examine my iniquities,
I would completely melt away, without even
coming before you.

¹⁴Mt. 25:41-45.



If you were to allow the sprouts of sin to grow with me,
I would be choked off by them and waste away.

¶

Always powerful, almighty God,
glance my way, so that
the sins within me might be set to flight,
so that your goodness might come in their stead.

O compassionate God, praiseworthy provider,
inextinguishable light, with unbounded power,
command that the essence of my nature be
established anew under the roof of my body
and its parts, in order
that you might dwell here with happy fervor,
and stay without ever leaving,
uniting my soul with you and
banishing completely the corruption of sin,
immortal king, Lord Jesus Christ, who gives
life to all,
blessed forever.
Amen.

Prayer 79 (ՏԹ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

Remember, Lord, Lord of mercies,
who loves justice, true God,
to look again upon me in my ever erring
human condition.
Check again the circulation of my blood
throughout my body.
Like a physician examine me,
for I am a man possessed of an unripe mind
filled
with faulty thoughts
as you yourself know, seer of the non-existent,¹
for you
alone are devoid of the darkness of falsehood.
This is why it is more proper to record me

¹Gen. 8:21.

among sinners,
I who repeatedly succumb to the weaknesses of
human frailty
like all other mortals born of the flesh on earth,
otherwise your word might appear false.²
For you indeed know that
“they were made evil and their wickedness is
innate,
and their way of thinking will never change,”³
as the learned man, wise in the ways of the
soul,
observed long ago in his writings.

¶

Ease the severity of the torment
that awaits me and
those children of hell, the ornaments of eternal
death.⁴
Lift away my shameful sins
that are kept to reprimand me, wretch that I
am,
at the tribunal of the last judgment.

Let it be for my peace that my punish-
ment has already been given by your mercy,⁵
so that unbearable terror does not loom before
me
and hopelessness might not overwhelm
life-giving contrition.

Terrifying day of judgment,
judge that cannot be bought or deceived,
awful shame, fearsome rebuke,
inescapable reprimand, unavoidable torment,
terror that cannot be comforted,
trembling that cannot be stilled,
inconsolable weeping, incurable gnashing of
teeth,⁶
untreatable disease,
the curse of your awesome divine word,⁷
the shutting down of compassion, cutting off
of mercy.

²Ps. 51 (Arm. 50):6.

³Wis. 12:10.

⁴Mt. 23:15.

⁵Is. 53:5.

⁶Mt. 25:30.

⁷Mt. 25:41.



At the time when the heavens will be rolled up
like a scroll⁸
and the earth will be shaken to its very founda-
tions,
and billowing waves of the tempestuous sea,
pursue each other, crash against each other and
counteract each other's force,
jolting and shaking
the foundations of the earth's thick surface
across its expanse
with forceful blows to its very core
and with thunderous sound,
laying the mountains low,
and melting the substance of stone with fire,
with all the other elements of nature at that
time:

then the heavens will be cleared in pu-
rity
and the creatures together with all their ele-
ments
will be recreated in new form
and our hidden misdeeds will be made known⁹
and our invisible passions will be revealed
the conduct of each person's inner beliefs
will be displayed on our bodies¹⁰
and the king of heaven will sit at his tribunal
with the due sentence in his hands.¹¹

¶

Woe to me, sevenfold woe!
An endless perdition in the measure of this ci-
pher, seven,
that symbolizes the infinity of numbers.¹²
What shall my pitiful soul do on the solemn
day of peril?
For the thought of what lies ahead is worse than
the event itself.
As one of the prophets vividly wrote,
it is as if one were to escape from the clutches
of a lion,
only to run into a bear,

⁸Rev. 6:14.

⁹Is. 65:17, Rev. 21:1,5.

¹⁰Lk. 8:17.

¹¹Mt. 25:31.

¹²Rev. 8:13 (in the Middle Ages, the number 7 was associated with infinity).

and fleeing the bear,
you enter a house and lean against the wall,
only to have a hand bitten by a snake.¹³
And he makes the situation yet more terrify-
ing,
saying, "Indeed, the Day of the Lord is dark-
ness" ¹⁴
"That Day is gloom and darkness, a day of
clouds and thick fog." ¹⁵

¶

When the guardian angel who is our compan-
ion
for life,¹⁶
accuses us like a stern official
and the awesome judge justly reprimands us,
the king's servants rush about without delay,
inviting some to life and condemning others to
shame,
showing to some a cheerful face,
but to me appearing fearsome and horrifying.
To some they shall offer a halo of glistening
light,
and others mortal perdition.
To the just, the voice of good news,
but to me, the sad news of endless grief.
When for the good, the victory of death itself
expires,¹⁷
for me, wayward soul, it is repeatedly ex-
tended.
At that point knocking at the door will do no
good,
for my quota of mercy will have run out.¹⁸

There, when the amazing and miraculous
book is
opened, showing all manner of hitherto hidden
acts done by mankind and
the conduct of our human nature,
for which reason all beings were created,
then upon each body all this shall be manifest
in full,¹⁹

¹³Am. 5:19.

¹⁴Am. 5:18, 20.

¹⁵Zeph. 1:15.

¹⁶Ps. 34 (Arm. 33):7.

¹⁷1 Cor. 15:54-55, Rev. 20:14.

¹⁸Mt. 25:11-13, Lk. 13:25.

¹⁹1 Cor. 3:13.



so that before our eyes shall ineffably appear,²⁰
that which is sealed away from the comprehension of this world.

Here, heaven can be found at the cost of lamentations and tears,
there, these are despised and rejected like so much untimely vanity.

The sighs of the heart that are not delivered now

will not be accepted later.

Kindness sparingly sown²¹

shall not light the way before us.

There, the loud-voiced accusers shall be
the ark against the lawless of the time of Noah,
and the Old Testament against those who
blasphemed the Lord, along with the awe-
inspiring sign

of the cross against us now.

I will be accused

first for breaking the natural law of our earliest
forebears,

second for dishonoring the tabernacle of
worship to the invisible spirit, and

third for the blood of great God.

And I also accuse myself.

How shall I be consoled when my hope is cut
short?

For if the forces of light, the ranks of the just,
who are glorified in benedictions, tremble in
fear,

and cannot bear the terrifying face of the great
judge,

how shall I come before him, miserable wretch
that I am,

a disinherited son condemned to death,

who does not expect a halo

but unbearable punishment

and endless ruin?

᠖

Hasten to extend your hand of salvation to me,
for I am captured by the Destroyer,

Lord almighty beyond words, who gives all
things.

For with your help, I might turn back from the

gates of hell, and properly armed, I might es-
cape

punishment completely without harm,

seeing with my mind's eye the things to come,

I am already sufficiently chastened

by the terrifying reports of awful tortures that
await me.

By your good will, I might be saved unscathed,
and not thrown to the young lions,

who beg for me as food,

so they can devour me with their ferocious
teeth

and fill their womb of death with me.

They, who have grown fat in this world,

will digest me and drag me away to the store-
house

of surplus sin, there to consume me forever in
torment.

For you alone are able to wrest me from the
jaws of death, and deliver me to everlasting life
and bliss,

refuge of all, king of light,

Lord Jesus Christ, blessed forever.

Amen.

Prayer 80 (2)

*Speaking with God from the Depths of the
Heart*

᠒

And now, after all this despair

and terrible heartbreak,

angry reprimands and divine wrath,

with a soul completely tormented by grief,

I pray to you, Holy Mother of God,

herald to mankind, angel in bodily form,

heavenly queen,

pure as air, clean as light,

clear as the image of the sun at its height,

higher than the forbidden dwelling place of the
holy of holies,¹

place of the blessed covenant, a breathing
Eden,²

tree of immortality, guarded by a fiery sword,³

¹Heb. 9:7.

²Gen. 12:7, Gen. 2:8.

³Gen. 3:24.

²⁰Rev. 20:12.

²¹2 Cor. 9:6.



strengthened and protected by the exalted Father,
 prepared and purified by the Holy Spirit that
 rested upon you,⁴ adorned by the Son who
 dwelt
 in you as his tabernacle,⁵
 only Son of the Father, and for you the first
 born,⁶
 your Son by birth, and your Lord by creation,
 together with your unsoiled purity, spotless
 goodness,
 together with your immaculate holiness,
 guardian intercessor.
 Receive these prayers from me, who believe in
 you.
 Together with my ode to you⁷
 offer and present them to God as your own.

Weave and mix into your prayers of hap-
 piness
 and adoration the bitter sighs that I, a sinner,
 utter,
 you, who are the tree of life bearing the blessed
 fruit,⁸
 so that always receiving help from you and
 through your
 good deeds, and taking refuge in the light of
 your
 holy motherhood,
 I may live for Christ, your Son and Lord.

¶

Assist me on your wings of prayer,
 you, proclaimed Mother of all the living,⁹
 so that my departure from this earthly valley
 may be without torment, leading to life in the
 lodgings
 you have prepared,¹⁰ that my death might be
 light,
 though I am weighed down by iniquity.

⁴Lk. 1:35.

⁵Jn. 1:14.

⁶Lk. 2:7.

⁷St. Gregory wrote an Ode to the Mother of God in 984.

⁸Lk. 1:42.

⁹Gen. 3:20.

¹⁰Jn. 14:2-3.

Make the day of my anguish a festive
 holiday,
 you, healer of the sorrow of Eve.¹¹
 Speak on my behalf, beg and beseech for my
 sake,
 for as I believe your purity is beyond words,
 I also believe in the power of your words.¹²

Blessed among women, I am in trouble.
 Help me with your tears.
 Ask on bended knee for my reconciliation,
 Mother of God.¹³
 Care for me who am miserable, altar of the
 exalted.
 Lend me a hand, for I have fallen, heavenly
 temple.
 Glorify your Son,
 by performing upon me the divine miracle of
 mercy and pardon, handmaid and Mother of
 God.¹⁴

¶

Magnify your honor through me,
 and my salvation will be manifested through
 you
 if you find me, Madonna,
 if you pity me, blessed among women,
 if you rescue me in my waywardness,
 immaculate one,
 if you care for me in my fear, happy one,
 if you lift my head bowed in shame, good
 grace,
 if you intercede for me in my despair,
 ever Holy Virgin,
 if you include me in my rejection, exalted of
 God,
 if you show me kindness, undoer of malice,
 if you steady me in my doubt, repose,
 if you calm my anxiety, pacifier,
 if you show me the way from which
 I have strayed, praised one,
 if you appear before the tribunal for me,
 vanquisher of death,
 if you mellow my bitterness, sweetness,

¹¹Gen. 3:16.

¹²Jn. 2:3-5.

¹³Lk. 1:42-43.

¹⁴Lk. 1:38.



if you eliminate my separation from God,
 reconciliation,
 if you lift away my uncleanness, you who
 stamp out corruption,
 if you save me in my condemnation, living
 light,
 if you cut off the sound of my wailing, bliss,
 if you restore me, for I am broken, salve of life,
 if you look upon me in my ruin, you filled
 with the Spirit,
 if you visit me with compassion, legacy given
 us.¹⁵
 You alone shall be on the pure lips of happy
 tongues.
 Indeed if but a drop of your virgin milk
 were to rain on me, it would give me life,
 Mother of our exalted Lord Jesus,
 creator of heaven and earth,
 whom you bore complete in humanity and
 total in divinity,
 who is glorified with the Father and the Holy
 Spirit,
 uniting his essence and our nature in a manner
 beyond human understanding.
 He is all and in all, one of the Holy Trinity.¹⁶
 To him glory, forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 81 (2U)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Accept, kind and merciful God,
 with the prayers of the Mother of God,
 the petitions of the immortal angels, adorned
 in light,
 which sing, without ceasing, with their pure
 mouths
 in constant intercession for my sake.
 The angels are virtuous, created good by you,
 doer of good,
 They are ignorant of evil, established by your
 command, which rules all, God who is.

¹⁵Jn. 19:27.

¹⁶Col. 3:11.

They are a mighty force at your disposal,
 exalted God,
 holy, pure, spotless, blessed,
 splendid, victorious and invincible,
 swift as a flash of the mind.

These guardian angels serve us and plead
 for us,
 just as for the barren fig tree¹
 that did not give fruit for three years,
 an eternity encompassing past, present and
 future,
 for a long period it took root
 in the vineyard of this world,
 decorated with useless foliage, but gave no
 fruit.
 And this is the very image of wretched
 mankind.

The angels brood over us constantly.
 They aid us in our frailty.²
 They tend our portion of virtue
 with everlasting life they pray for our salva-
 tion,
 saying these words: "Forsake not the work
 of your hands."³
 For truly, this prayer is ours.
 You, God on high arranged for them
 to say this for our sake,
 for they were created by the word,
 and we by the action of your hand.⁴
 They shall come with your only begotten Son,
 as fearsome witnesses at the last judgment,⁵
 true accusers of the sins of earthly beings,
 before the terrifying tribunal,
 justly and fairly counseling us.
 There too, they sympathize with us, pleading
 with sighs,
 the perpetual chant of their voices:
 Have mercy, you who created them.
 Do not destroy them.⁶

¹Lk. 13:6-9.

²Book of Tobit, where the Angel Raphael comes to the aid of the persecuted, but righteous Tobit.

³Ps. 138 (Arm. 137):8.

⁴Gen. 2:7.

⁵Mt. 25:31.

⁶per K?chichian, p. 434, n. 2, this phrase is a citation from a hymn to the angels in the Armenian Ritual.



P

Now, with their voices in thanksgiving
and their prayers, immortal and sublime,
inhale also the savory scent of our sighs,
creator of all.

You exceed those above and below with
your compassion,
since from you flow all good deeds for us and
for them.

And for the sake of the splendor of the
incorruptible beings, miraculous in their fiery
forms,⁷

unadulterated purity, sinless, made of fire and
spirit, invincible, with the immense advantage
of

their higher status,
their abundant, brilliant knowledge,
fervent with an ardor that does not cool,
with an innate passion for the love of God,
like them, may our cold, smoldering hearts,
be rekindled brightly at the sublime mystery of
the holy table, which is your sanctuary,
and without drowsiness or lethargy,
may we await the blessed command
of your life-giving will, creator of all,
to be united with God inseparably
in cherubic virtue.

They are the great heavenly principalities,
soldiers, pure and awesome,
the virtuous and noble ministers in your
heavenly kingdom,
the glimmering rays of your cloud of light,
God on high.

Q

Through them, Jesus, show your merciful
love for mankind
for me also, sinner born of earth that I am.
Through the prayers of my guardian angel
turn me toward the good path of your light,
so that the inheritance of my soul
which you entrusted to his protection,
may be received by you from this life,
with a joyous heart, jubilant within me,

⁷Heb. 1:7.

blameless and blessed by you,⁸
might he bring me forward and present me
with a glad and cheerful face,
to you, praised and merciful Lord,
sublime king of glory beyond comprehension,
in the midst of the blissful choir in tumultuous
jubilation.

And to you, who are beyond understand-
ing,
with your Father, beyond reach,
and your Holy Spirit beyond words –
glory, honor and adoration,
unto the ages of ages.
Amen.

Prayer 82 (2P)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Lord God, doer of good, generous king,
refuge of life, form of light,
spacious place of repose,
who for the sake of sinners like me
came, took the form of man
accomplishing things beyond telling
and performed miracles,
even perfecting our humanity¹
with the fullness of your divinity.

Now for the holy apostles,
whom you ordained with your heavenly hand,²
and anointed by your Holy Spirit,³
whose deserving praises I have sung
as much as I could
for your glory, Lord of all, in another work.⁴
Have mercy upon me in the memory of your
chosen.

⁸Mt. 25:34.

¹Heb. 5:9; 12:2.

²Lk. 24:50.

³Acts 2:3-4.

⁴St. Gregory appears to be referring to his Ode to the Apostles and the sixty-six disciples in his Ode to the Cross and the Holy Virgin, dated between 984 and 1000. Critical Edition, p. 1100, n. 4.



Through them prepare for me a way to the
most desired bliss.

May the voice of these good shepherds
be heard beckoning me sweetly to eternal life.
May I partake of the jubilant hope
of everlasting salvation
with the lives of our leaders, the first to be
graced with this honor,
the glorified choir, the spiritual rivers,
the sublime evangelists, the illustrious princes,
those with sparkling crowns,
and those adorned in the untarnished
brilliant radiance of the strength of grace, yes,
those who have been made perfect with
the oil of gladness, your lordly light.



Together with your disciples,
Christ God on high,
and the self-sacrifice of your chosen martyrs,
who through mortification and torments of the
flesh,
and peril to life and limb and all manner of suf-
fering,
and who despite their earthly nature
struggled against every element of material ex-
istence to
win halos, transcending and reborn in spirit,
courageously. They departed this world, as
the prophets said,
as true witnesses to the trials and tribulations of
death.

They comprehended the unequivocal good,
unseen and hidden,
even in this world with the hope of things
seen.⁵

The disciples of the apostles and their
companions in suffering
are also equal to them in their works
and in their consummate and utter perfection
are jubilant with endless bliss.
By their pleasing and acceptable pleading,
honoring their prayers as a blood-drenched sac-
rifice of dedicated service

⁵Heb. 11:1.

offered with the incense of sweat,
accept me again to share their lot
and be established in you with everlasting sal-
vation.



Though a sinner deserving of punishment,
accept me,
together with those who fight with fire and
sword,
covered in blood, and together with the holy as-
cetics,
hermit fathers, and your other followers, Son
of God,
all who with invincible bravery and
undistracted vigilance, have courageously
struggled
against the baseness of the body
and fended off the bodiless Satan.
In the perpetual battlefield of our earthly life
without being worn down
upon the waves of this expansive worldly sea,
despite the heaviness of their bodily ark,
they sent their souls soaring in lightness,
reaching the safe haven of eternal life.
And like those who love the celestial realm,
truly and boldly, without reservations,
they have crowned themselves with
the tiara of victory, adorned with brilliant
gems.⁶
By grace of their worthy prayers and
dedicated supplications,
accept me too.



Mixing my impure words
with the glorious prayers of the blessed,
who for my sake call out to you in a pleasing
manner,
I too call out with them,
sour notes amidst the sweet,
thorns amidst the smoothness,
ugliness amidst splendor,
filth amidst glistening diamonds,
impurities amidst pure gold,
worthless rocks amidst silver,

⁶Phil. 3:13.



contradictions amidst the truth,
grains of sand amidst the soft bread.

Listen, mighty, ingenious, praised, Lord,
to their prayers for me and mine for them,
for their praise, my salvation, and for your
glory,
O Lord, all-compassionate, doer of good,
blessed,
long-suffering, potent, beyond understanding,
beyond words, incorruptible and uncreated.
Yours are the gifts, and yours is grace.
You are the beginning and cause of all good.

ⲉ

You are not the accuser, but the liberator,⁷
not the destroyer, but the rescuer,
not the executioner, but the savior,⁸
not the scatterer, but the gatherer,⁹
not the traitor, but the deliverer.
You do not pull down, but lift up.
You do not knock down, but stand upright.
You do not curse, but bless.
You do not take revenge, but give grace.
You do not torment, but comfort.
You do not erase, but write.
You do not shake, but steady.
You do not trample, but console.
You do not invent the causes of death,
but seek the means to preserve life.
You do not forget to help.
You do not abandon the good.
You do not withhold compassion.
You do not bring the sentence of death, but
the legacy of life.
You are not opposed for your generosity.
You are not blasphemed for your grace.
You are not cursed for your bounty.
You are not insulted for your free gifts.
You are not mocked for your patience.
You are not blamed for your pardon.
You are not accused for your goodness.
You are not dishonored for your sweetness.
You are not despised for your meekness.
For these, we send not complaints,

⁷Jn. 8:11, Lk. 9:56.

⁸Jn. 10:10.

⁹Lk. 15:4.

but gratitude that cannot be silenced.
Take away my sins, Almighty.
Remove the curse from me, blessed.
Pardon my debts, merciful.
Erase my transgressions, compassionate.
Extend your hand of deliverance
and I will instantly be made perfect.
What is easier than this for you Lord,
and what is more important to you?
Thus, providential Lord, revive me
made in your image and brought to life by your
breath¹⁰
in order to renew the breath of your pure
enlightening grace,
protecting my sinful soul.

ⲉ

Do not dispatch me, merciful Lord, before my
time.
Do not let me depart this life empty-handed,
before my journey is accomplished.
Do not offer me the cup of bitterness in my time
of thirst.
Do not block me, compassionate Lord, from
the
path of doing good,
and do not permit the nightfall of death to over-
take me
like a band of thieves in a sudden ambush.¹¹
May the feverish heat of the sun at an
unexpected moment
not cut off and dry up my roots forever.¹²
And may the lunacy of the moon, arriving in
secret,
not cause harm.¹³
May rest not bring death
and slumber not lead to slaughter.
May sleep not destroy me
and may drowsiness not corrupt me.
May my death not strike me at an
inappropriate moment.
And may the release of my spirit upward not
be cast down.

ⲉ

¹⁰Gen 1:26, 2:7.

¹¹Lk. 12:39.

¹²Ps. 121 (Arm. 120), 6, Mt. 13:6.

¹³Ps. 121 (Arm. 120):6.



You are the Lord, you are compassionate, you
are the doer of good.
You are patient and almighty.
In all things you are strong beyond comprehen-
sion
and words¹⁴
to pardon, to save, to grant life,
to enlighten, to establish anew,
to snatch from the jaws of ferocious beasts,
or from the teeth of dragons and restore life,
to lead from the depths of the abyss to the light
of bliss,¹⁵
and from drowning in the waves of sin
to be seated among the righteous with the glory
of the blessed.
Every soul awaits you with hope and expecta-
tion,
longing for your grace,¹⁶
whether heavenly or earthly,
whether fallen in sin or exalted with righteous-
ness,
whether master or servant,
whether lady or maid.
And in your hand is the life breath of every
creature.¹⁷
To you with the Father and the Holy Spirit,
glory forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 83 (24)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Exalted and inscrutable, terrifying power,
lord of creation, king of heaven,
creator of angels, who fashioned the spirits,
and made the fiery beings,
good chief of souls, helping hand,¹
tranquil repose, vision of enlightenment,²

¹⁴Gen. 18:14; Lk. 1:37.

¹⁵Jonah.

¹⁶Rom. 8:18-25.

¹⁷Job 12:10.

¹Ps. 73 (Arm 72):23.

²Mt. 11:28-29.

brightness of bliss, path to beatitude,
cause of life, source of intelligence,
salvation without evil, guide to peace,
rampart of strength, bulwark of protection,
wall of the great fire of blessing,³ definition
of unvengeful,⁴
remember the lamentations and confessions in
this book,
for those of the human race who are our
enemies as well,
and for their benefit accord them pardon and
mercy.

Do not be angry at them for my sake,
Lord,
as if they blasphemed the saints,
on account of your love which is upon me,
but rather treat them as if they are reprimand-
ing evil and justly rebuke me,
while forgiving them their transgressions.
For when we both appear before you, just
judge,
perhaps some of those who have harmed me
have sinned little
and justly spoken against me,
whereas I have committed innumerable and
immeasurable breaches of my vows,
with respect to you, generous Lord.

¶

Remember your greatness, Lord,
when looking upon my lowliness.
And while I petition you to do good to my
enemies,
you in your magnanimity beyond words
show your miraculous favor toward them who
are
also your enemies.⁵
Do not destroy those who persecute me, but
reform them,
root out the vile ways of this world,
and plant the good in me and them,
especially since you are light and hope,
and I am darkness and foolishness.
You are true good, praiseworthy Lord,

³Zech. 2:5.

⁴Hos. 11:9.

⁵Lk. 6:27-28.



and I am thoroughly evil and helpless.
 You are the Lord of everything on earth and in
 the heavens, and I do not control my breath or
 spirit.
 You are exalted, free of any needs,
 and I am in pain and peril.
 You are above all the passions of earth,
 and I am base, disgusting clay.
 In the words of the prophet:
 you endure in perpetual infinity on high
 and I continuously perish.⁶
 In you there is neither darkness nor deceit,
 and in me, they are complete,
 since I have wasted my inheritance of good-
 ness.

Take me out of my prison and free me
 from my bonds.⁷
 Remove my chains and rescue me from
 drowning.
 Free me from anxiety and release me from my
 irons.
 Deliver me from preoccupations and banish
 my doubts.
 Console my sadness and calm my vexation.
 Dispel my afflictions and quiet my agitation.
 Cure me of my tears and stop my sighing.
 Drive away my lamentations and heal my
 sobbing.

God of mercy and giver of sweetness,
 do not despise me, whom you have redeemed
 with your almighty blood.
 Do not condemn me to a place of perdition.
 Prop me up for I have reached the shores of
 death⁸
 through all manner of fatal illness.



Look how through the seasons of my life
 my vain acts have piled up and accrued,
 for from the day I appeared on this earth,
 I have been good for nothing,
 and in the field of my mother's womb
 I was a sprouting thorn bush of sin.

⁶Ps. 102 (Arm. 101):26-27.

⁷Ps. 142 (Arm. 141):7, Lk. 13:16.

⁸Is. 38:1.

Nevertheless, do not be a wounding sting for
 me,
 as you were for the house of Judah or the de-
 scendants
 of Ephraim.⁹
 And since I sowed in my soul
 weeds that prick, poison that numbs me,
 instead of the good seeds of wheat,¹⁰
 as the Scriptures say, which are older than the
 Gospels,¹¹
 why should I not call my soul a foul field,
 choking with the accursed thorns of sin?¹²
 I did not sow justice, as Hosea said,
 so why should I reap and gather the fruit of
 life?¹³
 I lost the pure innocence of my soul,
 as the prophet said of Israel:¹⁴
 Now can you restore it, Lord?
 I spread forth and opened the bed of my will
 to the demons of lust, in the wayward ways of
 Judah.¹⁵
 It is in your hands to restore that innocence.



If the union of the prostitute with the prophet¹⁶
 purified her, how much more, Savior,
 will our spiritual union purify me?
 If the inanimate sun which you created,
 provider of the earth, dries the foul swamps
 and brings the immature fruits to ripeness,
 then you, Creator of all, Holy Spirit of God,
 how much more can you flush away the silt of
 my wrongdoing and cleanse the foul pus of
 my accumulated sin?

For this reason I hasten in this prayer to
 ask that
 you do good to those who hate me,
 so that you, blessed compassion, would not
 reject me,
 though I am deserving of death for my mortal

⁹Hos. 5:12.

¹⁰Job 31:40.

¹¹Mt. 13:25.

¹²Is. 5:6; Mt. 13:7.

¹³Hos. 10:12.

¹⁴Ezek. 23:3.

¹⁵Is. 57:8.

¹⁶Hos. 1:3.



sins and
you should banish me from your all-protecting
sight.

Give me life, although I have sinned in
all ways,
with every part of my body
and the conduct of my soul, give me life
that I might contemplate only that which is
pleasing to you.

To seek benefits for those who have done good
is

the law of nature, an instinctive urge.

And indeed, all manner of people are capable
of following this first rule.

But the second, that is, to pray for your
enemies

with the care of the first, comes close to
being the divine.¹⁷

For this reason, I presented the second first,
that is praying for my enemies
before asking favor for the good.

Ե

Remember twice those
who, in your exalted name,
accepted me, unworthy soul that I am,
and give them, most generous Lord, doer of
good,
without spite, the reward of the just and the
prophets.¹⁸

Although I may be devoid of virtues forever,
considering the belief and by the hope and
expectation,
they in their reasonable judgment have re-
garded
those like me, a slave to sin,
as if I had a secret compartment in my soul
filled with your life-giving relics.

Approaching me with your infinite com-
passion,
cleanse me, whose sins cannot be hidden from
your sight
or from your unerring judgment.

¹⁷Mt. 5:46-48.

¹⁸Mt. 10:41.

Thus protect me from being shamefully con-
demned
before the tribunal of the universe.

And as those whom you love, those who
for your sake
see your glory reflected on me, unworthy
though I am,

for they look upon my fine vestments
without knowing the defects they conceal
and call me in my pitiful state “blessed,”
may you, ingenious, bountiful, content
Lord, who loves mankind, with infinite mercy,
for the sake of the sighs of my most wretched
soul,

settle with them according to their faith.

On the terrible day of judgment,
when everything is tried and the good are
separated from the bad,¹⁹

offer and grant them your incorruptible glory
and your never fading crown.²⁰

Զ

You are the guarantee of salvation for a starv-
ing slave like me,
made worthy by the Word, your gift,²¹
to be redeemed for the benefits of heaven²²
by the largesse of your endless and priceless
treasure.

Lead me beside the still waters.²³

Erect in me like a monument, unchanging
God,
a ready assurance.

Establish in me, praised Lord, a sincere and
unshakable hope.

Accord me, you who provide everything, an
impartial defense.

In my unsteadiness, accord me the tranquility
of virtue,

in my doubt, the solace of enlightenment,

in my mourning, great happiness,

in my weariness, hope to live,

¹⁹Mt. 25:32.

²⁰1 Pet. 5:4, 1 Cor. 9:25.

²¹Mt. 28:18-20.

²²Lk. 19:13.

²³Ps. 23 (Arm. 22):2.



in my abandonment, steadfast help,
in my retreat, return without stumbling.
For all of this is yours, and all of this is from
you,
and through you are distributed the necessities
of
all creation,
and to you is fitting glory,
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 84 (2᠒)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Heavenly monarch, exalted king,
Lord of all, hope of each,
creator of the visible, establisher of the invisible,¹
cause of being, shaper of the future,
giver of light, impulse of dawn that prepares
the morrow,
who makes the evening appear and conjures the
night,²
ingenious artisan, applied wisdom,
blessed pardoner who liquidates sin, banishes
pain,³
and neutralizes bitterness,
preserver of tranquility, who induces slumber,
arranges sleep, grants rest,
who sustains our breathing, maintains our
senses,
dissipates our phantoms, moderates our imag-
inings,
displaces our terrors,
transformation of sadness, suppression of anx-
iety,
dispeller of doubts, calmer of turmoil,
who strikes fear in the heart of the wicked,
and cuts down demons,
wards off disease and drowns scandal,
protect me with your hand that shaped the

heavens.
Strengthen me with your exalted right hand.
Take me under your almighty wings.
Blanket me with your divine care.
Bolster me with the vigilance of your heavenly
host.
Encircle me with your army of immortals.
Surround me with the attachments of angels.
Fend off the enemy with the forces of the vigi-
lant.
Support me through prayers to your divine
Mother, for
I am shaken.
Assign your best troops to guard me.
Open the eyes of my soul along with the eyes
in my face.
Sober the passions that weigh me down along
with
my troubled soul.
Lift away, Lord, from my senses the stupor
that covers them.
Remove, Lord who only does good, the heavy
veil of darkness.
Make your mercy dawn with the breaking of
day.
Make your righteous sun shine on the gloom of
my
heart with morning light.⁴
May the ray of your glory illumine the cham-
ber
of my mind.
May the sign of your cross cast its shadow over
my whole spirit and body.
I commit to you today
this tabernacle of mine,
which you have given to shelter my soul.⁵
For you are God beyond understanding,
generous in all things,
perfect in all ways,
blessed forever.
Amen.

¹Col. 1:16.

²Jer. 33:20, 25.

³1 Jn. 2:2.

⁴Mal. 4:2.

⁵2 Cor. 5:4.

Prayer 85 (2b)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

And now, since our waking vigilance¹
appears like some kind of stupor to you
and our profound silence, owing to our ortho-
dox
faith in you,
seems to you sleeping with open eyes,²
direct me with your Holy Spirit's wisdom
to finish this the work of my hands,
the prayers of my sighing voice.

Strengthen me, Lord, in my courageous
labors
to fight the good fight.³
Be my aid against human frailty.
Lighten the task of my repentance, for it has
only just begun.
Quicken, always capable Lord, the work I have
set before me.
Ease the course to its conclusion.
Help me achieve the bliss of accomplishment.
Help me reach the destination I hope for.
Be my companion through the end of my
journey.⁴

In my ascending flight, speed me on the
course
toward the good.
Be at my right side when I am in danger.⁵
Make your voice heard in my time of need.
Grant me life with your hand in the hour of my
death.⁶
Intervene with your finger in my time of alarm.
Level the most harmful obstacles of alienation.
Send an angel, as you did to Habbakuk, to help
me.⁷
Inspire my speech before the tribunal of

¹Eph. 5:14.

²Ps. 24 (Arm 25):15, S. of S. 5:2.

³1 Tim. 6:12; 2 Tim. 4:7.

⁴Ps. 126 (Arm. 125):5-6; Lk. 24:15.

⁵Ps. 23 (Arm 22):4.

⁶Mk. 6:50.

⁷Dan. 14:33-39 (Arm. version).

judgment.⁸

Plant wisdom in me when I am being scruti-
nized.

With the cloud of your will miraculously
protect me.⁹

Calm my stormy seas with your tree of life,
the cross.

By your command, bridle my earthly impulses.
For if your mercy wills it, Lord,
the fluid waves of the sea will become harder
than stone.¹⁰

But if you abandon me on dry land, Lord,
the earth upon which I stand will move
and crumble beneath me.¹¹

P

Jesus, accept with favor
the supplications I make to you,
and turn my gnawing apprehensions into solid
faith.

In the time of the great flood that destroyed
everything,¹²

those who lived carelessly without fear
upon the steady plains of earth

were destroyed, bereft of your mercy,
while those who trusted in your name,¹³

stood on the rocking deck
of the covered ark of logs

and were saved.

Even so, rescue me with your love of mankind,
though I forever sway this way and that, and
deliver me to the port of your peace, I pray you.

Bearing the fruits of your grace with me
and leaving behind the heavy burden of sin
that

weighs me down,

I fall before you, Lord, in the words of your
parable,¹⁴

uniting with you completely, inseparably,

O Lord, blessed in all things.

⁸Lk. 12:11-12.

⁹Ex. 13:21, 14:19-20.

¹⁰Ex. 14:22.

¹¹Is. 24:19-20.

¹²Gen. 7:21-23.

¹³Gen. 8:15-19.

¹⁴Mt. 18:27.



Now chanting these prayers in antiphon
with the most pure angels
and with the earthly martyrs
who were tested by water and fire¹⁵
and who upon their departure from this life,
pray for us,
leaving their memory as encouragement,
let us say with them, in unison:
So be it.
Amen.

Prayer 86 (22)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Have mercy, praiseworthy and long-suffering king,
upon all souls through these prayers
of grieving lamentation,
composed on various themes,
and have mercy especially on those souls
who are cut off from the hope of salvation
who have died unprepared,
with lamps extinguished for lack of oil.¹
Remember, then, my compassionate Lord,
and consider me justified in this request also,
for in your splendid and awe-inspiring majesty
you combined opposites in the make-up of man,
a little gravity, a little levity,
on the one hand coolness, on the other heat,
so that by keeping the opposites in balance,
we might be called just,
because of this faithful equality.
And however virtuous we might be judged
on this account, when transported upward,
we should bear in view that we are made of humble clay
and accept the crown of tribulation.
But since we violated your commandment of the
Old Testament
and following our earthly nature, strayed like

¹⁵Ps. 66 (Arm. 65):12.

¹Mt. 25:8.

animals,
we were laid low and bound to the earth,²
in some instances by disease, and others by cruelty,
some by gluttony and passions,
as if a ravenous beast is joined to our nature.

Sometimes one of four primary elements,
lunges forward³ and uncontrollably, savagely
and
relenlessly raises its head.
And though warmed by the fervor of our love
for you
and by token of your spark which is in us,
the coldness that is its constant companion,
extinguishes it, disrupting the good.⁴
And although we ascend to you with the
airy ways of angels, the weight and density of
our first element, earth,⁵
holds us down, and hinders us.⁶

Œ

And now, defeated on all fronts and completely
forsaken,
like a feeble cripple, I am rejected, I am ban-
ished that
I might perish.
Worn down by the multitude of blows, I was
captured by death and deprived of grace.
I seek mercy with a shameful face.
I, who have committed all manner of sin,
pray for all the dead living in you.⁷
For you are able, with infinite ingenuity,
to save dying mortals like me.
For you everything is possible.
Especially since you have power that knows no
limits,
and you take delight in exercising your will for
good.
Therefore, when these two illustrious and
renewing graces come together – power and

²Gen 8:21, Ps. 44 (Arm. 43):26.

³St. Gregory refers here to the elements of classical cosmography: earth, air, fire and water.

⁴Rom. 7:14-25.

⁵Gen. 2:7, 3:19.

⁶Rom. 7:14-25.

⁷Lk. 20:37-38.



will –
 the despair that afflicts the race of sinners is
 lifted away
 and the light of your good news arrives
 with your prescription to heal our souls,
 Lord of all, blessed forever.
 Amen.

Prayer 87 (2E)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

And now, since I am approaching the end of
 this
 modest testament of lamentations,
 Lord, with these prayers, put an end
 to those demeaning blameworthy acts
 that have become a bad habit with me.
 You established the good news of hope for con-
 demned
 people like me, saying, “It is not the will of the
 Father,
 that the least of these little ones should per-
 ish.”¹
 And further, “This is the will of my Father,
 that I shall not lose those he has given to me.”²

P

Behold, you are blessed for compassion,
 ever praised for your sweetness,
 proclaimed for your patience,
 recognized for your help,
 preached as the Lord for salvation,
 celebrated for your bounty,
 honored for your protection,
 glorified for your deliverance,
 worshiped for your infinite highness,
 adored for your greatness beyond understand-
 ing,
 alone acclaimed for your triumph,
 exalted for your great strength,
 revered for your mercy,
 embraced for your mildness.

¹Mt. 18:14.

²Jn. 6:39.

Sharing in humility
 with your heavenly father,
 God of all comfort,³
 together with your Holy Spirit, filled with
 goodness
 who established the Law
 not to abandon the fallen beast of one’s enemy⁴
 nor the man who stumbles by his own stupidity.

Your gifts, Almighty, within me,
 and your virtue, great Lord, on high
 are celebrated endlessly by the eternal choir of
 angels,⁵
 thus hear my prayful voice
 through the intercession of the angels
 and along with the supplications of the mar-
 tyrs,
 in sweet and pleasing aroma.

Through the redeeming value of these
 prayers
 of reconciliation, almighty Lord,
 let my original sin be pardoned and
 my unseen wounds be cured,
 along with those committed in
 the course of my life and at my death,
 wounds that bring death to my body and my
 soul.
 Heal my inner and outer wounds,
 their traces, lines, and welts,
 with the exalted and pure salve of your mercy.
 The multitude of bites
 show you the essence of my character,
 both the base and that which is pleasing to you.

Q

And if I reach old age,
 having been guided by you to my worthy death,
 do not abandon me in my frailty.⁶
 Do not despise my gray hair.
 Do not destroy what is already broken.
 Do not bring down the bent.
 Do not knock down the humbled.
 Do not extinguish the flickering flame with

³2 Cor. 1:3.

⁴Ex. 23:5, Dt. 22:4.

⁵Is. 6:2-3, Rev. 5:11-12.

⁶Ps. 71 (Arm. 70):9, 18.



your wind.
 Do not shove the unsteady.
 Do not leave the shivering without a coat.
 Do not permit the afflicted to go without a cure.
 Do not leave the dilapidated untended.
 Do not let the old image be dishonored.
 Do not take the taste away from the sumptuous.
 Do not tarnish the splendor of grace.
 Do not insult the old.
 Do not send waves upon the ship of my soul.
 Do not cut the thread of hope.
 Do not sever the life line.
 Do not take away presence of mind or memory.
 Do not destroy what you have shaped.
 Do not clip the wings of ascension.
 Do not deform the cheerfulness of beauty.
 Do not retract the rays of light.
 Do not close the windows of the eyes.
 Do not block their light.
 Do not cut down my speaking image.



I pray you, compassionate Lord, I beseech you
 with
 all of the saints,
 listen to my prayers now, so that they will not
 later be forgotten.
 You led me, as the Psalmist wrote, and
 “restored my soul.”⁷
 Relieve me, Lord, as with the Psalmist,
 of the doubts and perplexities that cause me
 fear.⁸

But I am not worthy of this,
 no, not even of the common sustenance of a
 hired servant.⁹
 But you are able, according to your ways,
 to show kindness even to people who whine as
 I do.
 Yours are the amazing gifts beyond telling,
 you,
 who alone work miracles, continuously blessed
 with the Father and the Holy Spirit,
 forever and ever.
 Amen.

⁷Ps. 23 (Arm. 22):3.

⁸Ps. 71 (Arm. 70): 20.

⁹Lk. 15:19.

Prayer 88 (20)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart



Now with my broken soul, my deserted mind
 and
 my crushed heart,
 I pour forth the water of my will and the milk
 of my tears,
 just as the prophet Samuel,¹
 poured water before you, all-seeing God,
 to show his people how to bow
 in confession and obedience
 before your life-giving feet.



And now, accept these prayers of sighs and
 contrition,
 as you inhale the scent of this bloodless sacri-
 fice of words, king of heaven.
 Bless and sanctify the letters of this book of
 lamentation,
 and fix your seal upon it,
 as an eternal monument of
 servanthood along with others pleasing to you.
 May it stand before you forever,
 and echo in your ears constantly.
 May it be pronounced upon the lips of your
 chosen,
 and may it be spoken by the mouths of your an-
 gels.
 May it be spread before your throne,
 and may it be offered in your sacred temples.
 May it rise as incense in the houses of worship
 dedicated
 to your name,² and may it give fragrance at the
 altar of your glory.
 May it be kept among your treasures³
 laid up in store with your property.
 May it be recited to the ears of all generations,
 and may it be preached to all peoples.
 May it be inscribed on the doors of the mind
 and imprinted on the threshold of the senses.

¹1 Sam. 7:6.

²Ps. 141 (Arm. 140):2.

³Dt. 32:31.



As if alive and in person, may it recount
the iniquities I have confessed.
And although I shall die in the way of all mortals,
may I be deemed to live
through the continued existence of this book.
May it be protected from destruction by your
will, Lord,
that it might be for me, the condemned,
an ever watchful judge, fair accuser,
that reprimands with vigor and blames with
rigor,
that relentlessly criticizes and sternly shames
me,
that inhumanely hands me over to
the unbribable executioner from whom there is
no escape
like a ruthless informant coldly exposing me to
the whole world.
May it loudly trumpet my faults in confession
⁴
without break or end.

¶

This book will cry out in my place, with my
voice,
as if it were me.
It will uncover what I have covered up and
proclaim my secrets.
It will lament what I have done and
extol what I have forgotten,
reveal the invisible and relate my blasphemy,
preach about the depths of my soul
and tell of my sins.
It will lay bare the unseen and display the
shape of
what is hidden.
Through this book may traps be explored and
pitfalls be discovered.
May unspeakable faults be confronted and
the traces of evil wrung out.
May the life of your grace and mercy reign, O
Christ.
May my dry bones be preserved in your
treasury
so that at the time of eternal life,

⁴Mt. 24:31.

at the dawn of that first spring light,
on the day of renewed splendor,
through your dew my soul might again stir,
with your immortal salvation
and according to the hope held out in your
inspired
Scriptures, ⁵ may I again become green and
blossom,
and send up shoots of spiritual goodness
that will never dry out.

And to you, Savior, and to your Spirit,
of the same essence as the Father,
to your united lordship and your inexplicable
Trinity,
all glory and adoration
with mystic praise
forever.
Amen.

Prayer 89 (20-)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

¶

God and Lord, life and creator,
merciful, compassionate, light,
long-suffering, God who bears no grudges,
all-merciful, generous God who loves
mankind,
savior, blessed, praised, glorified,
storehouse of steadfastness, bulwark of faith,
good without guile,
radiance without darkness,
pardon of sins,
healer of wounds,
creator of unknowable mysteries,
the most approachable of the unreachable,
refuge from despair,
your name is proclaimed, God the Son,
and your Father's with you,
mighty and awesome,
and your almighty Holy Spirit
worshiped with you,

⁵Is. 26:19, Ezek. 37.



glory and thanksgiving forever.
Amen.

Prayer 90 (᠒)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Glorified God in heaven,
sole creator, lord of all,
awesome majesty,
compassion worthy of blessing,
mercy worthy of proclamation,
providence worthy of worship,
love of mankind worthy of celebration,
protection worthy of adoration,
exalted beyond understanding,
close to us by your choice,
unfailing refuge,
you comfort our hearts,¹
you make our grief disappear and reassure us
in our pain,
you end our despair and wipe away our debts,
you remedy our shortcomings, discipline our
passions, and shape our words,
you rein in our tongues, regulate our breathing,
and
control our speech,
you bring our thoughts together, discipline our
will, and settle our emotions,
you calm storms and restore tranquility to the
waves,
you hold the rudder of my impulsive will
and taming it with your wisdom,
you guide me back to you.

P

O ever exalted giver of gifts,
you are forbearing with lowly gentleness,
dwelling with fervor and untold miracles in the
souls of the saints.²
O king of all beings, merciful one proclaimed
by
the universe,

¹2 Cor. 7:6.

²Is. 66:1-2.

you are our forefather and originator of
the law of love.³
O path of life,⁴
you sweetly lead me, a learner, toward your
heavenly light.
O most steady outstretched hand,
you do not let me stumble to my destruction.
O image of hope,
you appear before praying human hands as
that truthful hope.
O refuge of peace,
you never lead us to the risk of condemnation.
O bestower of free grace,
you redeem us fully without compensation.
O generosity that knows no jealousy,
you adorn with your glory the base earth of
which I am made.
O brilliance without shadows,
who engulfs me, a miserable wretch, in the
radiance of your awesome majesty,
restore and make me flourish again.
O pardoner of our multiple sins,⁵
rekindling the former brilliance of those
deprived of salvation,
remake their splendor.
O Almighty,
you make it possible to reach the infinite
heights.
O certain path,
you lead us toward the promised joy.
O yearned for bliss,
it is pleasing to give up the breath of life,
that I might find you, Living God.⁶
O unwavering will,
who is able to pardon me, a slave,
you deserve all praise.
O unerring balm of life,
who performs miracles even over those
completely without life.⁷
O undoubted creator of all,
who resurrects in the blink of an eye,⁸
those consumed by fire, blown to the winds,

³1 Jn. 4:7-10, Jn. 15:12.

⁴Jn. 14:5.

⁵1 Jn. 2:2.

⁶Phil. 1:23.

⁷Jn. 11:39-44.

⁸Ezek. 37.



or devoured in the jaws of beasts,
back into their undiminished physical being.
O brave nobility without equal,
in whom it is right to boast and
in whose glory we can bask.⁹

¶

Look, Lord, from heaven, with cheerful sweetness
upon me, imperiled on all sides by destruction.
Calm my anxious sobbing.
Grant the ease of repose.
The deadly armies are mounted against me:
battalions of violent warriors armed with
all manner of demonic devices,
the barrage of ugly sins hateful to you,
the strokes of pain and destructive disease.
Repel them, take them away, cut them off, stop them,
drive them out, banishing them to a distant place.
Destroy them yet again
and erect the sign of your cross
as a destiny of life and beacon at my death
guiding me to your refuge,
O Salvation.

¶

And through the invincible, infallible and irresistible
power of your awesome majesty,
may the secret snares of Satan be undone,
may his tools be snatched away and the
stumbling blocks removed,
may his traps be foiled,
may his ambush be discovered,
may his treachery be revealed,
may his nets be lifted away,
may his weeds be burned,¹⁰
may the wicked spells be cast out,
may the deceptive ropes of the hunter of death
be cut,
may the liar's gossip be confounded.
may the troublemaker's weapons run out,
may the swords fall from the hands of the

⁹1 Cor. 1:31.

¹⁰Mt. 13:30.

bearer of death,
may the attacker's preparations be scuttled,
may the ropes of the tormentor come undone,
may the false appearances of the hypocrites
be unmasked,
may the heavy-handedness of the haughty be
banned,
may the bands of marauders be dispersed,
may the hordes of thieves be banished,
may the masses of barbarians be expelled,
may the fortresses of the rebels be demolished,
may the tempests of the boastful be checked,
may the rainstorms of the tempter be dispelled,
may the frost of the divider evaporate,
may the horn of the wicked be broken,¹¹
may the pedestals of idols collapse,
may the bragging of the proud be shattered,
may the aggressors' confrontations be repulsed,
may the troops of Belial be destroyed –
both spiritual and physical,
may the invaders from one route be set to flight
in seven directions,¹²
may they fall into the pits they have dug for
me,¹³
may the winters of discontent turn to summer,
may the ties that bind me to the tireless outlaw
be cut,
may the kiss of the flatterer upon my forehead
revolt me,
may the barrage of arrows from my tormentor
cease,
may the boat of the trickster always be rocky,
may the teeth of the biter be ripped from their
roots.

¶

Through the blessed wood of life,
upon which you were bound,
incomprehensible God,
by the memory of those nails,
with which you were spread upon the instrument
of death, creator of heaven and earth,
by your lordly blood, by which, as with a

¹¹Ps. 75 (Arm. 74):10.

¹²Dt. 28:7.

¹³Ps. 7:15



fishhook, you caught the great serpent,¹⁴
 by the bitterness of the bile,
 which you drank, pouring out the deadly
 potion of the destroyer,
 by the blessed recounting of your horrible
 torment,
 through which you shamed and silenced
 the impudence of the opponent,
 by your name that cannot be understood or
 explained in any way, before which the natures
 of the visible and invisible, tremble with fear
 and awesome terror and are condemned,
 may all these gifts of grace
 be for me, who proclaim them,
 protection, cure and pardon.

And for the serpent that brought the bitter
 poison of death,¹⁵
 by whom the universe was betrayed into evil,
 may these bring the death for him.
 May he be bound and taken captive,
 subjected to the stroke of incurable torture.

May your mercy, O creator, toward me,
 and the breath of my soul toward you,
 be united inseparably as one.

2

And let whoever may read these requests
 and supplications
 of the voice calling out in prayer,
 with the love of God,
 whether old or young, girl or boy,¹⁶
 or one of the maidens,
 may all equally receive, without distinction,
 from you a portion of the blessing of forgive-
 ness of sin,
 and be restored to their former spotless purity,
 sealed with your unchanging image.
 You who are almighty, powerful, beyond
 telling,
 beyond understanding, beyond comprehen-
 sion,
 look upon the cries of the sighing heart,

¹⁴Job 40:24.

¹⁵Gen. 3.

¹⁶Ps. 148:12.

offered to you from the lips of all,
 for your Father in heaven and doer of good,
 for the Holy Spirit, co-equal in glory and giver
 of life,
 through the intercession of your Mother of
 God,
 and the prayers of all the saints.

For you created everything
 and from you all things came into being,¹⁷
 and you rule over all,
 and to you is befitting glory from all creation.
 You, one of the very essence of the timeless
 trinity,
 infinitely glorified together,
 forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 91 (ՂԱ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

Ա

Lord, Lord filled with compassion, God of
 mercies,¹
 majestic name, awe-inspiring voice,
 severe summons, unbroken silence,
 thundering speech, shocking sound,
 hope of good deeds and all merciful sweetness,
 before which all creatures quake in fear.
 Before your awesome wrath,
 the seraphim take to flight and the cherubim
 huddle together.²
 the choirs of angels hide their faces,
 all the principalities of heaven shake in amaze-
 ment,
 and all of them rejoice with great trembling in
 jubilant celebration.
 the demons are frightened away and the
 evil bands recoil,
 the spirits of darkness are exiled and
 the angels of the banished one are condemned
 to the abyss.

¹⁷Jn. 1:3, Col. 1:16.

¹2 Cor. 1:3.

²Is. 6:1-5.



The attacks of the aggressors are held in check
by the
sign of your cross, and the vengeful Amalekites
are
locked away in their infernal prison.³
The enemy forces are bound with undoable
knots.
The legions of the warriors of death are jailed
in prisons
from which there is no escape.
The demonic hordes are arrested as in irons by
your command.
The instigators of mutiny are silenced.
The mobs of evil spirits are tied up and waste
away.
The emissaries of the Antichrist are locked in
unbreakable chains.

¶

In this midnight silence I lift
my hand toward you to make
the blessed sign of your cross, source of sight,
who never dims in the darkness of ignorance,
but eternally dwells in unapproachable light.⁴
With a grateful heart I implore
that this grieving soul be taken
under the protection of your almighty wing.⁵
Save me from the onrush of external illusion.
Endow my heart's eye with pure light.
Strengthen me with your cross, the wood of
life,
against nightmares.
Consecrate the boundaries of my cell with
drops of your
life-giving blood.⁶
Sanctify my threshold with the water and blood
from
your side.⁷
May the roof of my dwelling bear the shape of
your cross.
May the miracle of your sacrifice for our salva-
tion
appear as a vision before my raised eyes.

³Ex. 17:8-16.

⁴1 Tim. 6:16.

⁵Ps. 17 (Arm. 16):8.

⁶Heb. 9:11-24.

⁷Ex. 12:7.

May the instrument of your torment be fixed
upon my door.
May my faith and hope hang upon your blessed
tree.⁸
With your cross, Lord, stop the slayer of souls.
Let the protector of light enter.
Ease the severity of my pains
and lighten the burden of my guilt.⁹
In the silent chamber where my mind collects
itself
upon the cushion of my bed,
recalling the bitter fruits of despair,
I confess to you, all-knowing God, my
innumerable deeds of wicked iniquity in all
their forms.¹⁰

¶

Give me rest.
I am exhausted from the multitude of cares and
toil.
Remove the turmoil of doubt from my broken
spirit,
the bitterness along with the grief,
the sighing along with the misery,
the anxiety along with the wretchedness,
the cries along with the destruction,
the brokenness along with the stupor,
the delirium along with the folly,
the imprudence along with the stupidity,
the cooling of love along with the feverish
passion for luxury.¹¹

Come to my aid,
for I am weak with grief and poor in spirit.
With your right hand of beneficial grace,
with your finger of renewal, with your ever-
radiant glory,
with your eternal, incorruptible presence,¹²
with your cheerful countenance,
with the essence of your venerable being,
with your greatness worthy of worship,
relieve this labored sighing that is suffocating
me.¹³

⁸Wis. 14:7.

⁹Mt. 11:28.

¹⁰Ps. 32 (Arm. 31):5.

¹¹Mt. 24:12.

¹²Dan. 7:14.

¹³2 Cor. 7:10.



Stop the new tricks of evil and the old
deceptions of
the Troublemaker,¹⁴
the alienating impulses of the teacher of death,
the unfitting imaginings prompted by the one
who
kills us daily,
the mirages caused by the treacherous demon,
the enchanting sorcerer's fiery breath.

Protect my place of rest in the tranquil-
ity
resembling death,
from hidden thoughts and new errors,
from great misdeeds and small missteps,
from the evil machinations of idleness.

Banish from my senses, wayward servant
that I am,
inappropriate thoughts and base passions,
blameworthy conduct and unbecoming ambi-
tions,
erring actions, ridiculous illusions,
vile thoughts, and despicable babble.



Arm me, for I have taken refuge in you,
arm me with an unerring heart and undefiled
body,
against winds, the violent blows,
the battering of the storm, the pouncing of the
tempest,
the attacks of beasts.
When I close my eyes, do not let my heart-
vision
grow dark,¹⁵ rather let it awaken,
become bright and splendid
to shine with you, Lord Jesus Christ,
with the burning of the inextinguishable light.

With your word, cleanse my bedcham-
ber
of cunning and distractions,
of memories distasteful to you and thoughts
hostile to heaven,

¹⁴Wis. 2:24.

¹⁵S. of S. 5:2.

of criminal follies and ingratitude toward your
Lordship,
and heresies against God.
Stand guard over me with your heavenly host,
the principalities and dominions, and invinci-
ble powers,
pure ministers of your holy Godhead,
the apostles with the tidings of your Gospel,
the prophets with their testaments,
and the righteous with their prayers offered at
the
end of their lives,
that I might fall asleep in mourning pleasing to
you¹⁶
and awaken anew with the grace of your joy.
Though I sleep with trepidation,
may I arise again in spiritual bliss.
Though I go to bed in sinfulness,
may I get up with a clear conscience
and spotless purity.



Hear the sighing of my voice in prayer,
you who alone are most compassionate,
through the intercession of your Holy Mother,
and all the righteous and the chosen martyrs.

To you glory from all people, which I of-
fer up to you,
along with the choirs of immortal Holy An-
gels,¹⁷
in praise of your Father, our God,
and the Holy Spirit, the creator and renewer
of everything,¹⁸
forever and ever.
Amen.

Prayer 92 (ՂԲ)

*A Prayer of Instruction on the wooden bell that
calls us to worship, symbol of the trumpet on
the Day of Judgment.*



¹⁶2 Cor. 7:9

¹⁷Lk. 2:14.

¹⁸Ps. 104 (Arm. 103):30.



I give you thanks, compassionate Lord,
 friend of mankind,
 creator of heaven and earth,
 Son of the living God.
 As soon as I awake I am seized by yearning
 for your love, thanks to the sounding of your
 wooden bell.
 Hearing the bell's clipped resonance
 we awake and arise from our deathlike slum-
 ber.
 And as if called by a consoling voice,
 we are drawn to the service of blessing and
 come
 with joy before your throne to be judged.¹



Glory to you,
 name beyond definition, uncontainable power,
 who went to such amazing lengths to provide
 for my salvation.
 Immortal essence, praised with thanksgiving,
 your miracles in this world
 foreshadow the world to come.
 By this instrument, this wooden vessel,
 you firmly shake me from the stupor of sleep,
 as if you rouse me from my slothfulness
 with an admonishing reproach,
 adding percussive accompaniment
 to the gentleness of your fatherly love.
 By the clapping of two mallets,
 you sweetly rain your loving-kindness upon us.
 You do not plunge me back into the depths of
 sleep
 with hushed syllables,
 nor frighten my anxious soul
 with needless harshness.
 I worship you, upon my knees, Creator of all,
 who has given us in this world a sample
 of the sound of that terrifying alarm that will
 echo
 on the great day of resurrection.
 You brought me back to life
 from the tomblike numbness of oblivion.
 You sought a fool like me to invite
 to taste the wine of joy.²
 You made this instrument to prepare

the immaculate bride for your love, O groom.³
 With this humble spur, you struck fear in the
 monstrous demons.
 You tamed the Rebel by placing a massive yoke
 upon his shoulders.
 You muzzled the jaw of the Troublemaker with
 a restraining bridle.
 May your infinite highness be forever exalted
 great God,
 who turned the tree symbolizing our transgres-
 sion
 into the liberating grace of salvation⁴
 and who brought a muddled fool like me
 to my senses through the wisdom of your spirit.
 Through the strokes of the mallet on this
 wooden board
 you remind us that alone we cannot cure
 the serpent's bite.
 By the three blows at the end of the call to wor-
 ship,
 which symbolize the Trinity,
 you reinforce the three chains that restrain
 my destroyer.⁵



I send up odes of praise, with fragrant incense,
 to you
 God who cares for all,
 for your ways are more potent than the multi-
 tude of pagan gods,
 from whom you captured my sinful soul
 guiding me to your worship.

With the voice of this sacred wood, hardy
 and robust,
 you preached the truth.

With this worthy instrument
 you increased the honor of your New
 Covenant.

Its clamor calls your heavenly host to arms,
 Lord Christ, who rules over all earthly states
 and emperors.
 It is the sign of joy, Lord Jesus, upon your

¹Heb. 4:16.

²Pr. 9:5.

³Rev. 21:2.

⁴Gen 3.

⁵Rev. 20:2-3.



victory on the
field of battle, in which the Pharoah who
oppresses souls is seized and bound.⁶
This well-shaped piece of wood delivers a
daily beating
upon the head of the haughty evil doer.
By the sound of this wood, the sons of Zion
are
summoned to battle against the despot who
casts a
darkness over the world.⁷
And like a house of divine worship, built long
ago,⁸
this wood consecrated with oil, which neither
grows old
nor retires from service,
alerts us well in advance of the Day of Reck-
oning that
lies ahead.
It is like the tree of life in paradise, O God,
inviting
us to gather and hasten to the house of bless-
ings.
It resembles the tree of knowledge
created to distinguish good from evil.⁹
It is a solemn reminder of the sign of the cross
sealed upon my forehead by your Holy Spirit.
It announces the good news of your glorious
second coming to the bride, kept pure for you,
O King.¹⁰
It encourages the ranks of the saintly to rejoice.
It inspires an innocent yearning for spiritual
union
with the virgin queen, the mother of all, veiled
in splendor.
It prepares the secret treasures that adorn the
soul.
It is reminiscent of the thunderous message on
Mt. Sinai
and the aura of dwelling places of the Lord.
It crowns with glory the immaculate mother of
pure children, the splendid eternal virgin – the
church.

⁶Rev. 19:11-21.

⁷Eph. 6:12.

⁸Gen. 28:18-19.

⁹Gen. 2:9.

¹⁰2 Cor. 11:2, Rev. 21:2, 9, Eph. 5:27.



With the sounding of this wood,
stronger than the trumpeting rams' horns at
Jericho,¹¹
you brought down and leveled the tyranny of
Satan.
With this wooden slingshot you slew Goliath.¹²
You fashioned this new javelin that foretells the
destruction of Satan,¹³
for with this tool you pulled up the deep roots
of sin
and through its beneficial work
you recommitted me to duties I had forgotten.
If I call this alarm a voice,
that predicts the coming of your Word, O God,
I would not be wrong, but would be telling the
truth.¹⁴
By this humble instrument,
though material, yet bearing the spirit,
the majesty of your works are proclaimed, O
Jesus.
Through this unassuming sign,
signaling the place of refuge,
you draw our attention on earth
to your bounteous help from on high.



Your name is proclaimed,
God, who loves mankind,
who provides and cares for us beyond reason.
You are adored in the mystery of your Holy
Trinity,
O light whose image cannot be drawn.
By this twice dedicated wood,¹⁵
you shot arrows of sound,
through the air, reaching their targets
across long distances, bearing a living spirit,
foiling the secret designs of the archer of dark-
ness,
forcing him into retreat.
As if waging battle from a high fortress,
mighty and indestructible,

¹¹Jos. 6:1-21.

¹²1 Sam. 17.

¹³Jos. 8:18-19.

¹⁴Jn. 1:23 (Like John the Baptist).

¹⁵The Holy Cross and Consecrated Bell that calls to
worship.

you hurl down the strokes of this wooden bell,
 like an angel you send to confound the enemy.
 With the words of your covenant, Your Majesty,
 consecrated with grace by being mixed with
 your blood,
 you have sharpened this horn
 like a cross of redemption honed on the whet-
 stone,
 to strike down the blustering bully.
 By the clamor of this wooden bell,
 more tumultuous than a celestial chorus,
 the doors of the human will
 with its half-hearted and unseemly impulses,
 are knocked down
 taking with it the legalistic mentality of the
 Old Testament heart and its house which is but
 a shadow
 of your new covenant.

2

I offer you glory and praise,
 immortal king,
 I pray that you might renew
 with your mighty right hand
 all that you have created.
 By the reverberating wooden bell
 you drove away the wicked peril of the
 cunning Troublemaker,
 the feverish torment of sin,
 the sour breath of the deceiver,
 the impulsive and deadly misadventures and
 delusions,
 the harmful and depressing acts caused by
 weakness of the flesh,
 the diabolical whining that causes us to faint.
 Helped by the wings of the sign of your cross,
 dispel again with this wooden armament
 clouds that rain fire,
 thunder that brings hail,
 burning flames of smoky deception
 of the many-footed fire-breathing dragon,
 the butcher's knife, the confrontation of battle,
 the wild thoughts that overtake me
 like prancing demons.
 They are set to flight by this little bell,
 overcome with trembling,
 and they know the Lord

comes to judgment
 with a sound like this.
 And the pious warriors,
 well armed with the sword of the Holy Spirit,
 are spurred on with courage,
 when they hear the alarm of the wooden bell,
 which with an inarticulate cry calls all nations
 to sacrifice themselves for justice.

1

Listen to the great trumpet sound
 by which God is exalted in worship¹⁶
 throughout the world.
 It resounds in the ears of the heathens, causing
 them to scatter.
 It reinforces the voice of the watchmen of
 great God,
 and, in the words of Isaiah, has us singing
 together for joy.¹⁷
 Thanks to this wooden bell, the enemies of the
 cross,
 are separated like the waters.¹⁸
 The fruit of the first tree loses its
 far-reaching significance,¹⁹
 when wood becomes celebrated as the symbol
 of life.²⁰
 Compared to this wooden bell emitting the
 sound of life,
 the iron sword of war loses its luster.²¹
 And like something sacred,
 this wooden bell that rings out life
 was deemed worthy to be inscribed
 with the sign of the cross,
 like bells on horses, holy to the Lord.²²
 The sword of human authority is sheathed²³
 in deference to this anointed staff of the
 heavenly shepherd.
 No hammer of any artisan has nicked a
 stone of the temple,²⁴
 but on the altar built by God this sacred wood

¹⁶Ps. 47 (Arm. 46):5, Is. 27:13.

¹⁷Is. 52:8.

¹⁸Ex. 14:15-31.

¹⁹Gen. 3.

²⁰Prov. 3:18.

²¹Is. 2:4.

²²Zech. 14:30.

²³1 Sam. 17:32-51.

²⁴1 Kg. 6:7.

soaring with the wings of the cross wields power.
 Not only at the beginning of the month,²⁵
 nor upon the seven times seven years of the jubilee,²⁶
 is the wooden bell removed from its corner and sounded,
 but from the dawn of the universe to its far reaches,²⁷
 upon the waves of the sea and its islands,
 it echoes, divinely,
 announcing the good news.
 The swords of the butcher were broken
 by the sight of this wood,
 and the useless were transformed into ploughshares and pruning hooks.²⁸

Ⲛ

The sound of the wooden bell, is not like the harsh echo
 of stones in the depths of a pit,
 nor does it do violence to the air, in the words of
 a foreign sage.²⁹
 It does not pierce the ear with a sharp and annoying sound,
 nor does it make the skull vibrate unpleasantly.
 It does not cause bones to crack,
 nor does it stun the mind.
 It does not clang like a bell of copper,
 nor does it clunk without any sweetness like a stone on the pavement.
 It is the invincible keeper of the New Zion.
 It is one of the main, sacred vessels, given by God,
 that Christian clerics, along with the Levites,
 treat with care and reverence.
 It is like the voice of an angel,³⁰
 which in the words of the parable-teller,
 resemble the song of a bird.³¹
 It is a new musical instrument to announce the

grace of the good news.
 It awakens in us the Spirit of God
 more readily than the odes of Elishe's harp.³²
 It is the prelude to the lamentations,
 played upon the strings of a sweet and harmonious violin.
 It is cymbals with their allegorical expression.
 It is a new flute of a different sort
 that we have adopted instead of the old.
 It does not make hollow noises like reeds of the pagans.
 It does not make earthly noises like instruments of
 the Jews, about which the Lord said through the prophet,
 "Take these away from me."³³
 Rather, it is a God-pleasing sound, doubly honored,
 for it wards off attacking demons and other strokes of evil.

ⲛ

And now, I have accepted with blessing,
 veneration and praise, this sacred gift,
 as protection for me and glory for you,
 thanksgiving from me and worship to you,
 a wonder of your creative glory, wanting in nothing.
 May this Godly sound pierce through the joints of my body³⁴ to drive from my soul the deceitful ways of the demons and block corruption.
 Make this wooden bell a symbol,
 a harp of light, an invitation that cannot be retracted, an endless praise of your lordly providence.
 Hear us, O compassionate Lord, through this wooden bell.
 Grant us, I pray, almighty Lord,
 twofold protection against visible and invisible enemies.
 Give us, O generous hand,
 open and ready to offer and share good things,
 the sweetness of air and beneficial rains.
 May your order, voiced in this medium,
 curb the hellish blasts, the painful breathing,

²⁵Ps. 81 (Arm. 80):3.

²⁶Lev. 25:9.

²⁷Rom 10:18.

²⁸Is. 2:4.

²⁹Some commentators interpret this as a reference to Homer. Critical Edition, p. 1113, n. 14.

³⁰Mt. 25:31.

³¹Ec. 12:4.

³²2 Kg. 3:15.

³³Am. 5:23.

³⁴Heb. 4:12.



the attacks of the deceitful and evil brigands.
 By this instrument may we be delivered from
 the aggressive warriors who lead us to evil.
 By the cheerful voice of this anointed wood,
 may the worm, canker, and their kind,
 that draw strength from our sins and fight
 against us be driven away, cut down and killed.
 By this plant of bliss
 may our trust in you as our protector,
 Creator of all, lord of creation,
 take root, like the thicket where Abraham
 found the ram,³⁵ at the end of whose branches
 the sacred inheritance of my present salvation
 hangs before us, caused by you, Christ, to blossom
 and bear the fruit of eternal life.
 Before the ringing out of the good news heralded by
 his glorious wood,
 may the demon-possessed enemies
 and the lying and tricky many-handed hellions
 be set to flight and banished to the dark abyss.
 May this bell drive away from the fertile fields
 of our toil, the devastating blights and trampling
 bands of animals.
 Let this bell remove unbecoming excesses
 caused by the devices of evil,
 that render us yet more ugly.
 May this bell truly eliminate
 the faults generated by traitors
 in our two natures:
 from the spiritual, strange, false thoughts;
 from the physical, corruption caused by
 impure stirrings.
 Deliver me, Lord Jesus, I pray you!
 Deliver me, my benefactor.
 Reach out to me with your almighty right hand,
 and having helped me,
 free me of these enemies.



Mix and unite your commandments with the
 sound of the bell,

³⁵St. Gregory uses the Hebrew word *sabec* which means 'bush' or 'thicket', referring to the thicket where Abraham found the ram that he sacrificed in place of his son Isaac. Gen. 22:13. Critical Edition, p. 1114, n. 22.

so that my callous heart, hard as a diamond,
 might again bear the fruits of your word.³⁶
 May the sound of the bell strike and pierce
 my worn heart and forsaken soul
 and like a sharp stake of wonder,
 reinforce and shore them up,
 upright and steadfast,³⁷
 while softening the hardness of my soul,
 so that I might awaken, sobered with humility,
 like Paul and Matthew.³⁸
 O God who loves mankind,
 through this venerable wooden bell
 remind me of the gifts of your cross
 by which you did things beyond words.
 Lift away from me, Giver of life,
 the weight of my sins
 by the glorious yoke of your new tabernacle.³⁹

By your will, Almighty,
 may the ears of my stubborn heart be opened
 to the sound of life.
 By this tiding of your magnificent good works,
 may the ears of the deaf hear.⁴⁰
 Through this bell may the tongues of the dumb
 speak.⁴¹
 May the sight of the eyes be restored,
 that they might look upon you purely in
 unwavering adoration.⁴²
 May the weary wills of men be refreshed,
 that they might repent and return to you.⁴³
 In my turmoil, O Lord,
 grant me the rain of tears.
 Let this be from you to us
 a message of joy,
 a jubilant shout,
 a tranquil song,
 a thing of bliss,
 a means of salvation,
 an occasion for pardon,
 a banishment of grief,
 an extrication from entanglements,

³⁶Mt. 13:3-9, 18-23.

³⁷Is. 35:3-4.

³⁸Acts 9:1-9, Matt. 9:9.

³⁹Mt. 11:28-30, Ex. 25:14.

⁴⁰Is. 35:5.

⁴¹Mk. 7:32-35.

⁴²Jn. 9, Mk. 10:46-52, Is. 35:5.

⁴³Is. 35:3-4.



an easing of anxiety,
 a ceasing of cares,
 a dispelling of sighs
 an alleviation of groaning,
 an assurance of necessities,
 a discipline of passions,
 a consolation for disappointments,
 a cure for pains,
 an immunization against backsliding,
 a contemplation of things invisible.

†

Lead me across this bridge of yearning,
 which neither hinders nor causes us to stray,
 on our upward journey,
 upon this heaven-bound ladder marked⁴⁴
 by the footsteps of the saints.
 Offer me to your blessed Father,
 whose name inspires awe,
 O doer of good,
 may I be guided by your Holy Spirit,
 to inseparable unity with you.
 And to your one and only, holy and united
 Lordship and
 incorruptible creatorship, for which your crea-
 tures,
 both living and inanimate, give thanks,
 glory and dominion, forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 93 (᠒᠒)

*A Prayer of Instruction on the Holy Chrism, the
 light-giving oil of consecration*

‡

Holy, awe-inspiring name, too sublime to utter,
 ever desired object of our yearning,
 praised without end by the glorious seraphim,¹
 who sing, "Holy, Holy, Holy,"
 to you who dwell in the Holy of Holies,
 who are filled with bountiful goodness,
 you pour forth generously and without end,
 awesome and incomprehensible.

⁴⁴Gen. 28:12-19 (Jacob's Ladder).

¹Is. 6:2-3.

You are all and are in all.²

With these words, as my contract of hope,
 may I enter into a covenant with you,
 Almighty?

Yes, amen, alleluia!³

venerated king of the universe,

God of all, creator of beings and sovereign
 Lord,

sole cause of all consequences,⁴

forever adored, Savior and Christ, the anointed
 Messiah.

¶

The meaning of this priceless treasure and
 irreplaceable wealth

is given to us by your very name,

Jesus Christ heavenly king,

whom the immortal and sublime beings,

with mouths of light and breath of fire,

serve with trembling,

bowing to you on bended knee in thanksgiving,
 gladly without mental reservations,⁵

Creator of all beings visible and invisible.⁶

You who are and were totally perfect and
 lacking nothing, took our nature truly and in
 its entirety,⁷

in order to complete it with your perfection.

O blessed and praised Lord,

forever proclaimed for the incomprehensible
 sacrifice you made for our salvation,

to you, glory and praise for your goodness,

you, who are exalted beyond words,

sublime and awe-inspiring.

You are the source of grace given through
 anointing,

a great mystery that miraculously adorns us,⁸

for through it your light was revealed to us,⁹

O incomprehensible ray,
 boundless dawn,¹⁰

²1 Cor. 15:28, Heb. 1:2.

³Rev. 1:7, 19:4.

⁴Jn. 1:3.

⁵Phil. 2:10, Heb. 1:6.

⁶Col. 1:16.

⁷Phil. 2:7.

⁸1 Jn. 2:27.

⁹Lk. 2:32.

¹⁰Lk. 1:78-79.



sun shining fairly on all,¹¹
 star that divides the day in two,¹²
 lamp unto our feet and light upon the path,¹³
 thanks to you we see the meaning of this
 sacrament
 and compose this prayer,
 celebrating with angelic singing and jubilation,
 with a pure spirit,
 venerating with incense fit for our Savior
 your generous allotment of gifts, most wise
 Lord,
 through the oil of gladness and spotless be-
 lief.¹⁴
 For the first created man, my forefather, who,
 scarcely created, tragically lost the greatest
 gift,
 the breath of eternal life,¹⁵
 and forever withering in the hands of sin,
 became a captive of death.¹⁶
 He was tied into an undoable knot,
 into deadly decadence,
 and fell because of the tree of knowledge,
 unable to stand, stumbling toward destruction,
 expelled from the light,
 he was condemned to the darkness of this
 world.¹⁷
 But you, compassionate Lord,
 always knew your creature
 better than he knew himself.
 In pursuit of the divine knowledge he could
 not have,
 he lost the innocence he had,
 thereby becoming unable to look upon
 your sublimity which dwells in unapproach-
 able light,¹⁸
 O infinite God.

For this reason you did not reveal your-
 self
 in an ever radiant light that does not wane,
 but only as an aid against the terrors of the

night,
 when the feet stumble.
 You gave the oil, and in this oil you placed a
 wick,
 which exemplifies your union, without imper-
 fection, with our condition,
 formed and woven with your love of mankind,
 so that we, who find ourselves banished, in the
 shadow of death,
 because of the first transgressions against the
 tree,¹⁹
 through the fruit of the tree akin to it,²⁰
 might be enlightened with the flame of faith
 and restored to that former blessed state.
 And also by being spread upon the tree of
 death
 you spread us upon it as well,
 and thanks to this great mystery²¹
 united us with the tree of life.

9.

Now, just as the day is incomplete without
 night,
 so the household is incomplete without the sta-
 ple oil.
 For as ordinary, unconsecrated oil illumines the
 sight of the physical eyes,
 so the oil sanctified and chosen by the mystery
 of your breath of grace
 gives luster to our invisible souls in a glorious,
 miraculous way
 uniting us with you, Lord who cannot be seen.
 For as we believe, that by the washing of the
 body
 in the glow of holy baptismal font
 our souls are cleansed,
 so when anointed with chrism, that oil of hope,
 we believe, without the least doubt,
 that we receive through it the Holy Spirit.
 And since by your blessed commandment,
 Lord,
 you arranged in advance the pardoning of
 those afflicted with sin,

¹¹Mt. 5:45.

¹²Rev. 22:16.

¹³Ps. 119 (Arm 118):105, Lk. 1:79.

¹⁴Ps. 45 (Arm. 44):7, Heb. 1:9.

¹⁵Gen. 2:7.

¹⁶Gen. 3:9.

¹⁷Lk. 1:79.

¹⁸1 Tim. 6:16.

¹⁹Gen. 3:22-23.

²⁰The olive.

²¹The spreading of Christ on the Cross is likened to the spreading of anointing oil.

and for those who do not believe in this pardon,²²
 you performed before their eyes the miracle
 of healing as evidence for doubters.
 Similarly, this oil of salvation, sanctified with
 light,
 is poured on us to anoint our outer temple,
 and enters us in secret and unseen,
 whereby the inner man is born again.

ⲁ

This physical thing is a superb analogy for
 you,
 for the wise maidens who bore the oil
 received the benefit of your mercy,²³
 and in praise you defined yourself as merciful,
 saying:
 “I am merciful, said the Lord.”²⁴
 As your name is synonymous with love, O
 God,²⁵
 so in part your mercy and love are manifested
 by coming down to be reimprinted upon our
 nature
 according to the divine plan of salvation.
 The sacrificial fat is a fitting analogy for a
 great
 and sublime mystery,²⁶
 for as the fat is to the animal,
 so the oil is to the plant – its heavy, earthen
 part.
 And as you commanded in the Old Law
 that this part of the animal should not be eaten,
 but should be offered as a sacrifice to you, O
 Creator,²⁷
 so under the New Testament,
 this oil is a potent offering ceremonially given
 for your favor, fitting only for you Lord,
 the God who is,
 as the true travel-mate of my soul,
 to be kept and pledged to you, Creator.

²²Mt. 9:2-9.

²³Mt. 25:4-10.

²⁴Jer. 3:12.

²⁵1 Jn. 4:8.

²⁶St. Gregory refers here to the mystery of redemption, in a play on the Greek words, *helaion* = ‘oil’ and *heleos* = ‘mercy.’ K?chichian, p. 492, n. 3.

²⁷Lev. 7:22-25, Ex. 29:13.

For neither the lifeblood nor the savor of
 the burning
 fat,²⁸ which are the symbols of the soul and
 strength,
 are burnt to ashes with the meat of sacrifice,
 but are the portion offered before your throne
 in the heavenly kingdom, O Lord,
 so this light-giving substance
 may always burn bright and inextinguishable.

Ⲃ

The first-born male could not preside as a judge
 unless he was anointed,
 nor could the clergy set foot in the Holy of
 Holies,
 unless he were ordained and consecrated with
 oil²⁹
 Jacob poured oil upon the stone on which he
 slept,³⁰
 thus consecrating the distant archetype of
 the altar of God.
 This pouring out moreover symbolized your
 descent
 on that splendid ladder, O God exalted beyond
 words,
 to take me up on my heavenly journey.
 And for this reason, he erected and anointed a
 monument
 to remind later generations.
 The splendor of Aaron’s priesthood
 was fulfilled by anointing him
 according to your commandment, great God³¹
 In the words of the Psalmist,³²
 when oil poured down over his head and beard,
 he was miraculously transformed,
 regaining the original glory of Adam,
 and receiving your life-giving Holy Grace
 through union with our nature.
 The kings of this world would have no legitimacy,
 as the image of your creatorship on earth,
 were it not for their consecration with a horn
 filled with oil,³³ and the placing of the crowns

²⁸Gen. 9:4, Lev. 7:26.

²⁹Lev. 8:30, 21:10.

³⁰Gen. 28:18, 35:14.

³¹Lev. 8:30.

³²Ps. 133 (Arm. 132):2.

³³1 Sam. 16:1, 13.



upon their
heads in your name, Christ.
And how could I forget the first among these
sublime
figures, Melchisedek, the servant of your great-
ness and
your image beyond understanding?
Is it possible that Melchisedek
the symbol of your awesome truth,
on the Mount of Olives,³⁴
where later your feet, God incarnate, walked,
can it be possible he was not anointed by the
fruits of this
place by the angels on high?³⁵
Thus he was invested by you
to guard the tomb of our forefather Adam³⁶
in princely episcopal honor,
until you appeared, Lord,
the true priest fully revealed,
the regeneration and regenerator of Adam.

2

Since yours is grace,
and to you is befitting thanksgiving,
O blessed Son of God,
may you yourself place the seal of your blessed
image
upon these prayers, imbued with the oil of
humble love,
the incense of adoration
and the myrrh of repentance
that they may bring glory for you
and healing for me, a wretched sinner.
Apply, Lord Jesus, this oil of light to my
invisible sores,³⁷
and on the cauterized parts of these deadly
wounds,
put a drop of the blessed oil of your salvation
with the ever sweet wine of your love,
bound by you with the protective bandages of

³⁴Gen. 14:18-20, Ps. 110 (Arm. 109):4; Heb. 7:13.

³⁵Although the anointing of Melchisedek is not mentioned in the Holy Scriptures, St. Gregory relies on Armenian church tradition and the Synaxarion, marking Melchisedek's consecration on Mar. 25. K[?]chichian, p. 493, n. 8.

³⁶According to Jewish tradition, Noah buried the head of Adam at Golgotha, the Place of the Skull. Jn. 19:17.

³⁷Lk. 10:33-34 (the Good Samaritan).

your care,
so that this testament, my explanatory dis-
course in prayer,
might be endowed with fitting dignity,
under the wings of your Holy Spirit.

Your Spirit, O exalted God, came upon
David,
only after the day he was consecrated and
anointed.³⁸

Saul became a different man and joined the
band of prophets, when the anointing oil
descended upon his head.³⁹

The Assyrian Empire was conquered and taken
captive

by the anointed and joined to the house of
Israel.⁴⁰

Certain illustrious rulers, great and prominent
among the uncouth and barbarous nations,
upon whom was sprinkled the dew of this
life-giving oil, were caught as if in a trap,
joining your family in service to you, great
God.⁴¹

The heavenly word, spoken through the
prophets,

calling Cyrus, chosen of God,
also honored him by referring to him as
“the Anointed One.”⁴²

The Psalmist esteemed the title, “anointed”
greater than that of “prophet,” first stating the
prohibition, “Do not approach the anointed.”
and then adding, “and do not harm the
prophets.”⁴³

The divine mission entrusted to Elijah on
Mount Horeb,

which marked the end of the pagan cult of

³⁸1 Sam. 16:13.

³⁹1 Sam. 10:6, 1-12.

⁴⁰Is. 45:1, Ezra 1:2 (referring to Cyrus as the anointed, who in 538 BC helped the Jews out of their captivity to return to their homeland and rebuild the Temple).

⁴¹Among pagan emperors and kings who converted, Constantine of Rome, Trdat of Armenia, Clovis in France. K[?]chichian, p. 495, n. 1.

⁴²Is. 45:1.

⁴³Ps. 105 (Arm. 104):15 (saying in effect that it is a sin to harm the prophets, but it is forbidden even to approach the anointed).



Baal,
 was the anointing Jehu and Hazael.⁴⁴
 Your name, O bridegroom, the Christ,
 “the oil poured out,”⁴⁵
 is witnessed long ago by the inspired
 words of the sage.
 In this way, the Spirit, the eternal image and
 sign of God,
 might imprint your great image on this small
 drop of oil
 that we may be united with you, receiving your
 grace.

Է

Why do I belabor this point
 with images and farfetched analogies
 in long, complicated, poetic prayers to you,
 O exalted and awesome Lord
 O Lord and giver of life,
 O creator of heaven and earth?
 You began to preach the good news of your
 kingdom,⁴⁶
 only after you were anointed and proclaimed
 by
 John the Baptist as the Anointed One and
 “Lamb of God,
 who takes away the sins of the world.”⁴⁷
 Although the Holy Spirit was always in you
 with its
 complete essence, and your perfect union of di-
 vinity
 with humanity was an anointing in itself,
 the word, anointed, when applied to the saints
 describes the miraculous grace acting upon
 them,
 and through this word you prepare the servile
 flesh of Adam to be eternally ennobled.
 Opening the book of the prophet Isaiah,
 you read about yourself, O incarnate divinity,
 and in fulfillment of the words of your servants,
 O Lord,
 revealed yourself as the anointed,
 through the prophetic words:
 “the Spirit of the Lord is upon me,

⁴⁴1 Kg. 19:15-16, 2 Kg 9-10 (9th cent. BC).

⁴⁵S. of S. 1:3.

⁴⁶Lk. 4:18.

⁴⁷Jn 1:29, 36.

because he has anointed me.”⁴⁸

Then you closed the book,
 thereby showing the great difference in degree
 between these two anointings, ours and yours,
 and defined the great distance between them:
 ours is a bit of luster from a drop of grace,
 and yours is the revelation of your divine
 essence
 shared equally with your Father and your Holy
 Spirit.
 When you first made your incarnation known
 at your birth, the angels in high praise pro-
 claimed you
 the Anointed One by which name you became
 known to all the creatures of earth.⁴⁹
 The Prophet foretold the descent
 of your Father’s voice from the heavens
 at the River Jordan and on the chosen Mount
 Tabor,⁵⁰
 saying “He proclaims among the people his
 Anointed One.”⁵¹
 And the Psalmist also foretold your glory,
 Almighty,
 and of the honor bestowed by consecrating the
 human
 nature you have assumed, “God, your God has
 anointed
 you with the oil of gladness.”⁵²

Ը

“The breath of our face,” Lord Christ,⁵³
 your name is truly, “the Anointed One,”
 for in your goodness, you gave our souls
 the breath of life⁵⁴ and light of your counte-
 nance.⁵⁵
 The wise words of one favored by God⁵⁶
 proclaimed your love for mankind,
 while telling of a certain prophet:⁵⁷
 “He shall testify before the Lord and his

⁴⁸Lk. 4:18; Is. 61:1.

⁴⁹Lk. 2:11.

⁵⁰Mt. 3:17; Mt. 17:5.

⁵¹Am 4:13 (per the Armenian version).

⁵²Ps. 45 (Arm 44):7.

⁵³Lam. 4:20.

⁵⁴Gen. 2:7.

⁵⁵Ps. 4:7.

⁵⁶Jesu or Ecclesiasticus, the son of Sirach.

⁵⁷Samuel.



anointed,”⁵⁸

and confirmed the good news, saying:⁵⁹

“I have not taken so much as a pair of sandals from any man.”⁶⁰

In praise of Christ’s bride, the holy church, the Song of Songs, from beginning to end, explains the divine mystery, comparing incarnation to spiced wine⁶¹ and virtue to myrrh mixed with choice oil⁶² and perfect morals to a sweet perfume of myrrh and incense mixed with delicious powders.⁶³

When Daniel described in words that seemed beyond human expression your life-giving death,

Christ King of heaven, he predicted “the anointed one

will be killed in sixty-nine weeks,”

calling you the anointed leader.⁶⁴

The lamp stand of Zechariah, son of Berechiah and grandson of Iddo,⁶⁵

through its ingenious system of oil supply to the seven lamps, keeping them constantly lit,

symbolizes the anointing and salvation poured from your bounty upon us.

And according to the Old Law of prophecy, cereal offerings of round loafs of unleaven bread

of fine flour mixed with the oil⁶⁶

and peace offering of the anointed calf,⁶⁷

the portion called the Lord’s, and

purification sacrifice performed with two birds,

the living one dipped in the blood of the other,⁶⁸

as if with anointing oil,

all were performed at your altar in the temple.

All these are manifestations of the mystery,

all are signs relating to you,

only begotten Son, blessed of great God.

You alone are anointed in a new and marvelous way,

in and through yourself, with your whole essence,

perfectly and lacking absolutely nothing.



But does it make sense to multiply examples of

this great, inexplicable mystery?

To understand, we must taste you, sweet Lord,⁶⁹

and learn through you

the true meaning of the oil

for what is it, if not

the gladness praised by the Psalmist⁷⁰

that you grant by curing the grief

of the tree of our transgression?

What is it, if not the rich, fullness of heart,

by which you make us forget the food of death?

What, if not the anointing, that transforms our ashen

wretchedness into the brightness of perpetual good

cheer,⁷¹ that through the salvation of your name,

O Spirit of Might, we might become the children of God?⁷²

What, if not the cure that is the fervent desire of the

prophet’s heart, that is, to be anointed in his old age

with rich oil⁷³ that he might be anointed upon his head with oil⁷⁴

by which with the help of your protecting hand,

we are saved from the tragedy of the fall,⁷⁵

⁵⁸Saul.

⁵⁹Lk. 10:4.

⁶⁰Sir. 46:19.

⁶¹S. of S. 8:2, 1:2, 4:4, 10.

⁶²S. of S. 5:1.

⁶³S. of S. 3:6, 4:14.

⁶⁴Dan. 9:25-26.

⁶⁵Zech. 1:1; 4:1-14.

⁶⁶Ex. 29:2, 10, Lev. 2, 3:1.

⁶⁷Lev. 3:1, Lev. 7:11-16.

⁶⁸Lev. 14:5-7.

⁶⁹Ps. 34 (Arm. 33):8.

⁷⁰Ps. 104 (Arm. 103):15.

⁷¹Is. 61:3.

⁷²Is. 11:2; 61:3, 9.

⁷³Ps. 92 (Arm. 91):10-11.

⁷⁴Ps. 23 (Arm. 22):5.

⁷⁵Gen. 3.



which brings death.
 What, if not the thanks
 expressed for the lamp⁷⁶
 that shed light on the fog of sin and the
 darkness
 of idolatry, your union in my nature to
 become in me, Emmanuel?⁷⁷
 What, if not the consolation prophesied by the
 prophet
 of gladdening blessings as a sign saying:
 “They will be anointed with oil free of impuri-
 ties.”⁷⁸

Or when the wiseman in the name of bride,
 says to the
 maids of honor, “Sustain me with oil,
 shower me in apples,”⁷⁹
 and “Keep me in the embrace of the
 sweet balsam orchard,”⁸⁰
 referring to that fine substance, filled with your
 Spirit,
 whose light enables us to see
 your finer, higher, ungraspable element,
 praised Lord.

And now, our only provider and
 cause of all good things,
 listen with compassion, Lord,
 to the supplications I call to you,
 with my arms lifted up in prayer,
 bolstered from within,
 with the sighs of my heart,
 with the cries of my tongue and lips.
 Expressing thanks through these offerings,
 I offer up my gratitude to you,
 almighty, awesome, exalted, incomprehen-
 sible,
 forever embraced in unending love,
 constantly praised with the chant,
 Holy, Holy, only and always Holy,⁸¹
 blessed forever.
 Out of your great goodness,

grant me yet more help,
 for I am completely lost.
 Give me hope of sweetness,
 though I am not worthy of the least drop of
 your light,
 so that I might understand through you, good
 Lord,
 the subtle secret of this mystery.
 and mix thanks with my prayer,
 saying with David,
 “We have received your mercy, Lord,”⁸²
 and “your hidden and invisible secrets,
 you have revealed through your wisdom.”⁸³



And now, majesty to you, God almighty,
 whose generosity never ceases,
 whose compassion streams in all directions,
 who is always ready in healing,
 because you merged and mixed
 your splendid miracles, awe-inspiring beyond
 telling,
 into such a common and familiar material.
 For that force which the heavens in their height,
 and the earth in its breadth,
 and the abyss in its depth,
 and the seas in their multitude
 could not hold, you fit in this small drop of oil,
 a mere speck, compared with your immensity,
 truly and not just in appearance,
 so that when it performs a new miracle,
 unrelated to its nature,
 it does not appear to be some kind of
 illusion to onlookers.
 Instead it heals the doubting souls
 rather than wounding them.
 Just as out of the flour of wheat,
 blessed Son of God, you made your body,
 in reality and not in semblance,
 and out of the wine of the grape
 the blood of your side,
 and out of the bountiful water,
 the womb of spiritual birth,
 so you also bestowed on us, as you did upon
 your disciples, the immortal breath of your

⁷⁶Ps. 18 (Arm. 17):28.

⁷⁷Is. 7:14, Matt. 1:23.

⁷⁸Is. 25:6 (per the Armenian version).

⁷⁹S. of S. 2:5.

⁸⁰S. of S. 6:2.

⁸¹Is. 6:3.

⁸²Ps. 48 (Arm. 47):10 (per the Armenian version).

⁸³Ps. 51 (Arm. 50):8 (per the Armenian version).



Holy Spirit⁸⁴
 through and in this oil.
 For the people who walked in darkness⁸⁵
 you brought the dawn through your incarnation,
 and through your labors you gave birth to new life.
 You placed a seal upon them
 that cannot be effaced even by idolatry,
 just as no one can follow your example
 to further consecrate the wood of the cross,
 Lord.
 For by this mark of grace
 you brought light to the world,
 manifesting yourself in your perfect fullness,
 beyond understanding,
 in such a way, that the poor shall not want
 and the rich shall not take on airs,
 for like the air is distributed
 and the sunlight is spread
 and the stream waters flow
 equally to all, just as the manna was equally
 distributed to all people on earth alike,⁸⁶
 with more for the poor than the rich and powerful.

Ի

The deep mystery of this substance is
 marvelously explained by its very nature,
 for it does not shift around constantly
 as if it cannot make up its mind,⁸⁷
 nor does it steal away from its place of rest,⁸⁸
 nor can it be removed by the strongest soap,
 nor is it washed away by any other kind of liquid.
 And just as color is a necessary and permanent
 attribute
 of physical existence,
 because when there is color, the body exists,
 and when there is no color, the body seems not
 to exist,
 in the same way, by virtue of its natural powers,

⁸⁴Jn. 20:22.

⁸⁵Is. 9:1.

⁸⁶Ex. 16:16.

⁸⁷A reference to mercury. Kʿchichian, p. 502, n. 2.

⁸⁸A reference to water, which evaporates. Kʿchichian, p. 502, n. 2.

this oil takes hold and does not let go,
 and through it you were united and joined with us,
 Lord Jesus Christ,
 joining the inner substance with its outward form.
 You rendered visible
 that which was invisible for the eyes
 and incomprehensible for the desires of our hearts,
 by providing us this oil,
 made by pressing and squeezing fruits of the earth.
 Moreover, you did not command that this
 anointing oil
 be prepared by mixing together all manner of
 flowers
 into a strange concoction,
 in accordance with the old and benighted law.⁸⁹
 Instead, turning your name into reality,
 you mixed yourself into this pure oil,
 making it radiant with heavenly light.
 And although the savors of your sweetness are
 beyond expression and cannot be compared to
 anything,
 although you have variously been referred to as
 the flowers of the field or the lilies-of-the-valley,⁹⁰
 exquisite nard or sandalwood mixed with
 aloe,⁹¹
 the scent of saffron, the blossoms of the vine or
 a fine wine, you, Lord beyond understanding,
 deemed it fitting
 that your name be glorified simply as “oil
 poured out,”⁹²
 for you are the consummation of all things
 and lacking in nothing.
 Thus, not by the mixing of opposing elements,
 which at once symbolize a divided will,
 but rather in confirmation of our love,
 you revel in divine joy,
 for our sake, you manifest yourself in all your
 splendor,
 according to our needs,

⁸⁹Ex. 30:22-25.

⁹⁰S. of S. 2:1.

⁹¹Sir. 24:15.

⁹²S. of S. 1:3.



as the light of goodness
 or as a warming fire,
 or as the fervor of love,
 devoid of any hard-hearted coldness,
 in ways to make understandable to our minds
 that this drop of oil can really unite us with
 God.
 With Solomon the anointed and adopted of
 God,
 I sing with the mouth of a bride, to you heav-
 enly
 bridegroom, a song of praise and thanksgiving,
 yearning with the fervent desire of my heart
 for your sweet scent, more than for any in-
 cense.
 In the inspired words of the wiseman⁹³ and the
 theological evangelist,⁹⁴ let us hasten in your
 footsteps
 and the trace of your scent.⁹⁵
 Like one who has the words of eternal life,⁹⁶
 having washed my face with the water of life,⁹⁷
 which is more exalted than the waters above the
 heavenly firmament,⁹⁸ and having anointed my
 head
 with the heavenly oil of incorruptibility,⁹⁹
 I come before you with joy, cheerfully and
 without sadness.

I

This venerated and blessed oil,
 would not be an ointment for the chamber of
 my brain,
 or do the hair on my head any good,
 were it not sealed with the sign of your
 life-giving cross, Lord.

This miraculous oil brings the blessing of
 the Light to
 the Jew and the Gentile,
 the Indian and the barbarian,
 the Scythian and the Greek,

⁹³Pr. 4:10-11.

⁹⁴St. John.

⁹⁵S. of S. 1:4.

⁹⁶Jn. 6:68.

⁹⁷Mt. 6:17.

⁹⁸Gen. 1:7.

⁹⁹Ps. 23 (Arm. 22):5, Ps. 45 (Arm. 44):7.

the cruel savage and the fearsome dog-headed
 giants,
 the freeborn master and the slave by birth,¹⁰⁰
 making them Christians,
 baptizing them in your name,
 dedicating them to your Holy Spirit, and
 adopting them as the true sons of your Heav-
 enly Father.

See how varied its powers,
 first in the physical and then in inner strength.
 For as a wooden vessel easily cracks unless it
 is

rubbed with oil
 and becomes useless and worthless,
 so a person, if not anointed, is easily led astray,
 and separated from you, and
 remains unenlightened.¹⁰¹

This oil is your finger, O Jesus,¹⁰²
 with which you perform miracles,
 which like unscratchable, impenetrable armor,
 covers us with an ever protective cloak,
 from dark and foreign marauders.

For one pure as wool, dipped in this oil,¹⁰³
 can neither be stained with blood,
 nor fade into somber colors.

Spiritually, this oil enters
 and penetrates the very substance of our being.
 And if the curse of the Psalmist
 could soak the bones of the evildoer like oil,¹⁰⁴
 how much more will your Spirit
 through this oil of light,
 heal and make whole
 our invisible inner beings,
 from our windpipes
 to our toes,
 completely submerging
 any disturbing thought of death.

For your awesome, life-giving power, Lord
 Christ,
 is mixed in this oil and truly dwells in it.

II

Oil, this magnificent substance applied by
 wrestlers

¹⁰⁰Col. 3:11; Gal. 3:26-28.

¹⁰¹Jn. 15:5.

¹⁰²Ex. 8:15; Lk. 11:20.

¹⁰³Is. 1:18.

¹⁰⁴Ps. 109 (Arm. 108):18.



to their naked bodies, as an enhancement during tournaments, making it difficult for their opponents to take hold of them, sets demons and diseases to flight.

For, in the words Ezekiel addressed to the spiritual Pharaoh,¹⁰⁵ in the form of a satirical allegory:

“On the day you were created,
I placed you with an anointed guardian cherub amidst the fiery stones of the holy mountain of God.”

O blessed and awesome universal help,
who is always beyond words and beyond understanding,
who is constantly venerated through the gospel of life

as the new-born, anointed one from the city of David,¹⁰⁶

and constantly sought as in the question of the chief priest,

“Are you the Christ, son of the blessed?”¹⁰⁷

and in the blessed proclamation by Peter,

“You are the Christ, the Son of the living God,”¹⁰⁸

and by your suspicious interrogators,

“If you are the Christ, tell us plainly.”¹⁰⁹

And because of your teachings,
we believe you to be the Christ,
teacher and Lord of all.

And even before this,

Herod directly asked for you by name, O Christ,¹¹⁰

and you yourself answered, “How is it written that the anointed of God, the Son without beginning,

the one David calls Lord, could be his son in time?”¹¹¹

And we understand from this as a fitting interpretation,

that the consummation of this mystic calling is realized in us, who have the honor of being

called Christians.¹¹²

σ

The awesome word “anointing,”

evokes at once trepidation, veneration and rich adoration, that no earth-dweller dares be called God,

but only godly.

Likewise, no human being has been called the Christ,

but only Christian.

Not even the greatest of the prophets, John the Baptist,¹¹³

who by baptizing with water

prepared the way for the baptism with the spirit,

could claim this name,¹¹⁴

for he said, “I am not the Christ, but was sent before him.”¹¹⁵

In the words of the evangelist Mark,

the disciples set out in pairs,¹¹⁶

and as if acting with the genuine hand of God they would anoint with oil

and without invoking any other human devices, they would heal people.

For as darkness yields to the light,

and ailments to health

and night to day

and death to life,

so by virtue of this substance, given by the Lord,

all evil works are rejected, checked, and completely suppressed.

And just as for flies, spiders and insects that crawl into the ears,

the oil is a deadly poison that kills them,

so this oil strengthened with the abundant

blessings of grace,

wards off demons, dissolves the mortgage of evil and

tears up the death sentence.

The baptismal font is not complete unless accompanied by anointing.

¹⁰⁵Prideful man or Satan, cf. Ezek. 28:14.

¹⁰⁶Lk. 2:11; Mt. 2:5-6.

¹⁰⁷Mk. 14:61.

¹⁰⁸Mt. 16:16.

¹⁰⁹Jn. 10:24.

¹¹⁰Mt. 2:4.

¹¹¹Mt. 22:43-45.

¹¹²Rom. 8:29-30.

¹¹³Mt. 11:9-11.

¹¹⁴Mt. 3:11-16.

¹¹⁵Jn. 1:20-23.

¹¹⁶Mk. 6:7-13.



To the first man left mortally wounded by brigands,
 this salve of salvation was applied,¹¹⁷
 and it also served honorably
 as ointment for the incurable wounds of
 Jacob and Israel.¹¹⁸
 David wanted this oil
 as a fruitful olive tree in the house of the Lord,
 dwelling there always in trust,¹¹⁹
 predicting abandonment of circumcision
 and adoption of the grace of baptism.
 But how can I discourse
 convinced that I understand this completely,
 especially regarding holiness,
 when even the angels cannot explain it in
 words?
 How indeed could I hope to describe its true
 essence?



Glory to you always and in all things,
 immortal king, in the praise I now sing,
 which you created and perfected through me,
 good, caring, merciful and patient,
 wealthy and abundant, Lord, triumphant over
 all.
 The idea of anointing sketched by our forefathers,
 you made a reality in the fullness of time.
 You are light in your very nature¹²⁰
 and the ever-shining sun,
 and you called your disciples the light of the
 world,¹²¹
 for through them you filled the creatures of all
 the earth
 with rays of blissful grace.
 You accepted the anointing of your feet with
 the
 oil of sweetness¹²²
 as a symbol that our prayers are acceptable to

¹¹⁷Lk. 10:30 (The traveler on the way to Jericho is symbolically Adam beaten by the brigands who symbolize Satan, and cared for by the Good Samaritan with oil. K?chichian, p. 508, n. 1)

¹¹⁸Is. 1:6; Jer. 30:12.

¹¹⁹Ps. 52 (Arm. 51):8.

¹²⁰Jn. 1:9.

¹²¹Mt. 5:14.

¹²²Jn. 12:3.

you.
 And by the anointing of your head by a
 woman of ill-repute,¹²³
 you showed your compassionate love for us.
 And with such great pleasure, O infinite Lord,
 did you inhale the aroma of the oil,
 that you ordered as an inviolable command-
 ment
 that wherever the gospel is preached
 throughout the world
 that seemingly insignificant act of anointing
 should be remembered,¹²⁴
 to the amazement of your listeners
 and raising the hopes of future generations.
 “You have been anointed by the Holy One,”
 said that most blessed of your disciples,
 explaining the mystery poured out upon us
 from your overflowing bounty, O source of life.
 This drop of blessing from you who are praised
 on high,
 which endlessly inoculates us,
 bears a close, fitting and lasting resemblance
 to you who are light and to your Holy Spirit.
 It is called light,
 because it is like the first element of cre-
 ation,¹²⁵
 and the very symbol of you, our Creator,
 by which you drive away the gloomy
 darkness of evil.
 It is called fire,
 because in every element of creation
 there is distributed in some measure, your
 essence,
 hidden and manifest, silent and known,
 that unless provoked by the devilish adversary,
 it will not flare up by itself.
 It is also called anointing,
 because through it we are adopted
 into your majesty
 and are offered to your Father as his inheri-
 tance¹²⁶
 and marked indelibly with your mercy by this
 oil, like you, so we might shine brightly in the
 next life.

¹²³Lk. 7:46.

¹²⁴Mk. 14:3-9.

¹²⁵Gen. 1:3.

¹²⁶Rom. 8:17.



It is also called spirit,
because we are cleansed of the calamities of
deceit,
cunningly instigated by that troublemaker Sa-
tan,
so we might worship our heavenly Father
renewed in soul and with truth,¹²⁷
nailed to you with faith and hope,
all-giving God.



In truth, eternally and in reality,
this oil filled with light is
a venerable proof of your love, God on high.
This is why Paul himself deemed it fitting
to say directly in his teaching on grace and
thanksgiving,
“He who establishes us with you in Christ and
has
anointed us is God, who has also sealed us and
given
us the Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee,”¹²⁸
and also, “Do not,” he said, “grieve the
Holy Spirit of God,
by whom you were sealed for the day of re-
demption.”¹²⁹
“Anointed” is a title honorable and invincible
in the Old Testament, yet more so in the New.
In the words of the Psalm of David,
that predict faithfully the mystery of your prov-
idential
suffering, Lord, “The rulers of the people band
together against the Lord and his anointed.”¹³⁰
A great prophecy that imprinted upon the
Jewish throngs the unredeemable sin of
spilling your blood, caused by audacity toward
you,
Lord, “Who can put forth his hand against the
Lord’s anointed, and be guiltless?”¹³¹
For although Saul was killed by one of his
own,¹³²

¹²⁷Jn. 4:23.

¹²⁸2 Cor. 21-22.

¹²⁹Eph. 4:30.

¹³⁰Ps. 2:2.

¹³¹1 Sam. 26:9.

¹³²2 Sam. 1:14. St. Gregory assumes that the killer
was a Jew, when in fact it was an Amalechite employed
by Israel. Kʿchichian, p. 511, n. 3.

still they were not rejected in shame
or subject to the insults of foreign nations,
until they were implicated in the spilling of
your blood, Lord.
And these pleas in the Psalms are a great
pledge,
reminding us of the inheritance of future gen-
erations:
“For the sake of your beloved servant David,
you do not turn away the face of your anointed
one,”¹³³
and again, “Look upon the face of your
anointed”¹³⁴
and “show steadfast love for your anointed.”¹³⁵

2

This light-filled fluid, O Christ,
is the venerated gift of your hand,
for out of all riches in your kingdom,
the Prophet deemed nothing higher, Lord,
than that you would say,
“I have found David, my servant,
and with my holy oil I have anointed him.”¹³⁶
Thus, by this instructive example,
embracing your anointing with the light, our
Lord Jesus Christ,
you are known to us, unchanging and eter-
nal.¹³⁷
You are all and in all, the only king of kings,
and the true anointed one among the anointed,
glorified and worshiped yesterday and to-
day.¹³⁸
For as the wick, soaked in oil, does not give
light
until lit with a flame,
so we, who are anointed with the light,
do not glow until we are lit like torches in
heaven.
This is a clear explanation of its nature,
transmitted from the ancients till today,
painted in marvelously brilliant colors
through these felicitous analogies.

¹³³Ps. 132 (Arm. 131):10.

¹³⁴Ps. 84 (Arm. 83):9.

¹³⁵Ps. 18 (Arm. 17):51.

¹³⁶Ps. 89 (Arm. 88):21.

¹³⁷Rev. 19:16, 1 Tim. 6:16.

¹³⁸Heb. 13:8.

Ղ

Now, the cause of these sublime, life-giving,
divine effects,
characteristic of you, Creator,
without which one cannot be considered a
Christian,
or named a Nazarite,¹³⁹
or be remembered as a son of Judah,
or raise a battle cry in the name of the Lord of
Jacob,¹⁴⁰
is this substance, the oil of blessings,
in which your Holy Trinity is mixed and joined:
the ray of grace, the splendor of our forehead,
the image of our face, the comeliness of our
traits,
the light of our eyes, the sign of the cross on
our pupils,
the tenderness of our cheeks, the decoration of
our countenance,
the guardian of our lips, the attendant of our
faith,
the guide of our behavior, the tie that binds,
the strength of souls, the fortitude of resistance,
the barrier to spells, the destroyer of talismans,
the repeller of wizards, the confounder of sor-
cerers,
the exposé of heretics, the vanquisher of
demons,
the dispeller of pain, the fulfiller of the bap-
tized,
the fervent desire of converts, the incompre-
hensible
mystery of outsiders,
the bewilderment of pagans,¹⁴¹
the envy of non-believers,¹⁴²
the unmasker of secrets, the honor of the hum-
ble,
the glory of slaves, the adornment of women,
the growth of children, the joy of the aged,
the consecrator of the ordained, the counsel of
the pure,
the crown of kings, the grandeur of monarchs,
the excellence of emperors.
For as a sealed container indicates the value of

¹³⁹Num. 6:2.

¹⁴⁰1 Sam. 17:45.

¹⁴¹Acts 2:6-13.

¹⁴²Acts 8:18.

the contents,
so the sublimity of your grace sealed in us
by being anointed in your name, God and
Lord Jesus Christ,
is beautifully symbolized by anointing.
And the name of this substance, muron,
according to the inspired wisemen,
originated with the Egyptians and
expresses its very essence
as an image of an awe-inspiring mystery.

Ճ

For this blessed muron,
which the prophet foreshadowed,
referring in his prayer to the light of his eyes,¹⁴³
according to its etymology is derived from
homeron,¹⁴⁴
which means mother for me,
that is to say, that which strongly attracts our
nature to itself,
and solidifies through a wonderful transforma-
tion,
the fluid water of the font of light,
and like the ingredient that curdles milk into
yogurt,
so it stabilizes my untamed ravings and
the perpetually flowing stream of my con-
sciousness.
According to another etymology,
the word muron means ‘somber,’
that is, ‘obscure,’
since it refers to something dark, hidden or
unseen.¹⁴⁵
And this name is not some baseless metaphor,
since this word truly refers to something
that symbolizes a secret deeper than the holy
of holies.

¹⁴³Ps. 13 (Arm. 12):3.

¹⁴⁴St. Gregory, in a poetic etymology, discerns two
Greek roots, mi which he equates with “me,” and ro which
he equates with “flowing, or source,” resulting in, “the
source of me” or “mother of me.” Critical Edition, p.
1120, n. 77.

¹⁴⁵Some scholars derive muron from the Greek mau-
ros, “dark” or “black.” H. Acharian derives it from the
Greek muros ‘fragrant oil,’ coming from Proto-Indo-
European *smer (without s-movable), English smear.
Critical Edition, p. 1120, n. 77.



For muron does not wash away dirt like water,
or bolster the heart like bread.
Instead in a fittingly new way, with divine
providence,
it imprints the Lord on our senses,
nevertheless remaining exalted beyond our
comprehension, thus its name is beyond our
understanding.

For as God truly dwells in light that
cannot be approached,¹⁴⁶
with your boundless glory in its infinity,
you covered yourself in impenetrable cloud¹⁴⁷
externally sealed from our faculties.
In the same way, the flow of light
from the eloquent tongues of some,
in appropriate poetic composition is called
obscure,
because worldly natures cannot understand
essential truths.
The holy chrism richly and properly
commands both these divine names,
for the very name chrism resembles the name
of our
exalted Lord, Christ, doubly glorifying this oil,
consecrated with fine and fragrant incense.
For “Our God is a consuming fire,”
according to Moses,¹⁴⁸ and also,
“the light,” according to John,¹⁴⁹
thus Isaiah’s allusion is justified:
“The light of Israel shall become a fire.”¹⁵⁰

U

Once again I shall express the same idea
in different words and comparisons,
with renewed praise and blessings,
for I cannot forget my bitterness,
which you sweetened in your great compas-
sion.
For mera, which means ‘bitterness [in He-
brew],’¹⁵¹
appropriately signifies ‘wearisome torment

and pain,’
so in Armenian, muron is explained etymolog-
ically
as a derivative of merelutyun, that is, ‘mortifi-
cation.’¹⁵²
For by being anointed with this spirit-bearing
oil,
we are cut off from the vanities of this world,
those vile and deadly excesses of the Adver-
sary,
whose dankness makes my lyre go out of tune,
whose dampness muffles the sound of my
drums¹⁵³
that used to resound strong and bold when
struck
but whose soggy wetness drags us down
into the deaf numbness of death.

Yet again through this anointing we are
bound with hope
to the miracle of your cross, beyond telling, O
Christ,¹⁵⁴
for by baptism into your death, O living
God,¹⁵⁵
we partake in your divine immortality through
you
yourself, God, placing complete trust in you,
forever, fully and inseparably.

3

This oil seals us in your name, Jesus,
with a four-pointed mark in the form of your
sign,¹⁵⁶
conferring grace in glory and dignity to your
blood,
O Savior and giver of life,
and crowned with the same invincible glory
this oil is exalted.
It is called the wood-blessing oil,
in the words of the Prophets,¹⁵⁷

¹⁴⁶1 Tim 6:16.

¹⁴⁷Ps. 18 (Arm. 17):12.

¹⁴⁸Dt. 4:24.

¹⁴⁹1 Jn. 1:5.

¹⁵⁰Is. 10:17.

¹⁵¹Cf. Hebrew marah, English myrrh.

¹⁵²Critical Edition, p. 1120, n. 77.

¹⁵³Per the Haykazyan Bararan, q.v. t’mpuk, a refer-
ence to the deafening of the eardrum.

¹⁵⁴During baptism, the priest makes cross-shaped seals
of muron on the forehead, eyes, ears, mouth, heart, back,
hands and feet of the person being baptized.

¹⁵⁵Rom. 6:3.

¹⁵⁶See note 233.

¹⁵⁷The Olive Tree. Is. 41:19, Hag. 2:19.

for when this oil is miraculously applied
to common wood of the forest,
raw material, wild with evil and strange ideas,
becomes the mature equivalent of your cross,
to be offered up to you, O Creator.
Similarly, the windows of our soul, which are
always open, were sealed by you, in the name
of your
awesome majesty, with the sign of the cross
in providential modesty,
that we might inhabit a dwelling favored by
your
Holy Spirit,¹⁵⁸ and might be impervious to the
evil
delusions of the trickster
and his dark fog.
Restrained by this light, we gather for the
hymns of thanksgiving at the evening service
with the stars, your heavenly lamps,
symbolic of the light of your grace, the muron,
that burns in us.
And in this light, the oil reminds us of the
salvation of the good, planting this thought in
our souls,
making it blossom and bear fruit.¹⁵⁹
To make ready for the banquet
on the last night of your Second Coming,¹⁶⁰
we use this light like a torch.¹⁶¹

Ն

Now, if using the numerical value of the
Armenian alphabet,
we take the 24th letter with the value of 400
[n],
and apply it to the profound mystery of the oil,
we come up with an easily digestible explanation
to nourish those hungry for understanding.
For when we multiply twenty times four, we
get 80 [dz],
which is the first letter of the word oil
[dzet/dzyut]
in Armenian.
And when we substitute the letter 400 [n] for

80 [dz],
we change the word for oil [dzyut] in to the
word
for matter [nyut], which symbolizes the new
heaven
that miraculously raises up the lump of
dough.¹⁶²
And as the Gospel parable teaches,
though the smaller [80] does not contain the
larger [400],
nevertheless it can transform the whole mass
and
make it grow, so the anointing oil mixed into
our nature transforms and makes us grow.

Ը

This gentle oil is a constant reminder
of elevation and humility.
For when eaten in food it goes down soft,
like a balanced and kind word,
but when put on liquids, slippery and unstable,
it rises above them,
showing its glorious excellence and superior-
ity,
symbolizing its miraculous mystery.
And when applied to a leather container,
it is not absorbed like water or wine,
but rather stays on the surface within its proper
bounds.
Thus understanding the incomparable excel-
lence of
your goodness,
O Son of the living God,
by virtue of your blood,
we write on our foreheads
with this oil of sacred gifts,
and we imprint the breath of our nature with
your
Holy Spirit,
believing with the conviction of our heart
that this oil will forever show forth and shine
anew with
brilliant radiance upon the varied and mar-
velous expanse
like a beacon toward the glory of everlasting
life.

¹⁵⁸1 Cor. 6:19.

¹⁵⁹Jn. 15:16.

¹⁶⁰Rev. 19:9.

¹⁶¹Mt. 25:4, 10.

¹⁶²Mt. 13:33, Lk. 13:21.



And may this spiritual oil,
full of bliss and heavenly glow,
make the sign of your cross
shine upon my face, in your image.¹⁶³

Ω

And being incomprehensible, a power too
great for understanding,
even soaring with the swift wings of the mind,
before the pursuit of my thought
flying without trace into infinity,
completely disappeared, hid from me,
and it left no likeness,
resembled no parallel,
was defined by no formula,
and could be measured by no companion,
but rather was spiritually superior to them,
like the sign of your divine cross,
the equal to your blood, O Savior.
And now, Lord, bless us through it and in it.
And by it may your name become our salvation,
O awesome, light, heavenly and marvelous,
venerated with incense by the pure in spirit in
praise of
your ineffable glory,
holy, holy, beyond understanding, beyond
telling,
exalted, merciful, lauded, true, doer of good
and holiness,
Pardon us.¹⁶⁴
Grant us healing.
Cloth us in grace.
Endow us with bliss.
By being anointed with this oil, this heavenly
shower of light, may I be found sinless.
Do not let the sorrow of sinful infirmity,
invade and take over this anointed rational
fabric of mine, and commingle with the image
of my soul.
For those who present themselves to be
anointed
with this oil, let them be like a bride,
as for a glorious wedding,
beautifully arrayed in holy splendor,¹⁶⁵

¹⁶³Gen. 1:26, Rom 8:29.

¹⁶⁴Lk. 1:68.

¹⁶⁵Rev. 21:2.

their souls adorned with happiness.
And for those who approach it for purification,
may this light, this glorious fire, given by God,
be a double tempering and second immersion,
with fervent striving for the good,
through which they emerge as if newly created.
And in all ways fully armed with ever-ready
steadfastness, may I dwell upon your unshake-
able rock,¹⁶⁶
standing firm, my faith grounded in you
without any doubt.
For those who are on fire with this gift,
by this sign of victory, may they
not be doused with water,
not be burned by the fire,
not be frozen by the cold,
not be extinguished by the harmful wind,
not be stained by unclean dreams,
not betray Jesus' own to the Evil One,¹⁶⁷
not throw away the accumulated treasures of
life
at their moment of exit from this world,
not be outside the protection of your wings,¹⁶⁸
not be stripped of our being anointed by
unclean living.
But by your grace, may we be set on fire by it,
be filled with it,
be enlightened through it,
be justified by it,
be liberated, crowned and reign by it.¹⁶⁹
And to you alone, the only Anointed,
together with your Father and your Holy Spirit,
may all give
hymns of blessing, alleluias in all tongues,
resounding voices, triumphant praise,
lips lauding your goodness,
holy words of the Psalms,
forever and ever.
Amen.

The previous prayer (92) was about what
is holy, and this prayer (93) was a meditation
on the holy of holies.

¹⁶⁶1 Cor. 10:4, Mt. 7:24.

¹⁶⁷Jude 1:1.

¹⁶⁸Ps. 17 (Arm. 16):8.

¹⁶⁹1 Pet. 2:9.



Prayer 94 (᠒᠒)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Eternal God, almighty, doer of good,
 creator of light and inventor of night,¹
 life in death and light in the darkness,²
 hope for the expectant and patient with the
 doubters,
 who with your ingenious wisdom
 turns the darkness of death into morning,³
 dawn that does not dim, sun that does not set.⁴
 The dark of the night is not able to cover the
 glory
 of your Lordship, before which all creation
 kneels constantly in worship,
 those in heaven and on earth, and those con-
 fined in hell.⁵
 You who hear the sighs of those who are bound,
 and who attend to the prayers of the humble,
 and receive their supplications,
 my God and my king,
 my life and my refuge,
 my hope and my confidence,
 Jesus Christ, O God of all,
 holiness that dwells in the souls of the saints,
 consolation for the afflicted and pardon for sin-
 ners,
 you who know all things before they happen,
 send the protective strength of your right hand
 and save me from the terror of the night and
 evil demons, so that always embracing your
 awesome
 memory and your holy name
 on the lips of my soul and with the desires of
 my breath,
 I might be saved and protected along with those
 who call to you with all their hearts.⁶

P

¹Gen. 1:3-5.

²Mic. 7:8.

³Am. 5:8.

⁴Rev. 22:5.

⁵Phil. 2:10.

⁶Acts 2:21.

And by the seal of the sign of your cross,
 which you renewed by staining it with your di-
 vine blood,
 and by the same grace of your fatherhood,
 with which you baptized us,⁷
 and in the glory of your image, in which you
 fashioned and created us,⁸
 with these divine gifts,
 may Satan be confounded and his machinations
 foiled,
 may his snares be removed and his forces be
 defeated,
 may his sharp edged weapons be ineffective,
 may his fog be lifted, his darkness dispelled,
 his
 shadow withdrawn.
 May your arm shield me and your right hand
 seal me,
 for you are compassionate and merciful,
 and your servants are called by your name.⁹
 To you with the Father and your Holy Spirit,
 glory and power forever and ever.
 Amen.

Prayer 95 (᠒ᠢ)

Speaking with God from the Depths of the Heart

U

Sun of justice,
 ray of blessings,
 form of light,
 cherished desire,¹
 exalted beyond understanding,
 mighty beyond telling,
 joy of goodness,
 hope realized,²
 praised by heaven,
 king of glory,³
 Christ creator,

⁷Gal. 3:26-27.

⁸Rom. 8:29.

⁹Acts 15:17.

¹Mt. 13:17, Jn. 8:56.

²Lk. 4:21.

³1 Cor. 2:8.



life proclaimed,⁴
 finish, I pray,
 the meanderings
 of my wretched, errant voice
 with your own mighty words.⁵
 Help me to polish
 a pleasing prayer,
 to bring before your Father on high.
 You who took on my likeness
 submitting for my sake to trial and condemna-
 tion,⁶
 take pity on me.
 You who bless all life,
 God of Goodness,
 who provide all things above and below,
 who were willing to die for me,⁷
 God and lord of all,
 who have borne the pangs of mortal flesh,
 take pity on me,
 for I am wracked with pain.⁸
 Take pity on me, stay with me, a wretched sin-
 ner,
 and pray with me to your Father, your equal in
 glory.⁹

¶

By your noble and glorious blood,
 offered unceasingly to please God who sent
 you,
 may the dangers be lifted from me, the con-
 demned,
 may my transgressions be forgiven,
 may my vices be pardoned,
 may my shamelessness be forgotten,
 may my sentence be commuted,
 may the worms shrivel,¹⁰
 may the wailing stop,
 and the gnashing of teeth fall silent.¹¹
 Let the laments lessen and tears dry.
 Let mourning end and darkness be banished.

⁴Jn. 6:68.

⁵Rom. 8:26.

⁶Heb. 2:18, Gal. 3:13, Phil. 2:7.

⁷Gal. 2:20.

⁸Heb. 4:15.

⁹Heb. 7:25.

¹⁰Mk. 9:48.

¹¹Mt. 25:30.

May the vengeful fire be tamped out
 and torments of every kind be exiled.

¶

May you who grant life to all be compassionate
 now.
 Let your light dawn, your salvation be swift,
 your help come in time, and the hour of your
 arrival be at hand.
 May the dew of your mercy quench the parched
 field
 where my bones have fallen into the pit of
 death.
 Prepare the earth for the day of light
 and let the soil bloom and bring forth fruit,
 heavenly cup of life-giving blood,
 ever sacrificed, never running dry
 all for the salvation and life of the souls in eter-
 nal rest.
 And though my body die in sin,
 with your grace and compassion,
 may I be strengthened in you, cleansed of sin
 through you, and renewed by you with life ev-
 erlasting,
 and at the resurrection of the righteous
 be deemed worthy of your Father's blessing.¹²
 To him together with you, all glory,
 and with the Holy Spirit, praise and resounding
 thanks,
 now, always and forever,
 Amen.

Postscript Dedication on the Composition of this Book

The sun that brings joy to our eyes
 the brilliant, glistening round disc,
 always brimming, radiant light bearer,¹
 measurer of days, dispelling darkness,
 is the creative dawn that counts years and
 groups
 them into centuries
 along the eternal cycle of life and death of this
 passing world.

¹²Mt. 25:34.

¹Unlike the moon which waxes and wanes.



At the end of the ninth jubilee ²
 and the commencement of the tenth
 according to the calendar of the people of the
 House of Japhet, ³
 three years after his arrival, in the
 north-eastern regions, ⁴
 the conquering Roman Emperor Basil, ⁵
 traversed the expansive frontier in all direc-
 tions
 and raised huge stone monuments wherever he
 laid his hand.
 Without blinking an eye,
 he took possessions to the left and right,
 without breaks or gaps,
 adding the parcels and territories
 of many nations to his realm.

In a tranquil period,
 when the enemies of the church were re-
 strained,
 I undertook the writing of this book.
 I planned, arranged, compiled, took notes,
 gathered, organized, composed, and set it
 forth,
 bringing together in one comprehensive work,
 in a single style, passages from many different
 sources,
 to produce this sacred book.
 I, Grigor, priest of the faith,
 the lowest in rank among the poets and the
 least of the teachers,
 working with my blessed brother John,
 a member of the noble brotherhood of Narek

Monastery,
 being relatives not only in body,
 but also in unity of soul, faith, honor, and
 thought,
 initiated in the same way of life,
 we lived as two persons with one persona,
 four eyes fixed on the same mystic vision.

And now, we ask you who partake at this
 banquet table
 with its various offerings,
 to remember us in earnest prayers
 and worthy supplications,
 with pure love and kind thoughts,
 that your name be written in the
 book of everlasting life in heaven on high.⁶
 Amen.

²9 x 50 = 450 (each half-century was a jubilee)

³According to Biblical tradition as set forth by the
 father of Armenian history, Movses Khorenatsi, the Ar-
 menians decedent from Noah's son Japhet, through his
 grandson, Togarmah (Armenian Torgom), whose son
 was Hayk, eponymous forefather of the Armenian peo-
 ple. See, Gen. 9:18-10:2, 1 Chr. 1:4, Movses Khore-
 natsi, History of Armenia, Bk. 1:5. The Armenian Cal-
 endar starts at 551, the year after the Council of Dvin.
 Since this is the first year of the tenth jubilee year, St.
 Gregory finished writing this book in 451 of the Arme-
 nian era, which is 1002 (451 + 551) AD.

⁴North-east of Vaspurakan and east of the Byzantine
 Empire.

⁵Basil II (976-1025) who came to Armenia in 999, to
 claim possessions left to him by prince David.

⁶Lk. 10:20, Rev. 20:12.